

A BOND OF SCALE AND SILVER

A BOND OF SCALE AND SILVER

a novel

Søren Stromberg

Copyright © 2026 Søren Stromberg

All rights reserved.

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places, and incidents are either products of the author's imagination or used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, events, or locales is entirely coincidental.

No part of this book may be reproduced in any form without written permission from the author, except for brief quotations in a review.

ISBN 979-8-1827-2378-7

First edition, 2026.

*For all the ones that were told to hide themselves from the
world. We see you.*

CHAPTER ONE

Contraband

The gown came up on a covered tray, the way everything came up on the nights the castle was full of strangers.

Amelia watched Della carry it in and lay it across the bed, and she counted the seconds it took, because counting was a habit she had never troubled to break. Four seconds from the door to the bed. Three to spread the skirt. Della did everything gently. She had been coming into this room for eleven years, and she loved the girl in it in the plain unspoken way of a woman who has helped raise a child not her own, and tonight she kept her voice low. Not because Amelia was a secret from her. Because Amelia was a secret from the two hundred guests three floors down, and the habit of quiet had long ago stopped being a rule between them and become a kind of tenderness they shared.

The silk was the grey of deep winter water. It caught the lamplight and gave a little of it back and kept most.

"Her Majesty had it made," Della said. "For the fitting." She smoothed a fold and glanced up, and there was an apology in her face she was too kind to say aloud, because they both knew there was no fitting. There was never a fitting.

"She has my measurements written down somewhere," Amelia said, "and sends them to a woman who has never seen my face."

"And never will, worse luck for her, because you'd make the poor soul weep to see how it hangs on you." Della said it warmly, almost fiercely, the way she said all the small loyal things she was not supposed to have opinions about. "There. It's a wicked color on you. Your mother has an eye, whatever else."

"You're not meant to have views on my mother."

"I'm not meant to have views on anything, and I've had them for forty years, and it hasn't killed me yet." Della folded the cover cloth over her arm and stood a moment looking at Amelia the way she often did, fond and a little sad, seeing at once the young woman on the bed and the small silver child who had once fallen asleep against her shoulder. "Eat your supper while it's hot, lamb. It's a wild house tonight. Half the kitchen's in tears and the other half's drunk already, and there's more strangers under this roof than I've seen in my whole life in service."

"I know," Amelia said. "I've been counting the carriages."

Della's face did the thing it did, the softening she never quite managed to hide, and she reached out and touched Amelia's cheek once, quick, the way you touch a thing you are not supposed to love as much as you do, and then she gathered herself and went to the door.

The door settled into its frame. On the far side the bolt went across, iron on iron, and Amelia knew Della hated the sound of it as much as she did, because Della always slid it slowly, as if going slowly made it less of a lock. It was a good bolt. It spoke in a low register that carried down the passage and came back off the stone a half-beat later, and Amelia had lived inside that sound so long she could tell, from the quality of the echo, whether the corridor beyond was empty or held someone waiting. Tonight it was empty. The echo came back clean, with the small flatness a stone hall gives when there is no warm body in it to soften the return.

She rated rooms this way, and had since she was a child, without meaning anything by it, the way another girl might have hummed. A room that gave your voice back whole would keep your secrets; a room that swallowed it was a room you could be overheard in. She knew the acoustics of every space she had ever been let into, which were not many, and this one best of all. Her own room returned a whisper at four parts in ten, and the figure never changed however many nights she measured it against her own breath, and there was a comfort in that she was not proud of.

It was a strange thing to be, a secret that a whole house loved. The cook sent up things she had no business sending, honey pears out of season and the first of the almond cakes before they went down to the hall, and never a word said about why the count came out short. Old Bram on the night watch had taught her, through the bars of the north gallery when she was nine, to whistle three ways and to tell a hunting owl from a barn one by the space between its calls. The girls who did the linens argued in front of her about their sweethearts the way they would in front of a sister, a locked room three floors up made over into another kind of parlor, and asked her which of the two dull brothers they ought to marry, and took her answers seriously, because she noticed things and they knew it. She knew all their names. She knew whose mother was ailing and whose brother had gone for a soldier and who was quietly in love with whom two floors down, and none of them had the first idea what her own days were made of, because her days were made of them, of the small borrowed pieces of their ordinary lives that came up the stairs to her on covered trays and went back down again. A household that adored her and could not save her had settled for spoiling her instead, quietly, against every rule. On the good days she had almost let it be enough.

She was alone now with a dress she would never wear anywhere but here.

She undressed and put it on, because there was nothing else to do with an evening, and because the body, given silk, wants to know what it feels like. It fit. Of course it fit. Her mother's arithmetic was never wrong. The bodice sat close. The skirt fell the way water falls, and when she turned, the whole grey length of it turned a breath after her. Obedient. Everything in her life was obedient, and a breath too late to be any company.

There was a glass on the inside of the wardrobe door. She had asked for it and been given it, which was not the same as being allowed a life but was the nearest her mother could come, and she stood in front of it and made herself look at all of her, because to flinch from your own face was a habit she refused to keep.

She was pale the way the underside of a leaf is pale. Her hair was silver, not the warm silver of an old woman who had once been fair, but a true cold silver, near to grey where the lamp did not reach it, the color of the moon on a night with no warmth in it. It had come in that way when she was small. Her mother had looked at it once for a long time and touched it and laughed and then, later, quietly, had it braided and pinned close, so that from any distance it might be mistaken for something ordinary. It was not ordinary. Nothing about her was, and the whole point of every year since had been to hide exactly how much.

She lifted her chin. In the grey gown, with the silver hair down, she looked like something a story would warn you about.

That was the joke of her, the whole of it. She had never done a single dangerous thing in her life. Twenty years old, and she had never been in a room with more than four people in it, never stood in a crowd, never been jostled,

never had a stranger step on her hem and beg her pardon without knowing her name. The most transgressive act available to her was to want, very much, to go to a party.

The wanting brought the smell up with it, the way it sometimes did. Beeswax, and cold stone. It came from nowhere and it came whole. There had been a gallery on the north side once, when she was small, sealed now, where the old lamps were kept and no one went, and she had been allowed to sit in it for hours because it had no windows and no door a stranger could reach, and so it was safe, and it had smelled of beeswax and old stone and nothing else in the world. She could not have said why the smell came to her now, with the music starting under the floor. It arrived at the wrong moments all her life, that smell, at the edges of frightened nights and once, absurdly, in the middle of her mother telling her that her grandmother was dead. She had learned to let it come and go and ask nothing of it. It was not a sign. It was only a thing she carried, the way she carried the rest of it.

Below her, three floors down and a wing over, the castle was already lit for one.

She could hear it. Not the words. The room she stood in had been built to keep sound out as much as in, and her own walls gave her only the shape of things. But the shape was enough. Carriages had been arriving since the light went. She had counted eleven so far by the particular way iron wheels changed their note crossing from the road onto the courtyard stone, and each one had loosed a small pour of voices that the great doors then swallowed. Musicians had been tuning for an hour. The kitchens had been at a rolling boil since noon, and the smell of it had found even her, roast and burnt sugar and the green smell of cut branches brought in by the cartload to make a hall smell like a forest for guests who had never slept in one.

The shifters were coming. That was the thing the whole castle was holding its breath around. The shifters were coming to the Queen's table, under the treaty, to eat her food and drink her wine and pretend for one long night that the last war had settled something. Their chief was bringing his people down out of the hills. There would be more strangers under one roof tonight than had stood inside these walls in Amelia's whole life. And she was to spend the evening exactly as she had spent every evening, which was here, in a beautiful room she loved and hated in equal measure, being no one.

She heard the outer bolt go back.

She had the gown half off before the inner door opened, because only one person passed that bolt without the guard, and that person never knocked. Her mother could not make herself knock at her daughter's door. She had said so once, laughing at herself. A queen knocks at no door in her own house, and a mother knocks at no door her child is behind, and so between the two of them there was simply no version of her that could raise her hand and rap on the wood, and she had given up trying years ago.

Her mother came in fast, the way she always came, as though the hours she spent being Queen were a debt and this small locked room was where she came to be paid back. She crossed to Amelia and took her daughter's face in both hands and kissed her forehead. Her hands were cool. They were always cool. The cool of her had frightened strangers all Amelia's life and had never, not for a single day of it, felt to Amelia as anything but home.

"Look at you," her mother said. She stood back to arm's length and kept hold of Amelia's hands and looked at her the way she looked at her every time, which was as though she still could not quite trust the evidence of her. "Look at you in it. Turn around. No, slowly. Oh." She pressed her lips

together. "I knew it would do that at the shoulder. I told her the shoulder. Turn back. Let me see the front."

"Mother."

"Hush, let me look at you. I get so little of it." She smoothed the grey silk at Amelia's waist with both hands, fussing, entirely a mother and not at all a queen, and for a moment the whole terrible weight of the house was nowhere in the room. "There has never been anything in the world as fine as you. Do you know that? In a thousand years of us there has never been a single one of you, and then there was, and she was mine, and she has her grandmother's mouth and my temper and hair no one was ever born with before. I made you out of nothing and love and spite, and you are the best thing I have ever done, and no one will ever, ever be permitted to know it."

She said the last of it lightly, the way she said the true things, so that they might pass for jokes. But her hands had gone still at Amelia's waist, and Amelia, who read everything, felt the change go through them, one clear note sounding in another room.

"You came up here to tell me something," Amelia said.

"Yes." Her mother let go and stepped back and became, not cold, but careful, gathering herself the way she gathered herself before a thing that was going to hurt. "Yes, I did. Take it off first. I can't say it to you while you're standing there looking like that. Take it off, and I'll say the ugly thing once, plainly, and then we won't speak of it again."

Amelia took the gown off. She did it without hurry. She stepped out of the grey silk and stood in her shift in the cool of the room and folded the gown over her arm, and her mother watched her do it with an expression Amelia had spent her life failing to name, something between hunger and grief, the look of a woman memorizing a thing she is not allowed to keep in the open.

"The dress goes back down tonight," her mother said. "She'll let out the shoulder and I'll have it made up again next season, and you'll try it on alone, up here, and it will go back down. That is what the dress is for. It is for the trying on." Her voice did not shake. She had had a lifetime of practice at not letting it shake. "And tonight, my love, of all the nights there have ever been, you must not exist. Not in the small safe way you exist on ordinary nights, behind a bolt where the household loves you and the world forgets you between meals. Tonight there are shifters in my hall who have spent thirty years looking for a reason. If one of them so much as hears that the Queen keeps a daughter, the treaty is ash by morning, and it will be your face they burn it over. Do you hear the difference? On an ordinary night you must only not be seen. Tonight you must not be."

And Amelia laughed.

It came up out of her before she could stop it, one bright ugly note, entirely wrong, and it rang off the stone and came back to her doubled and she heard exactly how wrong it was and could not call it back. Her mother's face did not harden. That was the worst of it. Her mother only looked at her, stricken, as though the laugh had gone into her somewhere soft. Amelia pressed her hand over her mouth, hard, and above her fingers her eyes were wet, and she did not know, standing there, whether she was laughing or doing the thing that looks like laughing when a person has run entirely out of the other options.

"I'm sorry," she said, from behind her hand. "I'm sorry. It's only that you said it as though it were new. As though we hadn't both known it since I was old enough to be told anything at all."

"I know." Her mother crossed the space between them and gathered her in, both cool arms around her, Amelia's face against the cold sweet-smelling column of her throat,

and held her the way she had held her through every fever and every nightmare of her childhood. "I know you know. I say it anyway, because I am the only one in this house who has to carry both halves of it at once, and tonight the halves are heavier than usual, and I needed to set one of them down in front of you for a moment. That's all. That's all it was. Forgive me."

They stood like that. Below them the castle sang. Amelia could feel her mother's stillness, the particular stillness of someone holding a great deal very carefully. Under her own composure her blood was doing the thing it did when she was frightened, which was to wake. A low warmth rose in her wrists. It wanted, always, to be let up and out and used, and she had spent her whole life pressing it back down, because there was no one to use it on and nothing it was permitted to do.

"Tell me the treaty," her mother said into her hair, gently, an old game between them. "The way I taught it."

"You know I know the treaty."

"Tell me anyway. It steadies you. It always has."

So she told it, her cheek still against her mother's throat, in the low voice she had used as a child. No new vampires would be made. That was the whole of the peace, past the seals and the signatures. Her mother's fingers moved slowly in her hair while she spoke, keeping time, the way they had when the words were only a lesson and not yet a description of her own life. The courts had grown hungry once, generations back, and hunger had made them careless. They had made new blood without counting what it cost, until the shifter clans came down out of the hills and counted it for them, in a war neither side remembered fondly. At the end of it there was a treaty. It said the thing that caused the war would never be done again. No one

would be turned. The line of the blood would close where it stood and not grow by so much as a single new mouth.

"And what does the treaty say," her mother murmured, "about a vampire who is born, rather than made."

"Nothing. It says nothing, because everyone who signed it believed that was impossible. We do not have children. We have never had children. In a thousand years no one of our kind was born, only made, and so the men who wrote the peace did not think to forbid a thing they were certain could not happen."

"And here you are." Her mother drew back just far enough to look at her, and her eyes, which the whole court feared, were wet. "My impossible girl. Do you understand now why I hold you the way I do. They will not believe you were born, Amelia. That is the thing I need you to keep in your two hands and never set down. It does not matter that it's true. The truth of it is nothing out there. It cannot be proven and cannot be shown, and no one beyond that door wants it to be true, so it will not be true for them however you say it. What they will see is a new vampire. A young one, made in defiance of everything a hundred thousand people died to stop. And they will not send a letter. They will send an army."

"And you would let them," Amelia said.

"I would have no choice, which is a different thing, though I don't expect it to feel different from where you stand." Her mother took Amelia's hands and held them between her own cool ones. "A queen who starts a war to keep one girl is a queen for about a week, and then she is a story her enemies tell to frighten the next one, and the girl dies anyway, and so does everyone who stood near her. I have done the arithmetic every night of your life. I did it the night you were born, with you still slick in my arms and

screaming, before I had even finished being glad of you. It is the only sum I have never been able to make come out kind."

It should have frightened Amelia, hearing it said so plainly, her own life set on the scale and weighed and found wanting. Instead what closed her throat was that it did not sound like a threat at all. It sounded like a wound her mother had been carrying, uncomplaining, since the day she was born, so that Amelia would not have to carry it herself.

"Say it back to me," her mother said. "So I know you have it."

"I must not be," Amelia said.

"Good girl." Her mother kissed her once more, on the temple, and then, all in a breath, put the Queen back on, the way another woman might put on a coat to go out into weather. It went on smoothly. It did not reach her eyes. "The gown goes down tonight. Eat your supper. Do not stand at the window. I'll come to you tomorrow, when they've gone, and we won't speak of any of this, and you'll be glad of that. I love you more than the whole of the rest of the world put together, which is precisely the trouble. Good night, my heart."

"Good night, Mother."

The inner door closed. The outer bolt went across, low, and the echo came back off the stone a half-beat late, and by the quality of it Amelia could tell that her mother stood in the corridor a moment longer than she needed to before she walked away. Three seconds. Amelia counted them. Then the soft sure sound of her mother going, and gone, back down the stairs to be the coldest thing in a hall full of enemies, because she had spent all her warmth up here, in a locked room, on the one person she was never allowed to spend it on in the light.

Amelia sat on the edge of the bed for a long time in her shift with the grey gown folded over her knees.

Below her the castle went on singing to itself. Another carriage came in over the stone, the twelfth, and loosed its small bright pour of arrivals, and the great doors took them, and closed. Somewhere down there was a hall she had never entered, full of guests who had never heard her name, doing the ordinary enormous thing that living people did, which was to stand in a warm room and be known to one another. A stranger would step on a stranger's hem tonight and beg her pardon. A man would laugh too loudly and be forgiven. Two people who had never met would meet, and it would be nothing, and it would be everything, and neither of them would count it a miracle, because they had done it ten thousand times and did not know that anywhere in the world there was a girl for whom it was the one impossible act.

She thought about her mother's arithmetic. She was good at arithmetic. Her mother had made sure of that, along with the stillness and the languages and the recitation of a treaty with a hole in it exactly her own shape. A field full of the dead. Her face on the reason. She turned the sum over and looked at it from the back, the way she looked at everything, and she found that she believed every figure in it and that it changed nothing. That was the discovery of the night, the thing that came up in her, quiet and certain under the fear, a second pulse beneath the first.

Because her mother, who did not make errors, had made one. She had said: you must not be. She had meant it, and meant it out of love, which made it worse and not better. But a person standing on a floor is, whatever anyone prefers, a person who is. The not-being could not be arranged. It could only be requested, in a warm broken voice, by a woman who adored her and would let an army come for her all the same — and the cost of it had always been paid quietly, three floors

up, behind a good iron bolt, by the girl who did the sum and stayed.

She was not going to keep staying. She understood that now the way she understood the acoustics of a room, plainly, without drama. If she was going to be the reason, if there was truly no version of the world in which she cost nothing, then she would find out, once, before the counting began, what the thing was worth. She would stand in the warm room. She would be, in front of them, on purpose, and let the arithmetic fall out however it fell.

And it would break them. That was the part she made herself hold, sitting there, because she was not a child and she would not let herself pretend. It would break Della, who loved her and slid the bolt slowly. It would break her mother, who had spent every scrap of her warmth on her in the dark. She was not planning to escape cruel keepers. That would have been easy. She was planning to hurt the only people who had ever loved her. Their love was the lock on her door. She had decided, at twenty, that she would rather be seen once and pay for it than be adored her whole life and never exist.

Not tonight. Tonight the wound was too fresh and her mother's cool hands were still on her. She was her mother's daughter, and she did not do dangerous things in a heat.

But the shifters would be at the Queen's table for three days. There would be another night, and a way down, and Della's fondness that had never learned to refuse her anything, and a household so busy loving her and hiding her that it had never learned to watch her. She had the whole geography of her cage memorized. She had never thought of it as a map, because a map is a thing you make when you mean to go somewhere.

She began to make it without deciding to. The laundry stair that Della used, which had no bolt, because no one had

ever imagined the girl at the top of it wanting to go down. The three nights the hall would stand full and the household stretched to its last servant, every eye turned toward the important strangers and away from the one unimportant loved and locked door. A gown the color of winter water that could go missing on its way back down and be lost in the general disorder of a feast. She had spent years learning how not to be seen. It came to her now, at the glass, with her blood awake in her wrists, that the same skill that keeps a girl hidden is the skill that carries her out, and that her mother had taught it to her stone by stone, and that it had simply never occurred to either of them that the pupil might one day want the lesson for herself.

She put her cold fingertips to the colder window she had been told not to stand at, and stood at it. The courtyard lay below in its skin of light, and the lit hall threw long gold shapes across the stone, and small warm careless figures moved in the gold, arriving still. Her blood lay awake and low in her wrists, and for once she did not press it down. If anything it was company, the one part of her that had never agreed to be smaller, and she let it lie there, awake, hers.

Below her the castle went on filling with people who would have called her impossible. She watched them come. Somewhere in that gold, or somewhere still out on the dark road, was the first stranger she would ever walk up to as a stranger. She did not know whose face it would be. She found she did not need to know. She only needed there to be one, out of all of them, and there would be. A house this full could not hold every door against one girl who had spent her whole life learning doors.

Then she turned from the window, laid the grey gown out flat for Della to carry back down, and settled in to lie awake and make her plans, very quietly and very well.

CHAPTER TWO

The Servants' Passages

Twice a week, for one hour, Amelia was allowed to be dangerous.

Her mother came for her herself. She never sent anyone. On the mornings they trained she arrived early, before the house was properly awake, and drew back the bolt with her own hand and stood in the doorway already out of her court clothes, in a plain dark dress with her sleeves turned back to the elbow, and she looked, in that hour and no other, a woman who did honest work with her hands.

"Come," she said. "While the corridor's ours."

They went the private way. There was a door behind the tapestry in Amelia's dressing room, and behind the door a stair that went down inside the thickness of the wall, narrow, unlit, cut for no purpose anyone living remembered. Amelia had walked it so often she did not need a lamp. She counted the steps out of habit. Forty-one down, a turn, nineteen more, and then the low door into the old north gallery, where the disused lamps were kept and the air had not changed in a hundred years.

She loved it there. It was the one room in the castle that was hers by use and not by permission. It smelled of beeswax and cold stone, and it had no windows, and its walls gave a voice back at nine parts in ten, almost whole, so that a word spoken in it hung a moment before it let you go.

Nothing said in it reached the house above. That was why her mother had chosen it. You could do a lot of harm in a room like that and the house above would sleep through all of it.

Her mother lit two candles and set them on the stone floor an arm's length apart and sat down cross-legged behind them, and Amelia sat facing her, and it began the way it always began.

"Wake it," her mother said. "Slowly. I want to see you find the bottom of it, not the top."

Amelia set her hands palm up on her knees and let her blood come awake.

It was not lighting a lamp. It was nearer to remembering something she had spent all week forgetting. The warmth started deep in her wrists, where the pulse ran nearest the skin, and rose, and she did not grab at it. She had learned better than to grab. She let it fill her hands the way water fills a cupped palm, patient, until her fingers ached with it and the candle flames a foot away leaned toward her without being told.

"There," her mother said softly. "Do you feel the two of them? The flames."

"Yes."

"Tell me what they are to you."

"Warm," Amelia said. "Small. Alive, almost. They pull on the same thread the blood pulls on." She turned one hand a degree, and the nearer flame stretched thin and tall and hungry, reaching for her wrist. She turned it back and the flame sat down again. "This one wants to come to me. It doesn't know it would go out if it did."

"Because you would take the heat out of it. Everything that lives runs on heat, and yours knows how to ask for it, and most things are lonely enough to answer. That is the whole of your gift, when you strip the fear off it. You ask, and

warm things answer, and if you are not careful you empty them." Her mother's voice stayed even and low and did not carry past the two of them. "Put them out. Both at once. Not with your breath."

Amelia drew the warmth in.

She felt the candles die against her palms, two small cold absences, and the smoke went up thin and grey and the gallery went dark except for the faint grey seam of the low door. In the dark her blood roared happily in her hands, glad of the meal, wanting more, and there was more everywhere, there was a whole warm sleeping castle of more three walls away, and for one long breath Amelia sat very still and did not reach for any of it, and that was the part her mother was really teaching. Not the taking. The not-taking.

"Good girl," her mother said in the dark. "Put it back down. All the way. I'll wait."

It took longer than the waking. It always did. Amelia pressed the warmth back down her arms into her wrists, into the deep place it lived, coaxing where she could not force, and when it was down she felt the ordinary cold of the room come back over her skin, and she was only a girl in a dark room again, tired, her hands empty.

"Now the hard one," her mother said, and reached behind her and brought out a shallow bowl of water she had carried down herself, and in the bowl a single small fish went round and round, a plain silver thing from the kitchen ponds. She set it on the floor between them. "Find it. Only find it. You are not to touch a hair of its heat, do you hear me, not the smallest thread. I want you to hold a living thing in your gift and give it nothing and take nothing and simply know it is there. That is the whole of the lesson. Anyone can empty a candle. It takes a grown woman to stand next to something alive and keep her hands to herself."

Amelia woke her blood again, lower this time, careful, and reached out with it the way you reach a hand into dark water, slowly, so as not to startle what is in it. And there it was. The fish came into her the way a lit window comes into a dark street, a small bright certainty of warmth turning circles, its tiny heart going very fast, frightened of the bowl and the dark and the two great cold presences bent over it. She could feel exactly how easy it would be. One thread. The fish would not even understand what had happened to it. It would only slow, and settle, and stop, and she would be warm.

She held it, and gave it nothing, and took nothing.

"Good," her mother breathed. "Oh, that is good. Longer. Feel how it wants you to. That wanting is not the fish. That wanting is you, and it will lie to you your whole life, and it will always sound like mercy. Let it go."

Amelia drew her gift back out of the water and left the small frightened life exactly as she had found it, going round and round, whole. Her hands were shaking. She put them flat on the cold stone until they stopped.

Her mother relit the candles from a third she had kept burning by the door, and in the new light she was watching Amelia with the expression that was not pride and was not fear but sat somewhere between, the look of a person handling something that could cut her and choosing to hold it anyway.

"You're stronger than I was at your age," she said. "I've told you that before. I want you to hear it a different way today, because of the house being what it is this week." She reached across the candles and took Amelia's tired hands in her own cool ones and turned them over, studying the palms for a mark the gift might have left that she could read. "There is nothing out there tonight that could take you, Amelia. Do you understand me. Not a room of shifters, not a

hall of them. If they laid hands on you, you could still every heart in that hall before the first of them finished drawing his knife, and some part of you knows it, and that is precisely why you must never be in the room. Not because you are weak. Because you are not. A weak thing they would only kill. A strong thing they will build a war on. You are the most dangerous person under this roof, and it is the reason you must live like the least."

She said it plainly, without drama, the way she gave Amelia the things she most needed to keep. And Amelia, who had been handled since childhood like something breakable, sat in the dark and heard herself named, for once, as what she actually was, and found that it did not comfort her at all. It only made the walls a different shape. She had thought of the cage all her life as protection. Her mother had just told her, kindly, that it was a muzzle.

"And the other way," Amelia said. She turned her palms up under her mother's cool ones. "If I could still every heart in that hall — could I hold one? Keep a thing from dying, the way you keep the peace?"

Her mother did not answer at once, and when she did there was a care in it Amelia had not heard before. "No. Not yet, and not for years, and it is the one part of this you must never get wrong." She pressed a thumb to the inside of Amelia's wrist, over the pulse. "Taking is easy. It is the easiest thing your blood knows. A candle, a fish, a man — they all go out the same way, by degrees, and you could learn the whole of it in a morning. Holding a life inside a body that means to leave it, catching a fast wound before it empties, holding the blood in when every drop of it is running for the door — that is the slow craft, and it took me the better part of a thousand years, and I am still not always quick enough. You have the strength for it now. You have none of the hours. Never stand over a dying thing and think that because you

are strong you can keep it. Strength stops. Only craft catches, and craft is only time, and time is the one thing I have never found a way to hand you with the rest."

"Never a person," her mother said, the old rule, the last thing she said every time. "You may practice on a flame, on a fish, on the cold, on anything with no name. Never a person. Not to save yourself, not to save me, not for anything. The day you reach into a living person and take, you will find out how easy it is, and you will not be able to unlearn the ease of it, and it will start to want people the way it wants the candle now. Promise me."

"I promise," Amelia said, as she did every time, and meant it, as she did every time. She did not know yet how easily she would break it. She only knew, from twenty years of study, exactly how walls came down.

Her mother kissed her hands and let them go. From somewhere far above, muffled by forty feet of stone, a bell began to ring the hour, and her mother's face changed at the sound, the plain honest morning-woman folding away and the Queen coming back into it by the line of the jaw first and then the eyes, until she was again the coldest thing the castle owned.

"That's mine gone," she said, and stood, and shook out her turned-back sleeves. "There are three of their clan-heads I have to be gracious to before noon, and one of them believes I had his cousin killed, which I did, so it will be a delicate sort of morning." She almost smiled. "Maren will take you up. Stay to the low ways, the house is thick with strangers and half of them are wandering where they've no business. Eat something. I'll come to you tonight if I can, and if I can't it's because I couldn't, and not because I didn't want to. You know the difference."

"I know the difference."

"Say it isn't cruelty."

"It isn't cruelty," Amelia said. "It's the only love you're permitted to give me."

Her mother stopped at the low door with her hand on the frame, and for a moment the Queen slipped again and something raw looked out of her, there and then gone, and she went up the private stair without another word, because there were things even she could not carry and go on standing.

Amelia sat alone in the beeswax dark until Maren came for her.

Maren came the servants' way, which was the other door, the one that let onto the back of the house where the walls were rough and unhung and the stone still bore the chisel marks of men six hundred years dead. She came with a covered plate balanced on one hand and a candle in the other and a look on her face that Amelia read before she was through the door, because she had been reading Maren's face since they were both small enough to hide under the same table.

"You've been at it," Maren said. It was not a question, and it was not quite approval. Maren had opinions about the training she was too loyal to the Queen to say and too fond of Amelia to hide. "You've the grey look. Sit down before you fall down and eat this while it's warm, and don't tell me you're not hungry, because I carried it up four flights and I'll be offended."

Amelia ate. It was bread and soft cheese and a boiled egg and three of the almond cakes that were meant for the hall, and Maren watched her eat every bite of it with the particular satisfaction of a person who has only one thing she is allowed to do for someone and does it fiercely. They had been raised together, more or less. Maren was two years older and human and the daughter of a woman who had served the Queen before her, and where Amelia had been

given languages and stillness and the treaty, Maren had been given the run of the house and the truth of Amelia at the same age, and had kept both, and had never in nineteen years let the second one slip. She was the nearest thing to a sister Amelia had. She was also, by every law the world outside recognized, a servant carrying a plate. Both things were true and they had long ago stopped bothering to choose between them when no one was watching.

"It's madness up there," Maren said, sitting on the cold floor beside her, drawing her knees up. "You've never seen the like. There's a shifter lord in the east wing who brought his own cook, because he won't eat vampire food. The two cooks have already had two fights and a reconciliation. And there's a boy, a shifter boy, one of the chief's own people they say, who got so turned around in the west stair last night that he ended in the still-room. He frightened the life out of Bess. She threw a ham at him." She said it easily, the way she talked about the surface of things, but her hands had found the hem of her apron and were folding it and unfolding it, and Amelia watched the hands and not the face, because the hands were where Maren kept the truth she wasn't saying. "It's a great deal of them, Amelia. Under one roof. I don't like a house this full. I won't say it's dangerous. I'll only say I've counted the silver twice this morning and it still came out one spoon short, and a short count in a full house is how trouble starts, and I don't like it."

"You always count the silver when you're frightened."

"I'm not frightened. I'm careful. They're not the same, whatever you think, and one of them keeps you alive longer." Maren stopped folding the apron. She looked at Amelia for a moment, straight on, in a way the household had trained itself out of, and there was the old fear in it, the one that had nothing to do with silver. "You've got a look of your own this morning, come to that. I've known that look

since you were nine and decided you were going to teach yourself to read the guards' lips through the bars. You're planning something. Don't tell me you're not, I can see it sitting on you."

Amelia did not answer at once. She was very good at not answering. She had learned it in the same school as the stillness.

"Show me the way up," she said instead. "The long way. Through the passages. I want to walk it today."

Maren's face did a complicated thing. "You want to walk it."

"You've always taken me the low ways. I've never been the one to choose the turnings. Show me. Let me lead and you correct me. It's the only house I'll ever have, Maren. I'd like to know it in my feet, not just my ears."

It was true, and it was not the whole truth, and Maren heard both, because Maren always heard both. But it was also the kind of small sad wish that Maren, in all their years together, had never yet had it in her to deny her, and Amelia knew it, and used it, and hated herself a little for using it, and used it anyway.

"Stay off the main galleries," Maren said at last, getting to her feet, holding down a hand. "Stay off any hall with a window on the courtyard side. If we meet anyone, you're a girl I've sent for extra linen, you keep your head down and your hair covered and you let me do the talking, and if it goes wrong you have never seen me before in your life. Say it."

"If it goes wrong I've never seen you before in my life."

"You'd say it and mean the opposite, which is the trouble with you." Maren pulled her up. "Cover your hair. That's the thing they'd remember. Come on, then. Lead, and I'll pull your collar when you're about to walk us into a wall."

They went out through the servants' door into the back of the house, and Amelia began, for the first time in her life, to walk her own cage on purpose.

It was a different country back there. She had been carried and led through it all her life, half-asleep or hurried, and she had never been allowed to simply move through it at her own pace and look. The passages ran inside and behind the grand rooms, close and plain and busy, the way veins run behind a face, and they were full of the ordinary traffic of a house feeding two hundred strangers, girls with armloads of pressed linen and boys bent under water yokes and an old man mending a hinge who did not look up. No one looked up. In the passages a covered head and a lowered face were the most ordinary things in the world, and Amelia walked through the middle of the whole loud living machine of the castle entirely unseen, and understood, with a lift in her chest she was careful not to let show, that being no one was not only a sentence. It was also a skill, and she had been perfecting it since before she could walk.

They met the shifter on the second landing.

He came down the passage toward them out of a cross-corridor, a big man in travelling leather with the road still on him, in the wrong part of the house and not caring. Here was someone who had grown up never having to make himself small. He filled the passage. The smell of him came ahead of him, woodsmoke and horse and something under that, a warm animal wrongness that Amelia had no name for because she had never yet stood close to one of them, and every hair on her arms stood up at it. Maren did not break stride. Maren put herself half a step ahead and dropped her eyes to the polite middle distance a servant keeps, and Amelia did the same a beat behind her, head down, the linen story ready in her mouth.

"You," the man said. "Girl. Which way to the east wing from here? Your stairs are built by madmen."

"Up two and along the gallery, my lord, the way you would have come," Maren said, to his boots. "This is the back of the house. There is nothing down here but linen and us."

He did not move on. She kept her face down and her covered head bowed, and his look moved over her, slow and unhurried, the way eyes go over a thing they cannot quite place. And under her ribs her blood came awake on its own, without her asking it, fast and glad and terrible. It had just spent an hour learning what a living thing feels like from the inside, and here was a great warm careless one an arm away. She could feel his heart. It was slow and strong and sure of itself. One thread. He would not even understand.

She put it down.

It was the hardest thing she had ever done and it took everything the fish had taught her and her whole mind went flat and cold and quiet doing it, the way a frozen pond goes quiet, every feeling on it iced over so that the one cold working part of her could do the work. She pressed the warmth down out of her hands, down her arms, into her wrists, and held it there shaking while the shifter lord looked at a girl sent for linen and found nothing worth the trouble. Whatever his kind could catch, it was blunted in the human shape he wore, and a covered servant with her eyes down was beneath the noticing of a man like him.

"Madmen," he said again, to no one, and went up the stair three steps at a time and was gone, and the warm animal wrongness of him went with him.

Maren let out a breath. "That," she said, low and unsteady, "is exactly what I mean about a full house. Come on. Quickly now, and do not tell me your heart is not going, because mine is fit to come out my mouth." She did not know the half of what had almost happened on the landing.

She never would. Amelia walked on with her hands fisted in her skirts until they stopped trembling, and did not tell her, and added the thing quietly to the growing list of what she carried alone.

She counted everything. She counted the turnings and the stairs and the doors that had bolts and the doors that had none. She rated the stairwells as they climbed them, and she found what she had come to find on the third flight, a narrow service stair that ran the whole height of the house on the north side, unlit, its walls so close and rough they swallowed a voice almost whole. A stair like that carried nothing. You could go up or down it at any hour and the house on the other side of the wall would hear a mouse and not a girl. It let out, Maren showed her without knowing she was showing her anything, three floors down at a plain door that gave onto the passage behind the great hall, close enough to the kitchens that a body coming through it would be taken for kitchen traffic and no one's business at all.

"And where does that go?" Amelia asked, keeping her voice bored, the way you ask about a thing you don't care about. She nodded at the plain door at the bottom, still two floors below them.

"The hall passage. The servers' door. You don't want that, that's the worst of the crush." Maren steered her up and away from it, back toward the safe high ways, and never knew that she had just handed Amelia the last piece of the thing, the door between the dark stair and the lit hall, the seam in the wall of the world she had been measuring her whole life. "Come up, it's this way. And slow down, you're walking like you're late for something, and a girl in the passages is never late for anything, that's how you get looked at." She kept talking as they climbed, low and fast, the way she did when a fright was still working its way out of her. About the cook, who had wept over a fallen tower of

spun sugar and then been talked round by the pastry girl and was now, apparently, singing. About the shifter customs nobody had warned the household of, the way they would not sit with their backs to a door, the way one old woman among them had refused a silver cup and asked for wood, and no one knew whether it was an insult to give her silver or an insult to take it back, and so the whole high table was being reset in a hurry. About her sister in the laundry who was sweet on one of the grooms and would not be told. It was nothing, all of it, the ordinary foam on the surface of a working house, and Amelia drank it in the way she drank everything Maren brought her, because it was the only weather she got of the world, secondhand, carried up four flights and handed over with the bread.

Amelia slowed down. She let Maren draw her up and away, back toward the bolt and the good grey room where nothing carried out, and she kept her face bored and her head down and her hair covered, and inside she was folding the map closed and putting it away where even she would have to work to find it again.

At the top, at her own door, Maren stopped with her hand on the bolt and did not throw it. She stood a moment, and Amelia saw the older girl gather herself the way people did before they said a thing that cost them.

"I owe her my life," Maren said quietly. "The Queen. You know that. You know why she won't feed on me and won't say why, and lets me alone when she takes from every other human in this house as her right. She spared me when I was too small to remember it, for a reason she has never told me, and I have spent every day since paying it back, and I would pay it back with my life and think it a fair price." She looked at Amelia, and her plain kind face was wretched. "And I love you more than her. That's the whole of it, and it's the worst thing about me, and I'd never say it in a room with a door

that carried. Whatever you're planning, Amelia. I won't say don't. I've never said no to you, not once, not ever. I'll only say that the day you make me choose between the debt and the love, one of them is going to break, and it won't be the love, and I am so afraid of the shape my life takes after that."

Amelia almost told her then. It came all the way up into her mouth, the whole of it, the stair and the hours and the grey gown that could go missing, because if anyone alive had earned the truth of her it was this woman on the wrong side of a bolt she hated. But telling Maren would only hand her the choice a day early, and make her carry it a day longer, and Amelia had lived her whole life being loved by people who were made to carry her. She swallowed it back down, the way she swallowed everything, and kept her friend clean of it one more day.

She eased the bolt across. The people who loved Amelia all did it the same way, gentle, reluctant, careful with a thing that did not deserve their care.

"Eat the other cakes," she said, not looking at her. "You're too thin, and it worries the cook, and she's got enough on."

And she went, and the bolt was between them again, and Amelia stood in the middle of her beautiful room with a full map in her head and the taste of almond in her mouth and a promise to her mother she meant to break and a promise to Maren she had not been asked to make and could not have kept if she had. She had come up the passages to steal the route out. She had not expected to be handed, on the same stair, the exact price of using it, named plainly by the one person kind enough to say it to her face.

She sat down on the edge of the bed. Below her, down in the lit part of the house, the strangers were waking into the second day of the feast, and somewhere among them a boy who had frightened Bess in the still-room was being no one at his own table, and Amelia did not know him and would

not have cared if she had. She had her own arithmetic to do. She turned the new figure over, the one Maren had set down — one of them is going to break, and it won't be the love — and found that it did not change the sum, only what the sum cost. She had always known it would cost everything. Knowing the pieces of it did not make it lighter to carry.

She ate the other cakes. Maren had carried them up four flights. It would have been unkind to waste them, and Amelia was not cruel, whatever else she was about to become.

When she had finished she went to the wardrobe and opened the door and looked, not at herself this time, but at the plain grey stone of the wall behind the glass, and behind that the stair, and behind that the whole counted length of the house dropping away beneath her to a lit door beside the kitchens. Everything she needed was there now except the nerve, and the nerve she would find the way she had found the rest of it, quietly, alone, over the two days she had left. She closed the wardrobe. Somewhere below her a great house was learning the manners of its enemies and reseating its high table and singing over spun sugar, and she was going to walk down into the middle of it and be a person, once, before it cost her everyone. She lay down on top of the covers in her clothes, because she did not intend to sleep, and she began to go over the turnings in the dark behind her eyes, one by one, until she knew them well enough to walk them blind.

CHAPTER THREE

Unshifted

Nobody in the whole retinue could build a fire worth spitting on, and Korvan had decided, somewhere around the third night out of the hills, that the shame of it would put him in the ground before the shifting ever got the chance.

He crouched at the ruin of the one Harl had made and did not say anything for a while, because there were things you could say to a grown wolf-clan man about his fire and things you could not, and Korvan had never in the whole of his life managed to work out which was which in time. Harl had built it angry at the wood. Great split logs stacked square and tight, no throat to it, no way for the air to climb, so that it sat there smoking and sulking and giving off about as much heat as a wet dog. Everyone in the clan built a fire the same way and they all did it wrong and not one of them would be told.

"It won't draw," Korvan said. He couldn't help it. It came out of him the way it always did, in spite of everything, in spite of the flat morning he'd had. "Harl. It won't draw, look at it, you've choked it. You've built it like a wall. A fire's not a wall, it wants to breathe, you have to leave it a throat."

"It's a fire," said Harl. "It's on. What more do you want off a fire."

"I want it to be warm, which is the whole entire point of a fire, and yours is a smoke machine with ambitions." Korvan

was already pulling the top logs off, because he could not physically leave it alone, his hands went at it without asking him. "Give me that kindling. No, the dry stuff, the stuff you were saving for no reason. You lay a little house first, see, with a door in it. You leave the fire somewhere to go."

Harl watched him rebuild it with the tolerant flat patience the whole clan kept for Korvan, the patience you spend on a dog that does a clever trick. The flames climbed up clean and yellow through the little house he'd made and the heat came off it in a good hard wave. Harl grunted, which was as close as Harl came to being impressed, and said, "You've a gift for it." Then he heard what he'd said. Both of them looked at the fire and not at each other, because the one thing Korvan had a gift for was the one thing no one was supposed to say out loud, on account of it being the only gift he had.

Nineteen years old. Twenty, near enough, come the next moon. And the only fire in him was the kind you had to light with your hands.

He warmed those hands at Harl's rebuilt fire and did not think about it, in the hard practised way he had of not thinking about it, which mostly amounted to pressing the bruise to check it still hurt.

The retinue was forty strong and Korvan was the only one in it with no second shape. He'd worked it out on the first day and there was no unworking it. Forty shifters and one boy. Bear-clan and wolf-clan mostly, a few of the cats, one old woman from the deer-clan who'd come along to say the words at the banquet and who looked at Korvan sometimes with an expression he'd stopped trying to read because reading it did nothing good for him. Every one of them had stood under a full moon at the right age and felt the thing come up and turn them inside out into what they were always meant to be. Every one of them had a clan and a

name and a shape and a place at a fire that was theirs by blood.

And Korvan had a father who was the chief of all of them, and no animal at all, which in his people was not poverty. It was something stranger and worse. He was a rumour. He was a thing that shouldn't happen and had, standing at the fire of a morning being a question nobody wanted to ask out loud.

"You're doing the face," Selwyn said, dropping down beside him with two mugs and handing one over. "The thinking face. You know it frightens the horses."

"I'm not doing a face. This is just my face."

"It's a terrible face, then, and I'm sorry for you, and for anyone who has to look at it." Selwyn drank. Selwyn was Korvan's age and bear-clan and had shifted dead on time at sixteen, easy as breathing, and had not once in the four years since made Korvan feel the difference, which was the entire reason Korvan could stand to be near him. He was broad and slow-moving and slow-talking and he said obvious things in the tone of a man delivering hard-won wisdom off a mountain. "Here's the thing about that fire, though," he said now, nodding at it. "It's better than the last one. That's the thing about fires. Some are better than others."

"That's the deepest thing anyone's ever said to me."

"I have a lot of them. It's from all the thinking." He fished in his coat and brought out a thing and turned it over in his big fingers, a little carved horse the length of a thumb, worn smooth. He'd bought it off a boy in the last village for more than it was worth, the way he bought something useless in every village they passed, a button or a knife with no edge or a stone with a hole in it, and stowed it in a coat that clanked when he walked. "Got this off a lad in Coombe. Look at it. It's rubbish. I love it."

"You've a whole coat of rubbish."

"I've a whole coat of things nobody else wanted," Selwyn said, with dignity, "which is different," and put the horse away with the rest of it. He did not say the thing Korvan knew was sitting under all of it. Selwyn was betrothed to a girl in the high steadings he'd met twice and did not love and could not get out of, and every mile of this road toward the vampire castle was a mile he did not have to spend at home being sold into a marriage he dreaded. They were a fine pair for a wedding party. The boy who couldn't turn into anything and the boy who was about to be turned into a husband. Neither of them said it. It sat there between them, comfortable, the way the true things sat between men who liked each other well enough not to make each other hold them.

The camp was coming apart around them, tents down, horses grumbling, the whole slow business of a clan getting itself back onto a road. And across the churn of it Korvan watched a thing he'd been half-watching for three days and could not make himself stop watching, which was young Tam of the wolf-clan being clapped on the back.

Tam had shifted a month ago. Fifteen and a bit, right on time, come up under his first moon a wolf and woken a wolf-clan man, and he had that new-minted glow on him still, that shine a boy gets when the whole world has just told him what he is and the answer was good. His uncles kept finding reasons to touch him. A hand on the neck, a cuff round the ear, come here, sit by me, you did well, you did just exactly what a boy of ours does. Tam pretended to hate it and did not hate it. Nobody hated it. That was the whole of belonging, right there in the churn of a breaking camp. Somebody's hand on your neck saying you did just exactly what one of ours does.

Korvan felt the old thing come up his throat, and he did with it what he always did, which was turn it into a joke before it could turn into anything worse.

"Tam!" he called, bright, across the camp, and Tam looked over, and every uncle round him looked over, and Korvan grinned at the boy with his whole face and cupped his hands and shouted, "You're still doing it wrong, you know. The howling. You sound like a gate." And he tipped his head back and did it, a long joke-howl, terrible, cracking in the middle, and the wolf-clan men laughed, because it was funny, because Korvan was funny, that was the thing Korvan was instead of the thing he wasn't, and Tam went red and laughed and howled back twice as bad, and for a second it was warm, it was almost like being one of them, it was the joke doing the work the shape was supposed to do.

And under the laughing, where nobody could see it, the wanting sat in Korvan like a swallowed stone. He would have given his right hand to have an uncle put a palm on his neck and say you did just exactly what one of ours does. He didn't have an uncle. He had a father, and his father was the chief, and the chief did not do necks.

"That was cruel," Selwyn said, comfortably, watching Tam.

"That was kind. I made him feel like a wolf. Nothing makes a boy feel more of a wolf than being told his howling's a disgrace. You wouldn't understand, you shift into furniture."

"I shift into a bear."

"You shift into furniture that can walk. I've seen you. You lie down and you're a rug." But his heart wasn't in it, and Selwyn heard that it wasn't, and did the kind thing, which was to let it go and drink his tea and say nothing, which was the only kind of thing Selwyn could reliably be trusted to do exactly right.

They were three days from the vampire castle. Korvan had never seen a vampire and did not much want to. His whole life the word had meant the same as the word war, more or less, the two of them wound so tight together in every story his people told that he could not think one without the other coming up behind it. And now his father was taking forty of his best down out of the hills to sit at the cold Queen's table and eat her food and smile, under the treaty, because the treaty was the thing that kept the war in the past tense, and a chief who wanted it to stay there went and smiled at his enemy across a banquet once a generation and called it peace.

Korvan was coming because his father had told him to come, and his father did not explain himself, and Korvan had learned a long time ago not to make him.

He found the chief by the horses, as he always found him, because his father did not sit at fires he did not have to sit at. The chief was checking the girths himself, which he did not need to do, which there were forty people to do for him, and did himself anyway, running a flat hand under each strap and along each animal's barrel, slow, feeling for the sore place, the loose buckle, the thing the men would have missed. He was a big weathered slab of a man gone grey at the temples and he moved the way old strong things move, without hurry, sure the world would wait for him because it always had. His father did not look up when Korvan came to stand beside him. He never did. He knew Korvan's step by the sound of it.

There was a horse his father would not ride, and never had, and the not-riding of it was one of the oldest facts of Korvan's life. A big quiet roan gelding, sound as a bell, sweet-tempered, the best animal in the whole string, and his father would sooner walk. It came along on every journey. It carried packs. It was groomed and shod and fed exactly like

the rest, and his father ran a flat hand along its barrel same as the others and checked its girth and lifted its feet, and would not put a leg over it. Never had. Had never, in all of Korvan's hearing, said a word as to why. Korvan had asked, when he was small and did not yet know the shape of the things you didn't ask, and his father had looked at the roan a while and said, "A man's allowed one thing he doesn't explain," and that had been the whole of it, then and every time since. Everyone in the clan knew about the roan. Nobody knew the reason. It was the single crack in a man who was otherwise all one weathered piece, and Korvan had worried at it his whole childhood the way you worry a loose tooth, and got nowhere, and come in the end to a kind of truce with it. There was a door in his father that had been shut Korvan's whole life. He had long since stopped trying the handle.

"She's favouring the off fore," the chief said, of the grey mare. "Tell Harl. Not the shoe. Higher. He'll want to look at it tonight before it's a real thing."

"I'll tell him."

His father moved on to the next horse. There were two of them and forty animals and a whole cold morning, and Korvan stood in it beside the only family he had left in the world and looked for a way in, the way he was always looking for a way in, feeling along the man for the sore place, the loose buckle, exactly the way his father felt along the horses.

"Three days out," Korvan said. "You think they'll have decent stabling? For this many."

"They'll have stabling."

"Because these hill horses won't stand tied in the wet, you know how the grey gets."

"I know how the grey gets." A long pause. His father's hand moved along a bay's neck. "It won't be wet. Wind's backing round east. It'll be clear and cold by the time we're

down, and hard frost the nights, which is worse for the men and better for the horses, and there's nothing in that either of us can do, so there's no use you and me standing here arranging the weather between us." Which was the chief all over. You asked him about the stabling and he answered you about the sky, and somewhere in the sky was the answer to the thing you'd actually asked, if you were clever enough to find it, and Korvan mostly wasn't. What his father had said was, I know what you're doing, and stop, and I love you, and stop. All of it folded up in the wind backing round east.

"Right," Korvan said. "The weather. Good talk. Glad we had it."

And his father did a thing then that he did about twice a year, which was that the corner of his hard mouth moved, not a smile, the ghost of the place a smile would go, and he said, without looking up from the horse, "You built a good fire this morning. I saw it from here. Best in the camp." And then, because he was who he was and could not leave a warm thing warm, "Don't tell Harl I said so. He'll sulk for a week and I need him useful."

It shouldn't have done what it did to Korvan, a scrap like that, a compliment about a fire from a man who wouldn't touch his neck. But it went into him warm and stayed, and he had to look hard at the grey mare's off fore for a moment so his father wouldn't see what a little kindness could do to a boy who was rationed them.

Standing there, he was small and in the river again. Five or six he'd been, and his father teaching him the water the hard clan way, one broad hand flat under Korvan's belly holding him up while he thrashed, and Korvan had been shrieking with the joy and the fear of it, and then at some point, without a word, without any warning at all, the hand was gone. His father had taken the hand away. And Korvan had gone under and come up and gone under and come up

furious and terrified and swimming, actually swimming, because the hand was gone and there was nothing else to do. He'd hated his father for it for about a day. He'd understood it later, or thought he had. His father let go so the boy would learn to hold himself up. It was the kind of thing his father did instead of saying he loved you. It was, Korvan thought, more or less the whole man, that one flat hand and the taking of it away.

His mother would have kept hold. He didn't remember her well enough to be sure of much, but he was sure of that. She'd died when he was seven of a fever that went through the high steadings one bad winter and took a quarter of them, and his father had buried her and come back down the hill and gone straight to the lambing because it was the lambing season and lambs did not wait on grief, and that, too, was more or less the whole man. Stay alive. Do the next thing. Grieve later, in some later that a man like that never quite got around to reaching. There'd been just the two of them ever since. A chief and his one boy who wouldn't turn. Not much of a clan. But it was the one Korvan had.

"Go on," his father said. "You're in my light. And put a coat on, you'll catch your death dressed like that, and then I'll have raised you nineteen years for the worms, and I'll be annoyed."

Korvan went. He'd gone about ten steps when his left leg cramped.

It came up the back of his calf sudden and vicious, a hot wire pulling tight. He stopped dead. His whole body went cold and still around it, because this was how it started, wasn't it. This was how they all said it started. A heat. A wrongness in the body. A thing coming up in you that wasn't you. His heart slammed once and he stood frozen in the churning camp with his hands half up, thinking here, now, in front of everyone, please, not in front of everyone.

The cramp let go. It was a cramp. He'd slept wrong on the cold ground and stood up too fast, that was all, and he was a nineteen-year-old man standing rigid in the middle of a breaking camp with his fists up, frightened of his own leg.

He put his hands down. Nobody had seen. He breathed out slow through his teeth and rubbed the calf and called himself, silently and with feeling, every name he had.

It happened maybe twice a week now, this. A twinge, a heat, a flutter behind the breastbone, and every single time some animal part of him leapt up shouting now, this is it, and every single time it was a cramp or a stitch or too much cheese, and he was starting to understand that this was the true shape of being late. Not the not-being-a-wolf. The waiting. The way your own body turned into a door you kept mistaking for opening. Past seventeen people stopped talking about you where you could hear, which was worse, and started giving you the look the deer-clan woman gave you, the one that had a funeral in it.

Maybe it wasn't coming. Nobody said that part out loud either. Maybe the moon had looked at him and found nothing to turn.

"You all right?" Selwyn had drifted over, chewing something. "You went a funny colour. Funnier."

"Cramp," Korvan said. "I'm fine. Leg's plotting against me. I'll deal with it when it sleeps."

"That's the thing about legs," Selwyn began, and Korvan said, "Don't," and Selwyn, wounded, said, "I wasn't going to say anything profound," and Korvan said, "You've never not said something profound in your life, you can't help it, it's your curse," and it was easy again, it was the two of them again, and the fright of the leg went down under the ordinary warmth of a friend the way most things went down in Korvan, which was not away, just down.

They rode out an hour later, forty shifters and one boy and a chief who talked to the sky, down out of the last of the hills toward the flat cold country and the castle waiting in it.

They passed through a human village at midday, the first Korvan had seen close in three days, and it taught him something about the road they were on that his father had not troubled to.

The place emptied ahead of them. That was the thing. Word ran quicker than horses, and by the time the head of the column reached the first houses the street was bare, the doors shut, the animals brought in, a whole village of humans gone to ground behind shutters at the sound of forty shifters coming down off the hills. A child had been left too long at a well and was snatched back by a fist of skirt as they came round the bend, the mother's face white as a plate over the wall. Nobody threw anything. Nobody shouted. It was quieter than that, and worse. They rode through a street that had decided, all at once and without a word, to pretend it was not there, and Korvan understood for the first time in his life what his own people looked like from the outside. Not proud hill-clans keeping an old peace. A column of things that could stop being men.

He had grown up inside it and had never yet managed to see it from without. To him a shifter was Selwyn, was Harl and his terrible fires, was an uncle's hand on a boy's neck. To this village a shifter was the reason you brought the children in. And the treaty they were all riding down to honour, the cold careful thing that kept the war in the past tense, he saw of a sudden was not made of goodwill at all. It was made of exactly this. Humans behind shutters and vampires behind walls and hill-clans smiling at a banquet, every side frightened of every other, all of them only agreeing not to be the first to start it again.

"They think we'll eat them," Selwyn said, not joking now, watching a shutter twitch. "My gran used to tell it that way to frighten us good. Be a good boy or the beast-men come. And here we come, forty deep, right down their one street." He lifted a hand to the empty windows, an awkward small wave, half an apology. Nothing waved back. "It's a rotten feeling," he said. "Being the thing in the story."

"You get used to it," Korvan said, before he could stop himself, and Selwyn looked at him, because of course Korvan would know. Korvan had been the thing in the story his whole life. Only his story was told by his own people, and this one was told by strangers, and for a moment the two of them stood side by side in his head and he could not have said which was the lonelier.

And it was on that ride, an hour past the shuttered village, near the middle of the strung-out line, that Korvan first properly noticed the man called Loric.

He'd seen him before. Loric had been with the retinue since they'd left, a wolf-clan man of middle years, quiet, tidy, the sort of man your eye slid off because he never did anything to catch it. But Korvan noticed him now because Loric had dropped his horse back alongside Korvan's without seeming to, the way a leaf comes to rest beside you without seeming to choose the spot at all, and rode there a while saying nothing, and then said, pleasantly, looking at the road ahead and not at Korvan, "It's a hard thing they do to you. Making you come to this."

Korvan didn't answer. He'd learned not to answer openings like that.

"I only mean," Loric went on, in the mildest voice in the world, "a banquet like this, it's all shapes, isn't it. All the clans at their tables by their animals, everyone knowing exactly where they sit. And they've brought the one man among them who hasn't got a table. It seems unkind, to me.

To make you stand in a room built entirely out of the thing you haven't got. I wouldn't have done it to you. But then I'm not the chief, and the chief has his reasons, and I'm sure they're good ones." He let that sit. His boots, Korvan noticed, were the cleanest boots in the whole muddy line, polished to a shine on a road that had no business leaving anything shined. "I only ask because it seems no one else does. Are you all right, going down there? Truly?"

And the maddening thing, the thing Korvan turned over for the rest of the cold ride, was that it was the kindest thing anyone in the retinue had said to him in three days. Selwyn made him laugh and his father praised his fires, but not one of them had looked straight at the sore place and asked him, gently, does that hurt. Only this quiet tidy stranger with the clean boots had done that. It had the feel of being seen, and it felt good. And some careful part of Korvan, the part that had spent nineteen years learning to read a room he was barely allowed in, filed it away uneasy and did not know why, and rode on toward the castle with the kindness sitting wrong in him, warm and wrong, the way the first bite of something gone-off is still sweet before you understand what your mouth is telling you.

The castle came up out of the flat country at dusk. It was bigger than anything Korvan had ever seen made by hands, a black weight of stone against a green-going-grey sky, lit along its whole front with a warm gold that did not reach the road, and somewhere in it, he knew, ten thousand candles were being lit for people who were not him. His father rode at the head of the line and did not slow. Korvan rode near the middle beside a friend who couldn't help him and a stranger who wanted to, toward a house so full of belonging they had built it three storeys high to hold it all.

The closer they came the less it looked a place where people lived and the more a cliff somebody had put doors in.

Every window was lit and not one of them was warm. Korvan had built enough fires to know the difference between a light that means come in and sit down and a light that is only a light, and the whole vast front of the castle was the second kind, gold and high and cold, ten thousand candles saying we are not afraid of the dark and saying nothing at all about him.

There were figures at the gate. His first vampires. He had braced for monsters and got, instead, people. Tall pale still people in dark clothes who stood the way a held breath stands, too quiet, not shifting their weight, not doing any of the small restless things a body does without being asked. That was the wrongness of them, he decided, watching over his horse's ears. Not fangs. Stillness. They stood the way the roan his father would not ride stood, a thing that had learned to wait longer than you could. One of them turned its head and looked down the column, and its eyes went over Korvan and moved on, bored, and he felt the look land and lift, a cold hand laid on him and taken off again, and every animal instinct he had no shape to shift into stood up anyway along his arms.

His father rode toward them without slowing and lifted one hand, and the still pale people bowed, and the smiling began. The peace. The thing they had come three days to perform.

"Cheer up," Selwyn said beside him, looking at the castle. "Might be food."

"There'll be food," Korvan said. "It'll be terrible. Vampire food. What do they even eat."

"Us, mostly," said Selwyn, cheerful, "if the stories are right," and Korvan laughed, because it was that or the other thing, and the two of them rode down the last of the road into the gold with the rest of the clan that was not quite theirs, and the great doors opened to take them in. Korvan

ducked his head going under the arch, though he did not need to, the way you duck under a thing that has no business being as big as it is. Then the cold gold closed over him, and the smell of a thousand strangers, and he was inside.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Man Who Only Asks

The clans would not sleep in the castle, and the vampires, to their credit, had not made a fight of it.

They had been given the whole of the west court instead, a broad flat yard of old stone inside the outer wall, and by the first evening the chief's people had made it theirs in the way clan people made anything theirs, which was to pretend very hard they were somewhere else. Tents went up that nobody needed. Fires were lit in a yard that had a hundred warm rooms around it, and men who could have slept on feather beds rolled out on the ground on purpose, backs to the fires, faces to the one gate, the way you sleep when you do not trust the roof. It embarrassed him and made plain sense to him at once, which was more or less how most things his people did sat with him.

He got a fire going properly, because somebody had to, and then he sat at the edge of the light where he sat at every fire, near enough to be warm and far enough to be forgotten, and he listened.

Above the camp, over the top of the outer wall, the castle stood up into the night with every window lit, and the two lights could not have been less alike. Down here was the clan's light, forty little fires of hauled wood, red and low and smoky, throwing big shadows that moved. Up there was the vampires' light, ten thousand candles behind glass, steady

and gold and remote, high up and giving off no heat a man down in the yard could feel. Korvan sat between the two of them, in the cold strip of dark where neither reached, and thought that was about right. That was about exactly where they'd always put him. He fed his fire and did not warm at either.

That was the other thing Korvan was good at, besides the fires. Nobody watched what they said in front of the boy with no animal. He didn't count. He'd stopped minding it years ago and started using it, the way you use anything you're given, and so he sat at the edges of forty men's fires and heard the clan talk to itself the way it never talked where his father could hear.

Tonight it was talking about his father.

"—came down out of the hills like a summoned dog," a bear-clan man was saying, two fires over, not quietly. Old Doran, grey in the muzzle even as a man, one of the ones who'd fought the last war and would not let anyone forget he'd fought the last war. "His father would never. Old Marrek would've sent the Queen's messenger back without his ears and told her to come up the hills herself if she wanted a word. And now we sit in her yard and eat off her plates and call it peace, and the young ones think that's how it's always been."

"It's how it's been thirty years," someone said. Younger. Tired of hearing about the war. "Thirty years nobody's died of it. That's not nothing, Doran."

"Nobody's died of it yet." Doran spat into the fire. "Peace is just the part of the war where they're getting their strength back. You mark me. A vampire doesn't forget. They've got the time for grudges we haven't got, that's the whole horror of them. She's sitting up there in that pile of stone being patient, and patient is the most dangerous thing a

long-living thing can be, and our chief brought us down here to be gracious at her."

Nobody argued him down. That was the thing Korvan noticed, sitting where he always sat. A year ago they'd have argued Doran down. Tonight they let it sit, and watched the coals, and a couple of them nodded, and the not-arguing was louder than the argument would have been.

His father's grip was slipping. Korvan could hear it going, fire by fire, the first soft give of ice under a foot, that long groan before anything cracks.

Not everyone let it sit. A little later, when Doran got himself going again, a young wolf-clan fellow named Bret came up off the ground across the fire. Younger, one of the chief's, a steady sort who'd never said a memorable thing in his life. He told Doran to shut his mouth or take it to the chief's face like a man. And for a moment it was the old way, the two of them on their feet with the fire between and the camp waking up to watch. Bret said the chief had kept every soul here alive thirty years, and what had old Marrek's ears ever kept anybody. Doran said a live dog was not the same as a live man. Bret said better a live dog than a dead fool, and put a flat hand to Doran's chest, and shoved. Doran came back off his heel faster than a grey-muzzled man had any right to and swung, and it caught Bret on the ear, and then it was fists, the two of them locked and staggering into the fire's edge, coals kicking up in a spray of sparks, men on their feet shouting, somebody's blanket already smoking. It was the realest thing that had happened in the camp all night, and every man in it leaned toward the violence the way cold hands lean toward heat. Korvan was half up himself before he knew it, on the balls of his feet, his heart gone quick and eager at the promise of it, his hands already curled. It shamed him even as it moved him. A fight was the one thing his body had ever wanted on time, the one animal

answer it gave without being asked, and he hated that of everything it might have been, that was the instinct that came. Somebody stamped the smoking blanket out. Somebody hauled at Doran's arm and got an elbow for it.

And then it would not. Because Loric was there, somehow, already between them, not pushing, only there, a hand on each man's arm and something low in his mouth that Korvan couldn't catch, and both of them came down off it. And Loric was already turning it into a laugh, clapping Bret's shoulder, agreeing with Doran, sending Bret off to cool his head, the whole flare of it made small and harmless in his two tidy hands. He had stopped a fight. Everyone would remember that he had stopped a fight. The peaceful man, the one who kept his head while hot fools lost theirs.

And Korvan sat where he was and watched Loric put out the one honest flare of loyalty his father had drawn all night, gently, and get thanked for the putting-out, and understood a piece of it then. Loric did not want them fighting each other. Not yet. He wanted them all facing the one way, and a clan busy tearing at itself could not be aimed at anything. It was the cleverest thing Korvan had ever half-understood, and it frightened him worse than the whole of Doran's war.

"You're brooding again," Selwyn said, folding down beside him with a leg of something. "I can hear it. It whistles."

"I'm listening."

"That's worse. Nothing good ever came of you listening." Selwyn tore off a strip of meat and chewed it and stared into the flames with the deep contentment of a man who had never in his life lost sleep over a thing he couldn't lift. "Here's the thing about listening, though. You hear things. And then you know them. And knowing things is how you end up carrying them. Whereas me, I don't listen to a word anyone says, and I sleep like a stone."

"That's the most coherent case for stupidity I've ever heard."

"Thank you. I've given it a lot of thought." He offered the leg. Korvan took a bite. It was, against all odds, not terrible. Vampire kitchens, it turned out, could roast a joint, which felt like a small betrayal of everything he'd been raised to believe. The vampires had been careful with them all day, which was its own unsettling thing. Korvan had braced for coldness and got courtesy, and the courtesy was worse. Twice since dark a servant had come out to the yard, human, soft-footed, to ask with lowered eyes whether the chief's people wanted for anything. More wood. More blankets. Hot water. And both times forty shifters had gone still and watched the poor man the whole way in and the whole way out, and both times he had left quicker than he came. Nobody in the camp would take the wood. They had a whole castle's warmth on offer and burned their own hauled logs on principle, and when a bear-clan boy reached for a folded blanket his mother knocked his hand down without a word. You did not take a thing from a house you might have to burn. Everyone in the yard knew it in the bone and nobody said it, and the human servants went on being gently, terribly kind, and the whole evening had the held-breath feeling of two dogs being polite in a yard too small for both. "Doran's going to get someone killed with that mouth," Selwyn added, quieter, the comedy going out of him for a second the way it did when it mattered. "My uncle's half with him. Half the older bear-clan is. They think your da's gone soft."

"My da could put Doran through that wall without shifting."

"I know it. You know it. That's not the kind of soft they mean." Selwyn shrugged, the subject too big for him, and let it go, because letting things go was the one thing he did as

well as Korvan did fires. "Anyway. Might be dancing later. At the thing. The banquet. You reckon vampires dance?"

"I reckon they stand very still and call it dancing."

And it was while Selwyn was laughing at that, a big honest bark of it that turned heads, that Korvan noticed Loric had come to sit at their fire.

He hadn't seen him arrive. That was becoming the thing about Loric, that you never saw him arrive, you only noticed at some point that he was there and had been there a while, quiet, taking up no more room than he had to. He had a rag and a little tin and one boot off, and he was working oil into the leather with slow even strokes, unhurried, a man doing a small task well. His other boot, the one still on his foot, was already clean. In a yard full of men who'd ridden four days through mud, Loric's boots were the boots of a man going to a wedding.

"That's a good fire," Loric said, to it, not to Korvan. "I've watched you build three of them now. You've a real hand for it."

"Anyone can build a fire."

"No." Loric said it mildly, the way he said everything, and did not look up from the boot. "That's what people say who can't. Anyone can pile wood and put a flame to it. That's not building a fire. What you do is a different thing, and you do it without thinking, which is the only way a thing is ever really yours." He turned the boot in the firelight, checking his work. "I've noticed people are quick to tell a man his one good thing is nothing. Have you noticed that? I've always found it strange. You'd think we'd be kinder about the one thing a man can do."

Korvan didn't answer. There was nothing to answer. But something in his chest had gone warm and careful at the same time, the way it had on the road, and he did not like that he couldn't tell the two feelings apart.

"I'll leave you your fire," Loric said, and pulled his boot back on, and stood, tidy, brushing off a knee that had nothing on it. He looked down at Korvan for a moment, and his face was kind, genuinely kind, there was no reading anything else in it. "It's a hard place they've brought you to, that's all. A house made of rooms and every room full of people who know exactly what they are. I hope you find a corner of it that's yours tonight. You deserve one more than most of them." And he went, off into the dark between the fires, unhurried, and a few fires down Korvan watched him fold himself down at Doran's fire the same easy way, and put a hand on Doran's shoulder, and lean in to listen.

Korvan watched him do it. He couldn't hear the words from here and did not need them. A life spent reading rooms he wasn't let into had taught him that much, and Loric at a fire was worth the reading. The man did not argue with Doran. That was the first thing. Doran was all old fury looking for a fight, and Loric gave him none, only sat and nodded and let the old man burn himself down, and every so often said some small thing that made Doran lean in and go harder, warming his hands at his own grievance. He asked Doran things. Korvan could see the shape of it even without the sound, the tilt of the head, the open hands. He was not telling Doran the chief was weak. He was asking Doran whether he thought so, and looking sad when Doran said it, and agreeing it was a hard thing, a sad thing, a pity, and never saying it himself, so that when Doran got up angrier than he'd sat down, every word of the anger was Doran's own, home-grown, and Loric had done nothing but water it.

Then he got up and moved to the next fire and did it again. And the next. Korvan lost count. He went round the whole doubting half of the camp that way, one fire at a time, a man with nowhere he had to be, and left each one a little colder toward the chief than he'd found it, and no mark on

any of it that you could point to. By the time he was done Korvan's neck had gone cold from the watching, though he could not have said what he had seen, because nothing had happened. A man had been kind to some angry old men. That was all a witness could have sworn to. And it was the most frightening thing Korvan had ever watched anyone do, and he stood at the edge of the firelight with his neck gone cold and no name for any of it, and rubbed the cold with the flat of his hand, and could not rub it out.

"I don't like him," Korvan said.

"Loric? He's harmless." Selwyn had gone back to his meat. "Quietest man in the clan. Never raised his voice in his life, my uncle says. Lost his whole family in the war, the wife and the boy both, and his old father before that, and he never went hard about it the way Doran did, never turned it to spite. Just went quiet. My uncle says he's the only truly peaceful man left who actually remembers the war, and that's why the young ones like him. He's proof you can lose everything to it and not turn into Doran."

"Then why'd he say all that to me."

"All what? He was nice to you. You're not used to it, so it reads as a trick." Selwyn said it kindly, and it was probably even true, and that was the trouble with it. "Not everyone who's kind to you wants something, Korvan. Some people are just kind. You've had a hard time working out the difference, is all, on account of you not getting much practice."

Which was, Korvan thought, exactly the sort of thing a man said when he'd been got at without knowing it. And also exactly the sort of thing that was simply true. He turned it over and could not make it lie flat either way, and gave up, because the fire needed feeding and that at least was a problem with an answer.

He found his father an hour later, up on the wall.

The chief had taken himself up onto the wall-walk of the outer court, away from the fires, where a man could look out over the flat dark country they'd ridden in through and be, for a while, nobody's chief. Korvan came up the stone stair and stood beside him and neither of them said anything for a good long while, which was how the two of them said most things.

There was a cresset burning low on the wall-walk, a basket of coals on an iron stand, and whoever had lit it did not understand fire, because it sat choked and smoking and throwing almost no light at all. Korvan's hands went to it while the rest of him worked up to speaking, the way his hands always went to a bad fire. He crouched and broke the clinker apart with the end of a stick and cut a channel down into the red heart of it so the air could climb, and it caught, and steadied, and threw a good clean light up over the two of them, and he stayed down at it after, feeding it a lump at a time. It gave his hands a thing to do that wasn't twisting. And it was easier, he had found long ago, to say a hard thing to a fire than to the side of his father's face.

"They're talking," Korvan said finally.

"They're always talking."

"Doran's talking loud. And nobody's talking him down." Korvan kept his eyes on the dark country and not on his father, because it was easier to say hard things to a view. "And there's that quiet fellow Loric, going fire to fire being gentle at everyone, and I can't work out what he's doing, but he's doing something, I can feel it, he's a man walking a fence in the dark, feeling for the loose post."

His father was quiet for a while. Down below, the fires of the clan he ruled made a scatter of small warm lights against the cold stone, and beyond the wall the vampire country lay flat and lightless all the way to a horizon you couldn't find.

"Loric," his father said, as if setting a weight down to look at it. "Aye. I know what Loric's doing."

"Then stop him."

"You don't stop a man like Loric. That's the whole difficulty of him." The chief leaned on the parapet, his big hands loose. "You watched him tonight. Fire to fire. He never says a thing you can shout at. He agrees with you, and asks after your health, and lets you be the one to say the treasonous thing out loud, so it's your own thought and not his, and a man will die for his own thought where he'd never die for another man's. You can't fight a man who never throws a punch. You can only outlast him."

"What's he want?"

"Loric doesn't want the way you and I want. Wanting a thing, you can bargain with. Give a man what he wants and he'll sit down." His father's jaw worked. "Loric had a wife and a son and a father, and the Queen's people took all three off him in one bad winter thirty years back, and he's not got a thing left in the world he wants except for her to hurt the way he hurt. You can't give a man that. There's no giving it. So there's no bargaining, and there's no shouting, and there's no stopping. There's only staying in front of it and not letting it past you, for as long as you last." He turned his head, finally, and looked at Korvan in the dark. "He doesn't even need to beat me, is the beauty of it," his father went on, quiet, as if working it out fresh in the cold air. "That's what the young ones never see. A chief holds by the clans' faith and nothing else. There's no crown to it. The day enough of them stop believing I keep them safe, some big angry man stands up at a fire and says he'll do it better, and then I fight him or I stand down, and either way the clan has watched its chief made small, and once they've seen that they can't unsee it. Loric doesn't want to be chief. He'd hand it to Doran and be glad. He only wants me pushed to the place where

I've to choose between looking weak and starting his war, because he knows I'll sooner start the war than watch my people decide I'm nothing. Thirty years' patience and one clean aim, and every kindness he does out there tonight is a stone off the wall I stand on." He breathed out slow. "Which is why I brought us down here to be gracious at a Queen half this camp thinks I ought to spit at. Because the day we stop coming to her table is the day Loric's been waiting thirty years for, and I would rather eat off her plates and be called a summoned dog by old fools than hand him his war. You understand me?"

"No," Korvan said honestly.

"Good. You're young. There's no reason you should yet." And that was as much warmth as his father had in him tonight, that *good, you're young*, and Korvan took it, because he took what there was.

They stood on the wall a while longer. Then his father said, not looking at him, in a different voice, lower, "He talked to you. Loric. Tonight."

"How'd you know that."

"Because it's what I'd do, if I were him and I wanted a way into me." The chief said it flat, without drama, and it went into Korvan cold. "You're the softest post in my fence, boy, and it's not your fault, and it's my fault more than anyone's. A resentful son's the oldest door there is. He'll be gentle with you. He'll be the only one who is, and every word he says will be true, and that's how you'll know it's him." He crouched down beside Korvan at the cresset, his knees cracking, near enough that the fire lit them both, and put a hand on Korvan's shoulder. His father had not touched him so in longer than Korvan could remember, and it sat there, heavy and warm and awkward, a hand that did not know its own way onto a neck. "Don't let him make you a door, son. That's

all I'll ask you. Whatever else you think of me. Don't be the way he gets in."

Korvan stood very still under the hand, afraid to move in case it left, which it did, soon enough, his father straightening back into the chief and clearing his throat like a man embarrassed at himself.

"Go and sleep," the chief said. "Tomorrow you sit at my left at her table and you smile at things that aren't funny and you eat what's put in front of you and you don't let a soul in that hall see it cost you anything to be there. Can you do that."

"I've been doing it my whole life," Korvan said, and it was out before he could catch it, and it came with more edge than he meant, and it landed, he saw it land, a small flinch in the big weathered face, gone before it had finished.

"Aye," his father said quietly. "I know you have. Where do you think you learned it." And he went down off the wall, heavy and slow and sure, leaving Korvan alone up on the stone with the cold country in front of him and the warm scatter of a doubting clan below and, somewhere down in it, a tidy quiet man moving fire to fire, saying only true things, polishing boots that were already clean.

Korvan looked for him and couldn't find him. That was the thing about Loric. You only ever noticed him once he was already sitting at your fire.

At the foot of the wall-stair the old deer-clan woman was sitting alone at a small fire, and she looked up at him as he came down, and this time he did not look away from the look.

Her name was Enna and she was older than anyone had a right to be, come along the four days to say the peace-words at the banquet because she was the last one living who still had them all by heart. She had been watching Korvan the whole road with the expression he had given up reading, and

he had assumed, the way he assumed about most people, that it was the funeral look, the one that had already buried him.

"Sit," she said. "You're letting the heat off my fire, standing there."

He sat. Up close her eyes were pale and steady and not sorry for him at all, which was so unexpected he didn't know what to do with his face.

"You think I look at you and see a boy the moon forgot," she said. It was not a question. "Half the camp does. I'll tell you what I see, since no one else will and I'm too old to be careful. I see a boy the moon hasn't got to yet. There's a difference, and it's the whole difference in the world, and you'll not believe me, because nineteen never believes the old about time." She poked the fire. "I said the words over your mother's grave, did you know that. And her mother's. I've said a great many words over a great many of your people, and I've learned one thing worth the saying, which is that the moon is not kind and it is not cruel. It is only slow. It comes when it comes. And the ones it makes wait longest" — she looked at him — "it has, now and again, made wait for something."

"For what," Korvan said. His voice had gone rough.

"How would I know. I say words over the dead, I don't read the sky." But she smiled, a little, the first warm thing anyone had spent on him without a joke or a fire between them all day. "Go to sleep, chief's son. And in that hall tomorrow, be slow with the one man who's kind to you." Korvan went cold, because how, how could she know. "Now go. You're still in my heat."

He went. He did not sleep straight away.

He rolled out near Selwyn, who was already asleep and already snoring, one hand closed round his stupid carved horse the way a child holds a toy against the dark. Korvan

lay on his back on the cold stone of his enemy's courtyard, in a camp full of men who thought his father was weak and a man who wanted them all dead being kind about it, and he stared up at the sky over the vampire castle and waited for it to tell him something.

It didn't. Skies didn't, whatever his father thought. What kept him awake was Loric. Not the fear of him now, lying in the dark. The other thing. The warm thing. Because his father was right, and that was the poison of it exactly. Loric had said the true things. It was a hard place. They did tell a man his one good thing was nothing. It was not fair, the way they'd raised him at the edge of every fire, the way his own father could not put a hand to his neck without it costing them both. Every word Loric had said was a word Korvan had carried by himself for years, and Loric had picked it up and turned it over and said, gently, yes, that is real, that happened to you, that is not nothing. Nobody had ever done that. His father loved him and could not say it. Selwyn loved him and turned it into a joke. And a man who wanted the whole world dead had walked up to his fire and been, for the space of a boot, the only person in his whole life to look at the raw thing straight and name it. Somewhere behind and above him ten thousand candles were burning in a house that had a warm bright place for everyone in the world except the one boy lying in its yard with no shape and no clan and, now, a fresh cold worry with his father's fingerprints on it.

His leg didn't cramp. His chest stayed quiet. He almost wished it would do something, anything, one honest wrench in the dark that meant it was finally coming, because a pain you could name was better than this long nothing. But it stayed nothing. Whatever was in him, or wasn't, went on not coming.

He thought about his father's hand, awkward on his shoulder up on the wall. He thought about Enna saying the moon had made him wait for something, and about Loric saying he deserved a corner of his own, and he could not have said, lying there, which of the three of them he most wanted to be right, only that they could not all be. He lay there being the one shape his whole world agreed shouldn't exist. And eventually, because the body does what it does no matter what a boy is carrying, he slept.

CHAPTER FIVE

Among People

The grey gown had gone missing on its way back down to be let out, exactly as Amelia had arranged, and nobody had said a word, because a feast eats small losses the way it eats everything else.

She had waited three days for the right night, and this was it. The second night of the banquet proper, when the newness had worn off the guests and the household had stopped counting heads because there were simply too many, and the whole vast machine of the castle had tipped over from vigilance into work, every hand full, every eye pulled toward the important people in the bright rooms and none to spare for the dark ones. She had lain awake two nights rehearsing it and she walked it now exactly as she had built it in her head, down the private stair behind the tapestry, along the cold gallery, and then out, for the very first time, through the low servants' door and into the loud living dark of the working house, where a bowed head and quick feet drew no eye at all.

She wore the grey gown under a servant's brown cloak she had taken off a hook. The cloak she would drop the moment she reached the hall, because a servant did not walk into the banquet, but a guest in grey silk might stand at the edge of it and be no one, and standing unseen at the edge

of a room was the one craft Amelia had drilled since she was small, without ever being told it was a craft.

She came up the north service stair, the one that carried no sound, forty-one steps she did not need to count and counted, and at the top she stopped at the plain door with her hand flat against the wood and made herself be still until her breathing slowed. On the other side of that door was everything. She had felt it building the whole way up, a great warm pressure of noise and light and heat pressing at the seams of the wall, the massed heat of hundreds of living bodies in one room, and her blood had woken at her wrists without being asked and lay there thrumming, glad, terrified, hers.

For a moment she could not make herself move. She stood with her palm flat on the cold wood and her heart going hard and understood that she was about to spend something she could never earn back. On this side of the door she was still safe, still hidden, still a girl who had done nothing that could not be undone. She could turn around even now, climb the silent stair, set the pins back in her hair, and be no one's trouble. On the far side of the wood she became, for as long as she stood there, a thing that had happened and could not be made not to have happened.

Her hand did not want to open the door.

She made it open anyway.

She dropped the cloak. She put back her shoulders the way her mother stood. And she opened the door and stepped out of the wall and into the world.

For a moment she could not take any single thing in, because there were too many things, and all of them were happening at once.

She had thought a crowd would be loud. It was not loud, exactly. It was a hundred quiet things laid over each other until they became a sea. The sea had a floor of low talk and a

surface of laughter, and running under all of it, the deep steady roar of a great fire in a great hearth and the massed breath of more people than she had seen in the whole of her life put together. She stood with her back to the wall she had come out of and let it break over her and did not move, could not move, and no one looked at her, and that was the first miracle. No one looked. All her life she had been the thing that must not be seen, and she had walked into a room of five hundred people and gone, in one step, completely invisible, because a room that full has no attention left over for a still girl at its edge.

And the heat. She had not once thought about the heat. Five hundred living bodies in one room made a warmth she had never stood inside, a thick animal warmth with the whole feast laid over it, wine and roasting meat and hot wax and cut green branches, and under all of it the warm bread-and-salt smell of crowded living people, which she had read of in books and never breathed. It pressed on her whole skin. She had lived her years in a sealed cold room where the air never changed its mind, and here the air was a broth of a hundred living things at once, and every sense she owned came suddenly and painfully awake, thrown wide after a whole starved life with almost nothing to spend itself on. It was far too much. She wanted, helplessly, more of it. She could have drunk the whole roaring room down like water and still been thirsty.

She was inside it. She was standing in a room with other people in it, and the world had not ended.

She made herself begin to see it in pieces, because pieces she could manage.

The hall was the largest room she had ever stood in and it had been dressed to look like a forest, which was, she understood after a moment, a courtesy to the shifters, an enormous cold-blooded courtesy. Whole young trees had

been brought in and stood in barrels wound with lights. The long tables ran down the length of it under a ceiling lost in dimness, and the tables were a map of the whole uneasy world in miniature, if you knew how to read them, and Amelia had been taught to read exactly this and nothing else her entire life.

The vampires kept to the high end, near the dais, pale and still and beautiful in the way of things that do not need to move. She knew them at once, her own kind, though she had never stood in a room with more than one of them at a time. They held themselves the way her mother held herself. Not one of them fidgeted. They lifted glasses they did not drink from and set them down untouched, and their stillness in all that warm motion was its own kind of announcement, we are the oldest things here and we are not warmed by any of it.

The shifters had the long low tables to the left, and they were everything the vampires were not. They ate. They ate the way people eat who have ridden a long way and do not trust that the food will come again, elbows out, laughing, reaching. A big grey-bearded man was telling a story with both hands. The whole table of them ran hot and loud and alive, and Amelia found she could not stop looking at them, at the sheer unguarded aliveness of them, the way you cannot stop looking at a fire.

All but one. She found him without meaning to, the way her eye always went last and longest to the wrong detail in a picture. Up near the head of the shifters' table, at the left hand of a big weathered grey-templed man who could only be their chief, sat a young man who was not doing any of it. He was not eating. He was not laughing. In the middle of all that warm noise he sat straight-backed, a small easy smile fixed on his face. He lifted his cup when the others lifted theirs and set it down untouched. And he was, Amelia saw

with a strange lurch, performing belonging exactly the way she had spent her own life performing invisibility, working just as hard at it, and just as alone in a crowded room. She did not know him. She would never know him, she thought, one shifter boy among forty. But for the length of a breath she felt a kinship with a stranger across a hall so sharp it frightened her, and then someone passed between them and he was gone, and she made herself look away, because she had come here to be among people, not to fall in love with the loneliness of one more of them.

And the humans moved between the two, carrying, pouring, clearing, quick and quiet and lowered, and nobody looked at them either, and Amelia understood with a small cold turn that she was watching the whole shape of the treaty laid out on a floor. The vampires who did not eat, at the high end. The shifters who ate everything, at the low. And between them the humans, who were, when you stripped the manners off it, the thing being eaten, carrying the wine to both.

She catalogued it. She could not help cataloguing it. But under the cataloguing was the deeper thing, the reason she had come down forty-one silent steps, and it kept rising through the careful sorting the way water rises through sand: it was better than she had let herself imagine, and also, in a way she had not imagined at all, almost unbearable, because every soul in the hall had done this a thousand times over and none of them knew it was a marvel. And she was doing it the once, and stealing it, and it would have to last the rest of her life.

A serving man came past with a tray and, not seeing her as anyone in particular, tilted it toward her in the automatic way of a man who has offered a thousand glasses that night. "Wine, my lady?"

My lady.

Amelia looked at the glasses and could not speak. It was such a small thing. He had not looked at her twice. He had taken her for a guest, a young vampire woman of the court in a grey gown, standing where guests stand, and he had offered her wine and called her my lady and was already, having got no answer, moving on to the next person, the whole exchange nothing to him, nothing at all, three seconds of his long night.

No stranger had ever, in the whole of her life, looked at her and not been told she was a mistake. She had not been corrected for existing. A serving man had simply offered her wine, like a person, and moved on, and the enormity of it stood her against the wall with her eyes stinging, and something in her that had braced her whole life for the correction let go all at once. She had been told a hundred times she was the same kind of thing as everyone else in the world. She had never let it in. A stranger with a tray had just put it past her guard in three seconds and would never know he had done the largest thing anyone had ever done for her.

She took a glass, so the next one who passed would see a woman holding wine and think no more about her. She did not drink it. She was, after all, her mother's daughter. But she held it, and she stood in the room, and for a while she simply let herself be there and did not sort anything at all.

The music started somewhere she couldn't see, strings and something lower beneath them, and here and there in the room people rose and began to dance, turning through slow careful figures in the cleared space before the dais. Amelia watched them with a hunger she was glad no one could see. She had read of dancing and never seen it done, never watched how a whole body could answer another across a single held hand, and she stood at the edge of it and drank it in and did not let herself imagine being asked.

She saw things she had no shelf to put away. A man and a woman down the shifter table, married a long time by the ease of them, fighting a whole silent war with their eyebrows while nobody else was the wiser, until the woman lost and laughed against her will and the man looked unbearably pleased, and it was nothing, the oldest smallest thing in the world, two people who knew each other, and Amelia could have watched it for an hour. A very drunk young lord being steered with great tenderness toward a chair by two friends who plainly adored him and plainly meant to torture him about this for the rest of his life. A serving girl palming a warm roll into her apron for someone, quick, when she thought no eye was on her, and Amelia was the one eye that was, and said nothing, and felt absurdly honoured to be trusted with a secret the girl did not know she had given away.

And she heard them, in scraps, as she drifted, the whole room talking to itself around her. "—third bad harvest running, and still they want the tithe in silver, not grain," a human factor, low, to another, both of them smiling in case an eye was on them. "Darling, he's two hundred if he's a day," a vampire lady said behind a painted fan, "of course he dances like that," and a soft ripple of laughter went up around her. Two shifter men argued a hunting boundary in voices pitched for a hillside and dropped them fast when a steward drifted near. And once, close to the dais and much quieter, a woman she could not find in the crowd: "—no heir, and none born in an age, so when she finally does go, who does the whole of it fall—"

"Not here," a second voice said, flat as a closed door, and the first went quiet.

Amelia's own name was in none of it. She drank it in anyway. It was the noise of a world that did not know it held

her, going about its evening, and no music in the room came close to it.

This was the thing she had come for. Not the cold beauty of the vampires or the loud danger of the shifters or the grim machinery of the treaty. This. The small ordinary traffic of people being people to one another, that every soul in the room owned and spent without ever counting it, and that she had come up out of her cage to stand at the edge of for one stolen night, and take what she could carry home in her two hands.

She began, carefully, to move.

Not far. Not toward the light. She kept to the deep edge of the room where the trees stood in their barrels and the shadows were kind. She moved the way she had learned to move in a house that must not know she was in it, without hurry, without aim, a woman going nowhere in particular. And she let the talk of the room wash over her and, because she had been built for exactly this, she listened.

She heard a hundred nothings. Who had worn what. Whose daughter had married badly. A long complaint about the roads. And then, threaded through the nothings, she began to hear the other thing, the thing under the feast, and it was the thing her mother sat up nights over.

"—can't hold thirty years on courtesy alone," a vampire lord was saying, low, to another, the two of them still as statues near a pillar. "The hill-clans are restless. You can smell it on them. Half that low table would have the old war back tomorrow if their chief would let them, and their chief is one bad season from being replaced by someone who would."

"Then we are gracious to the chief," the other said, "and we pray for his health."

"We are gracious to the chief. And we make very sure that when it does come apart, and it will, it comes apart on their

side of the line and not ours. Let them give us the cause. We only have to be patient. We are extraordinarily good at being patient."

Amelia moved on before the pause could turn into a glance. Her heart was going hard. It was one thing to recite the treaty in a cold gallery with her mother. It was another to stand in a bright loud room and hear two men she would never know discuss, over wine, the exact machinery of the next war, and to understand that they were not villains, they were merely careful, and that careful men discussing patience over wine was very likely how the last war had started too. She thought of her mother's face that afternoon, when she said the sun never came out kind. The whole bright warm room was a held breath, and somewhere at the head of it her mother was holding hers.

And because the thought had turned her that way, she looked up at the high table, and there was her mother.

She had told herself she would not go looking, that the Queen would be lost somewhere in the crush like everyone else. But of course she was not. She sat alone above all of it on a chair that was not quite a throne, and the whole enormous room arranged itself around her the way iron filings arrange around a lodestone, every face half-turned toward her without seeming to be, and she took notice of none of it. She was the same slight exact figure who had held Amelia that afternoon and kissed her temple and begged, her voice cracking on it, that she not exist tonight. And there was no more warmth in her now than in the stone she sat on. The cool hands were folded on the table and gave nothing. The face gave nothing. A shifter lord came and made her a small stiff bow and she answered it with the smallest incline of her head, spending nothing, wanting nothing, a woman holding a thirty-year peace together by the sheer cold weight of being impossible to read.

And Amelia stood forty feet off in a stolen gown and could not go to her. That was the cruelty she had not counted on. She had spent her planning on how to get into the room. She had not once thought about how it would feel to be in it and see her mother and have to stand there like any stranger, while every part of her wanted to cross the floor and put her own hand over those cold folded ones and say, I'm here, look, I did the impossible thing, aren't you glad. Her mother would not have been glad. Her mother would have gone white to the lips and had her carried out and the world might have come down. Amelia knew it. Knowing it did not touch the wanting, and the wanting, in the middle of all that gold, was its own small unbearable weight, and there it was, plain in the middle of the bright room: her mother did this every hour of every day. That the warm woman on the private stair was the stolen thing, and this cold one was the whole cost of her.

And there was worse, if you looked, and Amelia had never learned how not to look. A young human woman stood a little apart near the high end, dressed better than a servant, waiting. A vampire lord rose from his place and went to her and offered his arm as courteously as if she were a lady of the court, and led her out through a small side door, and she went with her chin up and her face carefully emptied of everything, and not one soul at the tables turned a head. Amelia understood what she had watched the way she took most things in, all at once and too completely. Not every human the pact gave over went to the kitchens. The protection had older courtesies in it than that, and they were done with beautiful manners, in good clothes, through side doors, and the whole gold hall had long since agreed not to see them. She thought of Maren, whom her mother would not feed on and could not explain. She understood, at last, the exact shape of the thing her mother was sparing Maren,

and why Maren had never managed to say aloud the size of what she owed.

It was too much. She had come down for the wonder and she had got the wonder, more than she could hold. And then on top of the wonder had come the weight, the two men by the pillar, the humans with the trays, the whole vast sorrowful clockwork of it. It filled her up past the top. She needed, suddenly and badly, to be somewhere with no people in it at all, which was, she thought with something close to despair, the one place she had spent every locked year of her life trying to leave.

She had almost reached the low doors when the woman looked at her.

A vampire of the court, dark-gowned, standing at the cold end of a table with a glass she was not drinking, and her gaze came to rest on Amelia and stayed, and would not move along. Amelia felt it settle and did not stop and did not quicken, because stopping and quickening were the two things that turn a glance into a question. She held her pace exactly what it had been, a young woman crossing a room toward some air, and inside her the part of her that went quiet and counted under pressure came up cold and clear and began, without being asked, to measure the distance to the door.

The woman was not looking at her gown, or her face. She was looking at Amelia's hair.

A strand of her hair had come loose, which four days of planning could never have fully prevented, because the one thing she could not hide was the one thing that named her. It had slipped its pin in the heat of the hall and now lay bright against her neck. It was not the soft faded grey that age brings to fair hair, but the other silver, the cold true moon-coloured one, and there was not another head of it in all the world. And one vampire of the court had just caught it

across a crowded room and was trying, Amelia could watch it happen behind the still face, to remember where she had heard a thing once, some rumour, some nothing, about the Queen and a—

Amelia turned her head, unhurried, and tucked the strand back with two fingers, a woman fixing her hair and nothing more, and used the turn to put a passing servant between herself and the watching eyes, and in that half-second of cover she stepped out of the woman's line and let the crowd close the gap. Her blood came up hard at her wrists, awake, offered. One thread and the woman would lose the thought forever. Amelia did not reach for it. She had promised, in a cold gallery, over a fish going round a bowl. She only walked, steady, into the drift of guests going out for air. Behind her the woman's attention lifted off her at last and went looking for someone to tell, or perhaps only for another glass, and it did not matter which, because by the time the thought finished forming in that still cold head Amelia would be gone, and a rumour with no girl attached to it was only one more thing said at a feast and forgotten by morning. Being forgettable had been the whole shape of her life, and tonight, of all nights, it had saved her.

There were doors at the low end of the hall standing open onto the dark, where the heat of the room spilled out into the night, and people drifted through them and back, and Amelia let herself drift with them, one more guest wanting air, and did not look back. She stepped out of the light.

The garden took her in.

It was a walled garden, formal, laid out in low hedges and gravel paths pale under a moon a few nights short of full, and after the heat and the roar of the hall the cold clean dark of it was like surfacing from deep water into air. She walked out along a path until the noise of the feast fell to a murmur

behind her and the small sounds of the garden came up in its place, gravel, wind in the hedges, and water.

She sat down on the first cold bench she came to and put her head down and breathed, and let the shaking have her for a moment, because there was no one to hide it from. That had been close. She made herself look at how close. One loosened pin, one curious woman, one rumour half-remembered, and it could have ended there, in the middle of the hall, her mother's face going white above the crowd and the treaty gone to ash over a girl who had wanted to go to a party. She had known the cost in her head. She had recited it to her mother that very afternoon, the dead lying in their fields and her own face on the reason. She had not felt it until a stranger's eyes stopped on her hair, and now she had felt it, cold and complete, and she found she was not sorry she had come, and that frightened her more than the woman had.

When the shaking passed she lifted her head, and the garden had been waiting for her.

There was a fountain at the heart of it. Not a grand one. An old stone basin with a single low jet that fell back on itself in a steady patter, and she went to it and sat on the cold rim of it.

She would have to carry it back up the north stair before the dark thinned, and put the pins back in her hair, and slide the bolt across from the inside so it would look untouched, and be, tomorrow, exactly the girl her mother came to twice a week, the one who weighed it all and stayed. She knew that. Already, in the back of her mind where the cold clear part of her lived, she was walking herself home step by step, forty-one of them, so that no part of tonight would show on her come morning. She was very good at leaving no mark. Tonight she had proved it on the largest scale of her life.

But she was not home yet. That was the thing she kept in front of her, sitting on the cold rim with the water falling. She was not home yet, and for a little while longer she was out, in the one hour of her whole life that was only hers, and she was not going to spend it grieving that it would end. There would be time to grieve it on the stairs. There was always time, going up, for grief. Tonight there was still, for a few minutes more, the garden, and the moon low over the wall, and the cold sweet air, and the sound of water taking every small sound and giving nothing back.

The fountain fell and fell. She noticed, in the idle way her mind noticed everything, that it was loud for its size, that the patter of it filled the little space and threw itself off the walls, and that a person sitting here could say a thing to another person and the water would take it and give nothing back, that two people could speak here and not be heard six feet away. A room, she thought, that keeps its own secrets. She liked it. She sat in the one private place she had found in the whole living world, by a fountain that swallowed sound, and she was, for once, exactly where she had wanted, all those locked years, to be, which was out, and among it, and briefly, gloriously, no one's secret but her own.

She tipped her head back and found the moon, low and swelling toward the full, sliding down the sky, and let the cold of the night come into her. For a little while she thought about nothing at all, a thing that had never been safe for her to do, not once. In her room there was always the listening, the counting, the bolt to track and the corridor to read and the long arithmetic of staying small. Out here, by a fountain that swallowed every sound, there was nothing to guard against and no one to hide from and not one task her mind was required to do. So she let it fall quiet. Truly quiet, in a way she could not remember it ever being, and she sat in the cold and the falling water and was, for the length of a few

slow breaths, only a young woman in a garden at night. It was the most ordinary thing in the world, and she had waited twenty years for it. It had been worth every locked hour of the wait. It could never be worth what it was going to cost her. She sat a while with both of those, in the cold, by the falling water, and did not try to make them agree.

She did not hear the man come into the garden behind her. The fountain took the sound of his feet the way it took everything, and gave her no warning at all.

CHAPTER SIX

The Garden

Korvan left the banquet the way a man leaves a house that is on fire but slowly, so as not to be seen running.

He had lasted longer than he thought he would. He had stood against the wall through the presentations, through the long roll of clans, each young shifter walked out into the light and named for the animal they had come into, wolf and boar and hawk and the small proud river-clans, each of them belonging to a word. He clapped when the room clapped and kept his face doing the ordinary thing. And then the marshal with the staff had come down the line taking the names of the fourth-years for the sponsor rolls, and had stopped in front of him, and had looked at his sleeve where the clan-mark should have been sewn, and had found nothing to write, and had moved on without a word, which was worse than any word. A clerk two places down had glanced up. That was all. A glance, and then the polite dropping of the eyes that people did around him now, the small mercy of pretending they had not seen the empty place where a man's whole self was supposed to be.

He had smiled at the wall as if the wall had said something funny. Then he had gone.

Nobody stopped him. That was the thing about being a clan of nothing. You could walk out of a hall packed to its

walls and the crowd would close over the space where you had been, smooth, like nothing had left.

The corridors past the hall were colder and blessedly empty. He followed them by the drop in the noise, turning each time toward the quieter way, until a door stood open on the dark and the night air came through it smelling of cut box and wet stone, and he went out into it because it was the opposite of the room behind him, and that was the only thing he wanted.

The garden was a small walled one, older than the hall by the look of it, the kind of place a great house forgets it has. Gravel paths, hedges gone shaggy, a few late roses giving up their smell to the cold. In the middle of it a fountain ran, a plain stone bowl on a plain stone stem, and it was loud. Louder than a thing that size had any business being, the water coming down hard into itself and throwing the sound back off the walls so that the little garden was full of it, a steady busy roar that ate the hall and the road and the whole rest of the world and left a man alone inside the noise of falling water.

He stood in it and breathed. His chest, which had been tight since the marshal's staff, came loose a notch. He set both hands on the gritty edge of a raised bed and leaned his weight on them and let his head hang and did nothing at all, and for a little while that was enough, and then he lifted his head and saw that he was not alone.

There was a woman sitting on the far lip of the fountain.

She had her back half to him and her face up to the moon, and she had not moved, and for one bad moment he thought she was asleep, or worse. Then he saw the small living tension in her shoulders and knew she was only sitting. She had a dark cloak on over something pale, and her hair was pinned close and it was fair, very fair, silver-fair in the moonlight where it caught, the way an old coin is silver. A

serving woman, he thought first, stealing a rest. Then, from the cloak and the stillness, someone's daughter stealing worse than a rest. Either way a person who had come out here for the same reason he had, which was to not be looked at, and here he was looking.

He should go. He got as far as taking his weight off his hands.

"You can stay," she said, without turning. "The fountain's the good part. You'd be giving it up for nothing."

Her voice came to him plainly through the water, which surprised him, and then the trick of it came clear. The noise worked both ways. It wrapped the two of them in and kept the rest of the house out, and she had known that before he came and had chosen this spot because of it. Clever. He filed it the way he filed a thing built well.

"I thought you were asleep," he said.

"I was practicing." She turned her head then, and he saw her face clearly at last, and it was not a serving woman's face and not, quite, the face he had built for her out of the cloak. It was younger than the stillness. Pale, fine, tired around the eyes in the particular way of someone who has been happy past the point of sense and is paying for it now. She looked at him without the flinch he was braced for. "Doing nothing," she said. "It turns out to be difficult. I keep catching myself listening for something."

"For what?"

"I don't know. That's the trouble." A corner of her mouth moved. "You'd be no help. You came out here listening for it too."

He had. The old reflex was in him even now, ears half back for the next small cruelty. He let go of the fountain's edge and came a step nearer, into the fall of the water where he could hear her without leaning, and sat down on the rim

an arm's length off, which was near for a stranger and he did it anyway, and she let him.

"Bad party?" she said.

"There's a word for me they couldn't write down," he said.

"It made a man with a staff unhappy."

She considered that. She did not ask which word, which he was grateful for. "And you'd rather be out here in the cold with a stranger than in there being not-written-down."

"Yes."

"Good," she said. "So would I."

They sat. The water went on being loud. Somewhere back in the house a swell of music started and the fountain took most of it and gave them a thread of it, far off, nothing to do with them. He found he did not want to fill the quiet with talk, and that she did not either, and that the not-talking was easy in a way it had not been easy with anyone in a long time. By every rule he should have been uneasy, a nameless man beside a nameless woman in a dark garden. He was not. He turned that over once and let it be.

She asked him things after a while, in the idle way of a person with nowhere to be, and he answered, and somewhere in it the questions gave themselves away. She was asking about the party the way a person asks about a place they have spent a life kept outside of. Not the way a bored woman asks. The way a child asks about a country it has only read of. What the long tables held. Whether the vampires truly sat at the high end and the humans at the low, or whether that was only a thing people said. What the music was for. Whether anyone danced to it or whether it just hung there filling the room.

He told her what he knew. Three of these he had been to now, and hated all three, but hating a thing teaches you its furniture, and he found he could lay it out for her without effort — the tiers and the order of the toasts, the way the

human envoys sat very straight and drank very little, the game the young lords played of arriving late so as to be seen arriving. She took it in with a plainness that would have embarrassed him to name in her. Once she said, "And the ice. Is there really ice, in summer, brought down off the mountains?" and he told her there was, a whole carved swan of it going grey at the edges by the great door, weeping into a silver tray, and she went still for a moment as though he had told her something enormous instead of something silly.

"You've never been," he said. Not quite a question.

"Not to one like this." She moved the moon around on the water with her eyes. "I've watched a great deal from far off. Watching is its own thing. You learn the shape of everything and the weight of nothing." She said it without self-pity, as she said everything, a fact about the world that happened to be about her. "Tonight I stood in the middle of a great crowd and felt the whole weight come down at once. I thought I'd hate it. I've spent years being sure I'd hate it if I ever got it." Her voice did something small and unguarded. "I didn't hate it. That's the thing I came out here to sit with. That it was better than I let myself hope, and that I can't have it, and both of those got bigger tonight instead of one of them getting smaller."

He knew that arithmetic. His own version of it had been grinding the wanting against the not-having for years, one whetting the other. He did not say so. He kept the particular quiet of a man it was true for, and she had said it to him and not to the moon, which was answer enough for them both.

"You're one of the hill-clans," she said at last. Not a question. "The way you carry it. Whatever they said you weren't in there, you were raised to be part of something."

"You can hear all that."

"I look at people for a living," she said. "In a manner of speaking. It's most of what I've been allowed to do."

Something crossed her face and went. "You were raised inside a thing. A place with a shape, and you had a shape in it. And tonight somebody told you the shape was empty and you believed them for about a minute, and it's still sitting on you."

He should have laughed it off. He was good at laughing things off. He looked at the water instead, at the moon broken up on the moving surface of the bowl, and he said, "There's a first shift. When you come of age. It puts you with your kind — your animal, your clan. Everybody's is late by somebody's reckoning, everybody frets. Mine's later than anyone's. Late enough that they've stopped saying it'll come and started being kind about it, which is how you know."

"So you have no people," she said.

"I have a father. A friend who won't quit." He turned the roan-colored surface of the water over in his mind and did not know why. "I have a whole clan that raised me and would put themselves in front of a blade for me. And not one of them is the same as me. There isn't one. Whatever I am when it finally comes, if it comes, there's no roll to write it on. No word for it. I'll be the only one." He heard himself and stopped, appalled a little, because he had said to a stranger by a fountain the thing he had not said out loud to a single soul who loved him.

She was quiet for a moment. When she spoke it was not with the quick sympathy he braced for. It was flat and certain, a person reading her own hand.

"A clan of one," she said.

"That's a grim way to put it."

"It's the true way." She was not looking at him now. She was looking at the middle distance, at nothing, the way he had caught her when he came in. "I've never had a word for it either. There's no one like me. Not one, anywhere, that I've ever been let near, and I've looked, believe me, I've spent my

whole life looking. My mother loves me past all sense. There's a household that would die for me. And not one of them is the same thing I am, and they all know it, and loves me the way you love a thing that washed up strange on your shore and turned out to be sweet." She turned her hand over in her lap and looked at the pale inside of her own wrist as if it belonged to someone else. "A clan of one. Yes. I've been that my whole life without the word. You've got years on me. You've got the good luck of finding out late."

It went into him further than he was ready for. Not the words. How she said them, without asking to be comforted, without leaving him a job to do, only laying the true thing down on the bare stone between them, the way a person sets down something heavy they had carried a long way.

"That's the worst thing anyone's said to me all night," he said. "It's also the only true thing."

"I know." Her mouth did the almost-smile again. "It's a specialty."

He laughed. It came out of him rough and surprised, and she looked over at the sound of it as if it were a thing she had not expected to catch tonight either, and for a moment they looked at each other with the water going down between them, two people who had each walked out of the same warm bright room for the same reason and found the reason sitting on the other end of a fountain.

He was aware, then, of her. Not as a puzzle to be read. As a person a hand's breadth of cold air away, breathing, watching him back, near enough that he could have named the exact place where the moon sat in her eyes. Something in him leaned toward her that had nothing to do with wanting anything from her, or that had wanting in it the way a cold man wants a fire, without design, the whole animal fact of him turning toward the one warm thing in a dark field. He felt his own pulse go up. He did not move. Neither

did she, and the not-moving was its own kind of loud, louder than the fountain, and they both sat inside it and let it be there and did not touch it.

"You haven't told me your name," he said. He had dropped his voice without deciding to. It was not a question. He had meant it not to be.

"No," she agreed. She said it gently, and there was a whole locked house behind the word, a lifetime of not saying it, and he heard enough of that to leave it where it lay.

"And I won't ask you to."

"Thank you." She let a breath out. "You have no idea how much I mean that."

"I might," he said. "I've spent a while now being a thing people can't write down. It's not the worst company, another one of those."

Her eyes moved over his face. Whatever she was reading there, she seemed to decide it was safe, or true, or both. "No," she said. "It isn't."

He was feeling bold, or stupid, the way the dark and the water made a man. "Let me guess one thing," he said. "The shape, not the name. Someone's daughter, kept close. Married off young to seal something, and you slipped the leash for a night."

He knew the moment it left him that he had got it wrong, or worse, near. Her face went smooth. All the small life he had been watching in it pulled down under the surface, out of reach.

"No," she said. Just that.

"I'm sorry. That was stupid."

"You did it because you're tired of being the one guessed wrong, and you wanted a turn." The life came back up by degrees. "You missed. Leave it missed."

"Gladly."

"Good," she said, and the corner of her mouth returned, and the small cold that had come into the garden went out of it again.

A little wind came over the wall and stirred the dead heads of the roses and moved a strand of the pale hair loose against her cheek. She put it back without thinking, and he watched her hand do it, and saw that she wore no rings, that her nails were kept plain and short, that there was an old faint mark on the inside of one wrist, a scald long since healed to a shine. He looked away before she could catch him cataloguing her. It was the kind of looking he did not usually do. He had spent years keeping his own eyes down and off other people, so as not to be the one caught wanting, and here he was memorizing a stranger's hands by a fountain and not minding that he could not stop.

"You keep still better than anyone I've met," he said, because it was true and because saying it was easier than saying the other thing.

"I was taught to." A wry note. "It was most of what I was taught. That and the treaty, word for word, and six languages I have almost no one to speak to." She tilted her head. "You want to ask what for. Everyone would want to. It's the first good manners you've shown all night, not asking."

"I ran out of my own answers a while back," he said. "I've stopped being greedy for other people's."

That reached her. He saw it reach her. She looked at him with something that was not quite trust, because trust was a thing she plainly could not afford, but was next door to it, a person leaning her weight on a door she has not yet decided to open. For a moment he thought she might tell him, whatever the great locked thing was, and his whole skin went alert waiting for it, wanting it, and afraid of it for her without knowing why.

She didn't. She looked back at the water and let it pass, and he was sorry and glad in equal measure. Sorry, because he wanted all of it, the name and the reason and the shape of her days. Glad, because he could feel the size of whatever she carried, and a secret that size, handed to an hour-old stranger in a garden, was a secret handed to the wind. He would keep the not-knowing before he would watch her regret the telling.

"You're a strange comfort," she said finally, "for a man I'll never see again."

"I'm a strange everything," he said. "Ask the marshal."

She laughed. It was a real laugh, low and surprised out of her, and it changed her whole face for the length of it, took ten years and a great weight off, and in that moment, with a plain and dangerous clarity, he would have given a great deal, from here to the end of him, to be a man who could make it happen again.

They stayed. He could not have told anyone afterward how long. The music in the house rose and fell and rose. The cold came up out of the stone and neither of them minded it. She asked him, once, what the first thing was he would do if the shape ever came to him, if he woke one morning finally something, and he found he could answer her, could say the small true stupid thing — that he would go down to the water and swim, that he had loved the water as a boy and stopped when the waiting got bad. She did not tell him it would come. She said, "Then I hope it's something that swims," and it undid him a little, because it was exactly the right thing and no one who loved him had ever managed it.

He asked her nothing back that she would have to guard. He asked her the safe kind of thing. What she had wanted, coming out tonight. She said, "To be in a room I wasn't the secret of," and looked at the moon, and did not explain it, and he did not make her.

They talked of smaller things after that, on purpose, the way two people step back from an edge they have both felt the pull of. She asked him about the hills, and he told her. The long cold uplands. Whole clans on the move with the herds in the warm months, then holed up close through the cold ones. The winter his father had carried a newborn lamb three miles inside his coat and it had lived. She took it in as though he were describing a foreign court, and he supposed that to her he was. Everyone he had ever known had heard these things a hundred times or lived them at his shoulder. To tell them fresh, to a person who leaned in for them, was a small pleasure he had not tasted in years, and he caught himself hoarding it even as he spent it.

"Your father sounds like a good man," she said.

"He is. It's the worst of it." He heard how that landed and tried again. "He's a good man who got a son he doesn't have the tools for. There's no shame in his whole body for me, none. I've watched for it. But he hasn't the words either, for a thing that's never happened to anyone, so he puts his hand on my shoulder and takes it off again, and we both stand there." He turned a bit of gravel under his boot. "A man who wants the world dead had more to say to me last week than my own father's managed in a year. That's a thing I'm carrying wrong, and I know it, and I go on carrying it."

He had not meant to bring the grey man into it at all, and had, and could not have said why.

"Then the man who had more to say was cruel," she said, "whatever gentle voice he used. Kindness that leaves you carrying it wrong isn't kindness. It's a hook with something soft on it." She said it with a sudden flatness, an old certainty, a person who had taken such a hook once and still felt the barb of it in her. "Be careful what you let feed you when you're starving. A starving thing will swallow the hook and thank the hand."

He looked at her. "You've been starving."

"I've been careful," she said. "Which is the same thing in better clothes."

The quiet came back heavier than before, the two confessions lying open in it. This time he did not hold still inside it. He turned his head and found her already turned toward him, nearer than she had been, near enough that he could have told apart the separate pale hairs the wind had worked loose at her temple. His hand was flat on the stone between them. He moved it the smallest distance toward hers. She looked down at it. She did not take it, and she did not draw hers back, and for one long breath the whole night hung on that unclosed half-inch of dark, louder than the fountain, the nearest he had come in his life to reaching for a thing and being let.

And then, past the pale fall of her hair, at the dark mouth of the garden path, something moved at the corner of his eye, and he lifted his head, and saw that they were not alone anymore.

A man stood at the edge of the light where the hedges broke. He was not moving, and not hiding either, exactly, only standing, the way a man stands who has been there long enough to have decided against announcing himself. The moon was behind him and Korvan could not make the face until the man shifted his weight and the pale of it came round, and then he knew it. The lean grey man from the camp on the road down. The one who had walked up to his fire and said the kind, terrible, true things. Loric.

Their eyes met across the little garden. Loric did not startle and did not smile. He inclined his head, a small grave courteous nod, the way you greet a man you know slightly and mean to know better, and then he stepped back into the dark of the path and was gone, without hurry, without sound the fountain would have let through anyway.

Korvan's stomach did a slow cold turn he did not understand. There was no reason for it. A man had walked in a garden and walked out of it. He told himself that. He told himself it was only that he did not like being seen sitting close in the dark with a woman whose name he had refused to learn, that it was the ordinary shame of being caught at something tender, and that a man like Loric, who had already looked at the raw parts of him without laughing, was the last man he needed to feel caught by. He told himself all of it and his stomach did not uncurl.

"What is it," she said. She had felt the change in him; she was watching his face, not the path.

"Nothing," he said. "Someone crossing to another door." It was even, most likely, true. He made himself believe it was true. "The party finds you eventually, even out here."

She looked at him a moment longer, and then she let it go, because she wanted, he thought, for it to be nothing as badly as he did. She drew her cloak closer and stood, and he stood with her, and the ease of the last hour bent under the plain fact that it was ending.

"I have to go in before I'm missed," she said. "Which will be soon. It's already been longer than it should have been." She said it lightly and there was nothing light under it at all.

"I know."

"I'm glad the marshal couldn't write you down," she said. "I'd have sat here alone and called it a good night, and it would have been a lie, and I wouldn't have known."

He wanted to say a great many things and had the sense not to say any of them. "Go carefully," he said, which was what his father said, and which he had never understood the point of until now, standing in a cold garden watching the only person who had made sense to him in a year get ready to walk back into a house and become a stranger again.

"You too, clan of one." She pulled her hood up over the pale hair, and the moon lost her, and she was only a dark shape moving toward the dark door, quiet as anything, sure of her way in the black in a manner that stayed with him to turn over later. At the door she stopped. She did not turn around. "If it comes," she said, to the door, "the shape — I hope you get the water. I hope it's the whole ocean."

Then she was through, and the door gave its small sound, and he was alone in the garden with the fountain going on and on, saying nothing, keeping every word they had given it.

He sat down again on the fountain's wet edge because his legs wanted it. Warmer than he had come out, and more undone, he could not have said whether the hour had been a good thing or a wound, only that it had happened to him, and that things did not, as a rule, happen to him. His eyes went to the place on the stone where she had sat, then to the dark path where the grey man had stood and nodded and gone.

He should go in. He knew it and did not do it. A man missed too long from a banquet was a man remarked on, and he had spent the whole night making himself easy to overlook, and there was no sense throwing that away now. Still he sat. The water ran. The cold worked up through the stone into him and he let it, because getting up meant the night was over, and the night being over meant tomorrow, and tomorrow he would be the shapeless one again in the daylight where no fountain covered anything.

Then he let his mind go to her instead, which was better. He turned the hour over piece by piece, the way she had turned the moon over on the water. How she had said clan of one and made it sound less a sentence passed on him than a country he might learn to live in. How she had wished him the whole ocean and meant every word. He did not have her

name and would not get it, and he found he minded that less than he should have, because a name was a thing a man could lose, and this, whatever it had been, felt harder to mislay.

Somewhere above and behind him the great house blazed, every window gold, warm and bright and full to the walls with people who had a word for what they were and a roll to be written on and a place laid for them at the long tables. He sat below all of it in the dark by the loud water, the boy with no shape and no clan, and for once in longer than he could measure the old aloneness had gone quiet in him. Not gone. Only quiet, and quieter for the knowing that one other person walked the world who slept, as he did, at the cold rim of every warm room. Some part of him understood, dimly, that a thing this good, in a world built the way his was, would be made to cost something. He could not have said what. He only knew, sitting there with his blood still up, that he would have paid a great deal, right then, to be let back through that gold door to find her.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Heads I Win

She should have gone straight up.

She knew the way. She had mapped it before she ever came down, the servants' stair behind the tapestry, the turning that skipped the lit gallery, the three doors that were never bolted before the small hours. She had the whole route folded away in her, learned by heart, and all she had to do was walk it, and be, by the time the candles guttered, only a story the household told itself and did not quite believe. That had been the plan. She had made it carefully, the way she made everything, and it had been a good plan, and she did not follow it.

She came back in through the garden door instead and kept to the dark along the wall and let herself have one more look.

That was the whole of her crime, in the end. She wanted one more look.

She could blame the garden for it. She had gone out there a careful thing and come back in a changed one, and the change was small and it was fatal. For an hour a stranger had sat beside her and treated her plainly, as a person and not as a danger to be managed, and had refused to learn her name so as to keep her safe, and had wished her, of all the mad kind things, the whole ocean. And some bolt that had been shot in her since before she could remember had

eased. She had let herself believe, sitting by that loud water, that a life with people in it was a thing that might be arranged, given care, given patience, given years. The belief was still warm in her. It made her slow. It made her stupid in the exact way the whole of her upbringing had been built to prevent, and she knew better, and she stood there anyway, wanting.

The hall was past its peak and did not know it yet. The music had gone slower and warmer. People had come loose from their careful arrangements and gathered in soft knots, laughing at things that were not funny, the human envoys pink now and less straight-backed, a vampire lord at the high tables turning a cup he would not drink from and watching the room with the patience of a thing that has all the time there is. Her mother sat above it on the dais, and Amelia let her eyes rest there the way she never allowed herself, openly, greedily, from the safe far dark by the door. The Queen was talking to no one. She had the stillness that Amelia had grown up inside, the stillness that meant she was tired and would not show it, and Amelia loved her so much in that moment that it was a physical thing, a pressure under the breastbone, and she thought: I was here. I stood in a full room and it did not end the world. And the thought was so sweet and so new that she took a step nearer to hold it a moment longer.

One step. Out of the dark by the door and into the thinning gold at the room's edge.

She felt him before she understood him. Not a sound. The fountain had taken all their sounds and this was the opposite of that, a quiet that arrived and spread, a place in the room where the laughter thinned and did not fill back in. She turned toward it the way you turn toward a draft, and the grey man she had glimpsed out on the garden path was

standing not eight feet from her, and he was looking at her, and he had been looking at her for some time.

Up close he was ordinary. That was the thing she would remember. A weathered man, plainly dressed for a hill-clan at a great house, his hands loose and empty at his sides, his face arranged into something mild and almost sorry. He did not look like the end of anything.

"There she is," he said.

He did not say it to her. He said it to the room, in a voice pitched low and clear and entirely without heat, a voice built to carry without seeming to try, and the nearest knots of people heard it and turned, because a man saying there she is in that tone makes you look before you decide whether you meant to.

"Forgive me," Loric said, to the turning faces, spreading his empty hands. "I'm a guest. I don't know the manners of a house like this. But I've been trying since I came in to work out whose daughter this is, and no one can tell me, and it's begun to trouble me, and I find I'd rather be troublesome than troubled." He looked back at Amelia, and his voice stayed gentle, which was the horror of it, the gentleness. "Whose are you, girl? It's a simple thing. Everyone else here has a name pinned on them somewhere. Whose are you?"

The floor was very far away. She was aware of it the way you are aware of the ground from a height, that it was there, that it would be involved. She had rated a thousand rooms in her life for how sound moved in them, and she understood, in the cold clear part that went on working while the rest of her fell, that this was the worst kind, a high hard-walled hall that took a low voice and handed it to every corner, so that a man could stand near you and speak softly and be heard by five hundred people, and there would be no way to make it quieter, no way at all, because the room itself was on his side.

"I don't—" she said. It came out of her small. She had six languages and could not find a word in any of them. "I'm no one. I'm a servant. I lost my way."

"A servant." He said it kindly, turning the word over, letting the room see him consider it and find it wanting. "In a cloak like that. With hands like that." He had not moved. He did not need to. "Take your hood back, then, if you're no one. No one minds being looked at."

She did not take her hood back. Her hands stayed at her sides. And that, she saw the instant it happened, was as good as doing it, because a servant would have obeyed and been forgotten, and a girl who stood frozen with her hood up in a bright room was a girl with something under the hood, and every eye in reach had already followed the logic of it and arrived, ahead of her, at the wanting to see.

"May I?" Loric asked, and he was already lifting his hand, slow, courteous, giving her all the time in the world to stop him and no way to do it, and she stepped back and her shoulder found a pillar and there was nowhere further to go, and he reached out and took the edge of her hood between two fingers, as gently as a man turning a page, and drew it back off her hair.

The light found her.

Her hair was silver. It had always been silver, the cold near-grey of the moon on a night with no warmth in it, and her whole life had been the management of that one fact, the braiding and the pinning and the keeping to rooms with kind light, and now she stood under the full blaze of a thousand candles with her head bare and the silver of her lit up like the one wrong coin in a dish, and she watched it happen to the room. She watched them see it. A sound went through the hall that was not a word, a single low intake, five hundred people understanding the same thing in the same half-second, and she knew what they understood because

she had been taught it before she could read. Only one kind of thing was born with the moon in its hair. Only one. There were no others.

She saw it move through them by kind. The humans first, the envoys and their people, who went white and still because they knew the treaty was the only reason they were not cattle and they had just watched its floor give way. Then the hill-clans, who drew in on themselves and reached, some of them, toward where their blades would have been if the house had let them keep blades. And then the vampires, her mother's own, the lords and their households at the high tables, and it was their faces she could not bear, because they did not look afraid. They looked hungry. They looked at her silver head the way a starving line of people looks at bread through glass, and she understood a thing she had somehow never let herself know: that even among her mother's kind she was not one more of them. She was the impossible thing, the proof they had all given up on, and half of them wanted her dead for the danger of her and half of them wanted her for what she might mean, and not one of them, not one, looked at her the way the man in the garden had looked at her an hour ago, as though she were simply a person who had been sad.

She looked for him. She could not help it, even then, even drowning. Her eyes went across the hall for the dark head and the outsider's stance, for the one face that had been kind, and he was not there, and the relief of that was so violent it frightened her. He was still out in the cold by the fountain, or gone up to whatever bed a chief's shapeless son was given, and he had not seen this, and whatever came next it would not have his face in it. She held to that. It was the last purely good thing she would have for a long while, the knowledge that he was somewhere she was not, and safe.

"Ah," said Loric, very softly, as though she had told him something sad. He let the hood fall from his fingers. He was not looking at her anymore. He had turned, unhurried, to the dais.

"Majesty," he said.

Amelia did not want to look at her mother. In all the long list of things she had been trained never to do, she had not been trained for this, because this had been the one thing that was never, ever supposed to be able to happen, and so there was no drill in her for it, no cold clear procedure, only the child underneath who wanted, more than she had ever wanted the party or the crowd or the ice swan or the man in the garden, for her mother to fix it. Her mother fixed things. Her mother had held her hands between her cool ones and worked the same terrible sum night after night so that Amelia would not have to. She looked at the dais because she could not not look, and she found her mother's face, and she gave it, without meaning to, the whole of her hope.

The Queen looked back at her.

And there was nothing there.

In private that face did a great many things it never did in public. It softened and crumpled and laughed with the mouth wide, and went slack, sometimes, with a love so plain it frightened her. The warm face was as familiar to Amelia as her own two hands. And now, across the length of the ruined hall, it closed. Not into coldness. Coldness she could have borne. Coldness was a thing you did at a person. This was worse. The warmth was simply going out of it, feature by feature, like heat leaving a stone after the sun is down, until what sat on the dais was a sovereign looking at a stranger who had caused a disturbance in her hall, mildly, from a great and permanent distance. Her mother looked at her as though they had never met. And the terrible thing, the thing that went into Amelia and did not come out again for a long

while after, was that she could follow every step of the reasoning. It was the most loving thing the woman had ever done for her, and it landed exactly like being dropped.

Her breath had stopped somewhere in her chest. She set her shoulders to the cold pillar and made herself take the next one, and the one after that, and did not let her face do anything at all.

"I don't know the girl," the Queen said.

Her voice was even and carrying and bored. She let her gaze pass off Amelia and onto Loric as though moving from one small tedium to a slightly larger one.

"You are a guest under my roof and my treaty," she said, "and you have pulled the hood off a frightened serving-girl and made a scene, and now you will tell me what it is you imagine you have found, plainly, so that I can have it answered and get back to my evening."

It was masterful. Amelia, drowning, could still see that it was masterful. Her mother had taken the whole weight of the room and set it down again as nothing, had made Loric the vulgar one, the guest who manhandles the help, had given the hall a version of events it would be relieved to believe. For a breath the balance actually tipped. She felt it tip. She felt the room begin, gratefully, to look away.

And then Loric, who did not want to win, said the only thing that could lose it for everyone.

"I don't imagine I've found anything, Majesty," he said, in that same soft sorry voice. "I'm a simple man. I asked whose daughter she is and she said no one's, and you say you don't know her, and I'm sure that's all true." He paused. He looked, for a moment, almost gentle, almost kind, a man reluctant to be the bearer of a small hard fact. "It's only that a natural-born can't be made. Everyone knows that. It's the whole of the treaty, isn't it, the one thing it rests on — that there aren't any more, that there can't be, that the last of you

came off the boats out of Atlantis and no new ones since, not made, and certainly never born." He tilted his head at her, unbearably reasonable. "So I'm not accusing anyone of breaking the treaty. How could I? There's nothing in the treaty about a natural-born child, because a natural-born child was never supposed to be possible. I'm only asking the room to look at her hair and tell me I'm wrong. That's all. Tell me it's dye. Tell me she's some fair human girl with a clever mother. Tell me, and I'll beg your pardon and leave, and we'll none of us speak of it again."

For a moment that had no bottom to it, no one said anything at all. The chance hung there in the bright air, and it was a real chance, and Amelia felt the size of it. All it would have taken was one voice. Her mother's, to name it slander and make the room believe her. Her own, to laugh and shake the silver loose and swear it was dye, some cheap alchemy off a market stall, and let five hundred people take the escape she offered them. A single human lord to stand and say he had known the girl's father in some far town, invent a name, hand the assembly its excuse. That was all the moment wanted. One person willing to lie well, and the whole night could still fold itself shut and become only a strange thing that had nearly happened at the edge of a good party.

Amelia opened her mouth.

She had six languages and a lifetime of careful untruths, and she reached for any of them, for the smallest serviceable lie, and found the well dry. Nothing came. The silver was on her head where the whole world could see it, and the truth of her was the one thing in the room too large to talk around, and she stood there with her mouth open and said nothing at all. And her nothing, like the room's, was an answer.

No one told him he was wrong.

That was the whole of it. He did not need proof. He had understood, better than she had, better than her mother had, that in a room like this proof was beside the point, that all he had to do was ask the question out loud and stand back and let the silence answer it. The treaty did not forbid a born vampire because a born vampire was a thing outside the world the treaty had been built to hold. And now here one stood, bare-headed under the candles, and the whole careful peace, the trains and the motorcars and the long tables and the human envoys and the hill-clans smiling at each other over cups, the entire structure that everyone in the room depended on and pretended to believe in, had just been shown its own foundation and found a girl standing on the crack.

It began to come apart in front of her, quietly, in a spreading of small failures. Down the hall the eldest of the human envoys, a spare old man who had drunk almost nothing all night, got to his feet unbidden and stood very straight, and she watched him understand that his people were three hundred miles from home in a house full of things that could run them down, and reckon, coldly, how fast their horses were. Among the vampire households a lord she did not know rose too, in no hurry, and turned his back on the dais, which was a thing she had never seen a living soul do to her mother, and two of his household stood with him. The hill-clan men had drawn into a tight knot around their chief. No one had shouted. No one had drawn anything. It was worse than shouting. It was a whole hall all at once beginning, without a word, to choose, and she stood at the center of the choosing and understood that whatever she was — valuable, dangerous, or simply doomed — she had already stopped being a person to any of them and become a question their lives now hung on answering.

She looked for her mother again, could not help it, and saw she had already turned away, down the hall, toward the cluster of hill-clan men near the great door, toward the weathered steady man standing at the head of them with his face like a shut gate. The chief. Father to the man from the garden. Amelia did not know him, had learned his shape only tonight, secondhand, from a son who loved and feared him in the same breath and had never told her his name. She watched the two of them find each other across the wreckage, the Queen and the chief, two rulers weighing the same cold facts, and she understood with a lurch that the sums were not about her. They had already stopped being about her. She had been the match. She was not going to be the fire.

Because a hill-clan man had made the accusation. One of the chief's own had stood up in the Queen's hall and named a born vampire, and now there were only two ways the night could end, and the chief could count them as fast as anyone alive.

She watched him do it. That was the thing she had not expected, that she would be able to watch the calculation happen on a stranger's face across a ruined hall. The chief did not look at her at all. He looked at Loric, and then at the Queen, and then at his own men ranged behind him, the young ones with their too-bright eyes, and she saw the weathered shut-gate face take in the shape of the trap entire in the space of three breaths and find no way out of it. He could stand behind his man. Declare the treaty a lie, the Queen an oathbreaker, and take the hill-clans to war with the humans dragged in behind whichever side would have them. Or he could disown the accusation, name Loric a liar to the whole assembly, and by doing it tell his own clans that their chief would swallow any insult, from anyone, to keep from having to fight, which was the single thing a chief could

not survive his people believing. Loric had built him a door with a wall behind it. Stand, and it was war. Kneel, and it was a challenge to his seat that he would not walk away from whole. Whichever face the coin showed, the grey man collected.

And Loric had not once raised his voice.

She had wanted to be seen. She had sat in a garden not an hour ago and told a stranger that all she wanted was to be in a room she was not the secret of, and she had meant it with her whole starved heart, and here it was, the thing she had wanted, delivered entire. She was in a room she was not the secret of. Five hundred people were looking at her and knew exactly what she was. And it was the end of the world after all. It had only waited until she was standing in the middle of it, glad, to begin.

The cold went out of her hands and into the rest of her. She was distantly aware of her own body, of the pillar at her back holding her up, of a high thin ring in her ears that had nothing to do with the acoustics of the hall. She thought, with the small mad clarity that comes when everything else has stopped, that she had never in her life been in a room with more than a handful of people, and that her first true crowd and her last were going to be the same one.

And then, under the fear, something else moved.

It came up from a place her mother had only lately begun to show her, in the quiet grey mornings behind the bolted door, two pairs of hands cupped over a bowl of water while the Queen taught her to make her own blood answer her instead of merely run in her. It woke now, unasked, all along the insides of her wrists, a slow hot pressure that had nothing to do with the cold everywhere else in her, and she understood with a jolt what it was offering. She was not a lamb in that hall. Here, at the dead center of it, she was the one thing none of them had ever actually seen used — not

the hungry lords, not the grey man, not the guards easing off the walls toward her. The rough shape of what she might do was there under her hands, and most of the ways it went ended with bodies on the floor. That knowing steadied her more than anything had since the hood came off. She was not helpless. She had only decided, in the half-second the power gave her to decide it, that a girl who tore a peace apart with blood magyk before the assembled world would prove every word the grey man had been too careful to say. So she held it. Pressing it back down the way she had been taught to draw it up, she kept her hands open and empty at her sides, and it was the most deliberate thing she had ever done, and not one soul in the room knew she had done a thing.

Somewhere near the dais a woman began, quietly, to weep. Amelia turned her head and found her without wanting to. It was one of the older serving-women, a comfortable grey person Amelia half-knew from the edges of the household, from a lifetime of trays left outside a bolted door and small forbidden kindnesses passed through the gap, and she was standing with a jug forgotten in her hands and tears running plainly down her face, not hiding them, looking at Amelia with a grief so open and so unafraid that it was the first thing all night that threatened to break her. The household knew her. The household loved her. And now the household was watching her be found, and could not do one thing about it, and that woman's face said all of that at once.

And the grey woman was not the only one. Amelia saw them now that she was looking, scattered through the hall in their livery, the people who had raised her at one remove her whole life. A footman she had never spoken to had gone the color of ash and was gripping the back of a chair. Two of the kitchen girls had caught each other's hands. An old man who tended the furnaces, who used to leave a warm stone outside her door on the coldest nights and never said a word

about it, stood with his cap crushed in both fists and his jaw working. None of them moved. They knew better than anyone in that hall what moving would cost, and what it would cost her, and so they only stood and grieved with their faces, a whole silent household saying goodbye to a girl they had loved in secret and were now, in the space of an evening, going to lose in the open.

Her mother's voice came down the hall again, and it had changed. Not much. Amelia doubted anyone else in the room could hear the change. But she had studied the register of that voice her whole childhood, through a bolted door, and she heard it now, the hairline underneath the command.

"Clear the hall," the Queen said.

Not to Amelia. Never again, perhaps, to Amelia. To the marshals, to the guards along the walls, to the great machine of the house that moved when she spoke.

"The evening is ended. Our guests will be shown to their rooms and their roads." A pause, one beat, the length of a held breath, the only grief she would permit herself in front of the world. "And someone will bring the girl to me."

The girl. Not her name. Not the hundred soft names her mother used in the dark. The girl, spoken to the room, the disavowal complete and the rescue folded inside it where only the two of them would ever find it, and Amelia stood against her pillar with the whole bright ruined hall turning to look at her one last time, and understood that she had been given, in the same four words, both halves of what her mother was — the sovereign who would not know her, and the woman who could not, whatever it cost, quite let her go.

Hands closed on her arms. Gentle ones, she registered, not rough, house guards, not the grey man's people, and she let them turn her, because her legs had stopped taking instruction and there was nothing left in the plan for a

moment like this. As they walked her from the hall she looked back once, over the sea of faces that had all been ordinary an hour ago, and she did not find her mother.

She found Loric.

He was not gloating. She had braced, somewhere, for gloating, and there was none, and its absence was the worst thing his face could have done. He was watching her go with an expression she had no name for then and would not have one until much later, an expression that was almost, unbearably, pity. He looked as sorry as she felt. And she had the mad certainty, in that moment, that the two of them, the girl who had wanted only to be seen and the man who had wanted only for someone else to ache as he ached, understood a thing about each other across the emptying hall that no one else in it ever would.

The corridor took her in and the hall let her go. She walked between the two guards on legs that had decided to work again, and she found, now that the worst thing had already happened, that she was not weeping. Some cold clear thing had come up in her and set her face for her, as her mother set hers. She made herself think of the warm face. She did it on purpose, the mouth wide with a laugh in the dark, the cool hand smoothing her silver hair back and calling it the loveliest hair ever grown on the nights the world beyond the door called it a death sentence. She was walking toward the woman who owned that face and had just, before the whole assembly, unmade it. And she was not angry. That was the strange thing, stranger than all the rest of it. She understood her mother down to the ground, and she was going to her, and some part of Amelia that had been a child until an hour ago finished, quietly, somewhere in that corridor, being one.

Then the doors closed behind her and the noise of the hall was cut off all at once, and she was walking between two

quiet men toward the mother who did not know her, and she understood, in the steady place the fear had not reached, that she had walked into a full room a girl and was walking out of it a war, and that not one blade in that hall had needed to be drawn for it.

CHAPTER EIGHT

What a Reasonable Man Does

He learned it the way he learned most things, last, and from the wrong person.

He had come back to the camp in the small hours with the garden still on him, warm in a way the cold night could not get at, and he had lain down in his blanket by the banked fire and not slept so much as floated, turning the hour over, the silver-haired woman and the fountain and the half-inch of dark his hand had not crossed to hers. He had decided, somewhere near dawn, that he would find a way to learn her name after all. He had gone to sleep on that. It was the last easy thought he would have for a long while.

He woke because the camp was wrong.

A camp has a sound the way a body has a pulse, and he had come up inside this one, and he knew before his eyes were open that its rhythm had broken in the night. There was too much low talking and not enough movement. Men were awake who should have been asleep, standing in twos at the edge of the firelight with their heads close, and when he sat up the nearest two stopped, and looked at him, and looked away, and that was the first of it. That was the first time a man he had known his whole life looked at him and then made a point of looking somewhere else.

"Selwyn." His friend was crouched by the fire feeding it sticks it did not need, which was what Selwyn did with his

hands when the rest of him did not know what to do. "What happened."

Selwyn did not turn around. "You weren't in the hall."

"No. I got sick of it. I went out." Not a lie, and not the truth, and he felt the shape of that in his mouth as he said it and did not like the taste. "What happened, Selwyn."

"There was a vampire." Selwyn's voice was careful, the careful of a man handling something that might go off. "At the banquet. A born one. The Queen's own, they're saying, a daughter, hidden all these years." He fed the fire another stick. "A grey man from one of the low clans stood up and named her in front of the whole hall. Pulled the hood right off her. Silver hair. You know what that means, silver hair." He said it the way he said all the things everyone already knew, as though laying them out made them safe. "It's the mark. There's no faking it. A whole hall full of people saw the Queen's secret standing there with the moon in her head, and now—"

"Silver hair," Korvan said.

Something had happened to the air. It had gone thin, and hard to move through, and very cold, and he sat in his blanket with the last of the garden's warmth going out of him all at once, the way heat leaves a stone when you finally lift it off the fire.

That cold silver of her, lit up where the light caught it. He had sat a hand's breadth from it for an hour. He had watched the wind pull it loose at her temple and thought about counting the separate pale strands of it. He had called her, at the end, clan of one, and she had looked at him and said, that's the true way, and told him there was no one like her anywhere, not one, that she had searched all her years and turned up no other of her kind, and he had heard a lonely woman being poetic about her own strangeness and had

ached for her because he thought he knew exactly what she meant.

She had not been being poetic. She had been telling him the plainest truth in the world. There was no one like her because there was, in the whole turning world, only her. He had wished a natural-born vampire the entire ocean and she had drawn her hood up over the moon in her hair and gone back inside to be found.

"Korvan?" Selwyn had turned around now. "You've gone a color."

"Say the rest of it."

"The rest of what?"

"You said 'and now.' And now what."

Selwyn's careful face got more careful. "And now your father's taken us to war," he said. "That's the rest of it. It happened while you were out getting air."

The whole of the next hour he would remember afterward in pieces, out of order, the way you remember a fall. He remembered getting to his feet and the blanket dropping. There was the walk up the slope to the chief's fire, and the way the talking stopped in front of him and started again behind him, a little wake of silence that traveled with him wherever he went, so that he moved through his own people inside a small quiet that was entirely about him and that no one would say a word of to his face. He had spent his life being the boy with no shape, the object of a careful kindness. This was not that. This was new. The careful kindness had had pity in it. This had something colder, something that was doing sums about him, and he understood before he reached his father's fire that Loric had not stopped at the girl.

Because a man does not just happen to be walking in a walled garden at midnight. Someone had seen him go out. Someone had seen who was already out there. And Loric,

who missed nothing, who had walked up to Korvan's own fire on the road down and named the raw parts of him with such terrible gentleness, had understood exactly what he was looking at when he stood in the dark mouth of that path, and had known precisely what it would be worth, later, to be able to say it: that the chief's own son, the shapeless one, the one already half outside the order, had been found sitting knee to knee in the dark with the vampire girl. Not a rumor the chief could kill. A thing that had been seen.

Heads I win, Loric had said, without saying it. The girl exposed the treaty. The chief's son exposed the chief.

His father was standing at his fire with three of the clan-heads and did not send them away when Korvan came up, which was its own answer. The chief looked at his son across the low flames for a moment, and his weathered shut-gate face did not do any of the things a father's face does. It stayed shut. But his eyes moved over Korvan once, quickly, taking inventory, and there was a question in them, one question, and Korvan understood that his father was asking it and that the three clan-heads were watching to see it answered.

"I sat with her," Korvan said. He said it to all of them, plainly, because a lie now would be the end of something he could not afford to end. "Last night. In the garden. I didn't know what she was. I didn't know who she was. She wouldn't give me her name and I didn't ask her for it, and we talked about nothing, about the cold and the hills and a party neither of us belonged at, and then a man stood in the path and we both went in. That's the whole of it. That's everything that happened."

It was the truth. It was the exact and complete truth. And he watched it land in the faces around the fire and do nothing at all, because the truth was not the point and had not been the point since the moment Loric decided to make

it not the point. It did not matter what had happened in the garden. It only mattered that it could be said.

One of the clan-heads, old Bricc, made a low sound in his throat. "Knee to knee with the thing in the dark," he said, "and didn't know what it was. A shifter's supposed to know. Supposed to feel a wrongness." He was not quite looking at Korvan. "But then. You've got no more nose for these things than the rest of a man's parts, have you."

It was the cruelest thing anyone had said to him in a year, and it was said in a mild grumbling voice, almost kindly, the way you would note that a lame horse could not be blamed for the ditch. No shape, no scent, no clan, no instinct. Not even good for smelling the enemy across a garden. Korvan felt the old heat come up in him, the fire-quick anger he had spent years learning to bank, and he banked it, because the anger was exactly the thing Bricc wanted to see, the shapeless boy losing his temper and proving he had nothing under it but temper.

But under the heat, quieter, there was a thing he could not have explained to Bricc or to anyone. The old man was wrong, and wrong in a way that mattered. Korvan had not failed to feel a wrongness in the garden because he had no instincts left to feel with. He had sat beside her for an hour, near enough to feel the cold that came off her, and some old animal part in him had known perfectly well that the person at his side was not like the people he knew, was colder and stranger and older somehow than a girl her age had any business being. And that part of him had sounded no alarm at all. It had settled. That was the truth he could never say aloud. His instincts had not been asleep in the dark. They had looked straight at the one creature in the world he was built to run from, and gone quiet, and called her safe. Whatever was unfinished or broken in him had reached toward her and not away. What that meant, he could not say.

But it was the most dangerous single fact about himself, and he buried it under the anger and under everything else and let Bricc think whatever Bricc liked.

His father spoke before Korvan had to. "That's enough, Bricc."

Not sharp. His father was never sharp. But the three clan-heads heard the door of it close, and after a moment they made their courtesies and went, back down the lines to wake their own men and give the orders that had been decided in the night, and Korvan was left standing at his father's fire in the grey early light, the two of them alone with the thing at last.

For a while the chief said nothing. He looked at the fire. He was a man who took long pauses before hard truths, and Korvan had learned as a boy to wait them out, to not rush into the quiet and spoil what was coming, and so he waited now, and the light came up thin and cold over the camp and the walls of the great house beyond it, and somewhere up in that house the girl with the moon in her hair was waking to whatever her mother had made of the wreck.

"I believe you," his father said finally.

It went into Korvan more than he expected. He had not known, until it eased, how tight he had been holding against the possibility that his own father would look at him and wonder.

"I believe every word," the chief said. "You sat with a lonely girl in a garden and didn't know her, and it was nothing, and it was clean. I know that. I know you." He turned from the fire and looked at his son, and for one moment the shut gate opened just enough that Korvan could see what was behind it, which was grief, an old deep steady grief that had been there so long it had stopped looking like grief and started looking like calm. "And it is going to make no difference at all. Do you understand me. I know it was

clean, and I am going to let them say it was not, and I am going to take our people into a war partly on the strength of a lie about my own son, and I am going to do it with my eyes open, because the other roads are worse."

"Then tell them," Korvan said. "You're the chief. Tell them it was nothing. Your word—"

"My word." His father almost smiled, and it was the grimmest thing his face had done all morning. "If I stand up and defend you, what have I told them? That the chief's blood is mixed up with the vampire's. That I have a reason to go soft on the Queen's people. I would be handing Loric the very thing he wants me to have, a stain he doesn't even have to prove, because I'd have spent my own honor trying to wipe it off." He shook his head slowly. "No. The only way to keep you from being the vampire's creature in their eyes is to give them a bigger fear to look at. So I give them the war. A chief who declares war on the people who hid a born vampire is not a chief whose son is a sympathizer. He's a chief who was wronged. You see? The war doesn't just answer Loric's challenge. It buries you. It's the only thing large enough to bury you under."

Korvan stood very still. Up the slope the house caught the first real light and threw it back, gold on grey stone, beautiful and enormous and full of a girl he had known for one hour and would now, it seemed, spend the rest of his days at war with.

"So the war is for me," he said. His voice did not sound like his own. "You're burning down the peace to keep them from calling me a traitor."

"The war is for many things," his father said, "and you are one of them, and if you make it only about yourself you'll go mad, so don't." He said it not unkindly. "Loric had built a room with two doors and a wall behind each. I have chosen the door I can live behind. That is the whole of what a chief

does, in the end. Not the right thing. There wasn't a right thing on offer. The bearable one."

Korvan looked at his father across the low fire, this steady weathered man who had raised him without ever being able to say the thing his eyes were saying now, and understood that he was being handed something. Not comfort. His father did not deal in comfort. A creed, maybe. The one his father lived by and had never spelled out, laid down between them because the morning had made it necessary.

"You always told me the highest thing a man can do is stay alive to act later," Korvan said. "I used to think that was you being careful. An old man's rule."

"It is an old man's rule." His father almost smiled. "It's also true. Dead men are very brave and no use to anyone. The trick nobody warns you of is that staying alive to act later costs more than dying would, most days. You swallow the thing a braver, stupider man would fight over, and you go on carrying it, and you let people think you a coward for the swallowing, and you wait. Sometimes you wait your whole life and the later never comes and you die with the thing still down your throat." He was quiet a moment. "Your mother had it in her stronger than I ever did. She could hold a wrong in both hands for years and not throw it. It is what let her keep this clan whole through the last war. And it is what killed her in the end, a thing held too long that turned inward for want of anywhere else to go. So I know the price of the door I am choosing. I have paid it once already, in her. Do not imagine I choose it lightly. I choose it because I have weighed the other door and it is worse, and that is the only reason a man like me ever does anything at all."

It was more of his mother than his father had given him in years, and Korvan took it and held it and did not ask the small hungry questions that rose in him, because he

understood that the door was closing on this too, that his father had opened himself exactly this far and no further and would not thank a son who tried to work the gap wider.

"Go and strike your camp," the chief said, and the gate shut, and he was only the chief again. "We ride within the hour. I don't want us behind these walls when this house wakes up and remembers it's angry."

That was the whole of the conversation. It was the most his father had ever said to him at once in his life, and it was a door closing, and Korvan turned and went back to do as he was told, because obedience was the only thing the morning had left him.

He struck his camp. His hands did it without him, the rolling and the lashing and the killing of the fire, while the rest of him stood off at a distance and watched a war get made out of a garden. And underneath everything, underneath the cold and the grief and the shame of Brice's mild little knife, there was a thing he was more ashamed of than any of it, a thing he could not say to a single soul, which was relief.

It was over. That was the shape of the relief, small and awful and undeniable. The pretending was over. For weeks he had been walking toward this banquet knowing it would be another hall full of people with words for themselves and none for him, another performance of belonging he could not perform, and now it had blown apart and there was nothing left to perform, nothing left to fail at, only a long hard road home and a war that at least, at last, made no distinctions. In a war he was not the shapeless boy who couldn't shift. He was just another man riding home. The peace had had a thousand ways to remind him of what he wasn't. The war, he thought, with the cold clarity of the truly ashamed, would have only the one enemy, and it would not care in the slightest what shape he wore.

He hated himself for the thought the instant he had it. Somewhere up in that gold house a girl who had wished him the ocean was paying for his relief with everything she had, and he stood in the wreck of her life feeling lighter, and there was no name low enough for a man who could do that.

And yet he could not make it go away by hating it. That was the part that shamed him most, that the relief did not obey him. A decent man would have felt only grief. He felt grief, and this other thing braided in with it so tightly he could not pull them apart. He had been the wrong thing in every room for so long that the ending of the rooms felt, in some low animal place, like being let out of a cage, and it did not matter that the cage had opened onto a war, or that a person he could not stop thinking about had paid to open it. Some starved part of him was quietly, unforgivably glad. Perhaps that was what his father meant about swallowing a thing and carrying it. He had one of his own now, with a garden in it and a war in it and a shame he could never confess.

"You want a hand with the—"

"No." It came out of him like a blow, and he heard it be a blow, and he saw Selwyn stop with his arm half out toward the tent-lashings, saw the flinch go across his friend's honest face, the small hurt of a man who has done nothing but be near. "No. Leave it. I've got it." And then, because Selwyn was still standing there, because Selwyn was always still standing there, loyal and useless and kind, Korvan said the thing he would spend the ride home wishing he had swallowed. "Not everything needs your help, Selwyn. Not everything needs you crouching over it telling it what it already is. Just once. Just let a thing be hard without narrating it."

Selwyn's mouth closed. He looked at Korvan for a moment with no cleverness in his face at all, just the plain

wound of it, and then he nodded, once, and picked up his own gear and went to see to his own horse, and did not say the obvious thing, and his not saying it was louder than anything he could have said.

The shame of that landed on top of all the other shame and did not make it lighter. Korvan finished his camp alone, which was what he had asked for, and found it was exactly as bad as he should have known it would be.

They rode within the hour. As the column formed up in the cold he let himself look back at the house one time. It stood up gold and enormous on its hill with the early light full on it now, five hundred bright windows, and somewhere behind one of them was a girl who had told him she only wanted to sit in a room she was not the secret of. He found the highest windows and looked at them and made himself stop. Whether she was up there, whether she was even still alive, he had no way to learn, and every mile they rode would put more of the cold grey world between them. There was a mercy in that he was ashamed to want and wanted anyway. The mercy of distance. Of not having to watch whatever was going to be done to her get done.

The gate of the great house let them out onto the road down, the same road they had come up two days before as guests, and they went out of it now as something else, a war-party that did not yet look like one, forty tired men on tired horses with the thing unspoken riding among them. No one blew a horn. No one drew anything. That was the part Korvan could not stop turning over as the walls fell behind them: that a war could start like this, with a party breaking up early and a column of quiet men riding home in the cold, that the largest and worst thing people did to each other could begin without a single raised voice, set going in a garden by a soft-spoken man who had only asked a question, and carried out here onto the road by a good father

choosing the bearable door. He had thought, when he was younger, that wars began with a scream. They began, it turned out, with reasonable men doing the reasonable thing, one careful choice after another, each of them defensible, all of them together making a fire no one had decided to light.

He rode near the back, where he belonged, where the shapeless one always rode. The roan he would not let himself ride was somewhere up ahead in the string. He watched its haunches move and kept his mind off the water, off swimming. She had refused him her name, and it had not been coyness or a game — that much was plain to him now. She had known exactly what she was and exactly what it would cost him to know it, and she had sat there in the dark and taken his loneliness and given him back her own and kept, through all of it, the one thing that could have ruined him, held it back on purpose, to leave him clean. He had spent the night thinking he had failed to get her name. She had spent it making sure he never could.

And there was no one on the earth he could say that to. His father took the garden for an hour of talk between strangers, and it would stay that. Selwyn would never be told what was in it. The clan had its story about a shapeless boy and a vampire in the dark and had settled already on what it meant. The truth of the hour was his alone — the shared exile, the near-touch, the ocean — and the telling of it would only confirm the lie and betray the one person it belonged to. So it stayed down. The single most important thing that had ever happened to him, and he would carry it in silence, down a road that ran to a war against the only person who had ever looked at him and seen a man.

The country rose around them as they climbed, the soft valley giving way to the hard bright uplands he had been born to, the air thinning and sharpening until it hurt to breathe it deep. Ordinarily that first cold cut of the home air

loosened some knot in him and said he was nearly back where he belonged. Today it did nothing. He rode up into his own country and it might have been anyone's, a place he was passing through on his way to somewhere worse.

In the afternoon he made himself close the gap and bring his horse up level with Selwyn's. For a good while the two of them just rode. The horses walked. The wind came down off the tops and worked at them both.

"The fire I laid this morning took on the first strike," Selwyn said at last, to the road ahead. "Wet wood and all. You taught me that, the twist of bark under the kindling."

"I know I did."

"I'm only saying." Selwyn still did not look over. "I don't need a hard thing narrated to me either. I know how to sit next to one and keep my mouth shut." A pause. "I'll practice, if you like."

It was as near to it as either of them would come, and it was enough. Korvan let his horse drop back a length, not off this time, only back, and Selwyn let him, and some small clenched thing in the afternoon eased by a degree.

Toward dusk the men made a rough camp in the lee of a shoulder of rock, and someone got a fire going, and the flames drew the cold faces in around them the way flames always did. Korvan sat a little apart, close to the warmth and easy to overlook, in the spot he always seemed to fetch up at when there was a fire and a crowd. He watched the men across the light, the clan he had been raised inside and was now, somehow, both more and less a part of than he had ever been. One of the younger men, a boy called Har who two summers back had trailed him everywhere, begging to be shown how to lay a fire that would take wet wood, caught Korvan looking and shifted his bedroll a foot further off, not quite meaning to, the way you move a hand back from a stove. Korvan marked it and said nothing. It would be like

this now. Not cruelty, most of it. Just a small cold reckoning running quietly in everyone who had ever been easy with him, a working-out of how near it was safe to sit to a man who had knelt in the dark with the enemy and come away untroubled. By rights the fear should have had him by the throat. A war was coming and he had helped bring it and would have to stand in it with no shape and no second self to carry him through the worst. His hands, holding themselves to the fire, were steady. That was the thing he could not explain and did not trust — that the fear stayed off, that some ground had come up under him in the dark where there had never been ground before. Something had started. It had cost more than he could yet count, and it wore a girl's face, and for once in his whole shapeless waiting life he was near the front of a thing instead of trailing at the back of it. He did not sleep much. But for once he did not lie in the dark begging his body to finally do the thing it would not do. He lay and turned over the ocean, and a voice saying she hoped it was the whole of it.

In the morning they rode on. He did not look back at the house again; there was no use in it, and a man learns young in the hills not to spend himself on the country behind him. He set his face the way his father set his and turned it toward home, and toward the war gathering past home, and he let the one thought he was not ashamed of ride out ahead of him into the cold. The world had gone to enormous trouble to hand him an enemy. He was going to find her.

CHAPTER NINE

The Reason Is Gone

They took her not to a cell but to her mother's own rooms, which was worse, because a cell she would have understood.

The guards left her at the inner door and did not follow her through it, and then it was only the two of them, the Queen and the girl she had told a hall of five hundred she did not know, in the warm lamplit chamber where Amelia had spent the safest hours of her life. Her mother was standing at the cold hearth with her back to the door. She had taken off the crown of the evening, the thin silver circle she wore to be looked at, and set it on the mantel, and without it she was only a woman in a dark gown, narrow and straight, and when she turned around the sovereign was gone out of her face entirely and what was left underneath was so undefended that Amelia almost could not look at it.

"Come here," her mother said. "Come here, come here."

And Amelia crossed the room and was gathered up, hard, into arms that were cold as they had always been cold and that shook, now, which they had never done. Her mother held her the way you hold a thing you have just watched fall a long way and cannot believe is whole in your hands. For a while neither of them spoke. Amelia stood inside the cold fierce grip of the only unconditional thing in her life and felt her mother's cheek come down against her silver hair and stay there, and thought, this is the warm face, this is the face

the hall did not get, and she is giving it to me now because she took it from me before the whole hall and this is the only sorry she can make.

"You went down," her mother said at last, into her hair. Not angry. Wondering, almost. "All these years. And tonight of all nights, you went down."

"I wanted to be in the room."

"I know what you wanted." Her mother drew back and held her at arm's length and looked at her, and the naked face was already closing, not into the public mask but into something harder and more purposeful, a woman doing sums against a clock. "Listen to me now. We do not have long and there is a great deal to arrange. You cannot stay here. You understand that. After tonight this house is the first place they will look, every one of them, the chief's people and the grey man and my own lords who watched you stand there under the candles and are already weighing what a natural-born might be worth to them. You cannot be where they can reach you. So you will not be."

"Where," Amelia said.

"There is a place in the north." Her mother had begun to move, gathering things, a habit of the hands that let her keep her voice level. "It has no name that anyone says aloud. My grandmother built it for exactly this, for a thing that must not be found, and it has held everything it was ever given. You will go there tonight, before the roads wake, and you will be safe, and no one living but Maren and I will know the ground it stands on."

"For how long."

Her mother did not answer that.

"Mother. For how long."

"For as long as it takes." The Queen set down the small case she had been filling and did not look up from it. "Grief has a season. Even a war has a season. Men who want you

dead now will want other things in ten years, or twenty, or when they are themselves dead and their sons do not remember why the grudge was lit. You are the one thing in this world that has time. You will use it. You will wait, the way I have taught you to wait, and one day the waiting will be over."

Amelia stood very still in the middle of the warm room and heard what the words actually came to, under the kindness of them, and the count of it went into her cold and clean. A month. A year. Ten. All of them. The rest of her life, in a house with no name, kept.

"You mean forever," she said.

"I mean until it is safe."

"You mean forever. You have just described forever and put a kinder word on the front of it." Amelia heard her own voice come out level and quiet, her mother's own register, the one that carried without rising. "It will never be safe. You know that better than anyone alive. There is no year coming in which a born vampire is a small thing the world has stopped minding. You are not sending me somewhere to wait out a storm. You are sending me somewhere to be kept."

"Yes." Her mother looked up, and there was no dishonesty in her at all, which was the worst of it. "Yes. I am. I have kept you since the hour you were born, and it has worked, you are alive, and every rule I made you hate has held, and I would make every one of them again. You think this is new. It is not new. It is what it has always been. I am keeping you alive. I will keep you alive in a box for a thousand years before I will watch them take you apart in the open, and if you knew, if you had the least idea of what they would do to you, you would be packing that case yourself."

"I know what they would do." Amelia did not raise her voice. "I have known since I was small why the door has a bolt. But listen to yourself, Mother. Listen to the reason. You hid me so I could not be used. So that no one could point at me and say there is a natural-born under the Queen's roof and the treaty is a lie and there is your cause for war. That was the reason. That was the whole of the reason, my entire life. And it was a good reason and I obeyed it, I obeyed it the whole of my life without once being asked whether I agreed."

"Amelia—"

"The war is declared." She said it into the warm room and watched it land. "The grey man stood up tonight and pointed and it worked, and the chief has taken his people home to make ready, and it is already happening, out there, right now, while we pack a case. The thing the hiding was meant to prevent has happened. The reason is gone. It died in the hall tonight the moment he pulled back my hood, and everything you are doing now, the north house and the no-name ground and the thousand years, none of it is the old reason anymore, because the old reason is dead. It cannot be served. There is nothing left to protect by hiding me except—"

"Your life," her mother said. "Your life is left."

"Yes." Amelia's throat had gone tight and she made it hold. "My life is left. And that is another thing entirely, Mother, a wholly different thing, and you have not seen that it is different because to you it was always the same thing. But it is not. Keeping me from starting a war was your duty and I owed it to the treaty and to the world and to you, and I paid it, in full, every year I have been alive. Keeping me alive is not a duty. It is a want. It is your want, a good and loving want, and I love you for it. But a want is not a duty. It does not have a duty's claim on me. And it is not yours to spend

my whole existence on without once asking me what I might spend it on myself."

The Queen had gone very still. She set down the thing that had been in her hands the whole while, a folded travelling shawl she did not seem to have known she was holding, and laid it on the bed and smoothed it flat with one palm, once, twice, a small pointless tidiness that gave her somewhere to put her eyes that was not her daughter's face.

"You want to be asked," she said slowly. "You are twenty years old and there is a war lit for you and hunters on the roads by morning, and you want, at this exact moment, to be consulted."

"I want," Amelia said, "to be the one who decides what my life is for. Since the reason I never got to is dead, yes. Now. At this exact moment. Because there will not be a better one."

For a long moment her mother only looked at her, and Amelia watched the love and the terror war in that undefended face. It was the same love pulling both ways. The love that made her mother need to cage her was the love that made Amelia need to go, and one of them was going to break the other's heart before morning, and there was no arranging it otherwise.

"No," the Queen said.

Just that. Quiet, final, a door going into its frame.

"You are the last thing I have and the first thing I ever made that the world could not spoil, and I will not hand you to it because you have discovered, tonight, that you have a will. You have always had a will. I gave it to you along with everything else and I have spent all your years being glad of it and frightened of it in the same breath. You will go north. You will go tonight. And you will hate me, and you will be alive to hate me, and that is a trade I made my peace with before you could walk." She turned back to the case, and her hands, Amelia saw, had stopped shaking, which meant the

decision was made and set, because her mother's hands only shook while a thing was still in doubt. "I will send Maren with you as far as the first house. Say your goodbyes to her tonight. You will not be coming back this way."

And that was the moment Amelia understood she was not going to be able to argue her way out of the cage, because the cage was not made of argument. It was made of love, and it had just closed, gently, with a woman she adored on the wrong side of the bars.

So Amelia stopped arguing.

"All right," she said.

Her mother looked up, surprised, searching her face, and Amelia gave her the flat unreadable calm she had been drilled in before she could read, the stillness that gave nothing back, and watched her mother decide to believe it because she so badly wanted it to be true.

"All right," the Queen said, and something in her let go, and for a moment she was only tired. "Good. Good girl. It is the right thing. You will see, in time, that it is the right thing." She came and touched Amelia's face once, the cool hand against her cheek, the oldest gesture in the world between them. "I do know you," she said, very low, and it was the answer to the thing she had said in the hall, the private true one laid over the public lie. "You understand that. Whatever I said down there. I know you better than I have known anything in my life. That is why I can do this to you. Because I know exactly what I am spending, and I am spending it anyway, because the alternative is worse."

Then her mother went to the small case, and took out of it something she had wrapped already in a fold of grey silk, and pressed it into Amelia's hands, and folded Amelia's fingers over it with both of her own cold ones.

"For the north," she said. "You will not be able to hunt up there, and I will not have you weak. This is mine. My own."

You know how to wake it now, I taught you, and a few drops of it will hold the hunger off a week when there is nothing safe to take. There is not much. Make it last. It is the only kind of thing I have been able to send with you."

Amelia unfolded the silk enough to see. A small stoppered vial, thick green glass, and in it a dark red no lamplight reached the bottom of. Her mother's blood, drawn cold and kept, the one inheritance a mother who could not pass on her power could still hand her child, a piece of the thing itself. Amelia closed her hand around it and felt the small weight of it, and something in her that had held level through the whole argument came very close, for a moment, to going.

"Thank you," she said.

"Do not thank me. Use it. And when it is gone, learn what the north house has arranged, there are ways, Maren will show you—" Her mother stopped herself, and breathed, and did not finish, because they were the practical instructions of a woman handing her daughter to a grave and calling it a journey, and even she could not go on saying them past a certain point.

"I know," Amelia said, and meant it, and kissed her mother's cold cheek, and slid the vial into the breast of her gown against her own cold skin, and said goodbye to her without either of them knowing it was goodbye, because she had already decided, in the flat working part of her that never stops, that she was not going north — and that she was taking her mother's blood with her when she went, the last of her, the only piece the world had left them able to give each other.

* * *

Maren came at the turn of the night, the servants' way, a travelling cloak across one arm and her face set wrong.

"It's not right," she said, before the door was even shut. "None of it. I've packed a case for you to go and be buried alive in a house with no name and I've done it with my own hands and it's not right and I've said so, to Her, to Her face, which you may believe I have not done once in my life, and she looked at me the way she looks at a spoon that's come out of the count short, and told me to be ready by the low gate at the turn of the night." Maren's hands were full of the cloak and had nothing to fold, so they were strangling it instead. "So I'll be at the low gate at the third bell. Because when She uses that voice there's no door left in the room. But I want it on the record, wherever the record's kept, that Maren Vesk thinks this is a wickedness dressed up as a kindness, and that she is doing it because she is a coward and not because she agrees."

"Maren." Amelia took the cloak out of the murdering hands and set it down. "Sit."

"I won't sit. If I sit I'll cry, and if I cry I'll be no use to you, and you'll need me to have a face on at the gate."

"Sit. Please. I have to tell you something, and I can't tell it to you standing up because you'll bolt."

Maren sat. She sat on the cold floor with her back to the bed the way she had sat there a thousand nights of their lives, and Amelia sat down in front of her, close, their knees nearly touching, and took both of Maren's hands so they would have to be still.

"I'm not going north," Amelia said.

Maren's face did not change for a moment. Then it did, all at once, and her hands went cold in Amelia's. "No," she said. "No, no. Whatever it is. No."

"The north house is a grave, Maren. You said it yourself, buried alive. My mother is going to seal me in a box out of love and I will be safe in it and I will be there in fifty years, in a hundred, a thing kept in the dark because the world can't

be trusted with it, and she will visit when she can and grow old and die and I will still be there, the same, alone, kept. That is the whole of the life she is saving. And she is doing it because she cannot tell the difference between keeping me alive and keeping me, and I love her, and I am not going to let her."

"So you'll do what instead." Maren's voice had gone flat and fast, the way it went when she was frightened past the surface talk. "You'll run. A born vampire, alone, on roads that by tomorrow noon will have the grey man's people on every one of them, looking for exactly you. You'll last a night. You'll last less than a night. At least the box is a box. At least in the box you're breathing."

"Breathing isn't the only thing a person is for."

"It's the first thing. It's the one all the others sit on." Maren pulled one hand free and pressed it flat to her own mouth for a moment, then took it away. "Don't do this to me. Do you understand what you're asking. You're asking me to open the door. Because you can't do it without me, that's why you're telling me and not just going, you need the servants' ways and the counts and the gate that isn't watched, and there's one person in this house who has all of that in her hands and it's me. You're asking me to be the one who let the Queen's daughter walk out to die. She will know it was me. There is no one else it could be."

"Yes," Amelia said. "I'm asking you that. I know exactly what I'm asking. It's the worst thing I have ever asked anyone and I'm asking it of the only person I love as much as her."

Maren stared at her, and the tears she had been forbidding herself came anyway, silent, running down without her permission while her face stayed almost steady, and Amelia held her one captured hand and did not look away from it.

"You'd really rather," Maren said thickly. "You'd rather be out there with a knife at your back and free than in here safe and kept. You mean it. It's not a tantrum. I keep waiting for it to be a tantrum."

"It's not a tantrum."

"No." Maren wiped her face with the back of her wrist, roughly, angry at it. "No, I can see that it isn't. I've known your tantrums since you were four and this isn't one, worse luck, because a tantrum I could talk you down from." She was quiet a moment. Then, in a small voice with almost none of her in it: "I counted the silver again tonight. After she told me. I don't know why. My hands wanted a job. It came out two spoons short this time, not one." A wet almost-laugh. "Two. A house this crowded, coming apart at the seams, and me on the floor counting spoons while the whole world tips over. That's what I do. That's all I've ever known how to do, count the things and keep them in their places and keep you in yours." She looked up, and something in her had settled, terribly. "And I can't do it anymore, can I. Keep you in your place. Because your place was never a place. It was a cupboard we all agreed to love you in."

"Maren—"

"I'll open the gate," Maren said.

Amelia's breath went out of her.

"I'll open the gate, and I'll give you the turnings, and the counts, and the three coins I've got saved and you're not to argue about the coins. And I'll take whatever She does to me after, and it'll be bad, and I'll deserve exactly none of it and take it anyway, because you're right, God help me, you're right, and I would rather cut my own hand off than help you and I would rather do it than watch you get sealed in the north and call it mercy." She gripped Amelia's hand back now, hard, the strength of her surprising as it always was.

"But you listen to me. You listen. If you're going out there to die, then I've killed you, and I'll not have it. So you're going out there to live. You're going to be as careful as you have ever been in your careful life, more, you're going to be careful the way you rate a room, every second, and you're going to find somewhere and someone, and you're going to send me one word, one, in a year, any word, so I know I opened that gate onto a life and not a grave. Promise me that. Promise me the one word or I swear I'll bolt the gate myself and sit on you till the third bell."

"I promise," Amelia said. "One word. In a year."

"Say it like you mean to keep it."

"I promise you, Maren. On the only thing we've got, which is each other. One word."

Maren nodded, and nodded again, and then she folded forward all at once and put her forehead against their joined hands and cried properly, briefly, the way you let a thing out when you have decided and there is no more use pretending you have not, and Amelia held the back of her neck and let her, and did not cry herself, because one of them had to have the face on, and tonight, for once in their whole lives, it was going to be her.

* * *

The third bell came the way everything came in that house, muffled, from a long way off, folded in stone.

They went down through the dark house, and Amelia led. That was the thing she would keep, after, when there was room to keep things: that Maren stood back at the first black turning and let her take it, and corrected nothing, because there was nothing to correct. Every servants' stair and skip-turning that Maren had walked her through as a wistful game a hundred nights of her life was in her feet now, exactly as she had wanted it. They went down the north

service stair that carried no sound, past the still-room where a banked fire threw a red line under the door, along the cold underhall where the six-hundred-year chisel marks ran rough beneath her trailing hand.

At the turn into the kitchen passage she stopped so short that Maren walked into her back.

There was a light ahead. A tallow candle, low and guttering, and a boy beside it, one of the spit-boys, eight or nine years old, asleep sitting up against the great hearth with his chin on his chest, set to watch a fire that had sunk hours ago to coals. He was directly between them and the yard door, and there was no other way down that did not double back through the wing where the guests slept.

Amelia stood in the dark with her pulse loud in her ears and rated the little room the only way she knew, the throw of the candle, the slow depth of the child's breathing, the four steps of open stone she would have to cross inside the reach of the light. If he woke, he would see a hooded stranger in the kitchens at the third bell, and he would cry out, because crying out was the whole of his job, and the house would wake, and it would be finished before it began.

She went. She crossed the light on the balls of her feet the way she had crossed her own bolted room ten thousand silent nights, three steps, four, near enough to smell the tallow and the warm sleep coming off the child, and the boy stirred and made a small sound and turned his cheek against the stone and did not wake, and she was past, into the dark beyond, and Maren came after her the color of the wall. Neither of them breathed until the passage bent and shut the candle away behind them.

She had done it on her own held breath and her own quiet feet, and it was the most frightened she had ever been, and under the fear a small fierce nameless thing came up in her that she had no time to look at and did not put down.

The low gate stood in the north wall where the kitchens gave onto the kitchen yard, a small iron door for deliveries that a scullery hand would swear had been bolted at dusk, because Maren had bolted it at dusk, in front of the scullery hand, and had come back after and drawn the bolt without a sound. Beyond it was the lane, and the dark, and the cold turning world that did not know it held her.

"There's a carter leaves the east market before dawn for the river towns," Maren said, low and fast, all business now, because business was the only thing holding her upright. "Fat man, red cap, drinks. He'll not look twice at a hooded girl who pays and keeps quiet. Get down the river and off it again somewhere small. Don't take the first town. Don't take the second. And Amelia—" Her hands came up and settled the hood close around Amelia's silver hair, tucking it, the old fierce gesture, the last one. "—cover it. Whatever else. You cover it. It's the loveliest thing on you and it's the thing that gets you killed, and I've hated that about the world every day of your life, and cover it."

"I will."

Out in the dark of the lane, somewhere beyond the wall, a horse went by at a walk, and then another, unhurried, iron shoes ringing once each on the cobbles and going quiet, men riding without lamps in the last hour before dawn, and both of them went still and did not breathe until the sound had passed. Amelia knew what it was. So did Maren. It had already begun, out there, the slow patient closing of the net, riders on the roads by morning exactly as her mother had said, except that morning was not coming first. They were already here.

"Go," Maren whispered. "Go now, while they're past. Go."

Amelia put her arms around her once, hard, and Maren gripped her back so tight it hurt, and neither of them spoke the word goodbye, because they had said everything else

and that one was too big to lift. Then Amelia let go, and drew the bolt, and opened the small iron door onto the cold, and stepped through it out of the house that loved her and had meant to keep her forever, into the lane and the dark and the enormous unmapped world where nobody knew her name and everyone was looking for her face.

The gate shut behind her. She heard the bolt go home, Maren sealing it after her so the morning would find it locked, and the small iron sound was the last she ever had of the only home she had known.

For a moment she could not move at all, because there was too much of it. She had never in her life stood under a sky with nothing over it. All her years had had a ceiling, a floor above her floor, stone set between her and the weather, and now there was only the enormous black reach of the early morning going up and up with no top to it, and a wind that had crossed open country to reach her, cold and wide and smelling of things she had no names for, wet earth and far woodsmoke and the river somewhere below. A dog barked once, a long way off, and another answered it from further still. Down the hill a man was singing to himself the tuneless happy way of the very drunk, and none of it was arranged and none of it was for her or against her. It was only the world going on in the dark being itself, the ordinary night of a place that had never held her and did not know, now, that it did. It was so big. Nothing in the whole of her sealed and managed life had readied her for a night with no walls over it, no corridor to read, no bolt to track, nothing between her and the entire turning dark, and for the length of one breath the sheer open size of it frightened her worse than any rider on any road.

Then she took the first step, and it was only a step, and the world let her take it. The cobbles were wet and cold through her thin indoor shoes. Her breath went out white in

front of her, and she watched it go, the first breath of her life that the house did not own.

She pulled the hood close over the cold pale silver of it, as her mother had taught her and Maren had just done for the last time, and she turned east toward the market and the carter and the river, alone, hunted, uncaged, and afraid all the way to the floor of herself, and walked out into it on her own two feet, because she had chosen it.

CHAPTER TEN

She Comes to Him

The child was the worst of it, because a child has no guile to hide the thing behind.

Her name was Wren and she was six and she belonged to one of the drovers, and she had spent the first three days of the road home riding up on Korvan's saddlebow whenever her mother would let her, because Korvan made the faces and did the voices and knew which clouds meant rain. On the fourth morning she would not come. He held down his hand to her out of habit at the cold dawn camp and she looked at it, and then she looked up at his face with the whole open puzzlement of a small person doing a sum that would not come out, and then her mother came and took her hand and led her to another horse, not unkindly, not meeting his eyes, and the thing was done. Nobody had said anything to the child. Nobody had needed to. She had breathed the camp's new weather for four days and learned, the way children learn the important things, without a single word being spent on it, that the man with no shape had been out in the dark with the enemy, and that you did not, now, ride up on his saddle.

Korvan took his hand back and turned it into a stretch, as if he had only been reaching for the cold, and got on with striking his camp, and did not let his face do anything,

because his face was the last thing he had that was still entirely his.

It went like that, and had been going that way since the gates of that house dropped behind them, and it worsened by small degrees. No one accused him. That was not the clan's way. They worked by the shape of a silence, by who stopped talking when he came near a fire and who found somewhere else to be, and the silence around him had changed its shape entirely, from the old careful pity to something with a colder floor to it. And it was being helped, which was the part of it he could feel in his teeth and never prove to a soul. There were two low-clan men riding with the tail of the retinue, come up from the banquet camps to travel under the chief's protection as far as the passes, and they were quiet men, courteous men, and everywhere they went a certain story went a little way ahead of them and settled. Nothing you could stand up and answer. Only a wondering, laid down gently, fire by fire, the way Loric laid everything. Strange, wasn't it, that the boy had gone out to the garden that exact night. Strange that of all the men in the hall it was the chief's own shapeless son the vampire had got herself close to. You had to wonder what a creature like that saw in a boy like that. A man might wonder what was in his blood that had called to what was in hers. Nobody said it. Everybody, by the fifth night, had heard it wondered.

He caught them at it once himself, watering their horses downstream of him at a ford, not troubling much to lower their voices, which was its own kind of message.

"—no shame in it, mind," the older one was saying, mild as milk. "A lonely creature reaches for a lonely creature. Almost a sad thing, when you turn it over. The pity is only that it was the chief's own boy. Puts a chief in a hard spot, doesn't it. A man can't well lead the clans to war on a thing his own son's been keeping warm."

"Keeping warm," said the younger, and grinned into his horse's neck.

"I said no such thing. I said no such thing, now." A pause, unhurried, pitched for Korvan's back not twelve feet off and every man at the ford besides. "I only wonder. It's a natural thing to wonder."

Korvan finished watering the roan and did not turn and did not hurry, gave them the bored face and the empty hands his father had asked of him, and led the horse back up the bank with his heart slamming and his face giving them nothing. He hated that his father was right. He hated that the not-answering was the only answer there was, that every word he might have flung back over his shoulder was one more handful of food for the exact fire he was trying to starve.

His father came to him on the fifth night. Not to his fire, because Korvan did not have a fire of his own, but to the place at the back of the camp where he had rolled out his blanket, and the chief crouched down beside him in the dark the way he did everything, without announcement, and looked out at the fires and not at his son.

"They're wondering aloud about your blood," the chief said.

"I've heard."

"Loric's two quiet men." His father turned a bit of pine bark over in his fingers. "I can't send them off. They've the right of the road as far as the passes and everyone knows it, and if I move against them I've told the whole camp the story's worth moving against, which is halfway to telling them it's true. So I can't touch it. Which means you carry it." He said nothing for a breath. "There's a way to carry a thing like this so it dies, and a way to carry it so it feeds. You give them nothing. No heat, no explaining, no going quiet in a corner where they can watch you be ashamed. A story like

this starves on a man who acts like there's nothing to the story. It fattens on a man who acts like there's a thing to hide. Do you understand me. Whatever you feel about any of it, you give them a bored face and an empty pair of hands from here to home, and in a month it's a thing that got wondered once on a cold road and came to nothing."

"Give them nothing," Korvan said.

"That's all of it, the whole trick." His father put a hand briefly on the back of Korvan's neck, awkward, there and gone, the nearest he came to it, and it landed on Korvan like a coal. "You've done nothing wrong, boy. Carry yourself the way an innocent man does. It's the one weapon you've got and it happens to be the true one." Then he rose, knees cracking, and went back toward the fires and his people, and left his son lying in the dark holding the words like something breakable.

An empty pair of hands. Korvan lay under the cold sky and turned the words over and over and held onto them, because they were the truest thing anyone had put in his keeping in a week, and because some part of him below the arguing had already gone quiet and certain in a way he did not like and could not read, quietly sure of a thing the rest of him had not yet been told.

So Korvan rode at the back and kept his face still and waited for a home that no longer felt like it would be one when he got there, and told himself none of it mattered, and did not believe himself, and this was the state he was in on the sixth night when he walked out from the fires to see to the horses and found the enemy waiting for him in the dark.

He knew it was her before he could have said how. The horse-lines were strung along the outer line of the camp under a stand of black pines, out past the last of the firelight, and he went along them in the dark by feel and by the warm grassy breath of the animals, checking a fetlock here and a

picket there because it gave his hands something to do that was not sitting still being wondered about, and somewhere in the deep shadow under the pines the dark changed. It did not move. It got, very slightly, more aware. He stopped with his hand on the roan's neck and his own heart going up, and he did not call out, and had no idea why he didn't, except that some old settled part of him had already told the rest of him who it was, the way it had told him in a garden, the whole animal truth of the man leaning toward the one creature he should have bolted from.

"Don't," said her voice, very low, out of the black. "Please. Don't call them. I know just what one word from you does. I've been lying here two hours working out whether you'd say it."

"You," Korvan said. It came out of him cracked.

"Me." A small dry sound that in a better world would have been a laugh. "You told me once the party finds you everywhere. Even out here."

He could see her now, or the shape of her, folded down small against the base of a pine with her knees drawn up and a dark cloak over everything, and he crossed the last of the ground to her without deciding to, and went down on his heels an arm's length off, close, the way he had sat down beside her at the fountain, and it was nothing like the fountain. At the fountain she had been a mystery he wanted to solve. Now she was a mortal danger he could feel the cold coming off of, and he still, God help him, wanted to be nearer her than he was.

"You're the vampire," he said. "You're the Queen's daughter. You're the born one. You're the whole war."

"Yes."

"You sat there. In the garden. And let me—" He stopped. His voice was doing things he could not govern. "I wished you the ocean."

"I know." He heard her swallow. "I have thought about that more than you would believe. It was the kindest thing a living soul had said to me and I couldn't tell you it was going to a monster, so I said nothing, and I've hated the nothing every day since. I'm sorry. It's a poor thing to bring you, six days late in the freezing dark, but it's true and I wanted you to have it. I'm sorry."

Korvan crouched there in the pine-dark with his blood roaring in his ears and tried to hold on to the anger, because the anger was the only thing in the situation that made ordinary sense. She was the reason. She was the pretext bleeding his clan, the crack the whole peace had fallen into, the thing his father had gone to war partly to bury him under. Every mile of misery of the whole miserable week had her name on it, the name he still did not have. And he could not make the anger keep its shape, because under it, plain and stupid and undeniable, was the fact that the one person in the entire turning world who had ever looked at him and seen a whole man was folded small and starving under a tree in his enemy's camp, and she had come to him.

"Why are you here," he said. "Why are you not a hundred miles from here in the other direction."

"Because a hundred miles in the other direction is where they're looking." Her voice steadied when it had a fact to hold. "The grey man's riders are on every road out of the low country. I got down the river two towns and there were already men in the third asking after a girl travelling alone, so I got off the river. I've been four days in hedges. I've been eating—" a small pause —"I've been managing. And I sat in a hedge two nights ago doing the only arithmetic that matters, which is where is the one place on the whole map that nobody, nobody, will think to look for the Queen's vampire daughter, and the answer came out the same every way I turned it. The last place anyone will look for me is inside the

war-party that's marching home because of me. Nobody hunts the fox in the hounds' own kennel. And there is exactly one person in that kennel who has already had every chance to hand me to the dogs and didn't take it, so."

"So you walked into the chief's camp."

"So I walked into the chief's camp," she agreed, "and I have been lying under this tree for two hours smelling forty men who would tear me apart on sight, waiting for the one of them who might not, and betting my life that he was still the man from the garden and not the man the last six days have tried to make him. It was not a comfortable bet. I would not recommend the making of it."

For a while he said nothing. The wind moved in the pines over them. Back at the fires a man laughed at something, and the sound carried out to them thin and far, a noise from a world that still made ordinary sense.

"You know what you've cost me," Korvan said at last. Not cruelly. He said it because it was true and it was sitting on his chest and he had carried it six days without setting it down for anyone. "Not you. I don't mean you did it on purpose. But the fact of you. A week ago I was a joke my clan was gentle about. Now I'm a man they watch. My father's hold on them is slipping fire by fire and half the reason is that his shapeless son was found in the dark with the war. There's a child who rode on my saddle for three days and won't come near me now, and nobody told her not to, she just breathed the camp and knew. And all of it, every mile of it, runs back to a girl with silver hair who wanted one night at a party. So I'll hear your sorry. But you should know what the nothing you couldn't say has grown into out here, because I've carried it every mile, and it's heavy, and it has got your face on it."

She took that in the dark and did not flinch from it and did not argue it, which was worse than either.

"I know what I've cost," she said. "Yours, and a great many people's, and I won't insult you by making it smaller than it is to buy a softer look off you. I did not start a war. The man who wants my mother to suffer started one, and used me to strike the match. But you're right that none of it happens without me. If I had never been born your clan would be asleep in its own hills tonight and that child would ride wherever she pleased. I've done that sum too. It comes out that the kindest thing I could be for the whole world is the thing my mother spent my life trying to keep me, which is nothing, which is gone and unseen and safely dead. And I find that I can't. I sat in a hedge four days and tried to want to lie down and stop, and I couldn't manage it, and I don't know whether that makes me brave or only selfish, and neither do you. So don't spend tonight deciding."

"I wasn't going to."

"Good."

He let a silence go by, and then he made himself ask the thing he did not have a clean word for. "When did you last. Feed."

The pause before she answered told him most of it. "I have something my mother gave me. Her own. A little, in a vial, and I've made it last as long as a thing like that can be made to last." Her voice had gone very level, and he was learning that the level voice was the frightened one. "It's nearly gone. That's the sum I didn't say out loud when I laid the rest of them down for you. Three days left in the glass, maybe. And after the glass there is a hunger I have been taught since before I could talk to fear worse than any hunter on any road, because it is the one thing about me that does not care in the least who it takes. So when you tell me not to feed on anyone in this camp, hear what you are actually asking. You are asking me to lie three feet from forty warm sleeping men, starving, for longer than I can honestly

promise you I can hold, and to die under that canvas rather than break your terms. I will try. I only want you to know that with me, try is a larger word than it is with other people."

Korvan looked at the dim shape of her against the black trunk and understood, cold and complete, that he was not proposing to hide a frightened woman. He was proposing to hide a danger that would, the moment he failed to keep her fed and hidden and whole, become the precise monster the whisper had made of her, loose in his father's own camp among his father's own sleeping people. It should have unmade the decision. He sat and waited for it to unmake the decision. It did not, and he stopped waiting, and that was how he knew the decision had already been made somewhere below the part of him that argued.

The heel of his hand went hard against his forehead, a white pressure building behind the eyes the way it did when the world asked more of him than he had. She had laid the whole thing down in the dark between them, plain, the way she laid everything, and left him the doing of it, and he understood with a cold lurch exactly what she was handing him and exactly what it would cost.

Because he could end it here. That was the thing that stood up in him and would not sit down. He could stand up out of this dark and take three steps toward the fires and say one word, her, here, the vampire, and everything the road had made of him would come undone in an instant. He would not be the shapeless boy the enemy had got close to. He would be the man who caught her. The chief's son who sniffed out the Queen's daughter in the dark and gave her to his people, redeemed at a stroke, a hero, a shifter after all in the one way that counted, the way that smells the enemy and does not fail. His father's grip would stop slipping. Brice would find something else to do with his mild cruelty. Wren would ride up on his saddlebow in the morning. One word

bought him back the whole of his life, and the price of it was folded small and shaking under a tree with her chin up, having bet that he would not pay it.

"You're doing it now," she said quietly. "The sum. I can hear you doing it. It's all right. It's the right sum to do. I did it myself before I came, from your side, every step of it, and I came anyway, because a person who's out of moves plays the one card that might be a person. If you're going to call them, call them. Don't crouch there and be kind about it. That I couldn't stand."

"Be quiet," Korvan said. "I'm thinking."

"I know. That's what frightens me."

And that, in the end, was the thing that decided it, though he could not have explained it to a soul and never tried. Not the garden. Not the pull, though the pull was there, low and constant and shameful under everything. It was that she had said be quiet I'm thinking back to him, dry, in the dark, with her life on the table, the exact register two people use who are on the same side of a hard problem. Nobody had ever put him on their side of anything. His whole clan stood on one side and Korvan stood alone on the other being a question, and here was a starving vampire who had crossed a hundred miles of hunting ground to sit on his side of a fire he had not lit yet, and the animal in him that had gone quiet toward her in a garden went quiet again now, and settled, and called her his.

"If I do this," he said, low and fast, "you do exactly what I say, when I say it, no questions in the moment, we can fight after. You don't let anyone see you. You don't feed on anyone in this camp, not a horse, not a man, nothing, I don't care how bad it gets, because a drained anything is the end of both of us. And if it comes apart, if we're found, you don't know me. You crept in on your own. You never spoke to me. Whatever they do to me for being a fool, they don't get to

hang the hiding on me too, because I'll have a war to try and live through and a father to try and look at. Those are the terms. All of them."

There was a silence out of the dark that had something in it he had not heard from her before.

"You're going to do it," she said. "You're actually going to do it."

"I'm going to regret it the whole rest of my probably very short life," Korvan said, "yes. There's a supply cart, third from the tail, half full of grain sacks and canvas and my own kit because nobody wants to load next to the shapeless one's gear. You can lie under the canvas by day. You move at night, when I move, and only where I put you. It's mad. It won't hold a week. But a week gets us up into the high country where the passes split, and up there I know ground nobody down here does, and a week is more than you've got lying in hedges. Can you walk? You sound like you can't walk."

"I can walk." She got up to prove it and swayed, and he had a hand out and under her elbow before he had told his arm to move, and she was appallingly light and appallingly cold, colder than the night, cold the way the dead are cold, and he made himself not react to it, and she felt him make himself not react to it, and something passed between them in the dark that had no name and did not need one.

"Thank you," she said. Not lightly. There was a whole life in it.

"Don't thank me. You heard the man from that garden say that. It's still true. Thank me if we're both breathing at the passes." He got her cloak straight around her, the way Maren had, the way her own mother had, an ordinary gesture that half the people who loved her had done and he now found himself doing, and he stopped with his hands on her shoulders and looked at the pale of her face in the

pine-dark and said the thing he had not planned to say and could not, once it was in his mouth, hold back.

"Korvan," he said. "My name. I never gave it to you. You crossed the whole country to a man you couldn't name, and that's—" he shook his head. "It's Korvan. Now you've got it. Now if you're going to die in my father's grain cart you'll at least know whose fault it was."

He felt her go still under his hands.

"In the garden you wouldn't even ask me mine," she said. "You said you wouldn't ask it. To keep me safe."

"Your name was the dangerous one, in the garden. Not mine. Mine was never worth the hiding." He let his hands drop. "And out here they've taken the rest of you already. What you are, whose you are, the whole of it, cried through a hall I wasn't even standing in. But not your name. Nobody in that hall ever got your name. It might be the one thing of yours the world hasn't closed its hand around. So I won't be the one to take it either. You keep it. Give it to me some night when it's yours to give and not a thing that can be used against you. Give it to me when it's only a name."

For a moment she did not speak, and when she did her voice had gone rough in a way that had nothing to do with hunger.

"You are a very strange man, Korvan," she said, "for a war to be about."

"A strange everything, remember," he told her. "I did warn you of it."

And she made the sound then that in a better world would have been a laugh, and this time it very nearly was one, low and broken and real, out there in the freezing dark of the enemy's camp. Korvan stood in it with a monster's weight leaning trusting against his hands, damned now past any story his father could bury him under, and he did not let go.

Getting her to the cart was the longest hundred feet of his life.

The camp was not asleep, not all of it. There was a fire still burning low at the center where three or four men sat up too wound to sleep, and there was a sentry, young Fenn of the bear-clan, walking a slow ring around the pickets with a spear up on his shoulder and nothing to do but be awake and watch the dark, which was exactly the dark they had to cross. Korvan stood at the pine-line with her at his shoulder and timed it, the way he timed a fire's draw, the swing of Fenn's slow circle, the count of his steps out and the count back, the moment the sentry's round turned him to face the black hills and put his back for a dozen paces to the carts.

"When I move, you move," Korvan breathed. "When I stop, you're a bush. He's got no reason to look hard. Give him no reason to start."

They went on Fenn's turn. Korvan walked it ordinary, upright, a man who could not sleep going to check his own gear, because a man creeping is a man seen and a man strolling is furniture, and she came at his hip low and silent and so light on the cold ground that he could not hear her over his own feet. Halfway across Fenn stopped. Just stopped, the spear coming off his shoulder, his head going up, and Korvan felt her turn to stone against his side and he kept walking, one more step, two, made himself yawn, wide and loud and rude, and Fenn's head came round at the sound.

"You," Fenn said. Not friendly. Not the reverse. Wary, the new wariness.

"Can't sleep," Korvan said, and it was true enough to sit right in his mouth. "Thought I'd shift my kit off the wet side of the cart before the dew got into it. You want to watch me do it, come watch me do it. It's grain sacks and a spare bridle. Riveting stuff."

For a moment the whole of both their lives hung on a bored bear-clan boy deciding whether the shapeless one shifting his own wet gear at midnight was worth the walk over. Then Fenn made a small disgusted sound, the sound of a man reminded he is cold and bored and would rather not, and put the spear back up on his shoulder and turned to walk his ring, and said, to the hills, "Rivets. God help us," and Korvan's heart started again.

He had the canvas up and her folded down into the well of grain sacks and the canvas back over her between one of Fenn's circuits and the next. It was done. She was in his father's supply train, a living vampire three carts from the tail, hidden under the kit nobody would touch because it was the shapeless one's, and there was no undoing it now, not without undoing himself along with it.

He lay down alongside the cart with his blanket over him and his back to the wheel, close enough to hear her if she moved, and he stayed awake there the rest of the night, listening to a camp that would kill them both by morning if it knew. Once, near dawn, something shifted under the canvas, a small dry sound, and without deciding to he put his hand flat against the cold boards between them. After a moment, past the boards, he felt her go still, listening back, close enough that a hand's-width of grain-cart pine was the whole of the distance left between them. Neither of them made a sound. There was nothing three inches of grain-cart board could be trusted to carry. He left his hand where it was until the sky went grey over the pines.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Two Targets

By the third day of it Korvan had learned that hiding a person is not a thing you do once. It is a thing you do every hour, at a cost that never comes down, and it had begun, quietly, to make him hate her.

Not her. The situation. But the situation wore her face, the way everything did now, and there were moments, lying awake at noon in the jolting stink of the grain cart with a vampire eighteen inches away under the same canvas, when he could not tell the two apart and did not try very hard to. Every stop was a small war. Every time the train halted and a man wandered back toward the tail carts to piss or to fetch a thing, Korvan had to be there, casual, in the way, a shapeless boy fussing over his own gear, and the fussing had a shelf life. Bricc had already asked him twice why he minded his kit so close these days, in the mild grinding voice, and Korvan had said something about a book he didn't want rained on, and Bricc had looked at him a beat too long. Selwyn had stopped coming back to the tail at all, which was worse, because Selwyn coming back would have been ordinary and Selwyn not coming back meant Selwyn had noticed there was a reason not to.

And she ate nothing, and got no stronger, and the not-getting-stronger was its own slow clock ticking under everything else.

The worst of it came on the third afternoon, at a water halt, and it was Bricc.

Korvan was at the stream filling skins when he heard the old man's voice change register three carts off, that flat pleased tone a man gets when he has finally decided to do the thing he has been not-doing for days. By the time Korvan came up the bank with the water slopping, Bricc was already at the tail, one hand on the corner of the grain cart. He was saying to nobody in particular that a wet spring made the sacks mold and somebody ought to turn the load, and reaching for the canvas.

"Leave it," Korvan said, too fast, and heard it be too fast, and made himself slow. "It's turned. I turned it this morning. You'll only untidy my kit and I'll spend an hour hunting my flint again."

"Will I." Bricc did not take his hand off the canvas. He looked at Korvan with the small patient cruelty of a man who has all afternoon and a suspicion he means to feed. "Funny thing. A man minds his gear this close, a body starts to think he's got more than flint under there. You've gone strange about this cart, boy. Whole camp's said so. So I'll just have a look, and then I'll have stopped wondering, and we'll both be the better for it."

There was nothing Korvan could do. That was the thing that opened under him like cold water. He could not stop a clan-head from looking in a supply cart without making the looking the most important act in the camp, and Bricc knew it, and was already lifting the canvas back, and Korvan stood there with the skins dripping down his legs and his whole ruined life about to be hauled out into the afternoon light in front of forty men.

The canvas came back on grain sacks, and his own roll, and a spare bridle, and nothing else.

Bricc stood looking at a cartful of exactly what a cart should hold. He prodded a sack. He lifted the edge of the bedroll with two fingers and let it drop. He grunted, a sound with disappointment in it and something that might, in a smaller man, have been the start of shame, and said, "Huh," and took his hand back, and told Korvan the load still wanted turning, and walked off up the line to be somewhere he had not just been wrong.

Korvan stood at the tail of the cart with his heart trying to climb out of his mouth and did not understand, for a moment, why he was still alive.

He found her after dark, when he walked the pickets and doubled back low along them, folded into the wheel-shadow under the cart bed itself, in a space he would have sworn on his life a child could not have taken, wedged up against the axle with her cloak pulled dark over the pale of her and not a line of her showing.

"How," he said, crouching, keeping his voice under the wind.

"I heard his boots change," she said. "Three carts off. The step gets heavier when a man's decided a thing. You told me once a fire wants a throat, that a thing gives itself away by its shape before it does anything at all. Boots are the same. I had a count of about eight before he reached the tail, and eight was enough. I have had a lifetime of practice at not being where the danger looks." A pause. "You were good, by the way. The flint. Small and dull and put-upon. Nobody hides a war behind a lost flint. You gave him a way to be wrong that cost him nothing, so he took it. That was well done. I'd not have thought of the flint."

Korvan crouched in the dark and found, to his considerable irritation, that being told he had done a thing well by a starving vampire under a cart landed warmer on him than any praise he had had off his own people in a year.

"You heard him from three carts," he said. "Half asleep."

"I don't sleep, much. And I hear everything. It's the one thing being what I am is good for, so I have made it the thing I am best at." He heard the dry note come back into her. "We are not bad, it turns out. At this. For two people who would each be a good deal safer with the other dead in a ditch."

"Don't," Korvan said, but there was no heat in it, and she heard that too, and let it lie.

They fought on the fourth night. It had been coming since the pines and it came at last in a whisper, in the black behind a boulder where he had walked her to stretch the cramp out of her legs while the camp slept, and it was, he thought later, the truest conversation either of them had yet had, because it was the first one with no manners left in it.

"You could go faster if you weren't dragging me," she said. She said it flatly, not as a kindness. "You know that. You've done the sum. You're three days from the passes and you'd be there tomorrow without a cart to nurse and a thing to feed and hide. I've watched you not say it for four days. Say it. It's cleaner said."

"All right." His own voice came out low and hard and he let it. "You want it said. You are the worst thing that has ever happened to me, and I have had a run of bad things. A week ago my clan pitied me. Now they watch my hands. My father's hold is going and half of why is you. There's a war on my people that is about you, that has your name on every mile of it, the name I still don't have, and I am carrying the actual cause of it in my father's own grain cart like a fool carrying the coal that's going to burn his house down. That's the whole ledger of it. You asked. There it is."

"Good," she said. "Now I don't have to wonder if you know."

"And you." He was not finished. It had been building four days and it came now. "You walked into my camp and made

it my problem. You worked it out from your side and it came out that the one card left to you was a lonely boy who'd already proved he was soft, and you played me, cold, the way you were taught to read a treaty, cold. Didn't you. You didn't come to me because I saw you as a person in a garden. You came to me because a man who'd sat with you once in the dark was your best odds of not being torn apart, and the person was just the part that made the odds work."

There was a silence out of the dark, and when she spoke there was something in her voice he had not heard before, an edge under the flat that was almost, not quite, hurt.

"Both," she said. "It was both. Do you want it to be only the cold one, so you can be angry clean? It won't be true. I did the sum and you came out the answer, and I also came to you and not to some other soft fool because it was you, because you were the one face in that hall that looked at me and did not first look at what I was worth or what I was owed. Both of those are true at once. I have spent my whole life being one thing to the world and another thing to the three people who loved me, and not once in all of it have I had the luxury of being only one thing to anybody, and I'm not going to start pretending to it now to make your anger simpler. I used you. I meant it. Both. Learn to hold two things or you'll be no use to either of us."

Korvan stood there in the black with his heart going hard and found he had nothing to throw back at that, because it was exactly the way she had undone him in the garden, the plain laying-down of a hard true thing with no handle on it for him to grab. And he understood, standing there furious and disarmed, that this was going to be the shape of it. That she was not going to be grateful and soft and rescued. That she was going to be this, sharp and honest and using him and meaning it, and that some wrong-wired part of him

would rather have this at knifepoint than the gratitude of any easier person alive.

"Fine," he said. "Both. Get back in the cart before Fenn comes round."

"There," she said, and there was the ghost of the dry thing in it again. "Was that so hard. Two things at once. You'll be a philosopher by the passes."

* * *

From under the canvas, in the long murdering boredom of the daylight hours, Amelia learned the clan by its sounds the way she had once learned rooms.

She could not see them. She could hear everything. And what she heard, hour on jolting hour, was a good people being made, gently and expertly and from a great distance, into a mob. She heard the two low-clan men at their work, and she had to admire it even as it turned her cold, because it was her mother's own craft turned to a smaller uglier purpose. They never lied. That was the thing. They only wondered, and left spaces, and let the frightened fill them. And what they were building, patiently, cart by cart and fire by fire, was Korvan. Not the war, not her mother, not even her. Him. The shapeless one who'd been out in the dark with the creature. The wrongness in their own midst that they should have smelled and hadn't. By the fourth day she heard a man she'd marked as decent, a bear-clan father who sang to his horse, say to another that there'd always been something not right about the chief's boy, hadn't there, some coldness, and that maybe it wasn't the boy's fault, maybe it was in the blood, but you had to wonder if a thing like that in the camp wasn't part of why the luck had turned.

She heard the whole of one such working, once, laid down so gently it could have passed for kindness.

"He's not a bad lad, mind," one of the grey men said, to the bear-clan father, easy, by a fire she could hear and not see. "I want to be clear on it. I've nothing against the boy. It's a hard thing, to be born wrong through no fault of your own."

"He shifts late, is all," the father said. "My own cousin's boy didn't come in till twenty."

"Course he does. Late. That's all it is." A pause, warm, unhurried. "Only, and you'll know this better than a road-man like me, only a late shifter still smells of his clan, doesn't he. Still runs warm to a nose that can read it. And I stood beside that boy at the ford today, close as I am to you now, and I'll tell you what I did not smell off him, and maybe it's nothing at all." Another pause, longer, the space left open like a held door. "You've little ones near that end of the train. That small girl that used to ride up on his saddle. I'd have thought not a thing of it a fortnight past. It's only now, knowing what he went out into the dark to sit with, that a man finds himself wondering. That's all it is. I only wonder. A father would."

And the bear-clan man, who was decent, who sang to his horse in the mornings, said nothing for a moment, and then said, low, "I'll keep Wren off that end of the train," and the road-man said, "I'm sure it's nothing," and that, Amelia thought, was how it was done. That was the entire black craft of it, and it was flawless. You never told a man to be afraid. You gave him a child to keep safe, and let the fear grow its own roots in the dark, and it grew them straight into the one man who had done nothing in his life but be kind to a frightened girl at a party.

She lay under the canvas and listened to them build a monster out of the one person keeping her alive, and understood that she was watching it happen and could do nothing, and that if she rose up to stop it she would only prove every word they had been careful not to quite say.

He had been good to her. That was the part that sat wrong in her, that she turned over in the dark and could not make lie flat. She had come to him as a calculation, and he had turned out to be, under the calculation, exactly what she'd gambled and more, careful and furious and honest and there. Every mile he was making himself more of a monster in their eyes by keeping her breathing. He knew it. He was doing it anyway. And never in her managed life had she been kept alive by someone who was paying for it in front of her, where she had to watch.

By that morning she was down to a mouthful in the vial. Tilted against the seam of light through the canvas, the dark red sliding, it came to two swallows, maybe three if she was cruel to herself, and after that there was the thing she had been raised since infancy to fear. Him she had told three days, and that had been days ago. The truth of how close it had come she had kept to herself. She could feel it now the way you feel weather coming, a low constant wrongness in the back of her jaw, a new and terrible interest in the warm sleeping bodies all around her in the dark, forty hearts she could hear if she let herself, forty warm easy—

It nearly took her that same night.

A man got up in the small hours to make water, one of the drovers, and he came back the long way, close by the tail carts, close enough that she heard the blood in him move, the whole warm working machine of him three feet from her head through a skin of canvas, and something in her that was not her sat up. She did not decide to move. She was simply, suddenly, halfway out from under the canvas, her hand already lifted, her whole body turned toward the sound of him like a plant to light. There was no thought in it at all. No counting. No rule. Only the want, vast and simple and older than she was. And the man yawned and scratched and stood not a stride off, his throat bare to the moon, with no

idea in the world that his death had just risen up quiet behind him and reached.

She got a fistful of grain sack in her raised hand instead of him. She did not remember choosing to. She held onto it, the rough burlap and the shift of the seed inside it, and made herself feel that, only that, the weave and the weight, while every other part of her screamed at the warm man walking away, and she lay back down by degrees, one degree at a time, her hand cramping shut on the sack, and she shook, silently, appallingly, for a long while after he was gone. She lay in the dark with the grain sack crushed to her chest like the last solid thing left in the reeling world and understood that she had two days, maybe less, before the thing that reached was faster than the thing that stopped it, and that when that happened it would not be a stranger's throat under her hand. It would be his, because his was the one she was always nearest.

She pressed the hunger down the way she had been drilled to, the cold clear discipline, and lay rigid and starving under the canvas of the man she was going to have to warn, and warn honestly, that the thing he was hiding was about to become the thing they said it was, and that when it did he should run and not look back, whatever he thought he felt. Because she had made him one promise already, in her head, that she had not said out loud, which was that whatever else happened out here she was not, she was not, going to be the reason his blood went into the ground.

That night, when he walked her out to stretch, she said, "It's sooner than I told you. The vial. I lied about the days. I'm sorry. It's two, maybe, and then I'm a danger you can't hide, because a starving one of me doesn't stay hidden, it hunts, and it won't know your face from any other warm thing. So you need a plan for that. A real one. Where you put me, or what you do to me, when it comes to that. I'd rather you

decided it now, cold, than in the dark with it already happening."

She watched him take it. He did not flinch and he did not soften, and she found she had come, in four days, to be steadied by exactly that, the way he met a hard thing with his hands open.

"We'll be at the passes in two," he said. "There's a herd-station up there, my uncle's, empty this time of year. There'll be a beast in the winter fold, there always is, a sick ewe or a lamed steer somebody left. It's not a person." He said the last part looking at her, level, and she understood it was a question dressed as a statement, the same shape she used herself.

"It's not a person," she agreed. "It has never been a person. That's the one rule under all my rules. Whatever else I am." She let a breath go. "But that's the good plan, and I asked you for the other one. The one for when the two days aren't enough. When it's the third night and the vial's dry and I wake already moving, the way I did last night, only with nobody's hand left on the rein. You get me to something with a heartbeat that isn't a person, and you do it fast. And the night there's nothing to get me to — you run. That's the whole of the other plan. Say you'll keep to it."

"I'm not going to say it."

"You have to say it. Now, while I'm still a person you can say it to. Because in three nights I won't be, and you'll be a warm heart eighteen inches from a starving thing that stopped being your friend, and you'll hesitate, because you're the man who wished a monster the ocean, and the hesitation is exactly how you die. So I need to know you've decided it already. I need to know there's a thing in your kit that isn't a flint, and that your hand knows where it lies in the dark, and that you'll use it on me before you'll use it on

the men whose fault none of this is. Tell me you will. It's the only thing you can give me that I actually need."

For a moment he did not answer, and the wind came down off the high country and moved the scrub around them, and she thought he would refuse her, the way soft people always refused this, out of a kindness that got everyone killed.

"There's a skinning knife in the roll," Korvan said at last, low. "Left side, wrapped in the spare shirt. My hand knows it." He looked at her, and there was nothing soft in his face at all, only the flat open way he met the worst things. "If it comes to it, I'll do it, and I'll do it fast, and I won't hang back, and I'll hate you for making me carry that as well, on top of all the rest you've loaded on me. Is that what you wanted. Does that let you rest."

"Yes," she said, and the word came out unsteady, because he had just promised to put a knife in her and it had landed like the gentlest thing anyone had done for her in years. She did not thank him. Somewhere back down the road she had stopped being able to tell his cruelties from his kindnesses, and she was no longer certain she wanted the trick of it back.

"Then we make the passes in two," he said, "and you hold, and I'll get you a beast, and we don't talk about the other plan because we're not going to need the other plan."

It was not true, or not certainly true, and they both knew it, and he said it anyway, the way he'd wished her the ocean, and she took it the same way, and neither of them put the word thank you into the air, because it had quit being, somewhere in the last four days, a thing they needed to say.

* * *

Three hundred miles behind them, in the great house, Maren Vesk stood in front of the Queen and lied with her whole body, which was the hardest work she had ever set it.

"She reached the first house before dawn," Maren said. "Cold and cross and safe. The northmen had the second team fresh and waiting, as you arranged. I saw her into the closed carriage myself and I watched it onto the north road and I did not come away until I couldn't see it anymore." Every word of it was a picture she had built in her head so carefully that it had almost the weight of a true memory, which was the only way she had found to say it without her hands giving her away. She kept her hands still by main force. She had counted the hall silver twice that morning to use them up and it hadn't been enough. "She'll be past the river fork by now. Another day to the ground you don't name. She's away, madam. She's away and she's safe."

The Queen was at the long window with her back to the room, looking down at a courtyard full of the beginnings of a war, and she did not turn from it, and for a long moment she said nothing, and Maren stood in the silence certain that it had not worked, that the Queen had heard the lie sitting under the words the way she heard everything, and was only deciding how to open her up about it.

"Thank you, Maren," the Queen said.

That was all. And Maren, who had braced to be caught, found that not being caught was worse. It meant the Queen believed her. It meant the Queen was standing at that window grieving a daughter she thought was safely buried alive, when the truth was that the girl was loose on a hunted road with a mouthful of blood between her and the dark. And the one person who could have told the Queen so was standing three feet behind her with her mouth shut, choosing the girl over the mother all over again, every second she stayed quiet.

"Did she leave me anything," the Queen said. Still to the window. Still even. "A word. She was angry when she went. I would not blame her for leaving nothing, but I find I would like to know if there was anything."

And here was the place where a lie cost too much. Maren felt the whole weight of it come down on her at once. The Queen was not asking as a sovereign now. She was asking as a mother, quietly, with her back turned so no one would have to see her face do it. To invent a tender message would be a cruelty, and to invent nothing would be another one, and Maren had a half-second to choose which cruelty to be.

"She said," Maren began, and found her own voice had gone unsteady and let it, because an unsteady voice was the one true thing she had to give and it happened to fit, "she said to tell you she understood. That she wasn't going quiet, and she wasn't going grateful, but that she understood, right down to the ground, why you did the thing you did. And that it was the most loving thing that had ever been done to her, and that she hated it, and that both of those were true, and you'd know what she meant by that even if no one else alive would."

It was not a message Amelia had given her. Amelia had given her no message but the one about the year and the one word. But it was the truest thing Maren knew about the two of them, laid down as close to the real girl's own voice as she could shape it, and she watched it go into the Queen's straight back and she watched the straight back take it, and for three held breaths the two of them said nothing at all.

"Yes," the Queen said at last, very low. "That is exactly what she would say." And she did not thank Maren for it, and Maren was glad, because a thanks would have made it a gift and it was not a gift, it was a theft dressed as one, the last comfort of a mother stolen out of a lie.

"They will come to me within the week," the Queen said, to the window, "the ones who watched her stand there. Some to sell me their silence. Some to sell me hers, as if they had her. Some to find out what I will pay, so they can weigh it against what the grey man's side will pay, and take the better price." Her voice was even and cold and entirely herself, the sovereign back in it to the brim. "I will let them all believe I am buying. It costs a rumor nothing to let it think it has you frightened. And while they are busy pricing my fear I will find out which of my own lords carried the grey man into my hall. Because someone did. Someone opened a door for a low-clan nobody and pointed him at the one girl in five hundred. That person is worth more to me dead than the whole hill-clan army, and I will have their name before the snow." She turned from the window at last, and her face was composed and terrible and gave away nothing, and only Maren, who had been reading it since she was a child, saw the hairline of grief run under all of it like a crack under ice. "You did well to bring her out clean. Go and rest. You look as though you carried her the whole way on your back."

"I did, a little," Maren said, which was the one true thing she'd said since she came in, and went out on legs that did not feel like hers. In the cold gallery beyond the door she stopped and set her back to the wall and stood a moment with her eyes shut, her hands wanting a count and finding nothing to count, nothing but the shape of the thing she carried now where the silver used to go, one word in a year. Then she straightened her apron and went down to see to the evening as though it were any evening, and shut the great door softly behind her on a queen who did not know she had just been comforted by the person who had unmade her.

CHAPTER TWELVE

The Burned Village

They smelled it a mile off, and every man in the column knew the smell, and nobody said what it was.

It came down the wind ahead of them, over a low green shoulder of the hills. It was woodsmoke first, which was ordinary, a village at its evening fires. And then under the woodsmoke was the other thing, sweet and thick and wrong. The horses did not like it and the men went quiet, and the chief lifted a hand and the column slowed without a word being said. Korvan, at the tail, felt the quiet travel back down the line to him last of all, as it always did, and knew from the shape of it that whatever was over the shoulder was bad.

It was called Aldstkey. He learned that later. It had been a middling place, forty houses maybe, a mill and a green and a stone shrine, the kind of human village the road ran through without stopping, that paid its tithe in grain and asked the wide world for nothing but to be left out of it. The road ran through it now the same as ever. The houses on both sides of the road had burned.

Not all of them. That was the part that got into Korvan and stayed, riding up the street at the tail of a silent column: that it was not all of them. A whole village burned is a disaster, a lightning fire or a raid, a thing with a shape you can hold. This was worse and smaller and more deliberate than that. Perhaps a dozen houses were gone, black and

fallen in on themselves and still smoking in places, and the houses on either side of each burned one stood untouched, whole, curtains in the windows, a rake left against a wall. Someone had chosen which houses. Someone had gone down this street with fire in the daylight and picked, house here, house there, and left the neighbors' walls alone, and the neighbors had stood in their own untouched doorways and watched it be done, because you did not burn a dozen chosen houses in a village of forty without the other twenty-eight at the least standing by.

The survivors were in the green. That was where the chief took them, because there was nowhere else for a column to go, and Korvan came up off the road behind the others and saw them, forty or fifty people sitting and standing in the trampled grass with the particular stillness of people who have done a thing they cannot undo and are waiting, without hope, to find out what it costs. Some were hurt. Some were burned. A woman sat holding a bundle that Korvan looked at once and made himself not look at again. And every one of them turned and watched the column of armed hill-clan men ride up onto their green, and there was fear in the watching, but it was not the clean fear of people who have been raided. It was the sick sideways fear of people who have already been the monster once today and think the next one has come for them.

The chief got it out of them slowly, dismounted, hat in his hands, in the flat gentle voice he used for the worst things. And the shape of it came clear the way the smell had, in pieces, and every piece was worse.

There had been a family in the burned houses. Or the trouble had started with a family. A woman up at the mill end had taken sick a week past, a wasting thing, gone grey and cold and off her food, and a child had died of a fever the same week. And then the word had come up the road, the

way word was coming up every road in the country now: that the treaty was broken, that a creature had been found under the Queen's own roof, a born one, silver-haired, that the old horror was loose in the world again. And a village that had a grey cold wasting woman in it, and a dead child, and a week of bad dreams, had sat with that word by its fires for three nights, and on the fourth evening it had decided, the way a frightened animal decides, all at once and out of nothing, that it knew where its creature was.

The wasting woman had been the first house. Her sister's family next, for being her blood. Then a widow at the end of the lane who kept cats and had always been strange, and the strange widow's neighbors for good measure. By then the fire had its own logic and did not need much feeding. And the men who had lit the first house to save their children found by the third that they could not stop being men who lit houses, because stopping meant they had murdered a sick woman for nothing.

"We thought," a man kept saying, to the chief, to the ground, to nobody. He had a scorched sleeve and eyes that had gone somewhere and not come all the way back. "There was a creature. Everyone said. There was a creature loose and we thought—"

"I know what you thought," the chief said, not unkindly, and did not tell him there had been no creature, because the chief, alone of all of them, knew there had been.

Korvan halted at the rim of the green holding his horse and understood that he was looking at the war. Not a battle. There would be battles, later, and they would be bad, but this was the war itself, its true first cost laid out on a village green, a dozen houses and a woman with a bundle and fifty people who would wake every day of their lives now inside what they had done on the fourth night. Loric had not lit this fire. Loric had only stood up in a hall three hundred miles

away and said the word creature into a room, gently, and the word had gone out over the country on its own legs and come here, to Aldstkey, and found the grey wasting woman and done the rest by itself. That was the whole horror of the thing Loric had built. It did not need him at all anymore. It needed only to have been lit the once, in the one hall, and after that it walked the roads on its own and lit the rest itself.

And Korvan thought, with a coldness that frightened him, of the cart three back down the road, and the silver-haired thing folded under the canvas in it. The actual creature. The real one, the true article the whole panicked country was burning its own neighbors over. And he had it, he was hiding it, he had chosen it. He stood on the green of a village that had murdered a sick woman out of the fear of exactly the thing he had wrapped in his own spare shirt, and he did not know what he felt, only that it was too big to feel all at once and he put it down to feel later, as his father put things down.

* * *

They stayed to bury the dead, because the chief said they would, and because it was clan law that you did not ride past the unburied, whatever they had done, whatever they were.

It was bad work. The burned houses had not given up all of what was in them, and getting it out was a thing that had to be done and that the villagers could not do, because the villagers could not go near the houses at all, could not look at them, sat on the green with their backs to what they had made. So the clan did it. And Korvan did it, because Korvan was strong, stronger than a man his age and shape ought to have been, strong the way the shift was meant to make a man and had not made him, and grim heavy work was one of the few places in the world his strength was a use and not a rebuke.

He worked. He shifted fallen beams that took two other men to shift. He went into the black wet stinking ruin of the mill-end house where the worst of it was and brought out what had to be brought out, wrapped in what there was to wrap it in, and he did it steadily and did not stop. After a while he noticed that the other men had drifted to the far houses and left him the mill-end one alone, and that they were not looking at him, and that the not-looking had the old shape.

A boy was watching him, though. One of the village boys, ten or eleven, sitting on the green where his mother had put him, watching Korvan carry the dead out of the mill house with the whole flat unblinking attention of a child too far past horror to look away from anything. And when Korvan came out the last time and straightened, with the last of it in his arms, the boy said, across the green, in a clear carrying voice with nothing in it but a terrible simple curiosity:

"How's he so strong. He's not shifted. Look at him. Something's wrong with him."

His mother hushed him, fast, both hands. But the green had heard. Fifty people who had murdered their neighbors four nights ago on the strength of *something's wrong with her* went still, and turned, by ones and twos, and looked at the shapeless hill-clan man standing in the door of the burned house with a dead villager in his arms and a strength on him that no natural thing his age should have. And Korvan watched the fear find him. He watched it travel the green. He was doing the one purely good thing anyone had done in Aldstkey in four days, carrying their dead out of the fire so they could be put in the ground, and he watched them begin, helplessly, out of the very habit that had burned the place, to be afraid of him for it. The stronger he was, the better he worked, the more he was the thing they had been taught to

look for. His goodness was not evidence of anything to them. His strength was.

He carried the dead man to the row by the graves and laid him down as gently as he had ever laid anything down, and stood up, and met the eyes of the nearest villagers. He did not smile, because a strange strong man smiling was worse. He did not speak either, because his father had the right of it and the not-answering was the only answer. Then he went back to the mill house for the next one, and the fear closed over the space where he had stood exactly the way his own clan's silence did. And he thought that he had come three hundred miles to learn that there was no place in the whole world, burning or peaceful, hostile or his own, where being good bought a man like him a single thing.

An old man came to the chief while Korvan worked, the reeve or what was left of one, a spare grey figure with a burned hand wrapped in a rag. Korvan heard it because the wind carried it, and because after twenty years he could pick his own name, or the absence where his name should be, out of any crowd the way a dog picks its own.

"We're grateful," the old man said. He did not sound grateful. He sounded like a man saying the words that would get the armed strangers gone soonest. "For the burying. We can't go near them, we can't, so. We're grateful. But I'll ask you to be away by morning, chief. You and your men. We've no quarrel with the hill-clans and we'd like to keep it so."

"We'll be away by morning," the chief said.

"And the one." The old man stopped. Started again, lower, not low enough. "The big one. Doing the mill house. There's talk. I'm not saying there's anything in it, mind. I'm past saying there's anything in anything at all, God forgive the lot of us. But the people are frightened and he's, well. You'll know your own man, chief, I'll not tell you your business. I'll

only ask you keep him off. Off the dead. It's not right to them, is what's being said. To have that. Handling them. After."

And there it was, at last, in the open, in a broken old man's shaking voice on a murdered green: keep the monster off our dead. Korvan stood in the door of the mill house with a child in his arms, a child he was three slow steps from laying in the ground, and heard a village ask that he not be let to touch it, because his kindness was the wrong shape, because a strong strange man doing them a mercy frightened them worse than the want of the mercy did.

He waited to hear what his father would say. He wanted, badly, more than he would have owned to, to hear his father say the true thing, that the man in the mill house was worth the whole trembling green of them and more, that he had done nothing, that he was good. His father did not say it. His father could not say it, out here, any more than he could have said it in the camp, because to stand up for the shapeless one was to make the shapeless one a question, and a chief with an army at his back does not hand a frightened village a question.

"He'll finish the mill house," the chief said instead. "Nobody else will set foot in it and you know it. He'll finish, and it will be done right, and then we'll be gone. And you can tell whoever's doing the talking that the hill-clans buried your dead when you could not, and let them make of that what they please." He set his hat back on, which was the end of it. The old man went away not comforted, and the chief did not once look toward the mill house. And Korvan went back inside the mill house, because there was one more in there, and no one else would.

He knew she was watching. The cart had been drawn up at the far side of the green with the others, and he could feel it the way you feel a window at your back, the small held awareness of her under the canvas eighteen inches from a

village that would tear the cart apart plank by plank if it knew what rode in it. She could see the burying through some gap in the canvas, he was fairly sure. All of it, probably. She was watching him be good for nothing in the ashes of what the fear of her own kind had done. And he found, hauling the dead through the smoke, that he was not ashamed to be watched at it. It was new. It was the first work he had ever done that he did not mind her seeing, and he did not have time to wonder what that meant.

They finished as the light went, and filled the graves, and the villagers drew off to their untouched houses to not sleep, and the clan made its cold camp well back.

The chief came to him at the graves when the last was filled, and stood beside him looking at the raw turned earth and not at his son, the way he did everything.

"You heard the reeve," the chief said.

"I heard him."

"And you finished the mill house regardless."

"Somebody had to."

The chief was quiet a while. The wind came over the green and moved the smell of the burning around and took it off again. "When your mother was dying," he said, which was so far from anything Korvan had braced for that he turned and looked at the old man's shut profile in the dark, "the healers stopped coming at the end. There was a thing in the way of it that frightened them, and they found reasons, and they stopped, and I tended her myself, because somebody had to. And the village looked at me sideways a full year after, for having been the one who could do the thing they couldn't stand to. You follow me."

"No," Korvan said, and meant it.

"I'm telling you that being the one who does the thing nobody else will touch is not a curse and it isn't a blessing. It's a place a man stands. And it's a place, as it turns out, that

you and I both stand in, come to it from different doors." He was silent a moment. "I couldn't say it to the reeve. You know why I couldn't."

"I know why."

"Then I'll say it here, the once, where there's no one to make a question of it." And he put his hand on the back of Korvan's neck in the dark, the awkward there-and-gone way he always did it, except that this time he did not take it away again at once. He left it, heavy and warm, a breath and then another. "You were the best man on this green today. Every soul on it was frightened of you, and you were the only one of the whole lot worth the salt in him. Don't you dare carry it home that you did a wrong thing here. You did the one right thing that got done in this place. I saw it. And that's the end of what I'm able to give you, and it is not enough, and I know to the bone that it is not enough."

Then he took his hand away and went to see to the watch, and Korvan stood over the filled graves in the dark with the warm print of it still on his neck, undone past speaking, and did not trust his own face, and was glad, for once, of how little light there was to show it in.

* * *

There was a beast, in the end. That was the other matter, the one he saw to in the last grey of the light when the graves were filled and the men were making a cold camp on the green's far side, well back from the village, and it was the worst thing he did all that long day and he did it without letting himself think about it more than once.

A milk goat, in the untouched half of the village, its owners dead or fled, its leg broken in the panic and left, lying in a doorway crying the thin exhausted cry of an animal that has been crying a long time. It was going to die. It was dying already, slow, the way a thing dies that nobody

comes for. Korvan knelt by it in the dusk with his hand on its warm heaving side and did the arithmetic he had sworn he would not have to do. The vial dry two days now. Her voice in the pines, not a person, it had never been a person. And he thought, this was no person, and he thought, this was a village's goat, and he thought, I am a man who buried children today and now I am stealing the last living thing off their street to feed a vampire. He could not make any of it come out clean, and he did it anyway, because the alternative was her hunting in the dark tonight not eight feet from a boy who had already lost everything, and there was no version of that he could allow.

He carried the goat out the back way in the dark, its heart going fast and trusting against his chest, and got it to the cart, and put it in where her hands could reach it, and said, low, to the canvas, "It's dying anyway. Its leg's gone. It's not—" and could not finish it, and did not need to.

"I know," she said, from beneath the canvas, and her voice was terrible, gentle and starving and ashamed all at once, and then, after a moment, very low: "I saw you today. All of it. I want you to know that I saw."

For a moment she did not touch the goat. He could feel her not touching it, the whole held stillness of her deciding, and then she said, so low he nearly lost it under the wind, "I buried a village today as well, you know. In my own way. I lay in the dark and listened to fifty people grieve the thing they'd done, and I have never in my life wanted so badly not to be what I am. And now you've brought me a warm creature to keep me alive by, off their own street, and I am going to take it, because I promised you I would hold and I cannot hold without it. So I'll take it. But I want it set down somewhere that I did not take it easy. That it cost me. That is the whole of the decency I have left to offer anyone, that at the least it still costs me."

"It's set down," Korvan said, before he knew he meant to. "I'll be the somewhere it's written. Now take it."

He heard her take the goat then, at last, a small shift and a going-still in the dark. "Don't thank me for it," he said, already turning, already walking away before she could hear that his own voice had gone, because he had held it all day, through the burying and the boy and the fear, and he was not going to spend the last of the holding on being thanked for a mercy that was half a theft.

* * *

The wrongness came in the night.

The camp was worse that night than it had been, and he understood why, and could do nothing about it. The men had watched a whole village be afraid of him. Forty hill-clan men who had spent a fortnight teaching themselves, gently, fire by fire, to be afraid of the shapeless one had ridden into a place full of strangers and watched the strangers arrive at the same fear from a standing start, in an afternoon, with no help at all, just by looking at him. And a fear that a stranger comes to on his own is a fear that feels like proof. Nobody said it. A man he'd shared a fire with a hundred nights, a bear-clan man named Orry who had taught Korvan to whistle a marsh-bird two summers back, got up when Korvan came to warm his hands and found a reason, a real-sounding reason, to be at another fire. He did it clumsily, and could not look at Korvan's face while he did it. And that was the piece Korvan carried back to his own cold fire — not the village, not the writ, just Orry getting up to warm his hands somewhere his old friend was not.

"Sit where you like," Korvan told him, quiet, to spare them both the pretending. "It's all right, Orry. I'd not sit by me either, the mood the road's in."

"It's not—" Orry started, and stopped, because it was, and they both knew it was, and there was nothing to put in the space where the lie wouldn't fit. He went to the other fire. Korvan warmed his hands alone and did not mind it as much as he should have, because he had somewhere else to put his mind now, three carts down, cold under a canvas, and a man with somewhere to put his mind is harder to freeze out than a man with nowhere.

He bedded down apart, as he did, near the cart and away from the fires, and had not thought to sleep, and slept all at once, the deep swallowing sleep of a body that has hauled the dead all day. And somewhere down in it the wrongness started.

It was not a dream, or it was not only a dream. There was heat. He was too hot, and then far too hot, a heat that came from inside and had nothing to do with the cold ground or the dead fire, a heat that started deep behind his breastbone where the shift was supposed to live and rose up through him like a kettle coming on. His bones ached. Not the ordinary ache of hard work. A wrong ache, a growing ache, as though the bones themselves were being asked a question they did not have room to answer, his jaw and his shoulders and the long bones of his arms all pulling at once toward some shape that was not there and would not come. And under it, worst of all, was the water. He was in the river again, the boy in the river, his father's hand under his belly, and then the hand left him, as it forever did in the memory, but this time when he sank he did not come up at all thrashing and human. This time the water ran warm, and he was long in it, and there was a great slow strength in him that moved the whole river when it moved, and something down his spine unfolded that had been folded his whole life, and he opened a mouth that was not his mouth and the river turned to steam around it—

He woke with his heart slamming and the taste of hot metal in his mouth and his hands, when he lifted them in the dark, shaking, and burning, actually burning, hot as a man in fever though the night was cold enough to see his breath.

He lay still and did the thing he had not done since he was a boy, which was to take a careful private inventory of his own body in the dark, the way he used to on the mornings after the moon when he was young enough to still believe. He put his tongue to his own teeth, half certain they would have changed, that he would find something in his mouth that had not been there at dusk. He reached back and pressed the knuckles of one burning hand up the length of his own spine, feeling for the thing that had unfolded in the dream, the thing down there that had opened, and found only his spine, ordinary, a man's, and did not know whether the wave that went through him at that was relief or the plainest grief he had ever felt. Both, he supposed. Relief and grief with no seam between them, and he was getting used, out here, to things that came in that shape. Nothing had changed. He was the same shapeless man he had lain down as. And a starved, treacherous corner of him he was ashamed of on this night of all nights, three feet from graves he had filled with his own hands, had wanted, in the heat and the water, more than he had ever let himself want anything, for it to finally be true.

Because that was the thing nobody warned you of, about waiting your whole life for a shape. You did not only dread it. You came, over the long empty years, to need it, to have built your whole idea of your own rescue around it, so that a low animal in you would take even this, even a fever in a murdered village with a monster in your cart, and think, half asleep, in a voice you would never own to in the light: now. Please. Let it be now. Let me finally be the thing, whatever it

costs and whatever it is, only let me stop being the thing I already am.

And then he was awake enough to hear himself, and to be sickened by himself, and to press it down.

He lay still and told himself it was the day. It was the mill-end house and the smell and the dead and the boy, and a body could run a fever off a day like that, anyone could, it meant nothing. He had waited nineteen, twenty years for the shift and it had never come, and it was not going to come now, tonight, in a murdered village with a starving vampire in his cart. The world did not arrange its miracles that neatly. Whatever this was, it was only the day working itself out through him, and he would sweat it and it would pass.

He believed almost none of it. But the heat did bank, slowly, over an hour, down to something he could lie inside, and the ache eased, and the water let him go. He lay on the cold earth under the hard stars and did not sleep again. And he watched the east and thought, once, with a lurch he could not govern, of a long warm strength moving a whole river, and put it down, hard, to think about never, and did not quite manage it.

Near dawn he heard her shift under the canvas, close, and without deciding to he pressed his still-too-warm hand to the cold boards of the cart, the way he had that first night. And after a moment, from her side of the wood, he felt her lay her cold one against the same place, so that only the plank was between them, his running impossibly hot and hers running impossibly cold. No word passed between them, because there was nothing the plank could be trusted to carry. And they lay like that, the too-hot and the too-cold with a board between, until the first grey came up over the graves and the ash.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Blood Answers

The goat had bought her back some of herself, and Amelia had not known, until she had it again, how far gone she had been.

Two nights it had been now since Korvan carried the dying thing to the cart, and the warmth of it had gone into her slow and shameful and life-giving, and the low red roar at the back of her jaw had quieted, and she could think again in something like straight lines. She could feel her own hands. She had not been able to feel her own hands for days, up under the canvas, only the hunger wearing them like gloves. Now they were hers. It was a small thing to be grateful for, having your own hands, and she was grateful for it the way you are only grateful for the things that have been taken away and given back.

The plan, such as it was, had held. Two days past the burned village the road had forked, and the retinue had gone left and down toward the low steadings and home, and Korvan had told his father he would come on behind by the high way with the spare string, which was a thin enough story but the kind a chief who did not want to look too hard could let stand. So they had gone right, and up, the two of them and four horses and a cart nobody would miss for a week, into the roof of the world where Korvan's uncle kept a herd-station that stood empty from the first frost to the

thaw. A day more and they would reach it. A day more and she would have walls again, and a roof, and a door that shut, and it should have felt like safety and did not, quite, because she had passed her whole life behind walls and doors that shut and had learned that the thing they mostly kept in was herself.

"You're brooding," Korvan said, that first evening on the high road, not unkindly. "I can hear it. It has a pitch."

"I'm deciding whether I'm glad to be nearly somewhere with a door," she said, "or sorry."

"And?"

"I'll tell you when there's a door to stand behind and be sure."

They were high now, up in the hard bright country Korvan had been born to, and the retinue was camped a mile back and below in a fold of the hills, and Korvan had walked her out and up, away from the camp, the way he did every night, except that tonight he had walked her further than usual, up over a shoulder of rock to a small black tarn that sat in the high stone like a held breath, still and cold and starlit, because she had told him she wanted, once, before the thing that was coming came, to stand somewhere with no walls and no canvas and no forty sleeping men, and be only herself in the open for the length of an hour, and he had heard the size of the wanting under the small words, because he always did, and had brought her here.

She stood at the lip of the water and did not speak, and he stood a little back, and neither of them filled it, and for a while it was the most peace she had had since a garden and a fountain a lifetime ago.

After a time she reached up and took the pins out of her hair, one by one, and let it down, the whole cold silver length of it, the thing that got her killed, the thing she had spent all her years braiding close and hiding under hoods, and she let

the high wind take it and move it, and she tipped her head back and looked at the stars, which she had seen perhaps a dozen times in her life through a dozen high windows and never, until tonight, with nothing at all between her and them.

"There are more of them than I thought," she said. "The stars. In the books there are never this many. The books make it look manageable."

"That's just the low country's share," Korvan said. "Wait till you're properly up. Another day higher and you can't find the dark between them. My father used to say a man who's afraid of dying should go up above the tree-line on a clear night and have a look at how little the sky's going to miss him." He paused. "He meant it as a comfort. My father's comforts are all shaped like that. You have to hold them a while before you find the warm end."

She almost laughed. She had not laughed, really laughed, since before the hall, and she felt it start in her, small and astonished, a thing she had thought the last weeks had taken from her for good.

"Thank you," she told him at last. "For this. I know what it cost you to walk this far from the camp with me. If we're found out here there's no cart to hide in and no story to tell."

"We won't be found," he said, and it was the ocean speaking again, the thing he said that neither of them believed and both of them needed, and she had opened her mouth to say so when she felt them.

She went still. Not the ordinary still. The other one, the cold one, the flat frozen-pond quiet that came down over her when the cold flat part of her took the wheel, and Korvan saw it happen to her and stopped breathing.

"There are men on the rocks behind you," she said, low and even and entirely without fear, because the fear had gone under the ice with everything else. "Six of them. No,

seven. Spread wide, coming slow. They've been coming a while. I can feel their hearts, Korvan, all seven, going hard the way a man's heart goes when he's about to do a thing he's rehearsed. They're not the retinue. They came up the far side, quiet, and they knew exactly where to come, which means they've been on us longer than tonight." She had not turned around. She did not need to turn around. She could see them the way she saw everything now that the goat had given her back her gift, seven warm certainties strung out across the cold dark stone, closing. "They're the grey man's. They've found me."

"Get behind me," Korvan said, and had his knife out, the skinning knife, the one from the roll, and had put himself between her and the dark, and she loved him for it and knew, with the flat cold clarity, that it was going to get him killed, because one man with a skinning knife does not hold seven professionals who have climbed a mountain in the dark to do a job.

They came out of the rocks without being told to, all at once, when they understood they were seen. Seven of them, and she had been wrong about only one thing, which was the ease of them. They did not hurry. They did not shout. They spread into a loose crescent with the tarn at her back so that she had nowhere to go but the water, and the one in the center, an ordinary-looking man with a soft careful voice she recognized before he even spoke because it was cut from the same cloth as the grey man's, said, "Step away from her, hillman. She's not yours and this isn't your fight and you've done enough to earn a rope already. Step away and walk down that hill and we'll let you. We've no orders about you. We've orders about her."

"What orders," Korvan said.

"Alive if we can. Not alive if we can't. Honestly, friend, between us, it's the same coin to us and it'll be quicker for

her the second way, so if you love her at all—" the man's soft eyes flicked to Korvan, reading, cataloguing, the way the grey man read "—and it does rather look as though you do, God help you, then the kindest thing you can do for the creature is stand aside and let it be fast."

"She's not a creature," Korvan said.

"No?" The soft man smiled, and gestured, gently, at all of her, the silver hair loose now in the starlight because she had taken the pins out to stand bareheaded at the water like a person, the pale of her, the stillness. "What would you call it, then."

"A woman," Korvan said. "Standing at a lake. Which is more than any of the seven of you managed tonight, climbing a dark mountain to knife a girl on somebody's orders."

Something moved behind the soft man's soft eyes, a small cold flick of irritation, the look of a professional whose evening is running long. "You know," he said, "I did give you the door." He did not raise his voice. He did not need to. He only tipped his head a fraction, the smallest economical gesture, and two of the men on the wings started forward across the stone, unhurried, drawing as they came, and a third slid wide toward Korvan's flank where the knife could not reach, and with the cold flat clarity she saw that this was the moment, that in three more of their easy steps one of them would have an angle on Korvan's back, and that Korvan knew it too and had set his feet anyway, over her, in front of her, a man with a skinning knife widening his stance to die well in front of a thing that did not need his protecting.

And Amelia, standing at the black water with seven hearts strung across the dark and the one man she had left setting his feet to die for her, felt her mother's blood wake in her wrists, unbidden.

It came up as it had over the sleeping drover, vast and simple and far older than she was, except that this time she did not fight it down, and that was the whole of the difference, and it was the difference between everything she had been and everything she was about to be. She had passed her life learning the not-taking. Her mother had sat across a bowl with a single frightened fish in it and taught her, over and over, patiently, that the whole of the gift was the hand you kept to yourself. Never a living person. Not to save your own life, not to save the Queen's, not for any reason the world could set before her. Promise me that. And she had promised, and she had kept it, twenty years she had kept it, through everything, through her own starving in a grain cart eighteen inches from forty warm men.

She looked at the soft-voiced man opening his mouth to give the order that would put a blade in Korvan, and she broke the promise.

She reached out with her blood as her mother had drilled her to, over the bowl, slow, so as not to startle the thing in the dark, except that she did not reach for a fish. She reached for all seven of them at once.

A fish had been one small bright warmth turning circles in a bowl. This was seven grown men strung across cold stone, seven furnaces of blood, and she had thought, in the half-instant before she touched them, that it would be seven times as hard, and she was wrong, it was not harder, it was only bigger, and the bigness was the most frightening sensation she had ever met, because it was not a strain. It should have been a strain. Her mother had never let her reach past a single small cold-blooded thing, had guarded her from her own size her whole life, and now Amelia reached out with everything she had held back for twenty years and found that seven hearts were nothing to her, were easy, were a handful of warm coins, that she could have held

seventy, seven hundred, that there was no edge to it that she could feel, no bottom, no wall, only the gift opening and opening into a room in herself she had never been allowed to see the size of. She found their hearts, every one, going hard. She took hold of the thread she had been forbidden her whole life to touch. And she pulled.

It was so easy. That was what her mother had known and tried her whole life to spare her. It was so easy, and it felt like nothing, it felt like turning your hand a single degree, and across the dark stone seven men who had come up a mountain to kill her made, all at once, the same small surprised sound, and stopped.

Not fell. Stopped. She felt each heart come up short against her hold like a horse against a rein, stutter, labor, and she felt exactly how little it would take, a further nothing, the smallest additional turn of the same easy hand, to still them entirely, and she felt the gift lean into it, glad, wanting, the wanting that her mother had promised her would always sound like mercy and did, oh it did, it sounded like the kindest act there was, just a little further, just let them stop, and be warm, and be safe, and let it all be over—

"I'm here."

His voice. Not her name. He did not have her name, had never had it, had stood under the black pines the night she came to him and told her he would wait until it was hers to give and had held to that even out here, even now, with her hand closing on seven hearts at once. So he had no name to call her back with, and used instead the only thing he did have, which was that he was still standing there at her back in the cold, having chosen not to run, and was saying so, quietly, once, not a plea and not a command, set down in the frozen dark the plain way she set everything down, to remind her there was a person in here for him to be standing behind.

And she came back into the cold flat part of her and found she was standing at the edge of a black tarn with seven armed men down in the rocks, gasping, clawing at their own chests, not dead, held, held on the edge of it by a thread she had only to think about to cut, and she had a half-second, no more, to decide what kind of thing she was going to be, now, forever, having already broken the promise, having already reached in, and that the decision was going to define the rest of a very long life.

She could feel Korvan behind her. Not with the gift, because she kept the gift off him, always, had never let it so much as brush him, it was the one warm thing in reach she would not let it near, but with the plain animal sense of a person at your back. So she knew he was seeing this. All of it. Seven armed men brought down kneeling in the rocks, gasping, clawing at their own chests, and a silver-haired girl standing over them at the water with her hands empty at her sides, having done it without a touch, being plainly and unarguably the horror the whole world had burned a village over. She waited, in the frozen half-second, to hear him run. To hear the scrape of a boot going away down the stone, the small sound of the last person in the world deciding she was finally too much to stand next to. It did not come. He stayed where he was, at her back, breathing, and did not move, and that steadied her hand on the seven threads more than twenty years of her mother's drilling ever had, because it turned out the thing that let you hold a killing at its trembling edge and not fall in was not discipline at all. It was somebody choosing to stay behind you while you did it.

She did not kill them. She wanted to. The gift wanted to so badly it was a physical ache, seven warm lives held helpless in her cold hand, and the wanting had her mother's promised voice, the one that sounded like mercy, murmuring that it would be safer, that dead men carry no

messages and bear no grudges, that she would never be able to hold this many again if she let them go and they came back with more. She held them instead, all seven, kneeling and gasping in the stone, at the exact edge, and she made her voice come out flat and even and entirely her mother's, the sovereign's voice she had inherited along with the sovereign's blood, and she said, to their leader where he knelt with his careful eyes gone wide and white:

"You will listen to me, because I am only going to say it once, and you are going to want to have heard it. I can feel your heart in my hand. I can feel all seven. I have been able to since you were still down in the rocks thinking you were quiet. I have not killed you, and do you know why I have not killed you? Not mercy. Understand me: it is not mercy. It is that I need one of you to walk back down this mountain to the grey man and tell him what you felt up here tonight. Tell him what the Queen hid was real. Tell him it is stronger than the stories. Tell him it held seven of his best on their knees at a black lake with a turn of its hand and let them live only so one of them could carry the message. And tell him—" and here the flat cold voice did something that frightened her more than the killing would have, it warmed, a single degree, into something almost gentle—"tell him I know now why he is doing this. I felt it, in yours, just now, the fear you all carry of me. He is right to be afraid. He was always right. I am exactly the thing he says I am. Now go, before I change my mind about the mercy I keep telling you this isn't."

She opened her hand.

Seven men fell the rest of the way to the stone and lay there heaving, alive, and then scrambled up and went, fast and graceless, all the professional quiet gone out of them, back over the rocks the way they had come. The soft man was the last. He got to his feet slowly, one hand pressed flat over his own chest as if to make sure it was still his to

command, and he stopped at the edge of the dark and looked back at her, and there was no softness left in his face at all, only a raw white understanding.

"You've made a mistake, letting us go," he said. Not cruelly. Almost, now, one professional to another. "Not because we'll come back. I'll not come within a mile of you again for a chest of the Queen's own plate, and nor will these. Because now we've felt it, and I'm going to walk down this mountain and tell the grey man the plain truth, which is that what the Queen kept hidden is real, and stronger than any tale he's been spreading. And do you imagine that frightens him off?" A short, ruined laugh. "It's the best news he's had since the banquet. Everything he stood up and said, you've just gone and made true with your own two hands. He said there was a monster loose. And here you are, holding seven men helpless at a lake without lifting a finger. The more of us you spare, girl, the more you prove him. The kinder you are, the worse it reads. You could have killed the lot of us and been a rumour a man could still doubt. You let us live, and made yourself a fact he can put in front of the world."

He wiped his mouth with the back of a hand that had not quite stopped trembling, and gave a slow, wondering shake of the head, the shake of a farmer looking up at weather that has ruined his whole crop in a single afternoon.

"You've damned yourself to keep your hillman breathing, and you did it cleaner than anyone I have ever watched work, and did it to be good. There's a joke in that somewhere black enough for the grey man himself. I hope you never have to hear him laugh at it."

Then he was gone, and the rocks were empty, and it was only the two of them again at the black water under the enormous stars, and Amelia stood shaking now, the ice breaking up in her at last, the cost of it all coming due at

once, and did not dare turn around and look at Korvan, because she had just let him see the whole of what she was, and there was no unseeing it, and she did not think she could bear to watch him decide to be afraid of her the way the whole world was right to be.

She heard him come to stand beside her at the water. She did not turn.

"You broke a promise, doing that," he said. "I could see it on you. It cost you more than the seven of them. What was it."

She had not expected that. She had expected the fear. The question undid her worse than fear would have.

"Never a person," she said, and her voice was not flat now, not the sovereign's, only hers, and small. "My mother made me promise. On a fish in a bowl, when I was small. Never put the gift into a breathing person and pull, not for her own life, not for anyone's, because the ease of it can't be unlearned, and it starts to want people. And I kept it. I kept it my whole life. And I just broke it, on seven men, to keep them off you, and she was right, it was easy, and it is going to want people now, for the rest of my life, and I am never going to be able to make it not have happened." She made herself say the last of it, the true worst of it, into the cold. "I'm more dangerous than I was an hour ago. To everyone. To you. You should be afraid of me now. The man was right. You should walk down that hill."

Korvan let a moment go by. When he spoke he did not raise his voice, and he did not come any nearer, and both of those, she understood later, were mercies.

"I've spent the whole of my life," he said, "waiting to turn into something that would frighten people. Wanting it, even. Lying awake begging my own body to do the thing it never would, so I could stop being the one everybody's gentle with, the one they pity and edge away from and keep their

children off. And you've spent yours frightened of the thing you already are. Keeping your hands to yourself so hard it half killed you in a grain cart not a week ago." He looked at the water, not at her, giving her the not-being-watched the way she had once given it to him at a fountain. "Seems to me we've been stood on opposite sides of the same fear our whole lives. You terrified of your own strength. Me starving for one. And now here we both are on a mountain in the dark, and you've gone and spent yours to keep me breathing, and I'm supposed to be so frightened of you for it that I walk off down that hill and leave you alone up here to shake."

"You should be frightened of me. That's the point. That's what I'm telling you."

"I heard what you're telling me." He looked round at her then, straight on, and there was nothing in his face that was edging away. "You're telling me you're dangerous. I believe you. I watched you put seven armed men down on the stone without lifting a hand, and I watched you want to finish it, I saw that too, I saw how close it came. So I won't insult you by pretending you're a frightened girl I have to be gentle with, because that's the one thing everyone's always been to me and I know precisely what it's worth, which is nothing, which is a way of not seeing a person at all. You're not a frightened girl. You're the most dangerous thing on this mountain by a distance." He let that sit a beat. "And it's the first thing about you that's ever made me feel less alone in my life. Because a thing that could stop my heart with a turn of her hand is a thing I can't break by accident. And I have been so afraid, my whole life, once I started to feel what's coming, of being a thing that breaks what it gets near. You're the first person I've stood next to and not had to be careful. Do you understand what that is, to me. I'm not running from it. I'd sooner run from air."

And Amelia turned and looked full at him then, at the flat unhurried way he had of facing the worst things, and understood that he meant every word, that he was not being brave for her or kind at her, that some crossed wire deep in him was genuinely and terribly steadied by what she had just done, because it meant that whatever he was becoming in the nights now, whatever unfolded down his spine in the heat and the dreaming, she would never be a thing his becoming could ruin. He had been afraid of exactly that, she saw, all this time, more afraid of it than of the war or the retinue or his own strange body. Not of being a monster. Of being a monster that outlived the one soft thing it loved.

"We are not," she said, and her voice cracked on it and she let it crack, because there was no one left up here to keep a face on for, "a well-matched pair of people, Korvan."

"No," he agreed. "We're a well-matched pair of monsters. Which is rarer, and I'll take it." A corner of his mouth moved. "Come away from the water now. You're shaking, and it's cold, and you've had a night that would put a stone on the ground. Come on."

But he did not move himself, not at first. He stood a moment longer looking at the black tarn, at the stars laid out unbroken across it, and there was a look on his face she had not seen before, a kind of pull, a wanting turned toward the water the way she had felt her own gift turn toward the seven warm hearts, helpless and old and from somewhere under the thinking.

"You want to go in," she said. It was not a question. She had spent a lifetime reading what people wanted and would not say.

"It's ice-melt off the tops. A man goes into that at night, he doesn't come out." He said it flatly, the sensible thing, and did not take his eyes off the water. "I loved the water when I was a boy. My father taught me in a river, the hard way, took

his hand off my belly and let me go under so I'd learn to hold myself up." A pause. "I gave it up, later. Easier to lose a thing once than to want it every morning and be told it was never mine to want." He turned the words over as if they had surprised him coming out. "But lately I —" He stopped, and made himself turn from the tarn, and the pull went off his face by main force, the way she pressed the hunger down. "Lately I keep dreaming about it. Warm water. A river a man could stand in and not die. Which is a mad thing to dream, up here, where the real thing would have the life out of you before you got your boots off." He shook it off. "Never mind. Cold's making me foolish. Come on, before we both freeze standing here being profound at a puddle."

He took off his own coat and put it around her cold shoulders, an ordinary gesture, the kind that half the people who had loved her used to do, and this once she did not go still under it or catalogue it or hold any part of herself back from it. She let it be warm. And they went back down off the high rock together, the vampire and the shifter, the thing that could stop a heart and the thing that was turning in its sleep into something with no name yet, down toward the fold in the hills where a mile below a whole camp of ordinary frightened people slept. Not one of them would ever know how near the two things they feared worst than dying had stood together that night at a black lake in the stars. Or that the two things had looked at each other over the wreck of a broken promise, and chosen, the pair of them, the same impossible thing, which was not to be alone in it.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Let Go So You'd Learn to Swim

The camp had put itself to bed wrong, and Korvan felt it the moment he came down off the high ground into the light of the fires.

He had left Amelia in the black rocks above the tree line with his coat around her and a hard heel of bread she would not eat and a promise he would be back before the moon was down, and he had come back down the mountain alone through the same black he had climbed it in, by feel, and he had told himself the whole way down that the wrongness he could feel building at the bottom of the slope was in his own chest and nowhere else. He was wrong. It was in the camp. The fires were banked too low and there were too many men awake at them, sitting up in twos and threes where by rights they should have been rolled in their blankets, and the talk that ran between them was the low kind, the kind with no laughing in it, and it stopped in a small traveling hush as he passed the way it had been stopping around him for a week, only tonight it had a different weight, and he understood, before he was halfway to the chief's fire, that something had come into the camp while he was up on the mountain watching a girl hold seven men's hearts in her hand.

Selwyn found him first. He came out of the dark between two carts, fast, and got a hand on Korvan's arm and pulled him up short.

"Where in the cold have you been." It was not a greeting. Selwyn's face in the low light had none of its usual easy foolishness in it. "No. Don't tell me. I don't want it where I have to carry it. Just this. The reeve's men came in an hour after dark. Off the mountain. Seven of them, and there'd been more when they set out, that's the word going round, and they came in white and shaking and would not say a straight word to anyone but Bricc and your father, and now nobody in this camp is sleeping and half of them are cleaning weapons that don't need it." He searched Korvan's face and plainly did not like what the search turned up. "Tell me you don't know anything about seven men coming off that mountain like they'd been in a fire that left no marks."

"I don't know anything about it," Korvan told him. His voice came out flat and level, and it was the first outright lie he had ever told Selwyn in his life, and Selwyn heard it land as a lie. Korvan watched him hear it. Watched the hurt of it go across his friend's face and get put away, quickly, because there was no room for it just now, and something in Korvan's chest that had already been carrying too much took on that as well, the weight of a friend deciding, right in front of him, not to trust the answer he'd been given.

"Right," Selwyn said, quiet. "Course you don't." He let go of Korvan's arm. "Your father wants you. Has done since the reeve's men came in. I'd not keep him."

His father was at his fire with Bricc and two of his captains, and the reeve's men were gone from it, sent off somewhere to shake in private, and the chief was standing the way he stood when a thing had gone bad, still and square and taking up more room than a man his age had any right to. He did not send the captains away. He turned his eyes on Korvan across the low flames and let the other men stay and watch, the way he had the morning after the garden, and Korvan understood that whatever was going to be said here

was going to be said in front of witnesses on purpose, and that this too was a kind of message, though he could not yet read who it was for.

"Sit," the chief said.

"I'll stand."

A muscle moved in his father's jaw. He did not make it an order. That was his father all over, that he almost never had to. "Bricc," the chief said, without turning his head, "tell my son what came off the mountain."

Bricc was old and hard and had been finding the sore place on Korvan for as long as the boy had drawn breath, the way the chief found it on a horse, and he told it plainly, with a pedant's care for the parts that mattered. Seven of the reeve's men, sent up the high trail two days back on a hunter's writ that had come down from the Queen's own people, quiet, the kind of writ that pays in coin and asks no questions. Sent up after a rumor of a lone traveler on the heights, silver-haired, worth a great deal to certain parties alive and rather less dead. Nine had gone up. Seven had come down. And the seven had come down, Bricc said, with the particular flatness of a man laying out facts he does not enjoy, not wounded, not marked, not touched, saying a thing none of them would say the same way twice, which was that they had been up on a black tarn in the dark and something had reached into them, all of them at once, and taken hold of the beating of their hearts the way you would take a bird in your fist, and held them there on their knees at the edge of the water, helpless as calves, and let them go only so that they could come back down and tell it.

"Tell what?" His own voice did what he needed it to do. He was distantly amazed at it.

"Tell that the thing the Queen hid is real," Bricc said, and his old eyes did not leave Korvan's face. "And that it is stronger than the stories. And that it spared them apurpose,

so the tale would travel." He let it lie there between them. "And one thing more, that the soft-spoken one among them keeps saying, that has your father's fires burning low tonight. That it was not alone up there. That the witch had a man at her back in the dark. A big one. Hill-built. Who did not run."

The fire cracked. One of the captains shifted his weight. Nobody looked at anybody.

"There are a great many big hill-built men in this train," Korvan said.

"There are," his father agreed. "Forty of them, near enough." He was watching his son with the shut-gate face, the one that gave nothing, and behind it Korvan could feel the entire mass of the man working, sifting, doing the sums he had been doing since the garden, and coming, Korvan knew, to the answer, because his father always came to the answer. "Leave us," the chief said to the fire at large. "All of you. Bricc. Now."

They went. It took a moment, and Bricc went last and slowest and with a look at Korvan that had a whole sentence in it, but they went, and then it was the two of them at the low fire with the whole cold sky over them and the camp not sleeping all around, and his father regarded him a while and held his face closed, giving it none of the small movements a son looks to a father to make.

"You went up that mountain," the chief said finally. Not a question.

Korvan said nothing. Saying nothing was its own answer, and both of them understood as much, and he let it be one, because he found he could not, standing here, look into his father's face and tell the outright lie a second time. He'd spent it all on Selwyn.

"You went up that mountain," his father said again, slower, "and you stood at that girl's back while she put seven

of the Queen's own hired men on their knees, and you did not run." He said it without heat. That was the worst of it. There was no anger in the man at all, only that old steady grief wearing its calm face. "I have spent a week, Korvan. A week telling myself that what Loric saw in that garden was a boy being kind to a girl who had no one, and nothing under it. A clean thing. I stood at this fire and I told you I believed it, and I did, and I meant it. And now you come down off a mountain in the middle of the night with her blood-work still hanging in the air behind you, and you stand in my fire and you will not tell me you weren't there." He drew a breath, and it was not quite steady, and Korvan had not heard his father draw a breath that was not steady since his mother died. "So it was not nothing. Was it. It has not been nothing for a while."

And here it was. The weight he had carried alone for a week, up hills and down them, through the burned village and the long murdering days beside the grain cart, the thing he had not been able to set down for Selwyn or for anyone because setting it down would kill him and worse would kill her — here was the one man in the world with the right to ask it, asking. And Korvan found that he was so tired, so deep-down bone-tired of carrying it in the dark, that the truth came up in him like water finding a crack, and he could not have said whether telling it was strength or was only the giving-out of a boy who had run out of road.

"No," he said. "It hasn't been nothing."

His father closed his eyes for a moment. Just that. Then opened them.

"Then you have to hear me," said the chief, "and hear me as your father and not as your chief, because I am about to say a thing I have never said to you straight, and I will only say it the once." He came around the fire. He did not touch Korvan. His father did not do that. But he came close enough

that the witnesses, if any lingered in the dark, could not have heard, and he stood over his son the way he had stood over him at the water thirty feet down a river a lifetime ago, and he said, low, "You want me to have fought."

Korvan's throat closed. "You could have," he said, and it came out rougher than he meant it. "In the hall. When Loric stood up. You could have named him for what he is in front of every leader in that hall. You could have called the challenge and met it and let them see you were not afraid of a grieving man with a grudge. You're the chief. They'd have followed you. Instead you—" He stopped, because the next word was a hard one, and then he made himself say it, because he had come this far. "Instead you gave them a war. You looked at a lie about your own son and you decided the answer was to take four thousand people into a war rather than stand up in a room and say it was a lie. That's not survival. That's just losing quietly and calling it wisdom, and I don't know which of those is worse coming from you."

He waited for the anger. His father's anger, when it came, was a rare and terrible weather, and Korvan had steeled himself against it since he was small, the way you brace for a thing that hardly ever comes and levels everything when it does.

It did not come. His father looked at him, and something moved behind the shut gate, and what came out of the man instead was worse than anger, because it was patient.

"Do you remember the river," the chief said.

Korvan stared at him.

"I know you remember it. You bring it up sideways, the way people always do with the thing that made them. The water. My hand. You were five." His father's weathered face did something in the firelight that Korvan had not seen it do in years, which was soften, and it frightened him more than any hardness would have. "You think I pulled my hand out

from under you to teach you to swim. That's the story you've told yourself, and it's a good one, and it's half right. You've told it as a hard thing. The hard clan way. Father lets the boy go under to make a man of him. And I've let you keep it, because it was near enough, and because a boy needs his hard stories to hold onto." He gave his head one slow shake. "But that is not why I took my hand away, Korvan. I took it away because I had watched a stronger swimmer than you will ever be go into water like that with a man's whole hand under him, trusting the hand, and I had watched the hand fail, once, at the wrong moment, and I had watched the water take him because he had not in his whole life once had to hold himself up. He'd always had the hand." He was very quiet now. "I took my hand off your belly because the hand is the thing that kills you. Not the water. The water you can learn. It's the trusting the hand to always be there that drowns you, because one day it isn't, and you've never learned the other thing, and you go down still reaching for it. I let you go so that when I was gone, and I am going, son, we are all going, sooner in a war than out of one, you would not go down reaching for a hand that wasn't there anymore. You would already know how to hold yourself up in cold water. That is the whole of what I know about being a father. It is the only gift I ever had it in me to give you. And you have hated me for it for fourteen years, and I have let you, because the hating was you holding yourself up."

The fire burned. Up the slope a horse stamped and settled. Korvan discovered that his hands had curled into fists at his sides and made them open.

"That's not an answer about the war," he said, but it came out with the ground gone from under it.

"It is the only answer I have about the war." His father kept his voice low. "You want me to have kept my hand under you in that hall. To have stood up and held you up in

front of the whole council and said, my son is clean, believe me, and made them believe it by main strength. And maybe I could have. For a night. And then Loric, who is not a fool, who is the most patient dangerous man I have met in a long life of meeting them, would have spent the next year saying quietly to anyone who'd listen that the chief protects his boy from the vampire's charge a little too hard, doesn't he, a little too quick, makes you wonder what the chief has to hide, and it would have grown in the shadows the way that man grows everything, and in a year or two the story would not have been my son keeping a sad girl company. It would have been the chief's whole line is soft on the vampire, and it goes back to the boy, and the boy is why. I would have held you up above the water for one night, and drowned you slow over two years." He let the thought settle. "So I pulled the hand back. I gave them a war to be afraid of that is bigger than you, so that you would not be the thing they fear." He crouched and fed a stick into the low fire, slow, watching it catch, and did not look up while he said the rest, as if the words were easier laid on the flames than on his son. "A chief who takes his people to war over a hidden born vampire is not a chief whose blood is mixed up with hers. He is a man who was wronged, doing the hard thing wronged men do. It puts the garden out of sight. It puts you out of sight, under something too large for any of them to see past. It cost me four thousand people's peace, and I paid it wide awake, knowing the price to the copper, and I would pay it again before this night is out." His voice did not break. It came very close. "I am letting you go under, Korvan. On purpose. One more time. Because the alternative is holding you up where everyone can see me do it, until the day my hand fails, and then watching you drown reaching for it. I would rather you hate me and swim."

And Korvan stood in his father's fire and could not for the life of him find the place where the man was wrong, and could not make himself agree that he was right, and understood with a cold falling feeling that this was one of the things that does not come out even, that he was going to hold both halves of it as long as he lived.

"And the girl," Korvan said, when he could find the words. Because it was the only ground left. "You've buried me under a war. What happens to her."

His father was quiet a while.

"That," the chief said, "is the one place I cannot follow you, and will not try. She is not mine to weigh. She is the Queen's daughter and the war's whole cause and there is a hunter's writ out on her with the Queen's own seal quiet behind it, which means her own mother has decided she is worth more found than free, and if she is taken within a mile of this train it is the end of every reason I have given for anything, and it is your death, and it may be mine." He held Korvan's eyes. "I am your father and I have just told you the truest thing I know, so I will tell you this one as well, and then I am done. I know she is up on that mountain. I know you will go back up to her before the moon is down, because I raised a boy who does not leave a person on a cold rock, God help us both. I am not going to stop you. I am not going to help you. I am going to stand at this fire and be the chief, and I am going to fail, on purpose, to look toward that mountain, for exactly as long as I can, which is not long, because Bricc is not blind and the reeve's men have tongues and by tomorrow's noon there will be searchers on that high trail whether I will it or no." He turned back to the fire, and the shut gate came down over the whole of him again, and when he spoke the softness had gone out of his voice and the chief had come back into it. "Get her off my mountain, Korvan. Tonight. Before I have to be the man who found her.

Because if I am standing here when they bring her down, I will not be able to save you, and I will have declared a war and lost my son inside the same season, and no creed I have is big enough to hide me from that."

It was, Korvan understood, the closest thing to help his father was able to give, dressed as a refusal so that he could give it and still be the chief in the morning. It was the hand, taken away, one more time, in the only way the man knew how to leave it there.

"I hear you," Korvan said.

"I know you do." His father did not look round. "You always did. It's the doing you were slow at."

* * *

He found Selwyn where he'd known he would find him, at the far picket with the horses, because Selwyn went to the horses when he was frightened the way Korvan went to the fires, and the two of them had been going to their separate corners of a camp their whole lives and finding each other there anyway.

"I need a horse that won't be missed till noon," Korvan said. "And a skin of water and whatever's in your saddlebag, and I need you to not have seen me take any of it."

Selwyn kept his back to him. He had his hand flat on the neck of the grey mare he loved, the one he sang to in the mornings, and he kept it there, and he said, to the mare, "You're going to her."

"Selwyn."

"Seven men off a mountain," Selwyn said, still to the horse, and now his voice had a thing in it Korvan had not heard there in all their years, which was fear that had gone past its edge into something colder. "That did not run. A big one. Hill-built." He turned around then, and his face was terrible, because it was not angry, it was afraid, and it was

afraid for Korvan, and that was somehow past bearing. "I have spent a week telling every man who'd listen that whatever they're saying about you is horse-leavings, because you're the best man I know and you sat with a sad girl at a party and that was all of it. I've spent my own name on you, Korvan. Quietly. All week. Because I believed the small clean version. And now you stand there and ask me for a horse that won't be missed, in the middle of the night, an hour after seven men came down off that mountain half out of their minds, and you want me to hand it to you and ask nothing, and I—"

"Then don't hand it to me," Korvan snapped, and the words broke out of him hard and vicious and wrong before he could stop them, the old quick temper he had spent so long learning to bank coming up all at once and going straight at the one person in the camp who had done nothing but stand for him. "Don't. Go back to your fire and clean a weapon that doesn't need it like the rest of them and tell yourself you didn't see me and keep your precious name clean. That's what everyone else is doing. Why should you be different. God forbid Selwyn spend one more copper of his good name on the shapeless boy who's finally gone and proved he's exactly the trouble they always—"

He stopped.

He stopped because Selwyn had not flinched, had not fired back, had just stood there and taken it full in the face with his hand still on the mare's neck, and taken it, and let it land, and gone, if anything, gentler, the way you go still when a hurt animal bites you because it's hurt. And Korvan heard the whole ugly shape of what he'd just done hanging in the cold air between them, the exact thing his father had just refused to do to him, which was let go of the person in front of you in order to save yourself the weight of them, and he was so ashamed he could not breathe.

"Selwyn," he said. "Selwyn, I didn't—"

"Yes you did," Selwyn said, quietly. "But I know why. You're trying to make me let go of you before you have to watch what happens next. So it'll hurt me less." He almost smiled, and it was the saddest thing he had yet watched his friend's foolish face do. "You great idiot. You're doing your father's thing. Taking your hand away so I'll learn to swim without you." His jaw set. "Well, I won't. I've decided. So you can save your breath."

Korvan's eyes stung. He looked at the ground.

"I don't have a small clean version to give you," he said, low. "There isn't one. It's true, Selwyn. All of it. The garden and the mountain and — all of it. She's up there right now with my coat on and there's a writ out with the Queen's seal quiet behind it and I have got until about noon before Bricc puts it together and there are searchers on that trail, and I don't have a plan past getting her off the mountain before the sun's up. That's the whole story. That's what you'd be spending your name on. Not a sad girl I sat beside at a banquet. A born vampire the whole war is about, and a chief's son who's decided to run with her. Now go back to your fire. I mean it this time, and I mean it kindly. Go back to your fire so that when they ask, you can look them in the eye."

Selwyn was quiet for a while. The mare blew softly and leaned her big head against his chest and he put his other hand up and cupped her jaw without seeming to know he did it.

"There's a game trail," he said, "off the north shoulder, below the tarn. Goes down into the fold before it climbs. The reeve's men won't know it, they came up the writ-road, the easy one. It's rough and it's slow and a horse can just about do it in the dark if the horse is careful and the man leading it isn't a fool." He was not looking at Korvan. He had gone back

to the practical, the way he did, because the practical was a thing he could put his hands on when everything else was too big. "Take the grey. She's got the best feet in the train and she'll go quiet for you if you let her think it's her idea. I'll say she slipped her picket. It happens. I'll be very upset about it. I'll be upset about it loudly, for hours." Now he looked up, and his eyes were wet and steady both at once. "That's what I've got, Korvan. That's my name, spent. It's not much and it won't hold long. But it's a game trail and a good horse and a lie I'll tell well, and it's yours, and I'd give you more if I had it, and I gave it to you knowing to the letter what it was, because you're my friend, and I'd sooner lose my good name over a true thing than keep it clean over a lie."

And Korvan, who had come to the picket ready to burn the last bridge he had in the world so that no one would have to stand near him when he fell, found that he could not do it, that Selwyn would not let him, that his friend had reached straight through the ugliness and refused to be pushed off, and it broke something loose in him that he'd been holding shut since the garden. He stepped forward and got an arm around Selwyn's neck, hard, the way the uncles had put their hands on Tam, the way no one had ever done to him, and Selwyn hugged him back fierce and clumsy with the mare's rope still in his fist, and for a moment the two boys who had never quite belonged anywhere stood belonging to each other at the cold edge of a camp that was already coming apart around them.

"You did just exactly what one of ours does," Korvan said into his friend's shoulder, before he knew he was going to, the words he had wanted his whole life to have said to him, saying them instead, and Selwyn made a sound that was half a laugh and half a sob, and held on.

"Get up your mountain," Selwyn said thickly. "Get her down the north shoulder. And Korvan—" He pulled back and gripped him by both shoulders and looked hard into his face, and there was something in his face now past the fear and past the grief, a kind of wondering. "Whatever you are. Whatever's coming for you, that they're all so afraid of. I've known you since we were six. And I'd put my name on this too, at the end of everything: it's not going to be the monster they think. I don't know what it's going to be. But I've watched you carry a thing this week that would have flattened any man in this camp, and you're still climbing a mountain in the black night to bring a girl in from the cold. That's not the shape of a monster. Whatever else it turns out to be."

Korvan took the mare's rope. His hands were not quite steady. Above the black wall of the trees the moon had come round to full, or near it, so near that he could not have said looking at it whether it had one night left to run or none, and something low in his chest, the flutter, the heat behind the breastbone he had spent his whole life mistaking for the door opening, gave a slow deep turn that was not like any of the times before, and he was too full of the night to notice, and put it down to grief, and went up the mountain toward the girl with a good horse walking quiet behind him and his friend's spent name in his pocket and the full moon coming up the sky at his back.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The First Full Moon

The girl was where he had left her, and that was the first mercy of the night, and he was fool enough to think it would be the last thing the mountain took from him.

He came up over the lip of the black rocks with the grey mare blowing behind him and found Amelia sitting exactly as he had left her two hours gone, his coat around her shoulders, the heel of bread untouched on the stone at her knee, her back against the cold granite and her knees drawn up and her silver hair gone the color of the rock in the dark. She did not startle when his head came over the rise. She had heard him a long way off. She had the look she got when she had been sitting still with her own thoughts too long, the look of a person doing sums in the dark, and her eyes found him and moved once over the shape of him, quick, checking him the way he had learned she checked everyone, for what they were carrying and whether it was a danger to her.

"You came back," she said.

"I said I would."

"People promise all kinds of things on their way down a mountain." She got her feet under her without using her hands, one clean motion off the cold stone, and he saw the stiffness she would not let into her face travel through her shoulders instead. She had been up here freezing on a rock

for two hours and she stood as if she had chosen it. "The horse. You got a horse."

"Selwyn got a horse. I got a game trail off the north shoulder and a lie that'll hold till noon." He came the rest of the way up onto the flat and looped the mare's rope twice around a spur of rock and set his hand on her neck to keep her quiet, because she did not like the height and the wind and the smell of the tarn below them, and he did not blame her. "We've got that long. Till noon. Then there'll be searchers on the writ-road, and Bricc will have put your seven men together with a big hill-built shape that didn't run, and the whole of it will point at this mountain." He heard how flat he had made his own voice and let it stay flat, because flat was the only way to carry it. "So we don't sleep. We walk the grey down the north fold while it's dark and we're off the high ground before the sun shows us to anyone with eyes."

She was quiet a moment. The wind came up off the tarn and moved her hair and she put a hand up and held it out of her face, and the gesture was so ordinary, so much the gesture of a girl and not of the thing the whole war was about, that something turned over in his chest that had nothing to do with the flutter and everything to do with her.

"You told him," she said. Not the searchers. His father. She had gone straight to it, the way she did, past the practical and into the true. "You went down that mountain and you stood in your father's fire and you told him it was me."

"I didn't have to tell him. He'd done the sum before I got there." He looked at his hand on the mare's neck instead of at Amelia, because it was easier. "He's known since the garden. He let it lie because letting it lie was cheaper. Tonight it stopped being cheaper." The cold arithmetic of the man rose up in him and he pushed it down. "He's not

coming for you. He's not sending anyone for you either. He's going to stand at his fire and fail to look at this mountain as long as he's able, which is not long, and that's the most help he's able to give me and call it a refusal in the morning." He made himself say the rest, because she had a right to it, and because she was not a girl you protected by keeping the shape of the world from her. "He said if he's standing there when they bring you down, he can't save me. So we don't let them bring you down. That's the whole plan. Off the mountain before noon."

Amelia took that the way she took things, without a flinch he could see, folding it into wherever she kept the running total of what her life cost the people who touched it. But he had learned to read her by now, three weeks of hard road and one impossible garden, and he saw the small thing she did with her jaw, the setting of it, and he knew the sum she had just done had come out with his name in the debit column.

"You should have let them take me on that road," she said. "In the beginning. Before the garden. You'd have a father who trusted you and a friend whose name was still his own and a war that was about somebody else."

"I know what I'd have."

"Then why."

He had no answer for that he could say out loud. There was a heat behind his breastbone that had been building all the long climb, worse than it had ever been in his life. It was a slow deep turning low under the bone, and he had spent the last hour telling himself it was grief and exhaustion and the wine of a terrible day. Because it was always grief and exhaustion. It had been grief and exhaustion at the banquet, and in the hall, and every full moon of his life since the shame of the first one, the one that came and went and left him standing in his own skin while the others of his year

came up howling into their clans. His whole life his body had lied to him about this. His whole life the flutter had risen up in him at the edge of a moon and promised him he was about to become someone, and every time it had guttered out and left him a man. He had learned not to trust it. Long ago he had taught himself to put a name on it before it could hurt him, grief, or hunger, or fear, and go on. So he put grief on it now, and looked at the girl who had asked him why, and did not have a word for the answer, and the moon came clear of the eastern ridge behind her.

It came up full. He saw it come up over her shoulder, over the black shoulder of the mountain, huge and low and the cold near-white of struck iron. It laid a silver road down the black face of the tarn below them. The light of it fell on Amelia's hair and turned it to the same metal, and for one breath she stood haloed against the rising moon with her hair gone to silver fire. Korvan looked at her lit up like that, and the heat behind his breastbone turned, and the turn went deeper and surer than any it had made in twenty years.

He knew this one was different.

That was the cruelty of it, that after a lifetime of the flutter lying to him, the one time it told the truth he knew, instantly, in the animal middle of himself, that it was the truth. The turn went deep and it did not gutter. It caught. It caught the way a coal catches when you have been blowing on it in the cold for an hour and given up and turned away, and it took hold low under his breastbone and began, unhurried and enormous and entirely beyond him, to open.

"Korvan," Amelia said.

He could not answer her. His jaw would not do it. The heat had come up his throat.

"Korvan, your—" and her voice changed, the clinical cold coming down over it the way it did when she was frightened

and would not be, "your eyes. Something is wrong with your eyes."

It's grief, he wanted to tell her. *It's the day. It always feels like this and it always passes. Give it a moment and it passes.* He got none of it out. The words were in him and there was no longer a road from the middle of him to his mouth, because the middle of him had other business now, the middle of him had come awake after twenty years asleep and was reaching for the edges of him and finding them too small.

Then the pain came, and after that there were no more words anywhere.

* * *

It was not power. That was the thing no one had ever told him, in all the years of stories, in all the clan songs about the first shift that the boys sang to each other in the dark to make it sound like a glory instead of a fear. It was being unmade. Every bone he owned had decided at once that it was the wrong shape and had begun, without asking him, to become the right one, and there was no part of that a body could hold still and endure, because it was the body itself that was moving.

He went down. He knew that much. His knees were on the cold stone and then his hands were, and then his hands were not hands. He watched it happen. That was the part he would carry as long as he lived, that he watched his own hand on the granite in the moonlight stretch and lengthen and split its knuckles into something with too many joints, watched the nails go dark and hook and drive down into the granite and hold. And he heard a sound he had never made come out of him, low and torn, and could not stop making it.

Fragments. That was all there was now. The heat had left his breastbone. It was everywhere now, it was in his spine and in the long bones of him and in the sockets of his

shoulders where something was tearing and building at once, and his breath came in and did not fit, his ribs were the wrong number, his ribs were moving, he could feel each one travel and he could do nothing, a man cannot make his own ribs be still. His sight went strange. The moon splintered and doubled and came back sharper than any moon he had ever seen, every crater on the cold face of it suddenly close. The silver road on the tarn below was not silver anymore but a hundred separate points of light. He could see, he could see the individual pine needles on a tree forty feet down the slope. None of it was a gift. All of it was the horror of a body making itself into a thing that saw the world in a way his old self was never meant to bear.

He tried to say her name.

What came out of him instead came out on a breath that had gone hot in his chest, hot the way the smith's breath is hot, and it lit. He felt it light. Something turned over in a new place low in him, where no organ of a man had ever been, and the breath came up his throat and left him carrying heat. A thin line of fire went out over the black stone in front of his own long dark reaching hands and guttered against the rock. And the shame of that, even then, even inside the unmaking, the shame of a body doing a thing so far past monstrous that there was no clan song for it at all, was the last clear thing he owned. Then the pain took the top of his mind off, and he was only the shift, only the tearing and the building, only the animal core of himself dragging the rest of him out into the moonlight whether he would come or no.

He grew. The growing was a thing he could feel happening to him, cell by cell. The cold flat of rock that had been under his knees was suddenly a small thing under a great weight, and the spur where the mare was tied swung away below him. He heard the grey scream, one high tearing horse-scream of a terror older than her training, heard her

wrench her rope and go, hooves ringing away down the rock into the dark. He could not have called her back if he had a voice, and he did not have a voice. His throat was the length of a man now and getting longer. There was a spine that ran out behind him into the dark, a weight on the end of it that moved when he thought about moving. And he had, God help him, he had wings. He could feel them waking down his back, vast folded aching things bound down against his sides that wanted, the moment they knew themselves, to open.

And then it was done. It went out of him all at once, the way a fever breaks. The last of the building ran out to the edges of him and set, and the pain rolled back and left him lying on the black rocks under the full moon, in a body that was not a man's body, enormous and steaming faintly in the cold and utterly, ringingly silent. Korvan lay in it and did not move, because he did not know how, because he did not know what any part of himself was anymore. Above him the moon hung full and pitiless and silver and told him nothing. No elder. No song. No clan. Only the cold light and the terrible clarity of his new eyes, and the sound, very close, of a girl breathing.

* * *

She had not run.

That was the second mercy of the night and the one he had no right to and would never, as long as he lived, understand the size of. He got his new eyes to work, got them to swing the great weight of his head around on the long unfamiliar rope of his neck, slow, because everything was slow and vast and half a beat behind his wanting, and he found her.

Amelia had not run. She stood ten feet from him with her back to the granite wall and his coat fallen off her shoulders

into the rocks at her feet. She was as white as the moon. Her hands were down at her sides and open, turned a little toward him, and at the open wrists, faint in the dark, a light had woken, a deep-red gathering of her blood magyk called up and held ready. He understood even in the ruin of his new mind what that meant. It meant she was not frozen. It meant she had watched a man she knew come apart into a monster ten feet from her in the moonlight, and instead of running, instead of the good sane thing, she had stood her ground and called up the worst of what she carried and held it ready, not aimed, held, the way you hold a knife you have not yet decided to use, and she had made herself stay and see what came up out of the unmaking before she ran or struck or wept.

Both of them dangerous. Both of them standing in the moonlight on a mountain with the worst of themselves called up and showing, and neither of them running.

He made a sound. He did not mean to. It came up out of the great new chest of him low and long and it shook the small stones on the rock, and he felt her flinch, saw the red light jump brighter at her wrists, and he did the only thing he could think to do, which was to put the huge terrible head of himself down. Down onto the cold rock. Down, low, below the level of her eyes, the way you get low and small for a frightened animal, the way Selwyn got low for a spooked horse, and he lay there with his jaw on the stone and his new eyes turned up to her and made himself as little as a thing his size could make itself, and waited.

For a long time nothing moved but the wind.

Then Amelia let out a breath he heard travel the whole way out of her, and the red light at her wrists dimmed, and dimmed, and went out, and she took one step toward him over the rocks, and another, her bare hand coming up in front of her, and she said, in a voice with the clinical cold all

shaken out of it now, low and wondering and afraid and something else he had no name for, "Korvan. It's you. It's still you. I can see it's still you."

She should not have been able to see any such thing. There was nothing of the man left in the shape of him. But she said it as if she were reading it off him the way she read everything, off some tell he did not know he still had. She came the last step and laid her hand flat on the great scaled ridge of his lowered brow, her small warm living hand on the cold new armor of him. And Korvan, who had spent twenty years wanting only to belong to something, felt the touch of the one person on the mountain go through the whole enormous alien length of him, and he shut his terrible eyes and held still under her hand and let himself, for one moment, be touched.

* * *

The memory came then. The first of them.

It did not come as knowledge. He had thought, in all the years of imagining the shift he would never have, that a man came up out of it knowing his clan the way you know your own name, that the ancestral memory the elders spoke of poured in like water filling a cup and left you full and placed and belonging. It did not come like that. It came like a thing half-remembered from a fever, sideways, uninvited, called up by nothing he could name unless it was the cold moonlight and the height and the ache in the vast folded wings.

He knew, suddenly and without wanting to, how to open them.

He did not open them. But he knew. The knowing was in the wings themselves, not in his mind, a shape of moving that the great muscles of his new back had somehow always had, the down-sweep and the catch and the lift, and under

the knowing, for one breath, there was a sky. Not this sky. A wider one, a warmer dark, and other shapes in it, many of them, wheeling on a night wind over a country he had never seen, and a sound going between them that was not speech and was not song and carried, the way speech and song carry, the fact of not being alone. For one breath he was in it. For one breath the loneliest thing on the mountain remembered, in the meat of him and not the mind, what it had been to be one of a great many, turning together on a warm high wind, belonging to a sky full of his own kind.

And then it was gone, and he was here, alone on a cold rock under a strange moon with a girl's hand on his brow and no wheeling shapes above him and no sound going out and coming back, no clan, no elders, no song, no country, nothing above him but the empty silver dark. The memory did not place him. It did the opposite. It showed him, for one unbearable breath, exactly the size of the thing he did not have, and then it took the showing away and left him the lack.

He understood then what he was. He was not the first of a clan, because a clan is a thing you are born into a great many of, and he was one. What he was instead was the last of a clan that had died so long ago the world had forgotten it had wings, dug up alone by a calendar and a coming-of-age, hatched wrong into a night with no sky of his own kind to fly into. Every boy who shifted came up into arms. Came up into a howling welcome, into uncles and cousins and a place at a fire that had been waiting for him since before he was born. And he had come up into the largest body on the mountain and the smallest company in the world. He had wanted, his whole miserable life, only to belong, to stop being the shapeless one, the late one, the son who could not do the single thing every boy could do. And the shift had finally come, twenty years after every other boy's, on the first full

moon past his birthday, and it had made him the most alone thing that had drawn breath in an age, a dragon in a world of wolves and boars and hawks, a clan of one who would go his whole life and never come up into arms.

The grief of it came up in him past anything the day had held, past his father's fire and Selwyn's spent name, and it had no shape a man could weep, because he had no man's face to weep with. It came out of him instead as it had come before, on a breath gone hot, and a low mourning fire spilled from the great jaw of him over the black stone and lit the underside of the moonlit steam rising off his own cold scales, and Amelia was standing in the light of his grief with her hand still on his brow and did not take it away.

"I know," she said. She could not have known. She said it anyway, low, the way you say the true thing to a person past the reach of comfort. "I know. You wanted to belong to them. And now you can't belong to anyone." Her hand moved once on the ridge of his brow, the barest stroke, a thing he felt down the whole length of him. "I know precisely what that is. I've been that my whole life. There's a whole clan of us, you know. The clan of one." Something went across her voice that was almost, almost, the dry thing she used to keep from breaking. "It's the loneliest clan alive. But it isn't empty. There's two of us on it now."

He turned his great head under her hand, slow, careful past all telling of the small warm breakable fact of her so near the new lethal size of him. He looked at her out of his splintered silver sight, the girl the whole war was about, the born vampire with the hunter's writ on her, standing on a cold mountain with her hand on a dragon and telling him he was not alone in the one way that was true, which was that she was alone in exactly the same way. The two lonelinesses did not cancel. They did not make a company. But they lay down side by side in the moonlight and knew each other,

and he pressed the great blunt weight of his head once, carefully, into the cup of her cold hand, and let it rest there.

* * *

The wings wanted to open.

He had held them down against his sides through all of it, folded and aching, on the old instinct of a man who spends his life making himself smaller than he is, and now, with the grief run out of him and Amelia's hand gone from his brow and the moon riding higher and colder up the black sky, they wanted to open, and the wanting had no reason in it and would not be reasoned with. The wind off the tarn moved over them and found their edges and lifted at them, testing, and the great muscles of his back that had known the down-sweep before his mind did ran through the shape of it again without his leave, and it would be the easiest thing in the world. One beat. The wings knew how, even if the man did not yet. He had only to let the knowing move.

"Don't," Amelia said sharply. She had stepped back from him and was watching the wings, reading them, doing the sum, and she had come to the same answer he had and did not like it. "Not tonight. Whatever it is you're about to do, don't. There's a writ on this mountain and a camp of four thousand a mile down the fold and every one of them lying awake tonight because seven men came off this rock talking about a monster. You go up in the air over this valley on a full moon, Korvan, and there won't be a soul between here and the capital who doesn't see it." The cold measuring part of her was all the way back now, doing the only thing it knew how to do, which was to count the cost before the wanting could spend it. "A big man who didn't run, they can argue about. They can call it a rumor. A dragon in the moon, they cannot argue about. That's not a thing you can lie your way

past in the morning. That's the end of every clean story anyone was still able to tell."

She was right. He knew she was right the way he had known the flutter was the truth, in the deep animal fact of him, past argument. The forty who had ridden home from the banquet were the least of it now. In the weeks since the war-banner went up the clans had come in to the chief's fold from every high stading, herd and hunt and holding, until the train of forty he had grown up inside sat like a banked coal in the middle of a war-camp four thousand strong, spread down the dark valley below them. Four thousand pairs of eyes, and every one of them lying awake.

And the wings wanted to open.

He had spent twenty years being the reasonable one about his own body, putting the name on the flutter before it could hurt him, folding himself smaller, holding down the quick temper and the wanting and the shift that would not come. And here at last was the thing his whole self had been reaching toward, here was the sky his blood remembered and would never stop remembering, one beat away. The wind was under his wings and lifting. Every muscle he now owned was singing the down-sweep. And a girl who understood being caged better than anyone alive was standing on the rock telling him, for his own life, to stay caged one more night.

He shut his eyes. He held the wings down.

He held them down as his father had held his own hand back over the black river water a lifetime ago, on purpose, against everything the body wanted, because the wanting was the thing that drowned you. He lay on the cold rock enormous and steaming, the moon on his scales and the sky in his blood and the whole of his new self straining toward the one thing it had been made for, and he did not open his wings. It was the hardest thing he had ever done, harder

than the hall, harder than his father's fire, harder than telling Selwyn there was no clean version left. He held them down. For her. Because she was right, and because holding down the thing you most wanted, when opening it would cost the person beside you everything, was, it turned out, the whole of what he had learned about love on a mountain in the moonlight, and he had learned it too late to be a man and just in time to be a monster.

The wind came up off the tarn and moved over his folded wings and did not lift them, because he would not let it, and Amelia let out the breath she had been holding, and somewhere far down the fold, small and cold and coming, a light showed on the writ-road that had not been there before, one point of torch-fire on the high dark trail, and then another behind it, moving up.

He saw them with his splintered silver sight before she did. He saw them the way he now saw the pine needles and the craters of the moon, sharp and close and terrible. Two torches, and then three. Men on foot, coming up the easy road in the dark hours before a dawn that would show the whole valley what lay steaming on the black rocks above the tarn. And holding his wings down against the wind with the last of his strength, he understood that the night had one more thing to take from him after all. The mercy of the girl not running was going to cost her more than either of them had yet counted. They were out of dark to walk down in. And the thing on the mountain now was not a big man who could argue his way past a rumor.

It was the monster the propaganda had promised. And the searchers were on the trail. And the moon had not even begun to set.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

The Morning After a Body

The torches came up over the last shoulder of the writ-road, and Korvan, lying enormous and cooling on the black rock with his wings held down against everything they wanted, watched the men who carried them walk out onto the flat and stop, and saw the exact moment each of them understood what he was looking at.

He would carry that too. He was collecting the moments a person carries, tonight. The men came up talking, low, the way tired men talk on the last of a climb, a joke going between two of them about a third one's feet, and they came out onto the open rock with their torches high and their eyes still down on the treacherous footing, and then one of them looked up. Just the one, first. A big man, older, a soldier's economy in how he moved. He looked up the way you look up when the animal part of you has caught a thing the front of your mind has not, and he saw the shape on the rock. The torch did not fall from his hand. That was the part Korvan would remember, that the man did not drop the torch. He only stopped, entirely, the way a hare stops. And the joke died in the other men's mouths one by one as they followed his stare up into the moonlight and found the dragon.

Nobody screamed. There would be screaming, the small distant part of him still doing the work of a man had thought there would be screaming, and there was none. There was a

silence that had a texture to it, a held, wet, animal silence of six men learning all at once that the thing the Queen had built a war out of was smaller than the thing steaming on the rock in front of them, and into that silence the big older man spoke, very quietly, not to Korvan, to his own men, in a voice with no fear in it on top and every kind of fear in it underneath. "Easy. Easy now. Nobody move fast."

A younger voice, off to the right, cracked and climbing. "Captain — Captain, look at the size of it —"

"I see it. Mouth shut." The older man had not taken his eyes off the dragon. His hand went out flat and low, pressing the air, holding a line no one had drawn. "We came up for a girl. We back down for a girl. Slow. Nobody looses, nobody runs. A thing that size doesn't chase what doesn't run."

"There's no writ pays enough for that," another one breathed.

"Then it's lucky you're not getting paid to fight it. Down the road. Slow."

For one breath they might have done it. Korvan lay very still under the fading moon, holding the whole enormous new weight of himself flat to the rock, holding it the way he had held the wings, telling the great furnace of himself with everything the man in him had left that these were leaving, that leaving was allowed, that a thing could come out of the dark this size and let six men walk backward off a rock and down a road. He wanted it so badly the wanting shook the small stones under his jaw. He would learn, later, that the wanting had never been the deciding part.

Then someone at the back of the line lifted a torch a little higher to find the footing, and the light of it fell past the dragon onto the granite wall, onto a girl standing against it with silver hair, and a voice said, hushed and certain and ruined, "That's her. That's the witch. She's here, she's right there —" and the line the captain had held with nothing but

his flat hand and his flat voice came apart along its whole length at once.

It was good advice, the easy. Korvan wished, with the whole of the man still in him, that they had taken it.

* * *

Afterward he could never put it in an order that held. That was the mercy and the horror of it both, that the thing which happened next did not happen in the straight line a man's memory is built to walk down. It happened all at once and in pieces, and the pieces would come back to him for the rest of his life out of their order, in the dark, unbidden.

A young one broke. That was the first piece. Off at the left edge of the line, a young one, no more than a boy, a boy who had come up a mountain on a hunter's writ for coin and a story and had walked out onto a rock and found the end of the world lying on it, and the fear took his body before the big man's easy could reach him, and he did the thing you must not do, he ran. Not at the dragon. Away. He turned and he ran for the dark lip of the rock. The running was the thing. The running was what reached down into the new animal middle of Korvan and closed its hand, because there is a thing in the blood of a hunting animal that a fleeing shape switches on below all thought. He felt it switch on in him. He had one instant, one, the length of a heartbeat, in which the man in him knew what the animal in him was about to do and reached to hold it the way he had held the wings.

He was not fast enough. He had held the wings because holding was a thing done across long minutes. This was not long minutes. It was faster than deciding.

The next piece is the one he would not look at straight, not for a long time, not even alone. There was a movement in him that came from the new places, the throat, the deep

new furnace under where a man's heart would be, and there was heat, and there was a sound, and there was, for the length of it, no Korvan at all, only the thing the shift had made, doing the single thing its body knew in its bones how to do to a running shape in the dark. And then there was a smell he had no wish to name, and a stillness where the boy had been running, and the man came back up into the middle of the animal all at once, flooded back into his own splintered sight, and found the rock lit orange and himself the thing that had lit it, and understood, in a cold falling that had no bottom to it, that he had killed.

He had killed a boy who was running away.

The big older man was shouting now. The easy was gone out of him. He was shouting the things a captain shouts to break the freeze in men. Get back. Spread. Two of them had crossbows up and one of them loosed, and the bolt went into the great scaled slab of his shoulder and he barely felt it, a splinter in a door. The man in him did not care about the bolt at all. The man in him was still standing over a stillness on the rock that a moment ago had been a frightened boy, and would have stood there and let them shoot him full of bolts, would have welcomed it, if a voice he knew had not cut across the whole reeling dark.

"Korvan. Down. Get DOWN."

Amelia.

* * *

She had come off the granite wall while the boy was still running, out on the open rock now, between him and the crossbows, which was the wrong place, the place a person with any sense would never be. Her hands were up and open, the wrists burning that deep gathering red he had seen in the moonlight, only brighter now, brighter than he had ever seen it. And her face had gone to the flat clinical

cold that was the worst thing it could do, the cold that meant she had stopped feeling in order to work.

"Down," she said again, to him, not looking at him, her eyes on the men, and he did not understand until she said the next part. "If you're up, they aim at you and they hit me. If you're down, I can put myself in front of what's left of you. Get DOWN, you enormous fool, and let me do the thing I'm good at."

He went down. The great length of him folded to the rock behind her. She stood in front of the whole terrible cooling bulk of him, her back to him, her burning hands out toward five men, one boy dead on the stones and the rest of them with their weapons up and their courage breaking. She spoke to them in a voice that carried flat and even across the rock. It was the most frightening thing on that rock, more frightening than the dragon. Watching it, he saw at last what her mother's blood really was, what the whole war had been fought to own. Not the fire in her wrists. The cold in her voice.

"You've seen it," Amelia told them. "That's done. You can't unsee it and I can't let you take it to anyone who'd act on it before we're gone. So listen to me very carefully, because I'm going to give you a thing almost no one in my position would give you, which is a choice." The red at her wrists pulsed, and one of the men made a sound, and she did not raise her voice at all. "I have my hand on the blood in your chests. All five of you. I've had it since I stepped out here. You feel it. That flutter you're calling fear, that's not fear, that's me, that's my hand on your heart, and I want you to sit with how easy this is for me, how little it costs, because I need you to believe the next thing I say." She let it hang. "I'm not going to kill you. I've never killed a person and I'm not going to start on five frightened men doing a job. You're going to put down what you're holding, and you're going to

go back down the writ-road, and you're going to be alive tomorrow because I decided it, and every one of you is going to spend the rest of his life knowing the vampire had his heart in her hand on a mountain and gave it back. That's the story you'll tell. Not the monster. That one. Now put them down."

They put them down.

She did not kill a single one of them, and it was the coldest thing he had ever watched a person do, and Korvan, lying behind her with a crossbow bolt in his shoulder and a dead boy on the rock in front of him, understood the whole shape of what they were now, the two of them. The propaganda had promised two monsters. The truth was worse, and it did not fall the same on both of them. The truth was that she was the one with the rule, the one who had killed no one, the one whose whole life had been a discipline of the terrible thing she carried, and he was the one who had killed a running boy inside the first hour of what he was, with no rule at all, because no one had ever thought he would need one. She was the witch who held her hand. He was the monster who could not.

* * *

The five went down the writ-road. They went fast and they went badly, sliding, one of them weeping openly, and they did not look back, and Korvan lay on the rock and watched them go with the sight that saw every stumble, and knew, in the cold arithmetic that was the only thing keeping the rest of him from coming apart, exactly what they carried. They carried a dragon. Not a rumor of one. Not a big man who didn't run. A dragon, seen, on a rock, with the Queen's daughter standing in front of it holding it like a hound. By the time they reached the bottom of the writ-road the tale would have started to grow, and by noon it would be at the

reeve's, and by nightfall it would be riding hard toward the capital and toward Loric, who did not even have to lift a finger now, who only had to wait for the story to arrive and do to the chief exactly what the chief had spent four thousand people's peace trying to prevent.

"They'll bring more," he tried to say. It came out of the dragon as a low broken sound with no words in it, but she seemed to hear the shape of it, or to have done the same sum.

"They'll bring more," Amelia agreed. She had turned around. The red had gone out of her wrists and left her grey and swaying, because holding five hearts across a rock had cost her something after all, whatever she showed the men, and she put a hand out and steadied herself against the cooling scale of his foreleg without seeming to notice she was leaning on a dragon. "Not today. Today they'll run all the way to someone who outranks their fear before they say a word. But they'll bring more, and the more they bring will come for you, because a girl who spares five men is a rumor a captain can manage and a dragon on a mountain is a thing the whole of the Queen's army will want dead or chained before the week's out." She looked up the length of his terrible head, and her clinical cold cracked, at last, just at the edges, into something exhausted and afraid and, underneath the fear, unbearably gentle. "We have to be gone before the light. And Korvan. You can't go down a mountain looking like that. You have to come back. Do you know how to come back?"

He did not know how to come back. He had no idea how he had gone. He had no more idea how to unmake the dragon than he'd had, an hour ago, how to make it, and the not-knowing rose up in him with the dead boy and the going bolt and the leaning weight of her small grey hand, and the panic of it did the last thing panic does to a cornered animal.

It made him run.

Not down. Up. His wings were open before the man in him could hold them. They threw wide off his sides into the cold pre-dawn wind that had been testing them all night, and the new muscle across his back that had known the down-sweep all along did it now. One enormous beat. It cracked the air and drove it down and drove him up off the rock, and Amelia's hand tore away from his foreleg. He heard her cry out his name below him, already small, already far, because he was climbing. Then he was in the air, doing the one thing on the earth she had begged him not to do, and he could not stop. The wings had the wind and the wind had him. The whole grief and horror and newness of the night poured itself into the climb.

The mountain fell away under him. The tarn swung below, black, the last of the moon caught in it. The wind he had thought was cold on the rock was a different thing up here, a solid moving wall of it that shoved into the wound where the bolt had turned on his scale and made him roar, and the roar rolled out flat across the whole waking valley and came back to him off the far ridge a moment later, his own new voice, enormous, thrown back at him. He was not steering. That was the terror riding under the other terror. The wings banked and caught and beat on a logic that was in them and not in him, and all he could do was hang in the middle of the great strange body of himself while it carried him out over the fold on a long tilting curve he had not asked for.

And below, everything that lived turned its face up. He saw it happen the way you see a wind cross a field of grain, a moving line of small pale ovals lifting toward him across the grey valley. A herd-boy stood up out of the long grass by the horse-lines with a pail in his hand, and looked up, and did not run and did not shout, only stood, the pail tipping, the

water running unnoticed over his wrist. Dogs went off all through the camp at once, a ragged spreading fury of them. A picket guard on the near ridge dropped to one knee behind his own spear as if a spear were any use, and prayed, Korvan could see his mouth going. Somewhere a woman began to scream and could not stop, and the sound of her came up thin and far, and over all of it a bell started, one deep iron note and then another, the camp's alarm-bell, waking four thousand people to the fact of him. Every early riser at every fire, the writ-road with its five running dots, the whole grey valley — turned up, and saw, and would never after be able to say they had not.

Amelia had told him. *A dragon in the moon, they cannot argue about.* He had held the wings down all night for her, held them down through the shift and the grief and the coming of the men, held them the way his father held a hand over deep water. Then a dead boy and a bolt and a moment of animal panic had spent in one wingbeat every careful thing they had bought. Now there was no clean story left anywhere between this mountain and the capital. And he had spent it, not she. He had spent it, in the one instant he stopped holding.

* * *

He came down in the forest of the north fold because his wings gave out, not because he chose it. The newness of them turned all at once to a deep tearing ache that folded them whether he willed it or no. He came down badly through the tops of the pines in a long crashing ruin of branches and landed hard in the deep needle-dark under the trees where the dawn had not yet reached, and lay there. The moon went down somewhere beyond the ridge, and as it went the second unmaking took him.

This one he did not fight. He had no fight left in him. The dragon went out of him the way it had come, in tearing and building, while he lay in the cold needles and let it. The great bones shrank, the wings drawing back into shoulders that were a man's shoulders again, the terrible sight narrowing to a man's plain eyes in a dark wood. It hurt, as much coming back as going. When it was done he was Korvan, only Korvan, naked and human and shaking on the floor of the forest, a crossbow bolt's deep bruise blooming purple over his shoulder where the scale had turned the point. There was no dragon anywhere in him that he could find. And no way of knowing if there ever would be again, or if there would always be, which was worse.

And in the last of the going, in the moment the dragon thinned to almost nothing, the second memory came, sharper than the first, and it was not a warm sky full of his own kind.

It was the end of them.

It arrived the way the first memory had, sideways, in the body and not the eye. But this one gave him pictures, and he would sooner never have been given them at all. A red sky, the deep red of smoke over a sun going down, and wings across it, more wings than a man could count, wheeling and folding and falling. The falling was the thing. On every hill under that sky a beacon burned, a chain of fires lit ridge to ridge to pass the one word a whole world had agreed on. *Here. It is here. Come and help us end it.* Up out of the fires came the small dark ordered shapes of men, and the wings came down among them and did not rise again, one and then another and then too many to follow. And the sound that went between the falling shapes was the sound he had heard in the first memory, the not-alone sound, the wheeling-together sound. Only now it was the sound of the

not-alone becoming alone, wing by wing, until there was one voice left calling on the red wind, and then there was none.

His blood remembered being magnificent. It remembered, in the same breath, where magnificent had ended, which was here, in one last cold ember of it lying naked in a wood with a dead boy on a rock behind him and an army waking under him in the valley and no clan left anywhere alive to teach him the thing the memory kept trying to scream, which was that a dragon does not get to be left alone.

So that was why the shift had hung back all those years. His body had known before the rest of him. It had been carrying this the whole time, this ending, folded down under the flutter he'd spent twenty years misnaming, and it had not wanted to come, and he had told himself the hanging-back was shame, the shapeless boy's shame, and it was not shame. It was the dragon refusing to be born into a world that had already killed everything like it once and would set the beacons burning to do it again. All he had ever wanted was to belong to something. And the thing he belonged to had died screaming under a red sky an age ago, and left him the memory of the screaming as his only inheritance.

For a while he did not move at all. The cold came into him slowly, the deep floor-of-the-forest cold rising through the needles into a body that had no fur and no scale and nothing over it, and he let it. When he finally tried to get up his arms would not answer, and the second time they answered wrong and put him face-down in the needles, and he lay with the sharp green smell of crushed pine in his mouth and his own breath going ragged and waited to be able to be a man again in the small ways as well as the large. His shoulder had begun to speak now, a deep iron ache where the bolt had turned, worse for being a man's shoulder now and thinner

over the bone. When at last he got up onto his hands and knees the sickness took him and he brought up nothing but water and bile onto the forest floor, shaking, and stayed there on all fours over the mess of it. This was the glory the boys sang about in the dark, he thought, half-laughing and half not. This was the first shift. A man on his knees in a wood, sick, with the taste of a dead child's fear still somewhere in the back of a throat that was his own throat again. He crawled a little way from the sick and got his back against a pine and sat, and pulled his knees up, and shook, and could not stop shaking, and did not try.

* * *

She found him at full light.

He heard her a long way off, coming down the fold on foot, calling his name low and hard the way you call for a thing you are afraid to find and more afraid not to, and he could not answer for a while, and then he made himself, because letting her come down through that wood not knowing was a cruelty he would not add to the night's account. He said her name. It came out of a man's throat, cracked and small, and it was the most ordinary sound he had made in hours and it undid him more than any of it, that he could say her name in his own plain voice again, as if he were still a person a name like that could belong to.

She came through the pines and found him on the ground and stopped, and he saw her take in the whole of it, the man, the bruise, the shaking, the nakedness, and he saw her decide, in the cold quick way she decided everything, not to make any of it a thing he had to bear being seen in. She took off the coat, his coat, the one she had been wearing since the black rocks, and she put it over him without a word, and she sat down in the needles beside him, not touching him, near enough that he could feel the warmth

come off her, and she looked out through the trees at the paling wood and gave him the one thing he needed, which was a while in which nothing was required of him.

After a long time she said, "You flew."

"I know."

"They all saw."

"I know." His voice was steadier now. "I held it down all night. And then the boy ran, and I—" The thing he had done came up in him and he could not say the end of the sentence, and she did not make him.

"I know what you did," she said. "I was there." She was quiet a moment. "You want me to tell you it wasn't you. That it was the animal, the new body, the thing you couldn't hold. I'm not going to, because you'd know it for a comfortable lie and you'd trust me less after. It was you. There's no other name for the thing that did it. It was you, and you didn't choose it, and both of those are true and they don't cancel, and you're going to carry it, and I'm sorry." She turned her head and looked at him, and there was no softness in it, and that was the softness, that she would not lie to him even to be kind. "That's what my rule is for. The one I told them about. Never a person. I made it when I was nine years old, the first time I felt how easy it would be, because I understood even then that the thing I carry doesn't come with a rule of its own, it only comes with the power, and if I didn't build the rule myself and hold it every single day, one day I'd do exactly what you did tonight, and I'd have no name for it either." She looked back out at the trees. "You never got to build yours. Nobody thought you'd need one. That's not your fault. But it's your job now. Starting this morning. Because you're going to shift again, and there's going to be a next time a shape runs, and you don't get to not have a rule anymore. Not now that we know what you are."

He lay in the needles under his own coat and looked at the girl who had held five hearts in her hand and given every one of them back. She was the only person alive who could have said that to him. She was the only one who carried the same weight and had spent her whole life doing the thing she was telling him to learn, and this cold unsoftened honesty in a wood at dawn was the nearest thing to being handed a tradition that a clan of one was ever going to get.

"Teach me the rule," he said.

"I only know mine."

"Then teach me yours. I'll build my own from it."

She was quiet. Down in the valley the bell was still going. It had started under him while he was in the sky, and it had not stopped, faint now, carried up the fold on the morning air, the deep iron alarm-bell of a camp that had seen a thing cross the dawn and come awake to it. They both heard it. They both knew what it meant. The world they had walked up this mountain in was already gone. Down there, four thousand people were being told a dragon had crossed the dawn. Riders were being saddled. By tonight her mother's court and Loric both would have it. There was no more hiding, no more clean story, no road left back to the two people they had been yesterday.

"We have to go," Amelia said. But she did not get up yet. She sat a moment longer in the needles beside the last dragon in the world, in the ringing morning, with the bell tolling up the fold and the whole grey future opening under them, and she put her hand over his, once, on the cold ground, the first time she had touched him as a man and not a monster, and left it there while the bell rang, and neither of them said anything, because there was nothing left to say that the bell was not already saying for them.

Then she stood, and held out her hand, and pulled him up into the morning after, and they went down into the wood

together toward a world that knew, now, exactly what they were.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Banner

The news came to the castle the way bad news always did, from below.

Maren heard it in the still-room before it reached the throne floor, because the still-room was where the runners stopped to catch their breath and beg a cup of something, and a scared boy with a dry throat will tell a kitchen anything. She was counting the breakfast silver back into its felt when the boy came in, and she did not stop counting, because her hands had already started and stopping was harder than finishing. Twenty-two small spoons. She had got to nine.

He came in wrong. That was the first thing, before any word of it. He came in the way people come in when the thing behind them is worse than the thing in front. He was mud to the knee and his horse was blown, she could hear it in the yard, that ragged wet heaving, a horse run past what a horse should be run to, which no rider does for good news. Bess had him by the elbow and a cup in his hand before he'd got the door shut.

"Sit," Bess told him. "Drink. You look like death warmed twice."

"A dragon," the boy said, to Bess, to the room, to his own cup. "Over the hill country. In the dawn, three days back. Hundreds saw it. It came off a mountain with the witch

under it, the silver one, the Queen's own — " and here he remembered where he was, and shut his mouth on the rest, and drank.

Maren set down the tenth spoon. She did not set it down hard. She was proud of that, later, that her hand had been level. She had spent nineteen years learning to have level hands in a house built on a secret, and the training held even now, when the secret had grown wings over a mountain and been seen by hundreds and was traveling now toward the castle wearing her girl's hair.

"That's a story," she said to the boy, mildly, not unkindly. "Drink your drink. Stories walk faster than horses and get taller with the miles."

"I'm only saying what the north road's saying."

"I know what you're saying. I'm saying don't say it in this room." She went back to the silver. Eleven. Twelve. "Bess, give him bread, he's grey. And you," to the boy, "you carried a message. Go and carry it to the people it's for, and not to a still-room. Go on."

He went. Bess gave him the bread first. And Maren counted the rest of the spoons, all twenty-two, and then, because her hands were still not right, she counted them again, and it was on the second count, somewhere around fifteen, with the felt roll going soft under her fingers and the boy's word *dragon* sitting in the room like a smell, that the thing she had been holding off since the word landed came in quietly and sat down in her.

Amelia was found.

Not caught. Not yet. But found, in the only way that could not be walked back. For three weeks Maren had held one thing against the dark, the picture she had built and polished until it had almost the weight of truth: a closed carriage on the north road, a girl gone to ground where no one would think to look, safe because no one knew to look.

That was over now. The whole country knew to look. The girl had not stayed hidden — she had, of all the things a hidden girl could do, gone and been seen standing under a dragon in the dawn, and there was no ground quiet enough anywhere in the world to take that back.

Maren rolled the silver into its felt and tied it and did not count it a third time, because a third time was a thing she did not let herself do. Two was habit. Three was surrender.

Then she went up to dress the Queen, because that was her work, and the work did not care what had wings.

* * *

The Queen already knew. Of course she did. Nothing happened in her own house that reached her later than it reached the still-room. She was at her glass when Maren came in, straight-backed, already gowned, her women dismissed, and she watched Maren's reflection cross the room toward her and said nothing, and let the nothing do the work a lesser woman would have spent a hundred words on.

"You've heard," the Queen said at last. Not a question. The Queen did not ask questions. She issued the world its facts and let it agree.

"I've heard what a scared boy heard on the north road, madam. Which is not the same as heard."

"It's near enough." The Queen lifted her chin a degree so Maren could set the collar. Her skin was cool under Maren's fingers, the old familiar coolness Maren had stopped noticing thirty years ago, the coolness of the one thing in the world that had never frightened her, because it was the one vampire in the world who had promised, when Maren was a child, never to. "Say it plainly, Maren. You are the only person left in this castle who will say a thing to my face

plainly, and I find I have a sudden great need of it. What did the boy say."

Maren fastened the collar. She kept her hands at their work, because her hands at their work was the only steady thing she owned.

"He said a dragon came off a mountain in the hill country at dawn, three days back. He said it was seen by hundreds. He said the witch was under it. The silver one." She forced out the last of it, because the Queen had asked for plain, and plain was the one gift Maren had ever had to give her. "He said *the Queen's own*, and then he remembered whose kitchen he was standing in, and he stopped."

Something moved in the Queen's reflection. Not the face. The face gave away nothing, built over a thousand years, not lent to occasions. It moved under the face, in the place where Maren had taught herself to read her over thirty years, the way you learn a language you are forbidden to speak, in secret, until you are fluent in a tongue you can never use out loud.

"So," the Queen said.

"So," Maren agreed.

Neither of them said the rest. The rest was that a dragon and a silver witch, standing together in a dawn in front of hundreds, was not a rumor a court could argue about, and that the word *the Queen's own* had already left the still-room, and the kitchen, and the north road, and was loose now in the one place nothing could be recalled from, which was everyone's mouth at once.

The Queen turned from the glass. She looked at Maren, and for one moment, one, before the sovereign came back down over her like a portcullis, she let Maren see under it, and what was under was not fear, the Queen did not do fear, it was a mother doing a sum that would not come out.

"They will make a banner of her," the Queen said. "Before the week is out. You watch. Not the hunters. Mine."

* * *

Maren did not understand that, yet. She understood it by evening.

The war council met in the long room, and Maren was in it the way servants are in rooms, which is to say she was furniture that poured wine, present and unseen. It was the single greatest advantage her whole life had handed her, and she had spent nineteen years using it to keep a child alive. She poured, and she stood against the wall between pourings, and she listened, and she counted, under her breath, behind her teeth, the panes in the long window, because her hands had no silver in them and needed a job and the panes were what there was. Twenty-four panes. She counted them six times before the thing she was dreading arrived, and it arrived, when it came, out of the mouth of Lord Verrin, who was the loudest of the war party and the least afraid of the Queen, which Maren had always thought was less courage than a failure to understand what he was standing near.

"I will say the thing no one else will say," Verrin said, which was what he always said before saying a thing three others had been about to. "This is not a disaster. This is a gift, and we are sitting here mourning it like old women at a christening."

"Go on," the Queen said, from the head of the table, in the voice that gave nothing.

"A born vampire. A natural one. The first in a thousand years, and no one made her, she simply *is*, which the treaty never forbade because the treaty never dreamed of it." Verrin leaned in. "For a thousand years we have let them pen us with a piece of paper that says we may make no more

of our own. And now the world is handed proof, in front of hundreds of witnesses, that we do not *need* to make more, that our blood is waking on its own, that we are not a dying thing being managed toward its grave but a rising one. And she has a *dragon*, madam. The oldest terror in the songs, at her side. Do you understand what that is, on a banner? Do you understand what our people would do, what the shifter clans would feel in their bowels, if we rode under the sign of the witch and her dragon?"

"I understand it," the Queen said.

"Then let us use it. Let us find the girl before the grey man's people do, and bring her home, and put her at the front of everything. Not a fugitive. A standard. The proof that our time is coming back around." Verrin sat back, pleased, the way a man is pleased who has mistaken a cliff for a summit. "Whoever she is, wherever she came from, she is the best thing to happen to our cause in five hundred years."

A woman spoke from further down the table. Lady Corenne, who was old even by the measure of that room, and had come through the last war by being the one who counted the cost out loud while the rest of them counted the glory.

"And when the grey man hears we have named her our standard," she said, "what do you suppose he does, Verrin?"

"He does what he was always going to do."

"He does worse, and sooner, and with his own people behind him for the first time." Corenne did not raise her voice. She never had needed to. "He has held the clans off a war for two years on one thin promise, that the capital kills no more dark-born by decree. You would put a dark-born at the head of an army under a dragon. That is not a decree, my lord. That is the thing the decree was only a polite word for, done in daylight, with trumpets. You will hand him the one prize he has never been able to buy, which is a reason his own frightened people will follow him into the field. You will

make his war for him, and we will call it ours, and our grandchildren will pay for your banner in a currency you have clearly stopped counting in."

"His war comes regardless," Verrin said.

"His war comes if we feed it. You are proposing a feast."

"I am proposing we stop apologizing for being what we are."

"Then propose it softly," Corenne said, "and to someone whose grandchildren you have not already spent."

The room shifted. Some to Verrin, more of them than Maren liked. Some to the old woman. And the Queen let them shift and did not weight it either way, and then she asked, mildly, into the middle of the noise, "Where is she now, Lord Verrin?"

Verrin stopped. "Madam?"

"Your standard. This hour. Name me the road she stands on."

He opened his mouth, and found he had no road to name.

"You do not know," the Queen said. "Nor do I. Nor, and here is the only mercy in the whole matter, does the grey man, yet. You are every one of you planning what to hang from a pole you cannot find. So we will not raise a banner tonight that we would spend the morning hunting for. We will find the girl first. After that, her use may be argued by people who at least know where the girl is." She let it settle, and it settled through the room as a victory for the cautious, and it was no such thing. It was a delay dressed as prudence. And Maren, against the wall, counting the panes, understood the shape of the real move under it: the Queen had just made the whole court agree that the first task was to find Amelia, which meant the Queen would be first to know where her daughter was, ahead of Verrin and ahead of the grey man both, and would have that one turn of the game in which to

decide what finding her was going to mean, before anyone else was handed the chance to decide it for her.

And Maren, with the wine jug going slick in her grip, counted the panes and did not spill and understood at last what the Queen had meant at the glass that morning. *They will make a banner of her. Mine.*

Because it was worse than the hunters. The hunters wanted the girl dead, and a dead girl was at least a girl still, a person you could grieve. What Verrin wanted was to keep her alive and empty her — to take a girl who had wanted, her whole locked life, only to be a person in a room, and hang her off a pole over an army, and call the pole her freedom. Her own kind. Her own side. Reaching for her not to save her but to use her, to strip the person out and leave the standard. It was the one point the hunters and the war party agreed on without ever meeting: that Amelia was not a who. She was a what.

Maren had raised her. Maren had counted the silver on the nights the child could not sleep for the size of the empty castle. Maren knew exactly how much of a who the girl was, to the ounce. And she stood against the wall and watched a room full of powerful people begin, warmly, reasonably, to plan the girl's erasure into a flag, and she could not say one word, because furniture does not speak, and a keeper who spoke would be a keeper who cared, and a keeper who cared about that particular girl was a thread that led straight to the middle of the Queen's whole secret.

So she counted the panes. Twenty-four. And she poured Lord Verrin his wine when he lifted his cup, and did not let her hand shake, and hated him with a completeness that frightened her, and served him anyway, because that was the work.

* * *

The Queen let them talk. That was the terrible cleverness of her, that she let a bad idea run until it tired itself, rather than kill it in front of the men who loved it and make it a martyr. She let Verrin build his banner all evening. She asked him mild questions that seemed to help him and did not. By the time the candles were low she had let him talk himself into needing her, into believing the whole grand rising was his idea and required only her blessing and her ships and her gold, and she had promised him none of those and refused him nothing, and the men went out at midnight sure they had won something, and Maren, clearing the cups, could not have said what.

Then it was the two of them in the long room, the Queen and her servant, the way it had been ten thousand nights.

"You counted the window," the Queen said. She had not once looked at Maren all evening. "The whole time. I could hear you not-quite-saying the numbers. Twenty-four, over and over."

"Twenty-four panes, madam. I had no silver to hand."

"I know what you had no hand to." The Queen rose. She went to the window Maren had counted, and looked out at her own dark city, and did not turn around, and when she spoke again the sovereign had gone thin over the voice underneath, the way ice goes thin without breaking, so you can see the black water moving under it and know your weight is no longer safe. "He is not wrong, Maren. That is the horror of it. Verrin is a fool, but he is not wrong. She would make the banner of the age. And every reasonable thing I might do to stop him only helps the grey man. If I deny she is anything to me, I abandon her to Verrin, who will hunt her down to hang on his pole. If I claim her, I confess before the whole world that I broke the treaty and made a forbidden thing, and I hand the grey man his war, gift-wrapped, with my own name on the card. If I do nothing, they find her

without me, and I lose the last say in what happens to my own child." She was quiet. "Every road out of this room ends with someone else holding her. I have sat at the head of the world for a thousand years, and tonight I cannot find the move. There is no move. There is only the choosing of who takes her from me, and how far away I am standing when they do."

Maren stood with the cups in her hands and did not put them down, because putting them down would have made it a conversation between two women, and she did not have the standing for that, and the Queen would not have survived being seen to have it.

"There is one thing you have not said, madam," Maren said.

"Say it, then. You always do."

"You have not said, warn her."

The Queen went very still at the window.

"She does not know," Maren went on, quietly, to the Queen's straight back. "That's the thing none of your lords thought of, because none of them has ever been a frightened girl in the dark. She does not know they mean to make a flag of her. She thinks she is only running. She does not know that the danger has stopped being the men with the writs and started being the men who love her cause. If she knew, she could — I don't know what she could. Hide differently. Trust no rescue. Run from her own kind as hard as from the grey man's." Maren's voice did the thing it did, went to the negative, said the shape of the thing by saying what it was not. "I am not saying you can save her. I am not saying there is a move, if you say there is no move. I am only saying she is out there believing the wrong thing about who is coming for her, and there is one person in this castle who could put the right thing in her hand, and it is not you, madam, because

you are watched now to the breath. It is me. Nobody watches the woman who counts the spoons."

The Queen turned around.

For a long moment she looked at Maren across the long room, across thirty years, across the whole strange marriage of their two lives, the immortal and her human, the cage and the keeper, and Maren watched her do the arithmetic one more time, and watched it come out, at last, somewhere it had not come out before.

"If I send you," the Queen said, "I point them at her. You understand that. You are the one thread in this castle that leads to her, and the moment you go north, anyone watching this house — and they are all watching this house, Maren, Verrin most of all — will know the Queen's own keeper has bolted toward something, and they will follow you, because you are the map. I would be using the only person who could warn her as the very arrow that finds her. I would be doing to you exactly what Verrin means to do to her. Making a use of you. Pointing you like a thing."

"Yes, madam," Maren said. "I had counted that."

"And you will go anyway."

"I won't pretend it isn't a risk. I won't tell you I know a way to carry it that they can't follow. I can't." She set the cups down now, at last, because now it was the kind of moment that had already stopped being about her standing. "But I have kept that girl alive for nineteen years by being the thing nobody looks at twice, and I am not going to discover, at the end of it, that I kept her alive only to hand her to whoever asks nicest. She is not a banner. She is not a sign. She is not the best thing that happened to anybody's cause. She is a girl who cannot sleep in a room that's too big and counts on me to sit with her, and I will not leave her out there thinking her own mother's people are a rescue when they are a rope. If that makes me the arrow, then I had rather be the arrow that

reaches her with a warning than the spoon-counter who stayed safe in the castle while they made a flag of her. That's the whole of it. I've said more than I've said in a year. I won't say it again."

The Queen crossed the room. She did a thing she had done perhaps four times in thirty years. She took Maren's two hands in her two cool ones and held them, and stopped them, because they had begun, without Maren's leave, to count something that was not there.

"Then I will not send you," the Queen said. "Because if I send you, it is my doing, and they will know it was my doing." Her cool thumbs pressed the backs of Maren's hands, once. "But I cannot stop a servant who takes it into her head to leave a hard house in a frightening week. Servants do. It happens. I will be very angry about it. I will be angry loudly, for days, that my ungrateful keeper ran off when the trouble came, exactly the sort of thing you'd expect of the low-blooded, no loyalty in them, and I will make certain Verrin hears me be angry, so that when you are seen going north he is told a story about a frightened old woman fleeing a doomed house, and not a story about a message." She released Maren's hands. The sovereign came back down over her, complete, terrible, and inside it, only for Maren, only for the length of one more breath, the black water still moved. "It is the same road, Maren. The warning and the arrow. There was never going to be a clean one. There is only which thing you are willing to be, on a road that is both."

"I know it, madam."

"Yes. You always did." The Queen went back to her window and her city and her thousand years. "Go and count something. Your hands are a disgrace. And Maren." She did not turn. "When you find her. Tell her — " and here the Queen, who commanded and did not ask, who instructed the world and never begged it, stopped, because she had come

to the one sentence in the language she did not know how to give as an order. The silence went on. Maren waited, because waiting was a thing she was good at.

"Tell her I said she may be seen," the Queen said, to the glass. "That is the message. Nothing else. Not that I love her, she knows that, it is the one thing she has never had to doubt. Tell her the cage is open. Tell her her mother said she may be seen, and may choose when, and may choose how, and that no one, not the grey man and not Verrin and not me, gets to choose it for her. That is all. That is the whole of what I have to send, and it is worth precisely nothing against an army, and it is the only true thing I own, so carry it carefully."

* * *

Maren left before dawn.

She said goodbye to no one, because a goodbye is a thing that gets remembered and repeated, and she wanted to be, on the morning she left, the least memorable woman in the castle. Instead she did the ordinary things. She counted the breakfast silver into its felt and left it in the drawer where it lived, all twenty-two spoons, because a keeper who takes the silver on her way out the door is a keeper with a plan, and a keeper who leaves it is only a frightened old woman with nothing worth watching. She was proud of the spoons. It was the last careful thing she did in that house, and she wanted it done right.

Bess was in the still-room, banking the morning fire.

"You're up early," Bess said. "Or late. I can't tell with you anymore."

"Early. I've a headache and the cold helps it." Which was a true sentence built to carry a false one, the way Maren had built true sentences her whole life. "Mind the Queen's tray goes up hot this week. She's in a temper to freeze milk."

"When isn't she." Bess did not look up from the fire. "They're saying you had words with her. Last night. That she — " Bess stopped, and chose, decently, not to say it, and said instead, "You'd tell me. If a thing was really wrong."

"There's nothing wrong that a walk won't mend." Maren put her hand on the woman's shoulder, once, because Bess had thrown a ham at a lost shifter boy to defend a still-room, and was, in the small way the castle ran on, good. "Keep the tray hot. Keep your head down. It's a bad month to be seen."

She was at the servants' door with the cold coming under it when she heard the Queen begin, above, faint, carried down the stairwell the exact distance the Queen meant it carried. The voice was pitched to travel. It was doing outrage the size of a room. *Ungrateful. Thirty years and she bolts at the first hard wind. Low blood tells in the end, it always tells. Find her if you like, and do not trouble to bring her back.* It was a good performance. It was, Maren thought, standing in the cold doorway listening to the one creature in the world who loved her call her a coward loudly enough for Verrin's people to write it down, the greatest gift the Queen had ever handed her, and it sounded exactly like being thrown out like slops, and that was how she knew it was working.

She went out into the dark, and took the servants' road, the one she had walked ten thousand times with baskets, and she carried nothing that could be read if she were stopped, because the message was six words and she had put them where no one could search, which was behind her own teeth. *You may be seen. Cage open.* She had not written it down. She counted it instead, the way she counted everything she was afraid to lose, six words, over and over, down the cold road, in place of the silver she had left in its felt in a drawer in a house she was fairly sure she would not see again.

Behind her, if the Queen had done it right, an angry sovereign was already telling the castle a story about an ungrateful woman who ran. Ahead of her was the north road, and the hill country, and a girl under a dragon who thought she was only being hunted. And around her, in the grey, she could not tell yet, and would spend the whole long walk not knowing, whether the eyes she felt on her back were the ordinary eyes of a servant's guilty imagination, or Verrin's, or the grey man's, or all of them, watching the one thread in the whole tapestry that led to the middle, follow it now, patient, at a distance, north.

She had counted the risk. She counted it again, walking, because her hands were empty and the road was long. It came out the same as it had in the long room. She was the warning and she was the arrow, and there had never been a way to be only one, and she had chosen, and a thing chosen could not be uncounted.

She walked north into it, the spoon-counter, the furniture, the human the Queen would not feed on, the one nobody watched twice, carrying six words toward the girl she had raised, and did not look back at the castle, because looking back was a third count, and two was habit, and three was surrender, and she had a long way yet to go before she let herself surrender anything at all.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

What the Road Made

They had been four days in the high country, and for two of them they had not spoken except to fight.

Korvan knew why. He was not a clever man about people, his father had told him so and been right, but he had learned this much on the road, that when two people are frightened and cannot fight the thing that frightens them, they fight each other, because the other one is in reach and the fear is not. He and Amelia were both very frightened. So they fought. About the trail. About whether to light a fire. Whether she had slept, which she lied about, and whether he had eaten, which he lied about, and about the fact that neither of them had a plan past the next ridge, which neither of them could fix and both of them blamed on the other because there was no one else on the whole cold mountain to blame.

The worst of them had been that morning, and it had stopped being about the trail.

He had snared a hare at dawn, clumsily, and killed it clean, and he brought it to her gutted and still faintly warm and held it out. She looked at it and did not take it.

"You have to feed," he said.

"Not on that. There's not enough in it to matter. It would cost me more to hold my rule over a mouthful than the mouthful is worth."

"Then take more than the hare. Take — " He stopped. She watched the offer come up in him and get caught behind his teeth, and she hated him for having it in him to offer, and hated worse the thing in her that leaned one starving inch toward the warm animal heat of him.

"Say it," she said. "You were going to say *take me*. Say it out loud, so we can both hear how stupid it is."

"I wasn't going to say that."

"You were. You're the kind of fool who'd open his own wrist for a girl he met six weeks ago on a road that is going to get you killed." Her voice went flat, to the cold place she used to work. "You don't offer that. Not to me. You've seen me hold five men's hearts in the dark. You have not seen the other thing, the thing the rule is *for*, and you are not going to, because the day you offer and I take is the day I stop being a person and start being what all of them say I am. I would sooner starve on your cold hare. Do you understand me. I would sooner sit down in the snow the way your winter men sat down than have you be the thing that turns me."

He stood there holding his hare, this enormous careful dangerous man, and took it, all of it, the way he took everything. "All right," he said. "Then eat the hare."

She wanted to hit him. She ate the hare, furious, because he was right, and because being fed by a person you are going to get killed is a grief there is no good way to carry.

That was the morning. By the afternoon they had lain two hours in a ditch of freezing bracken while a party of horse went by on the road below. Six of them, unhurried, quartering the country the way men quarter it when they have been told a thing is worth the finding and given the days to find it. Korvan had put his body between her and the road out of an instinct he did not stop to examine, and she had let him, not because she needed the shield but because arguing would have made noise. They lay pressed together

in the wet, his heat sinking into her cold, and neither of them said that the pressing was the first time in four days they had touched on purpose. The riders went on. It had meant nothing. It had also meant everything, and they both knew it, and they got up out of the bracken not looking at each other and walked on north into the rain, carrying the new thing between them like a stone in a shoe, unmentioned, impossible to walk off.

The shieling saved them, or started to. It was a shepherd's hut, stone, half its roof fallen, standing in a fold below the tree line where the wind could not find it, and they came on it in the last grey of the fourth day with the rain coming sideways and both of them past the end of themselves. There was no fighting about the shieling. There was only the animal relief of a wall and most of a roof, and they got in under it and got the door-hide pegged across the gap, and stood in the sudden loud quiet of being out of the wind, dripping, not looking at each other, because being that glad about a wall in front of another person is a kind of nakedness, and they had been holding on hard to their clothes.

"I'll do a fire," Korvan said. "The far corner's dry. Smoke'll go out the roof."

"They'll see it."

"Not in this. Rain'll kill the smoke before it clears the fold." He was already crouching to it, because his hands wanted a job, because he had learned that from Selwyn, that when the inside of you is too much you give your hands a thing to hold. "You need to get warm. You've gone the color of the wall."

"I don't feel the cold the way you do."

"I know what you feel and don't feel. I've watched you not-feel it for four days." He got the spark to catch in the dry moss and fed it, small, careful, the way he was careful with

fire because fire was the one thing he had ever been good at before he was good at being a monster. "You not-feeling the cold doesn't mean the cold isn't taking you. It just means you don't get the warning. You go down without the warning. I've seen it in men on winter drives. The ones who felt it complained and lived. The ones who stopped feeling it sat down in the snow to rest and that was the end." He did not look up. "So sit by the fire. Not for the warm. For me. So I don't have to watch the door and you both."

She sat by the fire.

Her hands were too cold to work the ties of her sodden cloak. He watched her try twice, watched the fingers not close, watched her keep trying rather than ask, and he crossed the little hut and crouched and did it for her without asking, because asking would have made it a thing she had to allow. He worked the swollen knots loose with hands that could crush stone and were, just now, doing the most delicate work they knew. She let him. That was its own astonishment, that she let him. He got the wet wool off her shoulders and hung it on the fallen roof-beam to steam, and put his own drier coat around her in its place. She was shaking now, hard, the deep shaking of a body that has reached warmth at last and can finally afford to admit how cold it was, and she looked at her own shaking hands as though they belonged to a stranger.

"I didn't know I was doing that," she said.

"That's what I told you. You don't get the warning." He fed the fire. "The shaking's good. Shaking means you're still in there. It's when you go still and calm on me that I'll start to worry."

It was, he thought later, the first thing either of them had done in two days that was for the other one and not against.

* * *

Amelia watched him build the fire and hated, in a tired and formless way, how good he was at it.

She hated a great many things about him just then, because hating was warmer than the alternative and she was so cold. She hated that his hands were steady when hers were not. She hated that he had watched her closely enough in four starving days to know exactly how she failed, cold without the warning, down without the complaint, and she hated that he was right, and she hated most of all that he had dressed a plain accurate cruelty, *you have gone the color of the wall*, in the one thing no one had offered her in nineteen years, which was care that came with no price tag she could find. Everyone who had ever kept her warm had been keeping the Queen's daughter warm. Maren for love, which was its own kind of duty. The household out of a fondness that was also a job. This one was keeping *her* warm, the actual her, the hunted thing with the failing count and the wrong-colored face, and getting nothing for it, and losing everything for it, more of himself burned off with every day he stayed at her side, and he did it the way he did the fire, without being asked, without looking up, as if it were simply the work in front of him.

She did the sum, because she always did the sum. She had been doing it for four days. It was the only arithmetic she had left that still ran, and it came out the same every time, which was why she kept running it, the way you press a bruise.

He is the most dangerous creature alive, one side of it said. *He killed a running boy in the first hour of what he is. He has no rule and I have watched what a thing with no rule can do. He will be hunted to the end of the world and I am chained to him now by having been the only witness, and every reasonable part of me that is left says put distance between yourself and the dragon before the dragon is the death of you.*

And the other side, which was newer, and quieter, and which she trusted less precisely because she wanted it more: *He is the only person who has ever known exactly what I am and stayed. Not the Queen's daughter. Not the miracle. Not the banner. Me. The whole cold hungry dangerous truth of me, seen at the worst hour I have ever had, on a rock with five men's hearts in my hand — and he put his head down. He did not run. Nobody has ever not run.*

The sum would not resolve. That was the thing she could not get past, sitting by his careful fire with the rain loud on the broken slates above. Her whole life the sum had always resolved. Cold arithmetic was the one gift her mother's blood had given her that she was glad of, the ability to weigh a room and a risk and a person and get a clean number out the far end and act on it without her heart getting a vote. And now, for the first time she could remember, she weighed the thing in front of her and the number would not come, because the two sides were not on the same scale, because *he will get you killed* and *he is the only one who stayed* were both true and did not cancel, and she was a person who lived and died by making things cancel, and they would not.

She looked at him across the small fire. He had stopped feeding it and was watching the door-hide breathe with the wind. His profile was orange on one side and dark on the other, hill-built, too big for the little hut, a man who took up more room than there was. And she felt the thing she had been holding off with the arithmetic for four days come up quietly under all of it, the way the tide comes up under ice, lifting it, and she understood that she was not going to be able to think her way out of this, because it had stopped being a thing in her head.

She stopped doing the sum.

It was the most frightening thing she had done in her life, more frightening than the banquet, more frightening than

the seven men, more frightening than standing between a dragon and the crossbows, because all of those she had done coldly, in command of herself, doing the arithmetic, choosing the move. This she did with the arithmetic set down. She set it down the way you set down a shield you have carried so long your arm has forgotten the shape of anything else, and the not-carrying was terror and relief in one, and under the terror, waiting, was the thing the shield had been between her and for nineteen years, which was simply the truth of what she wanted, unweighed, uncoded, hers.

She wanted him. Not rescued. Not led. Not swept anywhere by anyone. She, choosing, with her eyes open and the fire low, wanted the dangerous devoted impossible man across the fire who had seen the worst of her and stayed, and she was done, for one night, in one dry hut, with a whole world hunting them both, pretending the arithmetic could tell her not to.

"Korvan," she said.

He looked at her. Whatever was in her face, he read it, because he had spent four days learning to read her the way she read everyone, and she watched him understand, and watched him go very still, the particular stillness of the strong keeping themselves in check, the leash pulled short.

"You should be sure," he said. His voice had dropped. "Whatever you're about to — you should be sure. Because I've got no give in me where you're concerned. I found that out on the mountain. There's no halfway with me. If you come across that fire I won't be able to be careful with how much I — " He stopped. His jaw worked. "I've spent my whole life making myself smaller so I wouldn't frighten anyone. I can't do it with you. I don't have it in me to do it with you. So be sure, because I can't be the one who's careful for both of us. Not about this."

"I know exactly how dangerous you are," Amelia said. "I have done the arithmetic on you every hour for four days." She got up from her side of the fire. "I'm not asking you to be careful. I'm the last person alive who needs protecting from what you are. That's the whole point of me. Don't you understand that yet?" She came around the fire, into the heat that came off him, the dragon-heat, the too-much warmth she had lain a plank away from for weeks and told herself she did not want. "I'm not crossing this fire because I stopped being afraid of you. I'm crossing it because I did the sum, and the sum won't come out, and I have decided, tonight, to stop letting a number I can't finish keep me from the one thing I've ever wanted that was only mine."

* * *

He reached for her the way a man reaches for the thing he has taught himself he cannot have, which is to say carefully, and then not carefully at all.

The first touch of her undid four days of holding. She was cold, cold the way she was always cold, and he ran too hot now, always too hot, and where they met the difference woke and would not settle, because they were never going to even out, that was the plain truth of the two of them and not a thing to be fixed. Her cool hands flattened against his chest, over the furnace of him. She took a small sharp breath when his heat reached the cold places, and the sound of it went straight through him and pulled the leash out of his hand.

He had been afraid of exactly this. Not of wanting her. Of the size of it. He had spent his whole life keeping the wanting banked, the temper, the hunger, the need, all of it held down under the flutter he'd misnamed for twenty years, and he had learned on the mountain what he was when the holding failed. He had killed with it. Now the holding was failing again, a different thing coming up out of him, and the

terror of it was real and honest: that he would be too much, that hands built to break stone did not know their own strength, that the devotion and the danger were the one muscle and he could not wake the first without the second.

"You're holding your breath," she said, against his mouth. "Stop it. I'm not going to break."

"You don't know what I —"

"I know exactly what you are. I did the arithmetic, remember." Her cold hands fisted in his shirt and pulled, not away. Toward. "Stop being careful with me. I didn't cross the fire for careful."

And that was the thing he had not let himself imagine — that he would not have to make himself smaller. That there was one person in the world built to stand in the full weight of him and not be crushed, who took his heat into her cold and pulled him down by the shirt and met the size of him with her own. When the last of the careful went out of him, what was left was not gentle, exactly. But it was hers. Every dangerous ounce of it turned toward her and held there by the one leash that had never slipped, which was that he would sooner die than do her harm.

Her cold hands found the hem of his shirt and dragged it up. He let go of her long enough to pull it over his head and throw it into the dark, and then her palms were flat on the bare heat of him, and she made a sound, low, that she did not know she made — the sound of a person warming her hands at a fire she has sworn for weeks she does not want. He got the laces of her shift loose the way he had got the swollen knots of her cloak, the big hands gone slow and exact, doing the most delicate work they knew. Where the wet linen fell away from her the firelight came up onto her skin, silver hair and pale shoulders and the old faded scar low on her ribs he had never asked about, and he stopped, for one breath, only to look at her, because he had spent four

starving days learning her face and had not once let himself think past it.

"Don't stop to be reverent," she said. But her breath had gone uneven. "I'm cold."

"I know what you are." He put his mouth to the cold line of her throat, over the place the count lived, and felt the shiver go the whole length of her, and felt where the cold gave way under his mouth to something that was not cold at all.

They came down together onto the folded cloaks by the fire. There was no grace in it and neither of them wanted grace. There was the cold length of her and the hot length of him, the rain going over the broken roof, the low red of the fire thrown across the pair of them, and the small helpless sounds a person makes when they have stopped, at last, after a whole life, defending themselves against being touched.

He learned her by hand the way he learned everything, slow and thorough, saving it against some later reckoning. Where the cold sat closest under her skin, at the insides of her wrists, the hollow of her throat, the small of her back, he put his heat and held it there until she stopped shivering from the cold and began to shiver from something else. The difference between the two he learned by the sounds she made and did not govern.

His mouth went down the cold line of her throat to her breast and closed over her nipple, and the sound she made then was not one she chose. His tongue worked it hard while his teeth held her just short of pain, and the cold went out of her skin and left a wet ache that ran straight down through her belly. Her back came up off the folded wool. Her hands went into his hair and held him there, not gentle, and she felt him smile against her, the first true smile she had ever

got out of him, felt more than seen, and she wanted and hated him for it in the same breath.

His hand followed his mouth down. It was a broad hand, built to break stone, and it moved over her belly and the jut of her hip to the inside of her thigh with a care so exact it was almost past bearing. She let her knees fall open for it. She was wet, wetter than she had ever been for anyone, the one place on her whole cold body that was never cold. When his fingers slid through the slick of her and found the swollen knot at the top of it, she said his name in a voice she did not recognize as her own. He went still to listen to it. Then he circled her there with the pad of one blunt finger, slow, learning by the catch of her breath exactly how she wanted it. She pushed up into his hand and gave up the last of her quiet. He pushed two thick fingers into her, deep, and she was so wet they went easy, and he worked them in her while his thumb stayed at her clit and did not let up.

"There," she said, and the words were coming loose from her. "There. Don't be careful now. I told you I wouldn't break."

"I heard you." His voice had gone to gravel against her breast. He did not stop.

He curled his fingers up inside her and pressed, and kept his thumb hard and steady on her clit, and worked her exactly as fast as her hips asked and no faster. The pleasure wound tight and tighter and low in her belly until there was nothing careful left in either of them. She rode his hand shamelessly, past caring how it looked, chasing it, and when it broke it broke hard. She came on his hand with her thighs clamped around his wrist and her cunt clenching around his fingers and her cry loud in the little hut. There was no one in the whole cold country to hear her but him, and he was the one she had chosen to come undone in front of. He did not

stop until she had wrung the last of it out and pushed his hand away, oversensitive, gasping.

She did not want the after of it. She wanted him inside her for it, and she dragged him up over her, reaching down to take his cock in her cold hand. He was thick and hard and hot against her palm, and she guided the head of him to where she was wet and open and pulled him toward her. He braced his weight on his forearms above her and pushed into her, slow, so slow, watching her face the whole time for the flinch that would have stopped him dead. There was no flinch. She took him inch by thick inch, the stretch of it dragging a low sound out of her, her nails going into the muscle of his back until he was buried in her to the root. He held there, shaking with the work of holding still, a broken sound in his throat with the dragon somewhere far down under it and none of the dragon anywhere in his hands.

Then he drew back and drove into her, and she met him, and there was no grace in it and neither of them wanted grace. He fucked her slow and deep, and then not slow at all, and she took all of it. Her heels dug into the backs of his thighs and pulled him harder. Her hips rose to meet every stroke. The rain ran off the fallen slates and the fire threw its low red across the pair of them and she told him without words and once or twice with them exactly how she wanted it. She was no one's to be done to. She worked a hand down between them to her own clit and rubbed herself in time while he drove into her, setting her own pace against his, and he let her, because letting her was its own undoing. He watched her take her pleasure from him with his jaw tight and his control gone to threads. When she came the second time it was around his cock, clenching hard on him, crying out into the join of his neck, and he could not hold any longer. He drove deep and came inside her, the whole enormous dangerous weight of him gone helpless at the last

in the one pair of hands in the world built to hold it. And the knowing of that, that she had chosen him and was choosing him still, undid him further than any touch.

Under all of it, the whole time, ran the other thing, and he did not have to name it, because she was carrying the same one and he could feel it in how hard she held on. This was not the start of anything safe. Two hunted monsters choosing each other by a dying fire was not a rescue from the dark. It was a deeper step into it. They were becoming, tonight, the very thing the world would hunt harder for being two, a witch and her dragon in truth now, and not only on a banner, and all of it would cost, later, in a coin neither of them could yet count. The dark of it ran under the heat the way the cold current runs under the warm top of a river. Neither of them stopped. They had both spent their whole lives being careful, and both learned, this month, precisely what all that care had bought them, which was to be alone at the worst hour of their lives. So they chose the dark thing on purpose, eyes open, because it was also the only warm thing either of them had ever been handed, and they had each decided, in their own way by the same fire, that they were done going cold to stay safe.

Afterward she lay along the heat of him with her cold cheek over the place his heart was, and he kept still, which was its own labor for a body his size, and let her listen to the too-fast human drum of it, and neither of them said the large thing, because the large thing did not need saying and would have been made smaller by words.

"Your heart's too quick," she said finally, into his chest. It was almost the dry voice, the one she used to keep from feeling. Almost. "You'll wear it out."

"It's been quick since the banquet," he said. "I've stopped expecting it to slow."

She was quiet a while. Her hand moved once, flat, over the drum of it, not to still it, only to feel it go.

"I won't feed on you," she said. "I want you to know that. You'll offer, because you're the kind of fool who offers, and I want it said first, before you can, so it isn't a thing you gave me. I don't feed on people. It's the one rule I built myself when I was nine and it's the only thing that's ever kept me a person instead of a hunger with a face. And you are not going to be the exception. Not because I don't — " she stopped, and he felt her choose the plain word over the safe one, the way she had learned to from him. "Not because I don't want to. Because I do, and that's exactly why. The things I want most are the ones I hold the hardest line on. You should know that about me, now, before this goes any further. I keep the rule hardest on the people I'd break it for."

He turned his head in the dark and put his mouth against her silver hair, and did not tell her she was safe, because she was not, and he would not lie to her, not in here, not now.

"Then we'll both hold our lines," he said. "You won't feed on me. And I won't let the thing I turn into get near you when I can't govern it. Those are the two most dangerous things in these hills, your hunger and my dragon, and we'll each keep our own on its leash, and trust the other to keep theirs." He felt her go still, listening. "That's not nothing, what we just did. I know it isn't safe. I'm not a clever enough man to pretend it's safe. But I'd rather stand in the open with you holding your line and me holding mine than be safe and alone in the dark for another night. I've had twenty years of safe and alone. It nearly killed me slower than the dragon will."

"That's the most words you've ever said at once," Amelia said.

"You bring them out of me. It's very annoying."

She laughed. He felt it more than heard it, a small warm shake against his chest, the first time her laugh had ever reached him from the inside, and he thought he would burn down more of himself than he had left, gladly, to have it again.

Later, he could not have said how much later, the fire low and the rain thinned to a drip off the broken roof, a sound came up the fold from outside, and they both went still in the same instant.

It was not much. A dislodged stone, a scrape of something on the slope below the hut, then nothing. But the change went through her against him, the cold body gone rigid, the count starting behind her held breath. And the other change started in him, the deep low turn under the breastbone he had learned to dread, the dragon coming up toward the surface unasked, because his body had decided in half a second that a sound in the dark near her was a thing to be answered in fire.

He put it down. He held the line by main force, the way she had taught him without meaning to. Her cold hand came flat on his chest over the too-quick heart, not to gentle him but to read it, to feel whether the thing under her palm was still a man's heart or had gone to a dragon's, and they lay like that, the two most dangerous things in the hills, each with a hand on its own leash in the dark, and listened.

Nothing came. A deer, maybe. A stone the rain had loosened. The hills were full of ordinary night. But in one small scrape they had both heard the whole shape of the thing they had chosen: that there would be no sound in any dark, ever again, that they would not have to sit up and answer, and that this was the plain price of the warm hour, and that neither of them, lying there with their hearts going and their leashes held, would trade the hour back to be spared it.

"That's how it is now," Amelia said, low, when the quiet had held long enough to trust it. "Every stone in the dark. For the rest of our lives."

"Every stone," he agreed. "For both of us." He turned his face into her hair. "I'd rather sit up and answer them with you than not hear them, alone."

* * *

She did not sleep, because she never slept much, and because sleeping felt like wasting the hour. She lay in the impossible heat of him and watched the fire go down and did the one piece of arithmetic that would still come out clean, which was the cost.

It was going to be terrible. She knew that with the cold measuring part of her, which had not gone anywhere, which had only, for one night, agreed to stand down. Two of them were harder to hide than one. A dragon and a witch who had chosen each other were exactly the banner Verrin's kind and the grey man's kind and her own mother's fear all wanted, made real, made flesh, sleeping in a shepherd's hut four days ahead of whatever was coming up the road behind them. She had not made herself safer tonight. She had made herself a bigger target, and she had done it on purpose, and she would do it again.

But the sum that would not come out had a new term in it now, and she turned it over in the dark and found that she did not regret the term, whatever it cost the total. *Whatever comes, she thought, whoever finds us, however this ends, and it ends badly, they all end badly, the ones like us, I will have had this. One night where I was not the Queen's secret or the world's monster or anybody's flag. One night where I was a woman by a fire who wanted a man and said so and was wanted back. They can take everything else. They cannot take an hour that has already happened.*

She thought, unbidden, of Maren, of a thing Maren used to say when Amelia was small and could not sleep for the size of the empty castle, that you cannot keep a good day, you can only spend it, and the spending is the keeping. She had not understood it as a child. She understood it now, in a stone hut in the rain, with her cheek over a too-quick heart. And she was spending it, as hard as she could, because she had finally, at nineteen, in the worst season of her life, been given something worth the spending.

Somewhere out in the wet dark, days south and closing, she could not have known, a woman who counted silver when she was afraid was walking north up a cold road with six words behind her teeth. *You may be seen. Cage open.* Amelia did not know she was coming. She only knew, lying in the heat, that the cage was already open, that she had opened it herself tonight from the inside, without permission, without her mother, without a number to justify it, and that whatever the message was that the world was carrying toward her through the rain, she had gone and gotten there first, the way she had spent her whole life getting nowhere first, and that this time being first had not been a survival. It had been a choice. Her own. The first one that was only hers.

Beside her Korvan had gone under at last, all at once, the way big exhausted men do, his breath dropping into something slow and deep, one heavy arm still curved around her out of an instinct that did not switch off with the rest of him. Asleep, he did not look like the last dragon in the world. He looked like a tired young man who had carried too much too far, his face gone loose and young in the low light, the hard watchfulness he wore all day fallen clean off him. She lay still under the weight of his arm and watched him breathe, the warm impossible thing she had chosen, and let herself, for once, keep the watch he did not know he needed,

and be glad, plainly and without a number, that he was there to be watched over.

She closed her eyes, not to sleep, only to be there, fully, in the one warm hour, and let the fire burn down, and did not count anything at all.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

A Dragon Can't Hide

The plan had been a small one, and Korvan had built it in the dark the way he built everything, from the bottom up, out of the plainest parts he had.

Get her clear. Get her north and over the neck of the range into the drowned country where the clans thinned out to nothing and a man could go a week without seeing a roof, and settle her somewhere with a wall and running water and a way out the back, and then take himself off. That was the whole of it. Take himself off and go so far and so small that the thing he turned into would have nobody left to turn on. No writ. No banner. No war walking behind him. A man with a bad secret could live a long quiet life in the drowned country if he wanted nothing and asked for nothing and let the world forget his shape. He had wanted nothing his whole life. He was good at it. It was the one thing the years of being unshifted had taught him that was worth keeping, how to want nothing out loud.

He had lain awake in the shieling with her cold cheek over his heart and turned the plan over and found it good.

She was not asleep either. She never slept much; he had learned that already, in the short hard schooling of the road, the way you learn a country by being hunted across it. She lay along the heat of him with one cold hand flat on his breastbone, not to gentle the too-quick drum under it, only

to feel it go, and he lay still under the small weight of her and did the one thing he had never in his life been able to do, which was want a thing out loud in his own head without shame folding it small. He wanted this. Not the war and not the drowned country and not the long quiet nothing he had built the plan out of. This. The cold hand and the silver head and the woman who had crossed a fire to him and not gone back.

"You're doing it again," she said into his chest, not moving. "The heart. It runs faster when you think. You'd make a useless spy. I'd read you the length of a room."

"Read what."

"That you're deciding to give something up." She turned her head, and in the last red of the fire her eyes came up to his, the flat measuring look gone soft at the one edge it only softened for him, and never for long. "Don't. Whatever it is in that plan where you take yourself off at the end and go small in the drowned country so the dragon's got nobody left to turn on. I worked it through while you thought you were being quiet. It comes out to you alone in a bog for the rest of your life, calling it keeping me safe." Her cold fingers spread on his chest. "I've had the alone. I'm not trading my cage for a man who builds himself one out of love and calls that different. Take the term out of the sum."

He put his mouth to her silver hair and did not promise, because she would have heard the lie in the heart under her hand, and they lay in the last of the warm hour and did not say the rest of it, which was that a plan with the two of them still in it at the end was the one plan the whole world was arranged to forbid.

And that had been the last hour it stayed good, because in the grey before the dawn the plan met the morning, and the morning was that they were out of food.

There was nothing left in the saddlebag but a fist of oats gone to paste and the memory of the hare. The grey mare had cropped the fold down to stone. Amelia had not fed in six days and would not on anything he could catch, and she had gone a color past pale, a color he did not have a name for and did not want one, and when she stood up from the ashes that morning she put her hand on the wall and left it there a breath too long.

"You need to eat," he said. "Both of us do. There's a steading where the trail comes off the north shoulder, down in the fold before it climbs. Selwyn told me of it. Drovers winter there. There'll be a smoke-house and a byre and people who'll trade for coin and ask nothing, because that's the whole trade of a place like that, you pay in silver and you buy the not-asking along with the mutton." He was already sorting the saddlebag as he said it, giving his hands the job. "I'll go down at dusk and come up in the dark. One night."

"You'll go down," she said. "And I'll do what."

"Stay up. Hold the height. Keep the mare quiet."

She looked at him. She had a way of looking at a thing that made him feel it had already been weighed and found to be exactly the weight he was afraid it was. "You want to leave me on a rock," she said, "and walk into the one place in forty miles where there are people, wearing a face half the hills have a description of by now. The big hill-built one who stood at the witch's back. That description came off the mountain with seven men. You told me so yourself."

He had. He had told her all of it, up here, in the long cold days, because there was no one else in the world he could tell and because she had earned it, hour by starving hour. It was a strange thing, to have a person he could not lie to. He had spent his whole life among people he could not tell the truth.

"Descriptions of big men are cheap," he said. "There's forty of us in the chief's own train alone, and a host behind it."

"And descriptions of silver-haired women are not." She pushed off the wall and stood square, and for a moment the color came back into her by main will, the way she could do, calling the blood up into her face like a thing summoned. "Think. Use the thing between your ears you keep telling me you haven't got. If one of us can walk into a drover's steading and buy mutton and walk out again a big man who bought mutton, it is you. If one of us walks in, the whole fold is on the writ-road by morning with the news that the moon-haired witch is in the high country buying meat. I am the recognizable one. I am the one worth a year's wages found. I am the reason there is a road up this mountain at all. So I stay on the rock, and I keep the mare, and I hold the height, and if anything at all comes up this fold behind you while you're gone, I will be the one thing in these hills that can stop seven men without moving, and you know that better than any creature alive, because you were standing behind me when I did it." She let that sit. "You're not leaving me to keep me safe, Korvan. You're leaving me because I'm the deadlier watch and the worse liability both, and we both know the sum, so stop dressing it up as chivalry and go down and buy the mutton."

He looked at her a while.

"You're a hard woman," he said.

"I'm a correct woman. You find them hard because you're not used to them." But something moved at the corner of her mouth, and she came the two steps across the ash and put her cold hand flat on his chest, over the heart, the way she had taken to doing, not to gentle it but to read it, to know whether the thing under her palm was a man's or had started its long slow turn toward the other. It was a man's.

She felt it be a man's and took her hand back. "Come up in the dark. Come up quiet. And Korvan. If it goes wrong down there, if there's a face you know or a face that knows you, you do not stand and be brave about it. You buy nothing and you walk out slow and you leave me the mutton and come up empty. I would rather starve one more night than have you learn the word for the color I've gone."

"You've thought about this."

"I think about everything. It's the only thing I've ever been good at. I've been doing your arithmetic since you fell asleep, because you don't do your own." She turned away and crouched to the mare's picket, and the conversation was over the way her conversations were over, all at once, with her back to him. He watched her check the picket-pin she had already checked twice, the small ordinary lie of a person's hands giving the fear somewhere to go, and he did not say anything about it, because he had a fire-tending version of the same lie and she had not ever said anything about his.

He went down at dusk.

* * *

The north shoulder came off the peak in a long broken stair of grey rock, and the game trail Selwyn had given him went down it the way Selwyn had said it would, rough and slow and mean to a horse. He went on foot and led nothing and let the dark come up to meet him. Below the tarn the trail dropped into the tree line, into birch scrub and then real timber, and the smell of the country changed as he lost height, went from stone and cold water to leaf-rot and wet bark and, at the very bottom of the fold, faint and animal and human all at once, woodsmoke. Woodsmoke and dung and tallow. The smell of people. He had not smelled it in a week and his mouth watered at it and his stomach turned over at

it in the same breath, because his body had learned on the mountain that people were the thing that hunted them, and could not any longer tell the difference between the smell of supper and the smell of a trap.

The steading sat where the fold flattened, a low stone house and a byre and a black smoke-house and a yard churned to mud, one lamp burning yellow in a shutter-gap. Dogs took him a hundred paces out, two of them, coming stiff-legged and loud, and he stood still and let them work him over and put the back of his hand down for them to read, and they read it and did not like what they read and went quiet in a way that was worse than the barking, and slunk off with their hackles up. He had noticed that with dogs, since the mountain. They went quiet around him now. They had used to come to him. He did not think about it. He did not have room to think about it.

A man came out into the lamp-light with a boar-spear held low and easy, an old drover, grey-stubbled, with the flat unhurried eyes of a man who had lived his whole life at the far end of everything and been robbed exactly as often as he'd expected to be.

"That's far enough."

"I've silver," Korvan said, "and I want mutton, and hard bread if you've it, and cheese, and anything that'll keep three days in a bag. And I want to have never been here. I'll pay for that too."

The old man looked at the size of him and at the coin Korvan held up flat where the lamp could catch it, and did the same sum every man in these hills did, which was whether the trouble in front of him was the paying kind or the taking kind, and he came down on paying, because Korvan had kept his hands where they showed and his voice level and had asked for the not-asking by name, which was the mark of a man who knew the country.

"Byre," the drover said, jerking his chin. "Not the house. Wife's poorly and I'll not have the size of you in her sight, she's superstitious and you've a look. Wait in the byre. I'll bring it out."

The byre was warm with the breath of a dozen wintering ewes and it stank honestly and Korvan stood in it with his back to a stall and let the warmth get into him and hated how good it was, because good was a thing he could not afford to get used to. There was a lamp hung on a nail. There were the ordinary tools of a steading on their pegs, a bill-hook, a coil of rope, a broken hame waiting on a mend that would never come. And on the byre door, on the inside, where a man would nail a thing he wanted his own household to see and not the road to see, there were two squares of paper.

He knew what they were before he could read them. Writs had a shape you learned to know. He crossed to the door and turned the lamp on its nail so the light fell on them and read them slow, because reading had never come easy to him, and he wished, standing there, that it had come harder still, that he had never been made to learn it, so that he could have looked at the two squares of paper and seen only paper.

The first he had half expected. It carried the Queen's seal, or the ghost of it, the wax pressed and then smeared so that a man could deny he'd ever displayed a royal writ while still collecting on it, and it offered, in the flat language of such things, a great sum for a woman of middle years' height, silver-haired, taken alive and unhurt and delivered to the Queen's own people at any of the northern posts, and a lesser sum, still a fortune, for true word of where she'd been seen. Alive and unhurt. He had known that one was out. His father had said it at the fire. Her own mother had decided she was worth more found than free. He read it again

anyway, the alive and unhurt, and made himself take the small cold comfort in it, that the Queen's people at least wanted her breathing.

The second writ had no seal at all.

That was the thing that stopped him. No seal, no name, no crest, no house. A writ was a thing a power put its mark to, because the whole point of a writ was that a man could trust the coin behind it, and coin came from somewhere, and the somewhere was always named. This one named nothing. It was money out of the dark. And what the money out of the dark wanted, in a clerk's careful hand that had been paid not to have a character of its own, was the dragon.

Not the witch. The dragon. The beast seen on the heights above the reeve's country, that had killed and flown, dun-and-grey, hill-built, the size of a barn. And the writ did not want it alive. It wanted it dead, and it would pay for dead more than the Queen would pay for the witch alive, and it would pay again, a second time, over, for proof past doubting, a wing, a jaw, the great head brought down off the mountain on a cart for the country to see. There was a line at the foot of it, added, it looked, after, in the same characterless hand. *That it be seen brought low. That the seeing be public. This is worth as much as the killing.*

Korvan stood in the warm stink of the byre with the lamp swinging a little on its nail and read that line four times.

He was not a clever man about people. His father had told him so. But he had spent a fortnight now living inside a war that a soft-spoken man had built out of grief, and he had listened to Amelia lay out, in the cold flat voice she used to keep from feeling, exactly how the man worked, and he did not need to be clever to read the shape behind the seal that was not there. The Queen's people wanted the witch alive because a live witch was a banner they could carry. And this other money, this money out of the dark, wanted the dragon

dead in front of a crowd, because a dead dragon dragged down and shown was a thing that broke the banner, that made the Queen's terrible weapon into a carcass on a cart, that took the one card her side thought it held and burned it in the square. *That it be seen brought low.* It was not strategy. Strategy would have wanted the beast alive to be turned. This wanted it humiliated in public, killed in the sight of everyone who had begun, this fortnight, to be afraid of it. This wanted the Queen to look at the ruin of the thing she'd meant to fly on her banner, and grieve, and know she'd lost.

It wanted the grieving. It had costed the grieving out to the copper and paid extra for it.

The old drover's boot scraped in the yard and Korvan turned the lamp back straight on its nail, fast, the way a boy turns from a thing he's not to have seen, though there was no reason on earth to hide from a drover that he'd read a writ every soul in the fold had read. His hands had done it before his head could tell them not to. He looked down at them. They were shaking, a fine deep tremor at the root of them, and it was not the cold, and it was not fear the way he'd known fear before, and there was a low turn starting under his breastbone that he knew now, that he would never again mistake for anything else, and he put it down. He put it down by main force, the way she had taught him without meaning to, and got his hands still by the time the door swung and the old man came in with a full sack.

"Mutton, half a cheese, two loaves gone hard, and a twist of salt I'll want paying for separate." The drover set it down and named a price that was robbery and Korvan paid it and a third again on top, for the not-asking, and the old man's flat eyes flickered once at the coin, once at the writs on his own door, once back at the size of the man in his byre, and Korvan watched the sum run behind them, watched him get

near an edge of something and then choose, hard, not to look over it.

"You'll be going," the drover said. It was not a question.

"I was never here."

"No," the old man agreed. "You weren't." And then, at the door, not turning round, in the low voice a man uses for a thing he has decided against his better judgment to give away for free, "There's men been through. Three, four days back, and again yesterday. Asking after a big one traveling with a woman. Buying that same not-asking off me you just bought, and I sold it to them and all, because a man's got to eat and I don't pick sides in what's none of mine. But." He worked his jaw. "The ones yesterday wasn't reeve's men and wasn't the Queen's. Different sort. Quiet sort. Paid in that same nameless coin as the second paper there, that I don't like the smell of and took anyway. And they wasn't asking after the woman like the first lot. They was asking after the beast. Where's it been seen. What it favors. Which way it flies of an evening. Which is a mad thing to ask a drover, and I told them so, and they paid me for the telling-them-so and went on up the fold." Now he did turn, and the flat eyes were not quite flat. "I don't know what you are, big man. I don't want to. But if I was traveling in this country with a beast on my back trail and men paying good silver to learn its habits, I'd want to know they was already up the fold ahead of you. That's the last of your not-asking, and it's on the house, and now you were never here."

* * *

He went up the fold in the dark with the sack on his back and the two writs burned into the inside of his eyes, and he had not gone half a mile before he knew he was followed, because a shape came off the timber at the trail's edge, low

and quick, and said his name in a voice he'd known since he was six.

"Korvan. It's me. It's Selwyn. Don't — it's me."

He had the bill-hook off his belt and half up before the name landed. He had not known he'd taken it. He stood there in the dark with a stolen bill-hook in his fist and his heart going wrong and made himself lower it, arm shaking, and it was the second time that night his hands had done a thing ahead of him, and both times the thing had been violence, and he stood in the cold and was afraid of his own hands.

"You great fool," he said, and his voice came out ragged. "I could've — Selwyn, what in the cold are you doing on this mountain."

"Finding you." Selwyn came the rest of the way out of the dark, and he looked terrible, thinner than a week could account for, mud to the knee, a pack on his back and a hill-pony's lead-rope over his shoulder and the pony standing patient behind him in the trees. He looked at Korvan for a long moment, taking in the size and the sack and the bill-hook, and something in his foolish honest face that had been screwed up tight for days let go a little, and it was worse to see than the fear had been. "You're alive. All right. All right. I've been three days on your trail, the game trail, the one I gave you, because I knew you'd have to come down for food eventually, nobody eats rock, and I've been sat below that steading two nights waiting for you to do the obvious thing, and you did, thank the moon, you did the obvious thing, so here I am."

"You followed the trail you gave me." Korvan's mouth had gone dry. "Selwyn. If you can follow it — "

"Anyone can follow it, aye, that's the first thing I've come to tell you and it's the worst, so I'll say it plain and not dress it. You have to get off it. The reeve's men found it, the north

shoulder, three days back, some tracker of theirs cut your sign at the tarn where the horse came down and now the writ-road's half emptied onto it. It's not a secret trail anymore. It's the trail. Whatever's up there with you, you have to take it off this line by tomorrow or you'll walk it straight into them." Selwyn dragged a breath. "That's the first thing. Here's the second, and it's why I couldn't just send word, why I had to come myself, because you have to hear it from a face you trust and not off a paper. There's a writ out on the beast now. Not the woman. The beast. The dragon they're all —"

"I know," Korvan said.

Selwyn stopped.

"I saw it," Korvan said. "In the byre. Both papers. I know."

"Then you know it pays double." Selwyn's voice had gone low and fast. "You know it's mad money, nameless money, more than the Crown's put on the girl, and every hard man and half the reeve's men and God knows who else is turning off the girl-hunt onto the beast-hunt because that's where the silver's gone. And I've been three days thinking about it, walking up here, I've had nothing to do but think, and Korvan — " He took hold of Korvan's arm, both hands, the way he'd taken it that night at the picket. "You're traveling with the thing they want. Aren't you. That's the shape of it. The woman's got the dragon somehow, it's hers, it's the witch's dragon they keep saying, and you're — you got yourself tangled up standing at her back and now you're between the whole country and the most-wanted creature in it, and you can't fight that alone, no man could, and you'd need someone. That's what I came to say."

"Selwyn."

"Someone at your own back for once in your stubborn life instead of always being the one at everyone else's. That's what I'm telling you. I'm coming with you. I've thought it

through. I've made my peace with it. I'll not go back down and clean a weapon that doesn't need cleaning and wait to hear you died up a mountain over a girl and a monster. I've a pony and I've a bow and I've the food you'll need to keep her and I've decided, so save your breath, because you gave me the your-father's-thing speech at the picket and I'm not having it twice. I'm coming."

He stood there in the dark, foolish and thin and terrified and shining with it, offering the one thing, the only thing, the thing Korvan had wanted his whole life from anyone, someone at his back who had chosen it, who had walked three days up a mountain to choose it, and Korvan had to say no.

He had to say no, and he could not say why, and the why sat in his chest like a swallowed stone. Because Selwyn thought there was a dragon and a man, two things, the beast and the friend, and thought he was walking up here to put his bow between the second and the first. He did not know he was offering to guard a man against the man himself. He did not know that the thing the nameless money wanted brought low and shown in the square, the wing, the jaw, the great head on a cart, was the same throat that his oldest friend was gripping in both hands in the dark. He had come three days up a mountain to help hunt the dragon, and the dragon was standing in front of him wearing the face he'd known since they were six, and Korvan could not tell him. Could not. Not because the truth would kill Selwyn. Because the truth would put it in Selwyn to carry, and a man who carried it would be asked, someday, by his father or by Bricc or by a soft-spoken man in a quiet room, whether he'd known, and Selwyn could not lie, Selwyn had never in his whole life told a clean lie, Selwyn had said so himself, and the not-lying would end him.

"No," Korvan said.

"Korvan —"

"No. Listen to me now. You listen." He got his own hands up and took Selwyn by the shoulders, hard, and it cost him, because he wanted nothing in the world so much as to say yes, to hand even one corner of the stone to another back for one mile of it. "You've done the thing. You hear me? You've already done it. You walked three days up a mountain to stand at my back. There isn't a man in that whole train would have done it and you did it and I will carry that to whatever end I get. But you can't come. And I can't tell you the whole of the why, and you're going to have to take that off me the way you took the mare off me, on nothing but that it's me asking, because I have never in my life needed you to trust me over an answer I won't give you the way I need it right now."

"That's not fair." Selwyn's voice cracked. "You can't just —"

"There's a thing up this mountain," Korvan said, low, "that is worse than the writ and worse than the war and worse than anything the reeve's men or the nameless money have got in their heads, and the only way I keep it from taking everyone I've got left is to be the only one near it. That's the truth I can give you. Not the shape of it. Just that it's true. If you come up this mountain with me, I don't get to keep you. I lose you the way I'll lose everything that gets close enough to it. And I have already spent your name, Selwyn. I spent it at the picket, and it was the dearest thing I ever bought, and I am not going to spend the rest of you on top. Not you. You go back."

"Back to what." It came out of Selwyn small and bitter and true, and it was the thing, Korvan understood, that the man had been carrying up the mountain under all the rest of it. "Back to what, Korvan. There's no back. You think I've got a back to go to? The whole train knows a horse went missing

the same night you did and I stood at that picket and was very upset about it very loudly for hours the way I said I would, and nobody believed me for a heartbeat, and I've spent this fortnight being the man whose best friend ran off to the vampire, watched, followed, my own name gone quiet in every mouth that used to say it easy. I haven't got a back either. That's the thing you've not worked out yet, standing up here being noble at me. There's no going small and quiet home for me now any more than there is for you. You made me part of it the night I gave you the mare, and I made myself part of it gladly, and now you want to hand me back a life that's already burned down behind me the same as yours has behind you." He wiped his face with the heel of his hand, angry at it. "The door's shut, Korvan. For both of us. You keep thinking you can put people back on the other side of it. You can't. It shut when the dragon crossed the dawn. It shut for everyone who ever stood near you."

* * *

Korvan stood on the mountain in the dark and could not answer him, because there was no answer, because Selwyn, who faked wisdom his whole life and was laughed at for it, had said the truest thing anyone had said to him since his father let go of his belly in the river.

He had built a plan out of the plainest parts he had. Get her clear. Take himself off. Go small. Want nothing. And every part of it had been a door he meant to walk back through, into the quiet, into the drowned country, into being a man who'd once had a bad season and let the world forget his shape. And there was no door. There had never been a door. The world did not forget a dragon's shape. It put it on paper with no name behind it and paid double for it dead and public. It emptied the writ-road onto his back trail. It turned its own hunters off a live girl onto a killed beast

because the killing was worth more, and it wanted the killing seen, brought low, shown in a square, so that a Queen would grieve. He could take himself as far and as small as the drowned country went and there would be a writ on the byre door of the last steading in the world, no seal, no name, money out of the dark, wanting him brought low in front of a crowd. A man could disappear. A dragon could not. He had thought the terrible thing was becoming it. The terrible thing was that becoming it had shut every door behind him at once, quietly, the way frost seals a latch in the night without a sound, and he had gone on making plans in a room he'd already been locked inside.

Both sides. The Queen's coin wanted the banner. The nameless coin wanted the corpse. He was wanted by the people who feared him and by the people who meant to use him and there was not, anywhere in the whole hunted country, a single square yard of ground that wanted him to simply go on being, quiet, harming nothing, wanting nothing, a man. That ground did not exist. He had been standing on it in his head for a fortnight and it had never been under his feet.

"I can't take you where I'm going," he said, at last, and the words came out of him plain and level and final, and they were the truth in every way that mattered and a lie in the one way he could not help, because where he was going was inward, into the thing under his breastbone that no man could follow him into, and he could not say that, so he let Selwyn hear it as a place on a map. "There's no version of this where you at my back keeps you alive. There's only the version where I get to watch it take you too. I've thought it through same as you have. I had a fortnight of nothing but thinking, same as you. And it comes out the same every time I run it, and I run it the way she taught me, cold, all the way to the end, and the end is always the same. The marked walk

alone, Selwyn. Not to be noble. Because the mark is the thing that kills whoever walks beside it. So I walk alone."

Selwyn stood very still. Behind him the hill-pony shifted and blew.

"You've started talking like her," he said. Not unkindly. It landed like grief. "Cold. All the way to the end. That's not you. You're the man who couldn't leave a person on a rock." His jaw worked. "But you're going to leave me on this one. Aren't you."

"Yes."

The word cost more than any coin in either writ. Selwyn heard it cost it. That, Korvan thought, was the whole of the friendship, right there at the end of everything, that Selwyn could hear what a plain word cost him.

For a long moment neither of them moved. Then Selwyn shrugged the pack off his own shoulders, slow, and set it down on the trail between them, and pushed it toward Korvan's feet with his boot.

"Then take the food, at least, you stubborn great fool," he said thickly. "There's more in it than in that sack, and it'll keep her another week. And take the pony's lead and turn her loose up the fold in the morning where she'll not be found near me, so it looks like she strayed and not like I brought her, because if I'm not coming up the mountain then I have to go back down it, and go back down it being a man whose pony wandered off, and be very upset about it, loudly, for hours." His voice broke on the last of it, on the old joke, made twice now, and Korvan felt his own throat go. "That's my name, Korvan. Spent again. Right down to the copper. It's all I've got and it never was much and it's yours, and I'd have given you the rest of me on top if you'd let me, and I want it on the record between us, up here where there's nobody to hear it but the two of us and whatever's up that mountain, that I offered. That I offered you all of it and

you're the one who said no. So that whatever happens to you, you don't get to lie down at the end of it and tell yourself nobody would have stood at your back. Somebody would have. I'd have stood there till it killed me. You wouldn't let me. Don't you dare forget the difference."

"I won't," Korvan said. "I won't forget it."

He picked up his friend's pack. It was heavy and it was warm from Selwyn's back and it smelled of the man, of the horses and the tallow and the camp, of everything Korvan was not going back to, and he stood there holding it in the dark and could not for a moment make his legs turn him up the mountain.

"Selwyn," he said. "The thing you said. At the picket. That whatever's coming for me, it's not going to be the monster they think."

"I remember it."

Korvan looked at him, and the truth of what he was rose up in him and pressed at the back of his teeth, wanting out, wanting to be set down in the one pair of hands that had walked three days up a mountain to hold it, and he held it, and held it, and it stayed his, because it had to, because that was the shape of the mark.

"You were wrong," he said quietly. "That's the last thing I'll give you, and I give it to you so you'll go down that mountain and not up it, and stay down, and stay away, and live. You were wrong about that one thing. Now take your pony's other lead and go home and be very upset, loudly, for hours. And Selwyn." His voice did the thing at last that it had been threatening to do all night, and cracked, and he let it. "Thank you. For the mare. And the trail. And the walking up here. You did just exactly what one of ours does. Twice now. Go home."

* * *

He climbed back up the north shoulder in the last of the dark with two men's food on his back and the truth still locked in his chest where it would stay, and behind him, far down the fold, once, he heard the hill-pony's small clatter going the other way, going down, going home, and then nothing, and he did not look back, because there was nothing behind him now that the turning would give him back.

The grey came up cold and clean and the peak went pink and then gold above the tree line, and he was most of the way up when he understood the second thing, the thing under the thing, the thing that turned him cold in the growing light and made him climb faster.

Selwyn had followed the game trail up. Three days on it. He had said so. He had said the reeve's men were on it too, that a tracker had cut the sign at the tarn, that the writ-road had emptied onto this line. Korvan had told her to hold the height and keep the mare and be the deadly watch, and he had gone down and left a fresh set of a big man's tracks going down and now coming up, a clean bright trail up the one line every hunter in the fold had already found, straight to the rock where the most-wanted woman in the country sat alone in the open with the moon-silver hair and no idea that the whole hunt had turned, this week, from taking her alive to killing the thing she was traveling with, in public, brought low, for a grieving Queen to see.

He had gone down to keep her alive and drawn a line up the mountain that led every knife in the hills to the exact stone she was sitting on. And somewhere below him now, on the same trail, coming up in the new light, he could hear, faint, carried up the fold on the cold morning air, the sound a body learns before it learns anything else to be afraid of, the sound of horses, more than one, unhurried, quartering, coming up.

He started to run.

CHAPTER TWENTY

The Shape of the War

The north road did not end at Elverford. It stopped pretending to be empty.

Maren had been six days on it. For five of those days the road had been a road she knew, a servant's road, grey and quiet and going nowhere anyone would look. On the sixth day it filled. First with carts going the wrong way, south, loaded past their axles with the insides of houses. A churn. A settle. A birdcage with no bird in it. Then with people on foot beside the carts, not many, and not talking. That was the thing that told her most. People with somewhere to go talk. These did not.

She did not ask them where they had come from. In a house that kept a secret you learned to find more out by not asking. She kept her head down and her feet going and counted the carts, because her hands had no silver in them and needed a job. Nineteen carts, and then the town came up out of the river-mist, and she stopped, because the town was the answer to the question she had been not-asking.

Elverford was the last stone bridge before the hill country. Maren had known that off a map, flat, with no weight to it. She had not known it the way she knew it now, standing where the road bent down to the water, looking at what the war had made of a market town in three weeks.

The bridge was still there. Everything else had been taken and put to a use. Pikes stood stacked in their hundreds against the church wall, and men counted them. The inn-yard held horses that were not the town's horses. On the river-meadow below the bridge, where in a peaceable year there would be nothing but geese, there were tents, rows of them going grey in the wet, and the smoke of a hundred cook-fires standing up into a sky too low to let it leave. In the square a levy-sergeant counted boys into companies with a tally-stick. The boys did not look like soldiers. They looked like boys. Maren could not get her eye off them, coming down the hill. Not the pikes. The boys who would be holding the pikes.

She had watched this be made. That was the weight of it. Three weeks ago she had stood against a wall in a warm long room with a wine jug slippery in her hand and heard a loud lord call a frightened girl a gift, and had thought the worst of it was what they meant to do to Amelia. She had not thought, in that warm room, that the same evening's talk would come out here, downstream, as this. Tents on a goose-meadow. A sergeant counting boys. The lord had said the word *rising* as if it happened in a song. This was the word made true, seen from underneath, from the road, from the place the carts came from.

She went down into it, because there was nowhere else the road went.

* * *

She learned the rest of it the way she learned everything, by pouring. Old habit put a jug in her hands inside the hour. The muster ran on ale and had too few hands to carry it, and a grey woman who took up a tray and did not talk was worth more to a harried pot-boy than she was worth watching. So

Maren carried ale to soldiers for a bed in the straw and a heel of bread, and she stood against walls, and she listened.

She learned that the decree was dead. No one said the word. They only stood on it, the way you stand on a floor without naming the joists. The capital had un-said the thing it said two years ago to hold the clans off. There would be no more holding-off now. A levy was called, and a march north into the hill country to answer a thing that had been seen there, and the men named the thing in two voices.

Some named it afraid. *The witch and her dragon*. They said it low, the way you name a weather you do not want to call down, and touched wood, and did not meet each other's eyes.

And some said it the other way, the way the loud lord had meant it said. Like a thing they marched toward and not away from. A born one. The first in a thousand years. Ours. A young sergeant, not much older than his boys, had it off by heart already. He told his company by a fire that they were the luckiest levy in five hundred years, because they would march under the terror out of the oldest songs and it would stand on their side of the field. The boys listened with their faces open, wanting it to be true, wanting the fear to have a use.

Maren poured, and did not spill, and thought: he won. The loud lord won. She stood in a goose-meadow full of boys and knew that the old woman who had named the price aloud that night had lost, and had lost the way the careful always lose to the loud. Quietly. Off in a corner. With no one marking the hour. Corenne had been right about every part of it and it had changed nothing, because being right was worth nothing against a young sergeant with a fire and a story, and the boys had already taken the story, and you cannot un-tell a story to a boy who needs one.

She thought all that with her face empty and her tray level. Then she came round the church wall and saw what a knot of townsmen stood at, not drinking, and the thought went out of her at once.

* * *

It was a list.

It was nailed to the church door where the fair-notice went in a peaceable year, a long sheet in a clerk's hand, and above it another, and above that a third, the newest on top. The townsmen stood at it the way people stand at a thing they must read and cannot bear to. Maren knew what it was before she could make out a word. A sheet nailed three deep to a church door is only ever the one thing.

She should have gone by. She had a message behind her teeth and a girl at the end of the road and no business at a dead-list in a town she was only passing through. Her feet took her to the door anyway, because the list was names, and she had never in her life been able to leave a column of small careful things uncounted.

She read down the newest sheet. It was not soldiers. That was the first wrongness, the thing that stilled her against the crowd. A levy that had not marched had no dead yet. These were villages. The clans had not waited for the war to come to them. They had come down first, into the frontier, into the little places with no walls, and the sheet was the frontier's account of it, settlement by settlement, the clerk grouping the names by where they had lived so a man could find his own by knowing where to look.

She found where to look without deciding to. Her eye did it the way her hands counted, on its own, faster than her leave. It went down past names she did not know, past *Sedge* and *Ott's Cross*, and it stopped, because the clerk had written,

halfway down the third column, in his flat fair hand, the word *Millbeck*.

Maren stood at the church door and did not put her hand to the paper, because putting out her hand would have been counting, and some things you do not let your hands count. She read the column instead, and she did not read it as names. She read it as a lane. The clerk had them top to bottom in the order of the lane itself, the way you would walk it, and so it was not a list to her. It was a walk down a lane she had not walked in forty years, past every door, and behind every door a name, and beside every name, in the same fair hand, the small flat cross that meant the door would not open again.

Ferrers the miller, who had been old when she was a child and must have been past ninety, with a cross by his name all the same. The whole of the Bick house, the father and the mother, and under them, indented, the way the clerk indented children to save ink, two more. No ages given, because the clerk did not have them. Maren had them. Four and six. She had held the elder as a baby the summer before she was sent to service. And at the bottom of the lane, where the bottom of the lane had always been, in the small house by the water she had been born in the back room of, one name. *Sib*. Her aunt. The last of them. The one who had stayed when Maren went, who had written her three letters in forty years in a hand worse than the miller's and signed them all *your Sib*. Beside it, the clerk's small flat cross.

She read the lane to the bottom. Then she read it again, which she did not let herself do, because to read a thing a third time was to admit that no reading of it would change what it said. But there was no silver here and no house and no Queen. There was only a church door and a lane full of crosses. She read it a second time, and got to the bottom a

second time, and her aunt was still there, still with the cross, and the reading had moved not one name off the door.

She made no sound. She was proud of that later, in the way a person is proud of the one thing they managed when they could do nothing. Her home village went past her eyes twice, a whole lane of it dead in a night, and her face did not do a thing a face could be marked doing, because thirty years of practice did not fail her, not even here, with the whole of where she came from behind it.

Only her hands moved. She looked down after a while and found they had come up without her leave, both of them, and had begun to count on their fingers, small, against her skirt, the way they counted the breakfast silver. One. Two. Three. She watched her own hands try to make her aunt into a number she could put away in felt and tie shut. She took one hand in the other and stopped them. She stood at a church door holding her own hands still.

The war had been a word. She had carried the word north for six days, and it had been a word the whole way, a thing the lords made in a warm room, a thing that happened to a country. Now it had a lane in it. It had Sib in it, and the Bick children indented to save ink. It was not a word anymore, and it would never be one again. This was what had been made that warm evening while she poured. This was what the loud lord's gift came out as, downstream, in the end. And Amelia was the sign they meant to raise over it, and no one in the whole muster, marching north to fight under the idea of her, would ever stand at this door and lay the lane beside her face.

* * *

Amelia had felt the hunters come up the fold in the grey, and she and Korvan had not been on the rock when they came.

She had felt them the way she felt everything now, warmth in the cold dark. Seven, and then more, a whole strung line of hard-going hearts coming up the one trail. She had put her hand flat on Korvan's chest to wake him without a sound and said one word, *down*. They had taken the mare and gone off the shoulder the other way, west and down, over the lip of the fold and into the timber on the blind side, while the hunt climbed the bright side to a cold rock with last night's ash on it and nobody there. She had listened to them find the empty fire. She had stood a quarter-mile off in the trees with the mare's nose in her two hands and counted the hearts on the rock. Eleven, standing where she had slept. She had felt nothing about it, because the cold part had the wheel, and the cold part did not do feeling. It did arithmetic. The arithmetic said keep going down.

So they had kept going down. Down was where the people were, and people were the danger. People were also the only thing that was not a bare mountain with one trail that every knife in the hills had found. Korvan had said it plainest, three days into the descent, watching a valley open below them full of the small movements of the driven-out. "We hide in a bare place, we're the only two things in it. We hide in a crowd of the running, we're two more of the running." He had not liked saying it. He liked people near her even less than she did. But it was correct, and she had told him so, and they had come down into the flow of the war's leavings. Into the lanes and drove-roads full of carts going away from a thing. A big hill-built man and a woman in a deep hood with not one thread of silver let show, going south with everyone else. Away.

It was on the fourth day, on a drove-road above a ford she did not yet have the name of, that they came on the wain with the broken wheel and the child bleeding under it.

The wain had gone into the ditch at speed, the way a thing does when the people pulling it are looking behind them and not before. Its wheel had come off. A whole household's insides had gone over with it and pinned a child under a corner of the bed-frame, and the iron cleat on that corner had opened the child's leg from the knee up. Amelia saw the blood before she saw the child. It was a great deal of blood for a small body, dark on the road-mud, still going. She knew the going of it. She knew it better than any doctor alive, because she had spent her years learning the blood of other creatures the way other girls learned faces, and this blood went the way blood goes when there is not much time left in the argument.

The child's people were there. A woman, an old woman, a boy too small to lift anything. They had the bed-frame half up and could not get it higher, and the woman was making a flat, wordless, repeating sound that Amelia would hear again in her sleep. No one else on the drove-road had stopped. A road full of the running does not stop. Everyone on it has their own frame to lift.

Korvan stopped. He was off the mare before she could say a word and had the corner of the load in both hands. He was the strongest thing on that road by a long way. He lifted the broken corner clear of the child in one grinding pull that Amelia felt in her own back, and the old woman dragged the child out into the mud by the arms. And that was when Amelia understood that the lifting had saved nothing. The child was out now, and the leg was open, and the blood still went, and the strongest thing on the road could do nothing at all about a small vessel cut through in a small leg. Korvan knelt with his empty strong hands over the child and could not use them. He looked up, once, at the deep hood where Amelia had not got down off the mare. She saw in his face that he knew what she knew. The child was going out under

all of them, on a road, in the mud, and no amount of the strongest thing on the road was any use to it.

She got down off the mare.

She did not count the cost first. That was the thing she understood afterward, when there was an afterward. All her life she had done the arithmetic before she did anything, weighed the cost of a step before she took it. For the once that mattered, she did not. She got down off the mare and knelt in the child's blood and did no sum at all. Her mother would have had the sum in a heartbeat. Her mother had drilled her over a bowl, over a single fish, over years, in the one law. The not-taking. The hand kept to yourself. Never a person, not for your own life and not for any other, promise me. And she had promised, and kept it through her own starving close as a wall to forty sleeping men, kept it on a high cold tarn with seven strung hearts under her will, kept it as the one part of the cage she never let fall. She knelt in a dying child's blood and did not so much as think of the law, because the law was about taking, and she was not, for once, going to take.

She put her two hands on the child's leg, over the wound, in the warm going blood, and she reached in.

It was the same reach. That was the horror waiting under everything else, the horror she would not get to until the child was safe. It was the exact reach she made to still a heart, the reach she had made over the drover, over the seven. The slow careful reach into another body's blood her mother had taught her never to make and had taught her, in every particular, how to make. On the tarn she had reached in to hold a thing still. Here she reached in to hold a thing *in*. She found the cut vessel from the inside, the small torn place the blood was leaving by, and she did not still the heart and she did not take the warmth. She took hold of the blood

at the edges of the tear, and with everything her mother had made of her, she told it to stay.

She had no idea if it would work. She had never tried it. There had never been a reason to try it, and every reason not to. This was not taking, but it was not the not-taking either. It was a third thing. A thing with no name in her mother's mouth, a putting of her own will into another body that the law had forbidden by forbidding everything near it. She had no drill for it. She had a dying child and her two hands and her mother's blood risen in her, and she told the blood to hold.

The blood held.

It held the way the fish had held over the bowl, the way the seven hearts had held on the tarn. Easily. At once. No argument in it, no resistance anywhere, as if, for everything she had yet asked of it, the difficulty had only ever been in the deciding and not in the doing. The dark going of it out of the child slowed, and thickened, and stopped. Amelia felt the tear draw shut under her will and hold shut. She felt the pressure come back up into the leg, the way it comes back into a thing that is going to live. The child, gone the grey-white she had a name for and hated, drew a breath with some bottom to it. Then another. And the flat wordless sound the mother made changed, went up, broke, became weeping, which is the sound a person makes when the worst thing has been called off.

Amelia took her hands out of the blood. They were red to the wrist. She looked at them.

* * *

It had worked.

That was the thing she could not get past, kneeling in the road with her red hands held out from her body while the old woman gathered the living child in. It had worked, and it had

been easy, and the ease was the whole terror. Had it failed, she would have known where the edge of her was. It had not failed, and so she did not learn the edge, not that day — but she felt the shape of where it stood, under the ease. The tear had been small and the blood slow, slow enough for an unschooled hand to find it and hold it. A wound gone faster than that, a wound gone wider, would run a body out through her fingers before she had the craft to close it. She knew it, kneeling there. The power would be equal to such a wound and she would not, not yet, because the power was the inheritance and the craft was the thing you only got with the years, and she had had the blood a lifetime and the practice a season. All her life she had lived inside the shape her mother drew, the not-taking, the hand to yourself, and believed, the way you believe the walls of the only room you have known, that the shape was the size of her.

It was not. She had put life back into a body that was losing it, and the doing had cost her about as much as breathing. So the shape her mother drew had never been the size of her. The law had not been the edge of her power. It had been a fence her mother built well short of the edge, so the daughter might never walk out to the real edge and learn what stood there.

And she knew what stood there, kneeling with her hands red to the wrist. Her mother's people had signed a treaty a thousand years back that no new one of their kind be made, and thought it airtight, because the making was a dark art half-lost even to the Queen. Blood put into a dying human and held there by a will strong enough to turn the death. She had just done the near neighbor of that to a stranger's child. Easily. On impulse. The only reason the child was a saved child and not a made one was that she had chosen, in the doing, to hold the blood and not give her own. She had stood one small decision from the thing the whole treaty was

written to prevent, and had not felt the nearness of it until now, with the blood drying on her.

And her mother had known. That was the coldest part, and she made herself hold it, because it was true. Her mother had known exactly where the edge was, and built the fence a mile inside it, and called the fence a law, and drilled it into her over a fish in a bowl so tenderly the daughter never suspected the fence was a fence and not the world. It had been the cage again. The same cage, worn as a rule instead of a wall, carried out of the castle and up a mountain, the one part she had brought with her when she walked out of the rest. And kneeling in a child's blood she had taken it off.

She got up. Her knees left two dark prints in the mud. She looked at them, and then at the child, breathing, grey going back to pink at its mouth. She did not know which of the two things frightened her more. That she had done it. Or that she already knew, the way you know a floor is under you, that she would do it again.

* * *

Maren left Elverford before the light went. She could not stay in a town with that lane on its church door. And the road she wanted went the one way the whole muster did not, north, up over the bridge and into the hill country the levy had not yet reached, and a woman walking into a war that everyone else is walking out of is a woman nobody stops to question. They only look at her the way you look at a thing you are glad is not you.

She stopped once, on the bridge, at the high point of the span, though she had told herself she would not. Behind her lay the goose-meadow full of tents and the square full of pikes and the church with the door she was not going to think about tonight. She did the one useful thing there was

to do with all of it. She laid it beside the message behind her teeth and weighed the two.

It was a handful of words, that message, and it was worth nothing against an army. She had known that when the Queen gave it to her. She knew it better now, standing over the army, a mother's love against a goose-meadow of boys and a lane of crosses. *Seen, when she chose, and how, and by no one's leave but her own.* The whole of it was the least thing there was, and it was still the only true thing she carried, and she was going to carry it north into the country all these boys were about to march into, and put it in the hand of a girl who did not know the half of what was coming. Who did not know her own mother's people had un-said the decree and called the levy and made a sign of her. Who was up in that hill country this hour thinking she was only being hunted, when the truth was so much larger and so much worse. That she was being marched toward, from the south, under her own face, by an army that meant to raise her over a war she had never asked for and could not stop.

Maren did not know where the girl was. She only knew, off the boys' own talk, where the war thought she was, which was somewhere up past the ford, in the fold country. That was more than she had had a day ago. It would have to do. A keeper who wants a thing done does not stand on a bridge waiting for a better map. She went down off the far side of the span, north, into the country the crosses came out of. She did not look back a second time. Looking back once was a thing she let herself do. Twice was a thing she did not, and she had a lane full of the dead to carry now on top of six words, and a girl to reach before an army did, and no silver at all in her hands to count against the size of it.

* * *

The wain's people moved on before the dark, because a road of the running does not stop even for a saved child. Amelia and Korvan went with them a while, until the drove-road forked and the wain took the south branch and they did not.

The old woman came back before the fork. Amelia had not looked for it. She had wiped her hands as clean as a road lets you and pulled the hood well down and made herself again the thing she had been all the way off the mountain, a hooded woman with no silver showing, no one. She had thought that was the end of it, that a saved child was a saved child and the road would forget. But the old woman came up the line against the flow, small and bent and fast, and took Amelia's wrist in a hand like a bundle of sticks, and turned it over, and looked at the whiteness of it inside the sleeve. Then she looked up under the hood at the hair the hood was there to hide, and Amelia went cold and still, because she had been seen doing the one thing that could not be a hooded no one's thing.

The old woman did not shout it. She was too old for shouting and had buried too much of her own to spend a saved grandchild on a fright. She only held the wrist and looked at what was under the hood.

"I know what you are," she said, low. "I'm too old to care and too grateful to say. But others aren't. And some of them saw it too, the hands and the blood stopping, and a thing like that runs a road faster than we can walk it." She let the wrist go. "So I'll pay you the only coin I've got, which is a road. You'll want one no army's on. There's the old salt way that crosses the Elver above the ford, up where the water runs shallow over the shelf. No toll on it and no watch, because it goes nowhere a cart wants to go, only where the driven-out want to go, which is away. We came down it. You go up it, if you're going up, and cross above the ford, where the whole world crosses at the ford, and nobody counts you." She

stepped back into the road, already going, already half gone in the way of the very old. "Cross above the ford," she said again over her shoulder, to be sure the girl had it. "It's the only kindness I've got that's worth a witch's while. God keep the shape of you, whatever it is."

Then the fork took her, south, with the living child and the weeping mother and the boy too small to lift, and Amelia stood at the branch of a drove-road with the name of a crossing she had not asked for and had not known she wanted. She understood two things at once, standing there, the way she understood everything now, cold and clear and too fast to stop.

That there was a way north across the great river that no army watched, and she had just been given it, and she was going to need it.

And that she had been seen. A dozen people on a road had watched a hooded woman put her hands into a dying child and hold the blood in it by will, and some of them had kept the picture, and the picture was already moving down the road faster than the people who carried it. A silver-haired woman who did not take life but gave it back. A stranger and a worse thing to be than a witch who only killed. It would go from cart to cart and fire to fire until it reached the ears listening hardest for exactly it, and then the hunt would change its shape again, because a witch who can be killed is one thing, and a witch who can undo a death is another, and no army raises a sign over a war and then lets that sign belong to a drove-road full of the driven-out.

She pulled the hood down and turned north, toward the salt road and the shallows above the ford. She did not tell Korvan yet what she had understood. There would be a fire tonight and a wall to put their backs to, and time enough then to say the size of it. She only walked. And for once the walking was not a thing done to her. She had got off the

mare. She had put her hands in the blood. It had worked, and it had been easy. South of her an army marched north under her face. Ahead of her a soft-voiced man was about to hear that the silver witch could give a life back. And Amelia found, walking into all of it with her hands still faintly red at the seams of the nails, that she was no longer afraid the way she had been afraid all her life, of being found.

She was afraid of the new thing. The worse thing. The thing that had got off the mare.

She was afraid of what she was going to do.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

Discovered

The last of the night before it came apart they had to themselves, and did not waste it on sleep.

They had made a cold camp off the track behind a fallen dyke, no fire, the mare hobbled near, and lain down together under the one blanket the way they did now, her cold length fitted along the warm of him, his arm over her and his hand spread open on her breastbone where the slow strange heart went at its own pace under his palm. He could not lie that near her any more and keep his hands to himself. So he touched her, plainly, a hand that had learned the whole cold country of her by now, and she let him, which was still the astonishment it had been the first night in the hut.

Before the grey came she turned inside his arm and set her mouth to the pulse in his throat, not hungry, not asking, only laying it there, the small hard claim of a woman who had spent her whole life forbidden to want a thing where it could be seen and had decided, here in the dark, to want this one out loud in the only place she had. He took the weight of her against the size of him and gave it back. He did not tell her it would be all right. She would have heard the untruth of it against his skin, and he did not believe it anyway. He only held her, and put his rough face down into the cold silver of her hair, and made himself learn the exact shape and weight and chill of her along him, the way a man fixes in his mind a

thing he has begun to suspect he will soon have to do without.

Some animal under the man knew before the man did. It stayed awake with its arm full of her and would not shut its eyes, and he stayed awake with it, and held her, and let the dark run out one careful hour at a time while she breathed slow against him and the war waited a few miles off for the light.

* * *

They came up on the drove-road an hour after first light, where the track ran narrow between two stone dykes and a man on foot had nowhere to put himself but along it.

Korvan heard them before the bend gave them up. Not the loose sound of drovers. Shod horses, walking, holding a line. He put his hand back to find Amelia's sleeve. She was already still, her head tipped the half-degree it tipped when she was counting hearts through stone.

"Four," she said. "Behind us. Not hunters. Hunters don't ride abreast to be seen." A pause. "These want to be seen."

The riders came round the dyke and spread as wide as the road allowed. At the head of them, on the old roan, was his father.

The chief did not hurry the last of it. He never had. He brought the roan up to a walk and then to a stop, ten feet off, and looked at his son. Then he looked past his son at the woman with the silver hair, hood down, hands loose and open at her sides. Korvan watched the whole weather of the man change. Not to anger. Never to anger. To the slow grief of a thing confirmed that he had been praying, against his own arithmetic, to be wrong about. Then his eyes came back to his son and stayed a beat past their business, as if there were a second thing on this road he could almost name and

could not, and he let it go the way he let everything go that came to nothing said.

"Down the road, Bricc," the chief said, without turning his head. "You and the rest. Far enough you can't hear me be a fool."

They went. Bricc went last, with a look at Korvan that had no sentence in it this time, only tiredness.

Then it was the road and the two dykes and the three of them. The chief stayed on his horse. Getting down was standing on the same ground as them, and he would not do it.

"I told you to get her off my mountain," the chief said at last. His voice was level. "That was a fortnight ago, with a war already declared and four thousand people on the road behind a banner I'd painted with a witch and a dragon. And here you are in daylight, walking her toward the very court that put the price on her. The one secret I built the whole war to bury, out taking the sun. Where any drover with eyes can sell her to Loric for the price of a pint." He was quiet a moment. "I painted a witch on that cloth to give the country a face to hate. I never thought you'd hand them the real one, Korvan. And on a drove-road, in daylight."

Amelia shifted her weight. Only that. But Korvan felt the air around her change, felt her attention go out and down toward the four men at the foot of the road, and knew that if she wanted them there would be four men on the stones and no one left to carry the tale.

The chief knew it too. He looked at her, and there was no fear in his face, which was its own kind of respect.

"You could," he said to her, plainly. "I can feel you thinking it. Four of mine down and no tongue to carry it. You won't. Four dead clansmen on this road is the banner made truer than my boy could make it, and you don't spend blood you'll only pay interest on." Something crossed his face that

on a lesser man might have started toward an apology.
"You'd have made a hard daughter."

"Then help us." Korvan's voice came out too young.
"You've four horses and a name. Get us over the river."

"No." Flat. "I can't be the man seen to help you any more than the man seen to find her. You've always known that. You're asking because you're tired." The chief gathered his reins. "I came myself because I couldn't send another man to do it. That's what I've got left to give you. That I looked with my own eyes before I turned them away."

He turned the roan.

"The ford's mine to hold, and it's watched, and there are Crown men on it counting heads for coin. You can't cross where I can see you. So go up. Above the ford the driven-out use a shelf, thin water, no toll, no one who counts. Cross there and be gone off the edge of everything I'm answerable for. Do it before noon, before I have to know I saw you." He did not look at his son again. Looking again was a hand reached out, and he did not do things that came to nothing. Korvan understood, watching him, where Amelia had learned it, though the two had never met until this road. "Wherever this road takes you now, don't come home. There's no home left in it for the man who's chosen her over the mountain. I let go of your belly in that river so you'd not drown reaching for me. So don't reach. Swim."

He rode down to his men and did not stop and did not turn. The four of them closed around him and were gone round the dyke. The road was empty. Off to the north the river was a grey sound.

* * *

The salt road was the safe way because everyone used it. That was the thing that killed it.

Korvan understood it too late, the way he understood most things, standing in the grey at the top of the shelf where the old track came down to the water and seeing, for the first time from above, what a choke it was. The Elver ran wide and brown at the ford a mile below, and there the whole world crossed, in a churn of carts and lowing and men with staves who took a toll. But above the ford the river spread thin over a stone shelf, ankle-deep and quiet, and no cart could go on it and no toll-man stood there, and so it was the crossing of the poor and the hunted and the driven-out, the ones with nothing to declare and every reason not to be counted. An old woman had given Amelia its name for a kindness. She had given it, Korvan thought now, to a hundred others too, because kindness spreads on a road the way anything else does, and a thing that a hundred desperate people all know is not a secret. It is a place to wait for them.

He did not see the waiting men. He saw the birds.

There was a stand of alder on the far bank, downstream a little from the shelf, and the birds came up off it wrong. Not the loose scatter of birds a fox moves. A hard vertical burst, all at once, the way birds come up off a thing that has held very still for a long time and then shifted its weight. He watched them go up and settle wrong and not come back down into the alder, and he stopped on the shelf-top with the sack on his back and the grey mare's rein in his fist and put his other hand out, low, without turning, to find her.

"Don't cross," he said.

Amelia had already stopped. She stood a pace behind him with the hood well down, and he did not have to see her face to know she had gone into the cold place, because the air around her changed when she did it, some quality of her attention turning outward and downward like water finding

a drain. She was reading the far bank the way he could not, in the only sense that told her true.

"Alder," she said. "Behind the alder. And in the reeds this side of the ford, below us." Her voice had no more heat in it than the river. "I count eleven hearts holding still that have no reason to hold still. Two more back in the willow scrub behind us, on the road we came down. That's the road home shut." A pause the length of a breath. "They let us come up onto the shelf before they closed it. They wanted us high and in the open and between the water and the wood."

"Reeve's men?"

"Reeve's men don't hold their hearts like that." She came up level with him, slow, and looked down the long grey slope of the shelf to the alder and the reeds. "These are the quiet sort. The nameless coin. The ones your drover said were up the fold ahead of us, asking after the beast and not the girl." Under the hood he heard her breathe once, carefully, the way a person breathes who is about to lift something heavy. "They didn't come here for me, Korvan. They came here for you. And they built the whole thing on me, because they've done their sums, same as I do mine. They know the one certain way to raise a dragon."

He knew it too. He had known it since the mountain, since the cold rock, since the low deep turn had come up under his breastbone at nothing more than a stone dislodged in the dark near her. His body had one answer to a threat that stood too close to her, and it was fire, and it was not a thing his head got a vote in. They had watched the beast on the heights. They had asked a drover which way it flew of an evening. And somewhere in the asking they had learned, or guessed, that the great dun creature that killed and flew had a woman at the center of it, and that the woman was the string you pulled.

"Then we don't play it," he said. "We go back."

"The road back has two hearts on it and forty on their way. There's no back." She said it the way Selwyn had said it on the mountain, plain, with the same weight, and for a moment the two of them stood over the water with the whole shape of it come clear at once, the alder and the reeds and the shut road and the thin bright crossing between, laid out below them like a thing already decided by people who were not there.

Down on the shelf, out of the reeds, a man stood up.

* * *

He was not a big man and he did not hurry. He walked out onto the stone with the water breaking white around his boots and stopped in the middle of the crossing, well out of reach of anything Korvan could do with his hands, and he looked up the slope at the two of them, and lifted one empty hand, palm out, the way you gentle a horse.

"That's far enough up there," he called. His voice carried flat over the water. "There's no call for anyone to move quick. We're all going to be reasonable about the next little while."

There were other people on the shelf. Korvan had not marked them until now, three or four little knots of the driven-out strung out along the crossing below, a man with a barrow, a woman with a child on her hip and another by the hand, all of them stopped now, all of them gone still at the sound of a stranger calling out over the water. One by one they read the shape of the thing they had walked into. The man with the barrow began, very carefully, to back it the way he had come. The mother did not move at all. She stood in the shallows with her children and watched the reasonable man the way a hare watches a stoat, and Korvan understood that these were the crowd the whale-iron wanted. Not a market-day throng. Just enough eyes. Enough mouths to

carry the seeing down to the ford and up the road, that the dragon had been dragged low in a foot of water while the poor stood by.

Beside him the birds still would not settle on the alder. Behind the alder, now that Korvan was looking for the shapes instead of the leaves, he could see them. Men lying to a frame. And across the frame, low and dark and longer than any bow, the thing they had brought, the thing that told him these were not reeve's men and never had been. It was a harpoon on a windlass, ship's gear, a barbed iron the length of a leg on a coil of tarred line, and it was not laid for a man. You did not build that to take a man. You built it to put a rope through something that could fly.

"They've a whale-iron," he said, low, not moving his mouth. "On the far bank. In the alder."

"I see it." Amelia had not taken her eyes off the man on the stone. "They mean to have you in the air and pinned before you clear the trees. That's the whole plan. Bring you up here, over a crossing where by noon there'll be two hundred people watching, and put the iron in you, and drag you down onto the shelf in front of all of them, and let the country stand at the ford and watch the terror out of the songs die in a foot of water." Her jaw did a small thing under the hood. "Brought low. Seen. Public. It's the nameless writ, written out in gear."

Korvan looked at the whale-iron in the alder and felt the low turn start in him, right on cue, the way they had built it to. His hands had gone cold at the roots. Something in the meat of his back, in the great muscle a man his shape had no use for, had begun to remember a shape of moving. He put it down. He put it down the way she had shown him without ever setting out to teach it, by main force, and stood on the shelf-top and held the line, and hated that the holding was exactly what they were counting on breaking.

"Here's what happens," called the man on the water, patient, reasonable, and Korvan's whole skin crawled, because he had heard that voice before, not this man's but its brother, in a garden, in a hall, the voice of the man who only asks. This one had learned it, or been taught it, or been bought by the man who owned it. "The woman comes down to us. On her own feet, slow, hands where we see them. She's wanted whole and breathing and there's people paying good silver for her to stay that way, so nobody here wants a scratch on her, least of all me. She comes down, and you stay right up there on your rock, big man, and don't do anything with your shape that the morning will remember. And everybody lives to see the noon." He spread both hands. "That's the reasonable thing. I'm only laying it out."

"He's lying," Amelia said, quiet, only for Korvan. "Not about me. About you. The moment I'm off the shelf and clear of you, they put the iron in you, because a man standing on a rock isn't worth a nameless copper and a dragon dragged down in front of the ford is worth two fortunes. He wants me clear so I'm not in the way of the shot." The cold in her voice did not waver. He could hear her reach the bottom of it. "If I go down, you die here. If I stay, they'll open me up a little to make you come up, and then you die here anyway, and I'm no use to anyone opened up. Either way the day ends with the iron in you and the crowd at the ford and a Queen somewhere getting a letter."

"So we don't give them the day," Korvan said.

"No." She turned her head, just enough that the hood's edge lifted and he caught the pale line of her jaw and the one eye, and the eye was doing arithmetic, and he had learned on the mountain to be afraid of her arithmetic when it turned this cold, because the coldest sums she did were always the ones that cost her the most and showed it least. "We don't give them the day. But there's only one way to take

it off them, and you're not going to like it, and we haven't got the time for you to argue, so I'm going to say it once."

Down on the stone the reasonable man tilted his head. "I'm waiting on the lady," he called. "But I'm a patient sort and my patience has a bottom, and the bottom is a bolt in your leg, big man, to speed the conversation. So."

"Say it," Korvan said.

* * *

"You go up," Amelia said.

For a moment he did not understand her, because it was the one word for the one thing he had spent the whole mountain putting down, and to hear her say it, her, the one who had counted the cost of a dragon under the silver moon and made him fold the wings back down, was like hearing the river run backward.

"You go up," she said again, fast now, flat, packing it tight, "but you don't come low and you don't come at them. You come up and you go over the wood and you keep going and you don't stop for the iron, because the iron only reaches the shelf. They need you down here for the crowd. Twenty feet of height past the alder and the line's spent and you're a shape in the sky they can't sell. A dragon dragged down at a ford is a fortune. A dragon that goes over the hill and is gone is a story that scares them and pays nobody. You take yourself off the board, up, out, west, into the empty country, and every quiet man behind that alder has to choose in one breath between the woman worth a purse and the beast worth two, and I'll tell you which they choose. They chose it a week ago on a byre door. They go after the two. They'll leave three men to walk me down to a Crown post, and the whole of that whale-iron crew will pour off after you across the river, and you'll lead the entire hunt off me, and off this crossing, and out of the war, into a hundred miles of nothing

where there'll be no one to bring you low in front of." She drew a breath. "That's the sum. You go up and you go away and you go alone and you live, and I'm walked south worth a purse and untouched, and both of us are out of their trap by different doors."

He stared at her.

"No," he said.

"I don't have the leisure for no."

"You want me to fly off and leave you standing on a rock." His voice came out of him rough. "Amelia. You're the one who told me on the mountain a dragon aloft ends every clean story we've got. You pinned the wings shut yourself. You put your hand on my heart to keep me a man. And now you want me to go up in front of two banks of hunters and just fly. Be seen. Be the witch's dragon, exactly the way the banner wants me. You'd hand them the seeing to keep them off you."

"I'd hand them the seeing to keep them off you." The correction came out of her like a blade drawn quiet. "You've got it backward. They already have the seeing, Korvan. The moment you shift on this shelf it's theirs, and there's no getting it back, and it was never the seeing I was keeping you from. It was the bringing-low. The iron and the crowd and the dying in a foot of water. That I can still take off the board, if you go high and go now and don't do the one soft stupid thing your whole body is built to do, which is come down to the rock to stand between me and them." Her hand came up and pressed flat and cold over his heart, the way she did, not to gentle it. To read it. "It's a man's, still. Just. Keep it a man's for the ten seconds it takes me to finish, and then be gone. Please. I have never asked you for anything. I'm asking you for this."

"They'll take you."

"They'll walk me south alive because I'm worth more alive and they know it. And alive I can do a great deal. You know that better than anything walking, because you stood behind me when I held seven hearts and chose not to close my hand." The wind off the water lifted the hood-edge, and he saw more of her face than she meant to show, and it was doing the thing her face never did, which was cost her openly, for one breath, before the cold took it back under. "I am not the one in danger here. You are. Don't die to protect me, Korvan. It's an insult. Fly, and let me take the whole hunt off you into the sky."

Down on the stone the reasonable man had stopped being patient. Korvan heard the small wet sound of a windlass taking up slack, and saw, on the far bank, the whale-iron's black length come up on its frame a hand's breadth and steady, and the birds go up off the alder a second time.

"They're set," Amelia said. "Now, Korvan. Up now, or it's all for nothing and we die here together, which is the one outcome I will not do the arithmetic for, because it comes out to nothing, twice."

* * *

The bolt came before he could answer her.

It came from the reeds this side of the water, low and mean, and it was not for him. He heard it before he saw it, that flat whip-crack, and then Amelia made a sound he had never heard her make, a small caught grunt, and folded a little at the middle, and put her hand down to her own thigh where the short quarrel stood out of the wool of her skirt with a dark wet blooming already around it. A leg-shot. A speed-the-conversation shot. The reasonable man had a bottom to his patience and this was it, and it was not even

meant to kill. It was meant to make her bleed, in front of Korvan, to raise the thing they had come to raise.

It raised it.

He did not decide. There was no decide. The blood on her, the smell of it, her folded there with her hand pressed to her own leg and her face going the color he had no name for, went into the animal under him faster than any thought, and the low turn that had been simmering all this while came up all at once through the whole length of him, and the world tore at its seam. His bones remembered they were the wrong shape. His back opened. The sack fell away from a shoulder that was no longer a shoulder and the mare screamed and bolted down the shelf into the water and Korvan came up off the top of the crossing into the grey morning as the thing they had paid to make him.

And in the tearing, in the half-second when he was neither man nor dragon but only pain becoming size, a memory came. It came the way they came, sideways, in the meat and not the mind, called up by nothing he could put a name to unless it was the iron and the trap and the closing net. Not the warm sky of the first one. Not the red sky and the falling wings of the second. This was smaller and older and it came almost as a smell, of cold stone and long waiting, of dark under a mountain, and in it there were not many. There were a few. A very few, folded down small in the deep dark while the beacons burned on the ridges above them, holding still, holding still, letting the sky be emptied overhead and not going up to be counted among the falling, waiting out the whole red age of the hunt in the black under the world. Outlasting it. Not dying. Not fighting. Going to ground and being nothing and nowhere until the fires burned down and the hunters grew old and the world forgot the shape of them, and coming up, after, into a sky that had stopped looking. The not-alone had a second sound, he

understood in that half-second, one the second memory had drowned out. Under the screaming there had been a hiding. Some had lived by refusing to be brought low.

Then it was gone, and he was in the air, and the iron was coming.

He did the one thing she had told him. He did not go down to the rock. Everything in the new great body wanted the rock, wanted to come down over her folded shape and throw himself in front of the reeds and open his throat at the men in the alder and burn the whale-iron to slag on its frame, and he did not do it, because she had said don't, because her voice was the last human thing he had and it had said up and out and away, and he held to it the way he had pinned the wings shut under the moon, by main force, hating it. He drove for height. The whale-iron loosed under him and he felt the wind of the barb go by the great membrane of a wing and the line snap taut and fall short, spent, exactly where she had said it would fall short, into the water below him with a sound like a stone dropped in a well. Twenty feet. She had known the reach of a thing she had seen for four seconds. Of course she had. She did the arithmetic. She had done his arithmetic since he fell asleep.

He beat up into the low grey and the crossing fell away beneath him, the shelf and the reeds and the alder and the reasonable man wading fast for the bank now with his face turned up, and there, small, at the top of the shelf, on her knees in the water with the quarrel in her leg, her hood fallen all the way back and the silver hair loose and bright as the one thing in that whole grey morning that would not be grey, was Amelia. Her face was turned up to him. She had got up onto her good knee. And she was not calling him down. She was doing the opposite, the very thing that broke him worse than the bolt had, she was waving him on, both

arms, west, away, go, get gone, her mouth making the word he could not hear over the drum of his own wings.

* * *

He could do nothing but keep flying. So he kept flying, north into the empty cold with the warm hour in the hut come due behind him and nothing in his hands to pay it with but distance.

The whale-iron crew broke from the alder and did not go for the shelf. Instead they went for their horses, fast, and came out onto the road below streaming west along the river's near bank, faces up, arms full of the tarred line, a second iron already on a cart. Behind them the two from the willow scrub came too. Korvan understood in the air that she had been right down to the last man. They chose the two. They left the girl. The nameless money had bought them a dragon, and they poured off after the dragon the moment it went up. He watched the whole quiet crew abandon the most valuable person on the frontier and gallop west under him along the river. She had made herself the small prize on purpose. She had made herself the leaving. It had worked, and the working was the worst thing he had ever seen from above.

Three men stayed. Only three, walking out onto the shelf now with no hurry, toward the kneeling woman with the silver hair, and Korvan, wheeling once, high, saw them reach her.

He saw what she did then, and he would carry it the rest of whatever he got.

She could have killed them. He knew it in his gut the way he knew his own name. Eleven hearts hung in a bowshot the moment she wanted them, and three at arm's reach were nothing at all. She had only to sit up on her ruined leg and close her hand, and all three would go down into the water,

and the shelf would be hers. He had stood behind her while she held seven. He waited, wheeling, wanting it, wanting her to do the monstrous saving thing and be free on the stone and run. And she did not. She stayed on her knee in the water with both hands loose and bare at her sides, and let the three men come to her, and did not close her hand. She had done that sum too. Three dead Crown men at a crossing was the silver witch of the banner made true, in front of whatever eyes were already gathering at the ford below. A woman walked south alive under a writ that wanted her whole was a woman with a hundred miles of road to work in. So she let a hunter's hand close on her arm and got up onto her good leg to walk where he pointed, unhurried, and did not look for the dragon again.

She did not look up again. She had told him once, with her back turned on a mountain, worrying a picket-pin she had gone over and over already, that she did not do things that came to nothing. Looking up was a reach after a thing that would not be there to meet it. Now she did it with her whole self.

The last he had of her was the top of her bright head going small on the grey shelf, three men around it, walking south toward the ford and the crowd and the road to the capital. Then the river's bend took a stand of poplar between them, and she was gone. There was only the near bank now, and the whale-iron crew galloping west under him and calling up to one another, and the empty country beyond, and the cold. There was only the great strange body doing the thing it was built to do, which was carry him away from the one place on earth he wanted to be.

He flew west because west was where the hunt was going and the whole of his use now was to be the thing they followed. He drew them off her, off the crossing, off the war, out toward the emptiness she had drawn on the air with both

arms. And he did not know. Could not know whether the alive-writ held past the poplars, or a leg-shot woman worth a purse stayed worth a purse all the way to a Crown post. He had her arithmetic and her waving arms and the pale of her hair going small, and that was all he was going to have, and he flew on it because it was all there was to fly on.

Below him the men who wanted him dead and shown rode hard and glad along the water, sure of their fortune, following the dragon into the empty land exactly as she had said they would. The frost of the coming winter was already in the high air. He climbed into it, and let it burn the wet from his eyes that a dragon should not have had, and went where she had sent him, alone, into a country with no one in it to bring him low and no one in it at all.

Somewhere under the world, an age ago, a few of his kind had lived by going dark and holding still and letting the sky forget them. He had the shape of that now, cold in the meat of him, the only inheritance the memory had given him that was not grief. Outlast it. Go to ground. Be nothing and nowhere until the fires burn down.

He did not yet know it was a plan. He only knew, flying west with the hunt strung out behind him and her small on the road behind them, that she had let go of him on purpose, the way his father had once lifted a steadying hand off him in the deep water, so that he would learn the thing a body only learns when the hand comes off. Not to drown. To hold himself up in the empty water alone.

He held himself up. The wings had the knowing of it, whatever the rest of him lacked. And he flew until the crossing was a grey thread and then nothing. The war was behind him. She was behind the war. There was nothing ahead but the long cold road of finding out whether the sum she had done in a foot of water at a ford had been, like all her sums, exactly right.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

Survive to Fight Later

For three days he was mostly the dragon.

He had flown west until the whale-iron crew were dots on the near bank and then were nothing, until the river was a thread and then was not there at all, into the fold country where no road went and no smoke rose and the hills came one behind another like grey water with no far shore. Somewhere in the second valley the last of the horsemen gave him up. He felt it more than saw it, the slackening off behind him, the hunt losing heart in a land that had nothing in it to promise them. He kept flying anyway. Flying was the one thing the great body did without asking him, and he did not want to be asked anything.

The man in him thinned out over those days like smoke off a dead fire. That was the mercy of it and the horror of it both. The dragon was hungry and the dragon killed, clumsily the first time, a hind he ran down against a scree and did not kill clean, and the animal did not care about the mess of it, and the man buried far down under the animal cared and could do nothing. The dragon was cold and found the sun-warm rock and lay on it. The dragon did not remember a woman on her knees in a foot of water waving both arms. Down under the wings, in the small dark place the shift had not reached, the man remembered, and had no mouth to say it with.

On the fourth morning he came back to himself.

It happened by a tarn high in the folds, black water with ice at its rim, and it happened the way it did now, not a tearing but a long grinding fold-down, the great shape closing in on itself, the wings drawing back into a back that screamed at having them and then screamed at losing them, bone remembering the wrong shape and then the wrong shape again. He came out of it on his hands and knees in the frost, a naked man, shaking, with the taste of blood in his mouth that was not his own. He knelt there until he could feel his fingers. The tarn gave him back a face he half knew.

He did the sum then. Her sum. He made himself do it the cold way, the way she would have, kneeling in the frost with his arms wrapped round himself.

The hunt was drawn off her. That part had come out right. He had watched the whole quiet crew of them pour west under him and leave the most valuable person on the frontier standing on a rock, and they had followed him into the empty country exactly as she said, and he had lost them here in the folds where a hundred empty miles did his hiding for him. So. She had traded herself down to a purse and traded him up to a hunt and put a mountain range between the two prices, and it had worked.

And then what.

Then he stayed out here. That was the shape of the thing she had drawn on the air with both arms. West, out, gone, into a country with no one in it to bring him low. Be the leaving. Be the shape in the sky that scared them and paid nobody, until the fires burned down and the hunting men aged out and the world stopped remembering him. Go to ground. Outlast it.

He knelt by the black water and understood, with the cold coming up through his knees, whose plan that was.

It was his father's. It was the whole of his father, laid out in her voice because the two of them thought the same way and had never met. Survive the thing. Wait it out. Do not spend what you will only pay interest on. His father had put four thousand people on a road behind a painted banner rather than face one challenge in a hall, and called it the bearable door, and it was the same door. It was always the same door. You lived by not reaching. You held still in the dark and let the sky be emptied over you and did not go up to be counted among the falling, and one grey morning a long time later you came up into a world that had stopped looking, and you were alive, and everyone you had held still for was gone.

She was walking south. Worth a purse, whole and breathing, kept that way by the writ that hunted her. But writs had a bottom to them the same as the reasonable man's patience had a bottom, and the bottom of it was a court and a Queen and the man who only asks, and a purse was only worth a purse until someone found her worth more opened up. Every hour he lay warm on a sun-rock in the folds was an hour she walked closer to the thing he had let her walk toward so that he could go up and be safe in the empty sky.

He got to his feet. His legs held.

He was not going to do the thing she had told him to do. Standing there with the ice at the tarn's edge and the folds going grey to the world's end, he knew it in the meat before he had any words for it, the way he knew when a green stick would spit and a seasoned one would not. His whole life had been learning to put things down. This one he put up instead. He turned, on the frost, and faced east, back toward the fires and the river and the war and the small bright head going small on a grey shelf, and the wind came off the folds behind him and pushed him toward it, and he let it.

He flew at night after that.

The country east of the folds was not empty. The war had lit it. He came up over the last high ridge on the second evening and the whole of the land below him was pricked with fire, watch-fires on the hilltops, muster-fires down in the valleys, the long strung lights of a Crown road where men counted heads for coin, beacons laid ready on the high places for the passing of a word. A country that in the summer had been dark was all eyes now, and every eye was turned up, because the story had gone before him on every road, the great dun thing that flew of an evening, and there was silver on offer for the man who marked which way it went.

He could not simply fly east through that. A dragon in a lit sky was a bell rung. He learned it the first night. A hilltop below him flared as he passed, a beacon fired at the shape of him, and answered a mile on by another, and another, the alarm running along the ridges ahead of him faster than he could fly. He turned back into the dark and came down hard against a scree and lay there with his heart going like a hammer. The fires burned and burned and men called across the valleys and found nothing, because he had made himself nothing, flat to the cold stone with the wings folded down and every part of him held still.

And in the holding still, it came.

Not the warm sky. Not the falling wings. This was the cold-stone one again, the oldest, the smell of dark under a mountain and long waiting, and it came sideways, in the meat, called up by the beacons on the ridges the way a smell calls a room you have not stood in for years. There had been a few of them, in the black under the world, while the fires burned above. He had that already. But there was more in it

tonight, a thing the second memory had always drowned before. The few had not only cowered. Some nights, when the ridge above went dark between one watch and the next, they had moved. Out of the one deep hole and across the emptied land to another, under the black, choosing the dark hour the way you choose the seasoned stick, surfacing only where no fire looked. They had not waited in one place to be outlasted. They had gone through the hunt, unseen, and come up where they meant to.

Then it was gone, the way they went, and left him flat on the scree with the fires burning far off and something in his chest that had not been there.

By the third night he understood it the way a body understands a thing before the head will say it plain. The dragon was not built only to be seen. He had thought it was one thing, a great loud shape in the sky that every eye found. It was two things. There was the loud shape, and there was the other, the cold-stone thing that went dark and held still and moved between the fires and chose its hour. She had sent him up to be the leaving, the loud shape, the story that drew the hunt. The other one was his to be now. A lit country full of watching men could be crossed unmarked, if he flew in the dark of the moon and came down before the beacons woke and held still through the days against the scree and the fell, and moved only in the black between the fires, and did not let himself, at any hour, be the shape they were all straining up to see.

It took him four nights to cross the country that had a war in it. Not one beacon lit for him. He went to ground by day in the high scree and the dead bracken and the shadow of north-facing crags, flat and dark and nothing, and by night he moved low along the valleys where the fires were fewest, and he learned his own country the way a poacher learns it, which was as a set of dark places strung between the

watched ones. On the fifth night, from a great height in the dark of the moon, he found the war.

There was no missing it. Four thousand people made a light you could see from the folds. It lay along the Elver's east bank below the falls, a town's worth of fires in the black, the picket-lines and the horse-lines and the long dark bulk of the baggage, and over the middle of it, lit from below by a fire kept burning for the purpose, the banner. He came down the sky toward it slow, in the dark, and he could see the thing on the cloth as he came, the witch and the dragon painted there, the two halves of the lie his father had built the war to hide. His father was down there under it. And here he came out of the dark toward it, the lie made true, the very thing.

He did not land in the camp. He came down half a mile off, on the bald shoulder of the hill above the horse-lines, where the pickets did not reach, and he came down quiet, in the black between the fires, the cold-stone way, and he stood on the hilltop as the dragon for one breath with the whole lit sprawl of his father's war below him. Then he folded down into a man.

It took a long time and it hurt the way it always hurt and he came out of it naked on the frozen turf, on his knees, shaking, with his breath going up white in front of him. Below him the horse-lines had caught the sound of it, or the smell, and gone to bedlam, horses screaming and pulling their pins, men shouting, torches breaking out and running, the whole near edge of the camp coming awake and turning up toward the dark shoulder of the hill where a thing had come down out of the sky.

He knelt in the frost and waited to be found.

* * *

One torch left the others.

It came up the hill alone, unhurried, while the rest of them held at the picket-line and shouted and did not follow, and Korvan knew the walk of it before he could see the man, the way it did not hurry the last of anything, and he got up off his knees so as not to be found on them.

The chief came up onto the crest of the hill with the torch held out to the side so it did not blind him, and stopped ten feet off, the way he stopped everything, and looked at his naked shaking son in the torchlight on the frozen turf. For the space of a breath he did look surprised. Something in the weathered face came open that Korvan had never seen open on it, a certainty arriving all at once and lodging in the body. It was a thing half-smelled on the drove-road, made whole only now, this second, and known. Then it shut over. Korvan understood, watching him, that his father had walked up the hill because he was the one man in that camp who would not run from a shape in the dark. The knowing had come to him here, on the frost, when the beast folded down and left his own son shaking in the torchlight. Behind him, down the hill, the shouting went on, and no one else came up. No one else would. The whole camp had run from the shape on the hill, and the one man who had walked toward it was the one who would sooner learn the worst with his own eyes than send another to bring it back.

"There's a cloak on my back," the chief said. "Take it before you shame us both with your knees knocking."

He unslung it one-handed and threw it, and Korvan caught it and put it round himself, and the warmth of it, his father's warmth still in the wool, went into him worse than any word could have. He held the cloak shut at his throat and stood in it and could not for a moment say anything at all.

His father looked at him a while in the torchlight.

"I told you not to come home," he said. There was no anger in it. There had never been anger in it. "I meant it kinder than it sounded."

"I didn't come home." Korvan's voice came rough out of days of not using it. "There's no home in it. You said."

"So I did." The chief planted the torch in the turf between them, so that neither of them had to hold it and both their hands were empty and lit, and he looked at his son over the small flame with the shut-gate face, the one that gave nothing and was working the whole time behind. "Then what did you come for, if not home."

And there it was. Korvan had thought, flying, that his father would rage, or grieve, or turn away. He had not thought his father would do the one thing his father always did, which was go straight to the sum. He stood in the borrowed cloak with the camp in bedlam below and his father's eyes on him and found he did not have the answer ready, and his father, watching him not have it, changed.

Korvan saw it happen. He saw the pragmatist wake up behind his father's face. He saw the man look down the hill at four thousand people he had put on a road, and up at the banner lit for the purpose, and back at the great cold thing that had just come down out of the sky and folded itself into his only son, and he saw the reckoning his father could not help but make, because his father always made it, and came, always, to the answer.

"You're here," the chief said slowly. "You. The thing on the cloth. Come down of your own feet into the middle of the war I raised to stand in for it." He was quiet a moment, and the small flame flared and settled between them. "Do you know what you are, standing on that hill? You're the one thing I put on the banner that I never had. I painted a dragon on the cloth to make the whole country afraid of a thing I was sure was a lie. And then a real one crossed the sky over my

own camp and woke four thousand of my people to it, and I have spent the season since in dread of what it meant and whose it was, and here it comes down out of that sky and it's my own boy." Something moved under the weathered face, something that in a smaller man might have been hope, and Korvan understood, with the cold coming up through him worse than the frost, exactly what was coming, and could not stop it. "You could end it, Korvan. You. In a week. There's a Crown host massing at the falls that outnumbers mine two to one, and their whole courage is that a painted dragon isn't real. Show them a real one over the water once, one pass, and half of them go home to their farms and the other half sue for terms, and I bury a hundred of my people instead of two thousand. You'd save more lives in an afternoon than I'll save in a year of being reasonable." He said it plainly, the way he said everything, and it was the worst thing he could have said, because it was true. "Be what I painted. Fly for us. Let the clan have you."

Neither of them moved, and the flame threw their shadows long across the frozen turf.

Korvan stood in his father's cloak and felt the pull of it go through him like the low turn itself, and it frightened him more than the whale-iron had, because the whale-iron had wanted to make him a thing and this wanted to make him a hero. Let the clan have you. His whole life he had wanted the clan to have him. He had stood unshifted at the edge of every fire while the others turned on time and belonged, and been the anomaly, the one still human when a man was long past due, the outsider ache walking round in a big hill-built body with nowhere to put itself. And here was his father, the chief, holding out the thing he had wanted since he was a boy, saying be of use, be needed, be the one thing on the banner that's true, come home in the only way there's a home in it,

come home as the clan's dragon. Save a thousand lives. Belong at last.

He wanted it. He stood there and wanted it so hard his eyes burned, and he let them, because a dragon should not have had wet eyes and he was not the dragon just now, he was a cold man in his father's cloak who had wanted to belong his whole life.

And then he thought of a foot of water at a ford.

He thought of the reasonable man on the stone with his palm out gentling a horse, and the whale-iron in the alder that was not built to take a man, and the whole country waiting at the ford to watch the terror out of the songs die where the poor crossed. What they had wanted, the nameless coin, was the dragon brought low and shown, sold, made into a thing the crowd could carry home in its mouth. And her hand came back to him, flat and cold against his heart, reading it, keeping it a man's for the ten seconds it took, and her voice saying it was never the seeing I was keeping you from, and he understood that his father was asking him, in the kindest voice, out of the truest love, for the exact thing the reasonable man had wanted. To be the dragon shown. To be spent. To let both sides pull the string with a woman at the middle of it. His father would spend him well, for good reasons, to save real lives. But you did not stop being a string because the hand that pulled you loved you.

"No," Korvan said.

His father did not flinch. His father waited. He was too old and too much the pragmatist to argue a first no, and he stood there and let it sit and did the next sum, and Korvan watched the second answer come up in his face, and it was a heavier one, and older, and it had grief in it that the first had not.

"Then you're for off," the chief said. It was not a question, the way nothing his father said was a question. He looked at his son in the borrowed cloak and it was as if he were already watching him go small in a grey sky. "You've had the taste of the empty country now, and you've seen it'll hide you, and you've come to tell your father goodbye before you take yourself off into the empty folds where no one can pull your string and no one can put an iron in you and no one can find you at all. Go dark. Wait it out. Come up in ten years into a world that stopped looking." Something in the weathered voice went very quiet. "I can't fault you it. God knows I can't. It's the door I've walked through my whole life. I only. I hoped I'd not taught you that one so well as the rest."

And Korvan understood that his father thought there were two doors, only ever two. The instrument or the runaway. Be spent for the clan, or vanish into the folds and outlast the whole age of it and be nothing and nowhere. His father had lived his life sure those were the only two, and he was standing in the frost braced to lose his son to the second one because he could not, in conscience, hold him to the first.

"No," Korvan said again. "That's not it either."

"Then say what it is, boy. I'm cold and my camp thinks a dragon's eating me."

Korvan looked at the fire between them, and he found, standing there, that the third thing had a shape now, had had a shape since the scree and the beacons, since the memory had come and given him the one part of the inheritance that was not grief. He had thought the going-dark was for hiding. It was not only for hiding. The old ones had moved under the dark. They had gone through the hunt and come up where they meant to, at the hour they chose, unseen the whole way and then not hidden at all but exactly where they had decided to be.

"There's a third door," he said. "I've been through it already. That's how I crossed a country full of your beacons to stand on this hill, and not one of them lit." He watched his father hear it. "I don't have to be the dragon shown or the dragon gone. There's a way to be the dragon no one sees at all, that goes where it means to and comes up at the hour it picks. I can go dark. Not to hide out the war in the folds till everyone's dead. To move under it. To cross to the capital without a beacon lighting, and come up in the one place the whole thing turns on, at the hour I choose, and not be seen doing a foot of it." He heard his own voice steady as he said it, and it was strange to him, because it was her steadiness, the arithmetic voice, come into his mouth at last. "She's walking south to the court. The whole war hangs off one man there, Loric, who can't be bought and can't be argued and only wants the Queen to suffer, and he's spending your four thousand and their eight thousand and her and me to get it. Fly over the falls for you and I save a thousand men this week and the war's still there next week, because the man who made it is still standing. But I can be in that city unseen, at her back, at the hour it comes to a head, and I can take the cause of it off the board. That ends it. Not the door where I'm spent, and not the door where I run. The door where I go and do the one thing that actually stops the killing, and no one sees me cross to do it."

The fire went up between them.

"You'd act," his father said. Very low. "Where I only ever waited."

"You waited to keep your people alive." Korvan said it and meant it. "I know what it cost you. I watched it cost you the whole way down the mountain. I'm not telling you you were wrong. I'm telling you I found a third thing, and it's mine, and I'm going to go and do it, and I came to tell you to your

face because you came yourself on the drove-road instead of sending a man, and I'll not do you worse than you did me."

For a long moment his father said nothing at all. The camp had quieted below them, the horses gentled, the shouting fallen to a wary murmur, torches held in a ring at the picket-line staring up at the dark hill where the chief stood over a shape they dared not name. The fire burned down between the two of them toward the turf.

And then his father did a thing Korvan had not seen him do in the whole of his life. His father's shoulders came down. Not much. A hand's breadth, the set of them, the thing a man carries between his shoulders let go all at once, and Korvan saw, in the torchlight, that his father was not braced against him. His father was relieved.

"I couldn't send you to it," the chief said. His voice had gone rough now too, the two of them rough together in the frost. "You understand me. I've seen the clean thing this whole war. I've known there was a door where a man goes and cuts the head off the cause of it and takes the killing onto himself instead of spreading it over four thousand who never chose it. I've known it was there. And I couldn't walk through it, because I've four thousand behind me and a name that keeps them fed, and a chief who spends himself on the clean thing is a chief who leaves his people leaderless in a war, and that's not a luxury the man in my seat gets to have. So I painted a banner and I did the bearable thing and I hated it, and I told myself there was no door but the bearable one, because if there was one and I couldn't take it, then I was only a man too small for it." He looked at his son over the guttering fire. "And here you are come down out of the sky to tell me there was a door all along, and you're built for it, and you're going to walk through it, and I don't have to spend you to do it. You've taken the clean thing off my

hands. I didn't know until this minute how heavy it was, carrying it and not being able to set it down."

Korvan could not speak. His throat had shut.

"Go on, then," his father said, and it was not a dismissal. It was a blessing, said in the only register the man had, sideways, gruff, the closest he came. "Go and do the thing I couldn't afford. Go dark and go under it and come up where it matters and end it. And don't fly for me over any water, not once, not to save a single soul. The moment they see you the third door shuts and you're back to the only two I had." He bent and pulled the torch from the turf and held it up between them so the light was full on both their faces, and he looked at his son the way a man looks at a thing he is not going to see again for a long time and knows it. "You'll go the way you crossed my country. Dark. Unseen. Alive until the hour you choose. That's not running, whatever it looks like from a ridge. A thing that means to come up at its own hour and act isn't hiding. It's only waiting for the right one." Something crossed his face, close to a smile and not quite. "I taught you to hold yourself up in the deep water. I never thought to teach you to cross it under the surface. Where'd you learn that."

"The dragon," Korvan said. "There were some, once, who lived by it. It came to me on your beacons."

His father took that without a flicker, the way he took the weather. "Then it's older than either of us, and it's yours, and I'll not ask you more of it." He put out his free hand, and Korvan took it, and his father's grip was hard and cold and it held a beat longer than a handshake held, and then it let go, the way his father let go of everything, cleanly, on purpose, so it would come to nothing left hanging. "Is she alive."

"I don't know." It came out of him small. "She was worth a purse when I went up. I flew her whole hunt into the folds so she'd be. I don't know if a purse holds all the way to a court."

"Then go and be sure of it." His father turned to go back down the hill to the camp that was afraid of his son, and stopped, and did not turn round, the way he had not turned round on the drove-road, because a backward look was a reach after nothing, and his father did not make them. "She sent you up to save you," the chief said to the dark ahead of him. "I felt her do it on that road, the same thing, let go of the belly so the boy learns to swim. You've both of you got a habit of throwing away the only thing you want so it'll live. It's a hard way to love a person, and I'd know, having done it to you the length of a war." He started down. "Go and do the opposite of it for once. Go and get the thing back."

He went down the hill toward the torches, unhurried, and the ring of them opened to let him in and closed behind him, and the murmur of the camp took him, and Korvan stood alone on the bald crest of the hill in his father's cloak with the small fire burning down at his feet.

He stood there until the fire was embers.

Then he took the cloak off and folded it and laid it on the warm turf where his father would find it, because there was no carrying it where he was going, and he stood naked in the frost with the whole lit war below him and the dark country beyond it running east toward a city and a court and a bright head going south under a writ that would keep her whole. The cold came into him and he did not fight it. He faced east. And the low turn came up under his breastbone, on purpose this time, called by his own hand for the first time and not by fear, and he folded up out of the man and into the great cold thing that could go dark and cross under the fires and come up at the hour it chose, and he did not once let himself be seen, and he went east, into the war, toward her, alone, and awake at last to what he was for.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

The Cause of Every Death

The town of Dunmoor had more people in it than it was built to hold, and not one of them was staying.

Amelia came into it from the north with her hood up and her hands inside her sleeves, walking the way she had learned to walk on the road, which was slow, and in the middle of others, and never as if she had anywhere in particular to be. The salt road had let her down onto the pike a half-day back and the pike had filled as it went south, cart behind cart, and the carts had brought the town up around her before she knew she was in it. There was no wall. There had not been a wall here in a hundred years. The war had found that out about Dunmoor the way it found out everything, and so the town was full of people who had come down out of the hills to stand behind a bridge and a market cross and pretend the pretending was a wall.

She had come to the pike on her own two feet, which was a thing she did not let herself think about in daylight. Three Crown men had walked her south off the ford with a quarrel through the meat of her thigh and a purse waiting on her at the capital, worth more alive than dead. On the second dark night of it, on a coast road with the sea loud below and the men grown careless with a girl who could barely stand, she had reached for the three of them the way she had once reached for a sleeping drover, and slowed the hearts in them

down and down until the men folded quietly into the verge and did not get up while she passed. She had not stopped the hearts. She had held them at the edge of it and not gone over, and had told herself, kneeling after in the wet bracken with her hand pressed to her own torn leg, telling the blood in it to close and close until it closed, that the not-going-over still counted for something. It was getting harder to say what.

She counted the ways out of the square before she counted anything else. Three. The pike going south, the lane down to the water, the gap between the corn-hall and the church where a dog was working a bone. Then she made herself stop counting, because counting the doors was a thing a hunted person did, and a hunted person was a thing to be noticed, and she had spent the whole road teaching her feet to be no one. She let her eyes go where everyone's eyes were going instead.

They were going to the cross. A crowd stood at it, thick and quiet, the wrong kind of quiet for a market. She had heard that quiet once before, in a warm hall, with a fountain somewhere behind her and her mother's face going to stone across a floor of candlelight. Her body knew it before her head did. Her feet had stopped. A woman jostled her from behind and said something, not unkindly, and moved around her, and Amelia stood in the flow of it like a stone in a race and looked at the platform they had built against the market cross out of trestle boards and a hay-wain, and the sheets of paper nailed up along the front of it, sheet above sheet above sheet, and she thought, with no feeling attached to it at all: *those are the dead*.

She should go down the lane to the water. She knew the lane to the water was the door. She stood where she was.

A man had come up onto the boards. He was not a large man and he did not raise his hands for quiet and he got it

anyway. He wore no colours. He had the look of someone's steward, tidy, unhurried, a man you would give your coat to hold. He waited until the square had given him everything it had, and then he did not shout. He spoke as if the front row were the only people there, and let the silence carry him back to the walls.

"I'm not going to tell you anything you don't know," he said. "I'm only going to read you a list. You've all seen a list. I thought we might read one together, for once, instead of each of us alone at a door."

He picked up the topmost sheet.

* * *

Maren had been in Dunmoor since the forenoon and she had not stopped moving, because a woman who stopped moving in a town like this got asked her business, and Maren's business would not bear asking.

She had six words behind her teeth and she had carried them from the capital to a goose-meadow at Elverford and from Elverford down to here, and in all that road she had not found the head they were meant for. She had looked for silver. That was the whole of her craft now, on the roads: look for silver, and do not let your face show what you are looking for. She had learned the girl's height off a life of standing beside it and she had learned to hate every tall grey-headed woman on the pike for the half-second it took to know it was not her. There had been a great many of them. Grey was a common colour on a frightened road.

She counted the pikes stacked against the corn-hall while she thought, because her hands were empty and her hands did not do well empty. Forty in the near stack. She did not get to the far stack. The crowd took her attention off it, the way it had taken the whole square's, drawing in toward the boards against the cross, and Maren went with it because a

woman standing still while a crowd moved was the one thing more marked than a woman walking against it.

She knew the man on the boards. Not his face. She had never been in a room with him, and she was glad of it, the way you are glad never to have been in a room with a particular weather. But she knew the *shape* of what he was doing, because she had stood against a wall three weeks gone and watched a loud lord do the crude version of it in a warm hall, and here was the thing the loud lord had wanted to be, done properly, done soft. The lord had wanted to hand the crowd a banner. This man was going to hand them a grief and let them find the banner in it themselves, which was worse, because a thing you find yourself you never put down.

She did not want to hear him read. She put herself sideways in the crowd so she could watch the faces instead of the boards, and she went on doing the only thing she had come to do, which was look for a silver head in a sea of frightened grey. She told herself she would not find it here. She told herself the girl was too clever to be in a square where a man was reading the dead. She had told herself a great many things on this road that had turned out not to be so.

She found her at the third name.

* * *

"Aldous Reeve, of Ferny Bank," the man read. "His wife. Their girl. Their boy." He let each one land on its own before he set down the next, the way you set down something you did not want to drop. "Ferny Bank had no soldiers in it. It had a mill and a chapel and a pound for stray beasts. It is not there now." He looked up, mild, over the sheet. "I asked, when I heard of it, who did this. And a man told me a thing,

and I want to be fair, so I'll tell it to you the way it was told to me, and you can make of it what you will."

Amelia stood ten deep in the crowd and knew what was coming, and could do nothing to stop it coming, and stood there anyway with her hands open at her sides and made herself watch, because the watching was the only thing she had left to give.

"There is a girl," the man said. "A witch, they say, though I don't like the word, it does the wrong work. A born one. The first in a thousand years, if the stories run true, and I'm not the man to say whether they do." He spread his hands, disclaiming it, giving it away. "And there is a thing that flies. You'll have heard that too. And a fortnight ago these two were seen together in the hills above the frontier, and a fortnight ago the frontier began to burn. Now, I'm not a clever enough man to tell you that the one made the other. I'm only a man who can count, and put a fortnight beside a fortnight, and read you a list, and let you be as clever as you like."

He picked up the next sheet.

There it was, and it was better made than any accusation Amelia had ever heard, because it accused no one. It laid the fortnight down beside the fortnight and stepped back and let four hundred grieving people do the joining, and they would join it, she could see them joining it, faces coming round toward a shape, toward a story with a girl in it and a monster in it, because a story with a girl and a monster in it was a place to put a thing there was otherwise nowhere on earth to put.

And she knew the truth. That was the unbearable part, standing there, the truth sitting whole and cold in her chest. The clans had come down first, into the little places, before any levy marched. She had knelt in a wain-crash on this very road and held a torn child's blood shut with her hands and

heard the country's account of who had raided whom. The war had been declared by a chief in a hall who would not die over a point of honour. And the man who lit all of it, who wanted nothing from any of these dead but that a Queen far off should someday hurt, was standing on the boards in front of them with a sheet of their dead in his tidy hands, reading the names in a voice you would trust with your coat.

She could say it. The thought came up plain and complete. She could put her hood back and stand up on a barrel and tell four hundred people the true order of it, every step, and she was near enough to the boards that they would hear her, and it was true, all of it, and true was supposed to be worth something.

She looked at the faces and understood that it was worth nothing. Not less than she had hoped. Nothing. There was no price you could get for the truth in this square because no one here had come to buy it. They had come to a market cross to be told where to put a grief that was going to kill them if they had to keep holding it with no name on it, and she could stand up and hand them the true name, *Loric*, a name none of them had ever heard, a man with no dead of his own on any sheet, and they would look at her, a girl, a stranger, silver under a hood, and they would put the grief exactly where the tidy man had already taught them to put it, and they would put her there too. The truth would not even slow it. The truth would be one more thing the witch said.

She kept her hood up. She kept her mouth shut. She had never in her life felt her own silence weigh what it weighed in that square, and no one saw it, which was the point of a silence, which was the whole art of the thing she had been raised to.

Then a horse came into the square from the south, and everything got worse.

It came at a working trot, not a gallop, a Crown horse with a Crown rider on it and a case of red leather at his hip, and the crowd opened for it the way a crowd opens for a thing with the King's colours on it, out of an old habit older than the war. The rider did not get down. He brought the horse round side-on to the boards, where the reading man stood mild and let him come, and he took a paper out of the red case, and he had the kind of voice that had been trained to reach a square, flat and carrying and proud of itself.

Amelia knew the seal before he read a word. She knew it the way she knew her mother's hands. She had watched that seal pressed a hundred times, the ring turned into the wax with the small particular weight her mother put on everything she touched, and it went into her now, across a square full of the dead, a spot of dark red wax swinging from a Crown decree, and her whole body went to water, because she understood before the man opened his mouth that her mother had done something, at last, and that whatever it was would be the worst thing that had happened yet.

"By the hand of the Queen," the rider read, "and under her seal, to all her officers and all her people on the northern roads. Be it known that the woman lately cried through the hill country as a witch is no witch, but the Queen's own daughter, born of her body, named and acknowledged and dear to her. She is under the Crown's protection entire. Any man who lays a hand on her lays it on the throne. Let her be brought south, safe and unhindered, to her mother, who wants her home."

He rolled the paper up.

There was a silence in the square then that was not like the first silence. The first silence had been grief listening. This one was the sound of four hundred people being

handed the one thing they had lacked. All the tidy man had given them was a girl in a story. And now the throne itself, in its own wax, over the Queen's own name, had leaned down out of the south and said: *she is real. She is mine. She exists.* The story had a body in it now, confirmed from the highest place there was. The witch was real because the Queen had said so to save her, and a thing the Queen would break her own treaty to own and shelter was a thing worth every death on every sheet, and more.

Amelia stood in the middle of it and felt her mother's love arrive across two hundred miles as a killing stroke. She had done it to save her. That was the horror sitting whole and cold in her chest, worse than the reading, worse than the names. Her mother, who could not help but reach out a hand, had reached one out at last, in front of everyone, the one gesture that could not be taken back, and the hand had come down on her like a roof. *She is the Queen's.* Loric had wanted, all along, for the crowd to believe the witch was real and worth a war. He had not been able to prove it. No one could prove it. And now the throne had proved it for him, in wax, to save the girl, and there was no un-saying a seal.

She had wanted, her whole life, to be seen. She stood in a square where four hundred grieving people had just been told by the throne exactly who she was, and she had never in her life been so completely unseen, because not one of them was looking at *her*. They were looking at the thing the seal had made. The seen thing was standing between her and every eye in the square, and it wore her name, and it was going to get all these people killed, and she was invisible behind it, hooded, holding still, no one at all.

* * *

Maren had her by the third name and she had not taken her eyes off her since, the small still figure in the north of the

crowd with the hood up and the hands in the sleeves, holding herself the particular way, the way Maren had watched her hold herself against a hundred walls in a house full of watchers. She would have known that stillness in the dark. She had helped to teach it.

She had six words for her and no way across.

The crowd was packed between them, a hundred bodies of frightened people, and Maren was a grey servant with no rank and no elbows, and the girl was ten deep in on the far side, and then the Crown horse came in and the seal was read and Maren understood, standing on her toes with her heart going, that the six words she carried had just been made into a lie. She had walked them here from the capital. *The cage stands open now. Let yourself be looked at.* The Queen had given her that to carry the night she staged her own daughter's disgrace, a small true thing pressed into a servant's hand in the dark, meaning: *when you find her, tell her the reason she hid is dead, tell her I set her free.* And now the Queen had gone and set her free in wax, in front of a war, and turned the gift into the thing that would hang her.

Maren knew what she had come to do and she knew it would cost her the only thing she had left, which was that no one in the north knew her face. She had spent a life being the one they did not look at. She was the woman who poured. It was the whole of her safety and it was worth a great deal and she was going to spend it now, all at once, in a square full of Loric's ears, because the girl was ten deep in a crowd being told she was the cause of every death in the county, and there was no one else on this earth who would cross to her.

She went in low, the way you go through a byre full of nervy beasts, not shoving, finding the give, her heart counting for her because her hands had nothing to count. She lost the girl behind a fat carter and found her again. A

man trod on her foot and she said nothing about it. She came up on the girl's blind side, close enough to smell the road on her, close enough to see the silver at the hood's edge that would kill them both if the wrong face turned, and she did not say the girl's name, because a servant who had learned anything had learned never to say the name.

"Don't turn round," Maren said, low, into the hood. "It's me. It's Maren."

She felt the girl go still in a new way, a whole-body stillness, the kind that costs.

"Your mother sends word," Maren said, fast, into the wool, with the reading man's voice going on over their heads and the Crown seal swinging in the light. "From before all this. Before the seal. She says the reason's dead and the door's open and you're to let yourself be looked at, on your own feet, when *you* choose it. Not this. Not the seal. This isn't what she — " Maren's voice did a thing it did not ask her leave to do, and she stopped it, and went on. "She meant to free you. She's gone and done it wrong from love, like she does everything. But the free part's true. You hear me. The free part was true before she ruined it."

And then a hand closed on Maren's shoulder from behind, and a voice she did not know said, pleasant and certain, "There now. I know your face."

* * *

Loric watched the servant taken and felt the whole of it come round, at last, to the place he had built it to come to.

He had not looked for the girl in the crowd. He never looked for the pieces. You did not need to see a thing you had already reasoned must be there; you only laid the ground so that when it moved it moved into your hand. He had read the dead and let the throne, all unknowing, put its own seal on his story, and now a woman with a court

stillness on her had crossed a whole square to a hooded girl in the north of it, which told him everything, more than a face, more than a seal. Servants did not cross rooms for strangers. He nodded to Har, once, and Har's man put a hand on the woman's shoulder, and it was done, and the girl beside her had gone stiff and still, and that was the girl, then, that was her, ten feet off and not moving, and he had her located to the yard.

He should have felt it as a weight coming off. That was the trouble.

He stood on the boards with the sheet of the Ferny Bank dead still in his hand and the win came in all around him, clean, complete, the Queen's own wax doing his last mile for him, and he waited for the thing it was supposed to bring, the thing he had been walking toward down all the years, the moment where the far cold woman in the south would begin, finally, to feel it. And what came instead, up out of him with no leave asked, was a laugh. It was very small. No one heard it but him. It was only breath. And it was his father's laugh.

He knew it the instant it was out. He had not heard it in nineteen years and he knew it whole, the low breath his father let out when a thing came right, over a mended trace, over a fair price, over a boy who had done a hard thing well. His father had laughed like that with a hand on the back of Loric's neck. And here it was, come up out of Loric's own chest above the counted pikes, at the exact moment his work came right, and it was not triumph. It was his father, alive for the length of one breath, laughing the way he laughed when he was pleased, and then gone again, because his father was gone, had been gone nineteen years, had been made gone by a woman in the south who to this hour did not know his name and would win or lose a war without ever once learning it. Loric stood with his father's laugh dying in his own throat and understood, for less than a heartbeat,

standing on his own gallows of trestle boards with everything come right, that when it was all finished and the Queen was on her knees at last, his father would still be gone, and the laugh would still be his to make alone, and there was no arrangement of the whole world's grief that would put a hand back on the back of his neck.

Then he put it down. He had a great deal of practice at putting it down. He set the sheet on the stack, tidy, corner to corner, and he came down off the boards to go and be kind to a frightened girl.

* * *

They had the servant. Amelia turned, because there was no not-turning, and she saw the man's hand on Maren's shoulder and Maren's face gone still and steady in the way that Maren's face went still, and she understood in one stroke that Maren had crossed the whole square to reach her and had spent herself doing it and was now a thing in a stranger's grip, and it was because of her, it was the private price of her, standing here.

The man who held Maren did not raise his voice. He never would; Amelia could see already what kind of man's man he was. He turned Maren by the shoulder, unhurried, and bent his head to her the way you bend to a child, and asked her something Amelia could not hear over the murmur of the square. Maren answered. Amelia could not hear that either, but she knew the set of Maren's mouth, and she knew Maren, and she knew it would be a *no* said in the only grammar Maren had, the one that never told you a thing straight. *I'm not the woman you want. I don't know any girl. There's nothing in me worth the walking.* The man listened to all of it with his head tipped, patient, and did not believe a word, and did not need to, because he had already seen the one thing that could not be un-said, which was that a

court-still woman had crossed a whole square full of the dead to get to a hooded stranger. He straightened. He nodded to the two behind him. They took Maren by the arms, one to each, and turned her toward the church wall where the pikes stood counted in their hundreds. Maren went. There was nothing in a market square a servant could do against three men and the King's new wax. She did not struggle. She did not call out. The crowd let them through and closed behind them without a sound, the way a crowd will let anything through that walks as if it has a right to.

Maren looked back once, over her shoulder, before the wall took her. Just once. She did not speak and she did not reach. She gave Amelia one flat plain look across the moving heads, and the look said, plainer than the six words she had carried two hundred miles, *go*. Not this. Not the seal. On your own feet, when you choose it. Go.

Amelia did not use the blood. It woke — it woke at her wrists the way it always woke, the old cold answer rising to be spent, four hundred hearts within reach and every one of them a thing she could reach into, and she held it down, because using it here was the last thing left that could make the tidy man's story true in front of four hundred witnesses, and because Maren's flat look had told her the shape of the only thing left worth doing, and it was not this square, and it was not now. She turned her hands over inside her sleeves and made the cold thing lie back down. She had learned that in the dark, from her mother, in the one hour a day the cage let them be only that. She made herself small the way she had been made, small and silver and no one, and she went.

She went down the lane to the water that had been the door the whole time. It was a cart-lane, rutted and running with the day's rain. It took her past the backs of houses with their shutters barred against the town's own square, past a woman pulling washing in off a line with quick frightened

hands, past the dog that had given up its bone now that the whole town smelled of fear. No one looked at her. That was the thing she carried down the lane, the old thing, the one she had wanted a lifetime to be rid of and had bought her life on all the same. Behind her the tidy man's voice had taken up the next sheet, and the square had gone quiet again to listen. Somewhere in that quiet was Maren, against a church wall, being asked patient questions by a man who would not raise his voice. Amelia put one foot in front of the other in the running rut and did not look back. Behind her was a thing no turn of her head could reach, and she had learned, at last, on this road, from a great many people, not to turn it. She had the empty vial cold against her breast, dry these two weeks. She had kept the rule the whole of them, taken the little she needed off what the road left dying — a snared hare, a broken-legged ewe, once a gull with a smashed wing — and not one warm human throat, and gone cold and slow between the times the land gave her nothing, which was most of them. The vial was the last of her mother she had to carry; the rule was the first thing she had ever kept whole by her own will and nobody's leave. Maren was taken in a square behind her, and her own name was nailed to a market cross in the King's red wax, and she went down to the water and along it and out of the town.

She got clear of the town and up onto the down above the river before her legs would stop, and she stopped there, in the wind, with the whole grey country running south toward her mother and the capital, and the man who had done all of this by asking questions at her back in the town she had just walked out of, and she did the sum, one last time, the cold way, standing on the down.

She had been seen. It had come, the thing she wanted her whole life. The throne had said her name to the world in wax and it had made her the cause of every death behind her and

cost her the one person who had ever crossed a room to reach her. Being seen by other people's choosing was not the thing she had wanted. It was only the cage turned inside out, the same walls painted the other way. Her mother had reached a hand out of love and it had shut over her like a lid. Loric had made her real to a crowd and it had made her a monster. Everyone who looked at her got to say what she was. She stood on the bare down with the wind going through her thin coat and her mother's blood cold in her wrists, and decided, without heat and without hurry, that she was done letting them.

There was one way left that no one had tried, because no one had ever let her try it. Not to hide, and not to be shown. She did not have the whole of it yet, standing there — only the shape of *no more*, and the certainty that the shape had a place in it she would have to walk to on her own feet.

And she began to walk.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

Seen on My Own Terms

The wind on the down came off the sea and had nothing to say to her, and she stood in it and did not go south.

South was the direction her legs had taken without asking her leave. She had walked most of a mile into it before her body understood what it was walking toward. South was her mother's hand, come down at last out of the red wax, and the capital, and the whole warm machinery of being saved by someone who loved her too far past sense to stop and count the price of it. South was a larger room. The largest there was. But a room a hand had shut her into for her own good, all the same, without once asking whether she wanted the door.

She let the road go past her. Carts and grey heads and children being pulled along by the wrist, all of them moving the way frightened people moved, which was away. She knew away. She had been going away her whole life. It was the one direction the household had ever left unbolted, because no one who loved her had imagined she would use it to go toward anything.

She thought of Maren against the church wall.

It came whole, the way the bad pictures always came. Maren with a man's hand on her shoulder and her mouth set in the grammar she used when she was lying to save a life, the grammar of what she would not say. Maren, who had

gone through a packed square that could have killed her the moment a wrong face turned, for the sake of six words that were already a lie by the time she said them. Maren had looked back once, over the moving heads, and the look had told her to go, and she had gone, because a servant's last order was still an order, and she had spent a whole life taking her orders quietly off covered trays and being grateful for them, and being grateful was a habit she was going to have to break.

She was not going to take this one.

The wind pulled at her hood. She put it down herself, off her own head, with her own two hands, and stood on the open down with her silver hair loose in the light for anyone on the whole grey country to see, and nobody saw, because there was no one up here but the wind. She had wanted, once, to be looked at. She had thought being looked at was a warm thing that happened to you in a bright room while music played under the floor. She understood now that it was not a thing that happened to you. It was a thing you did, once, on purpose, and paid for, and did not get back.

Her blood woke low in her wrists, the old cold answer rising to be spent. She had pressed it down every frightened night of her life and once more in the square below, four hundred hearts within her reach and every one of them left to keep its own time. She did not press it down now. She let it lie awake where it was, and it was not comfort and it was not company. It was only hers, at last, the one part of her that had never agreed to be made smaller, and she was going to use it.

She turned north, back toward the smoke of the town, and began to walk.

* * *

Dunmoor took her back in without noticing it had let her out.

That was the thing she had bought her whole life on, the not-being-noticed, and she wore it now the way she had always worn it, hood up again, hands in her sleeves, slow, in the middle of others. It sat on her like a skin she was about to shed. She went up the lane from the water that had been her door out, past the woman who had pulled her washing in, past the dog that had found a new bone, and the square opened in front of her exactly as she had left it, thick and quiet, the tidy man's voice going on over the heads of the dead.

He had reached the low numbers now. The sheets on the market cross had thinned to three. She stood at the edge of the crowd where the lane fed into it and made herself do the one cold thing she had climbed back down here to be able to do, which was to look at the church wall.

They had Maren there. Two men, not three. She counted them and did not let the count show on her face. The patient one who had taken her, the one Maren's whole body had gone still against, was not with them now. He had gone to be kind to a frightened girl somewhere in the press, and had not found her, because the frightened girl had walked out of his town and had come back a different thing. The two left were bored men holding a servant who had stopped fighting. One had his hand loose on Maren's arm. The other had turned half away to watch the reading. Maren stood between them with her back to the stone and her face empty, saving herself the only way she knew, by being no one worth the watching.

Amelia rated the square once, the old habit, because she needed the figure and there was no one to give it to her but herself. Stone on three sides and a hard-packed yard. It would carry a voice. A voice raised at the cross would reach the church wall whole and come back off it a half-beat late.

Whatever she said here, everyone would hear, and hear it twice.

Good.

She could have Maren out without a word. She saw the whole shape of it while she stood there, the way she saw everything, plainly, from the back. She could go along the wall in the noise of the reading, quiet as the linen girls' secrets, put the two men down between one name and the next, and have Maren into the lane and gone before the crowd had finished grieving the sheet in front of them. No one would ever know she had been in the square. She was very good at never having been anywhere. It was the finest thing she could do and the only thing she had ever been allowed to be good at.

And it would leave the square exactly as she found it. The tidy man on his boards with the dead in his hands and a witch in the story who was somewhere and nowhere, a rumour the crowd got to keep and to shape, a hidden thing to be afraid of in the dark. That was the thing he had built. That was the engine of all of it, the girl no one had seen, the secret everyone owned a piece of, the monster they got to find for themselves in the space where a real face should have been. She could free Maren and hand him back his square unchanged, the whole town still hunting a shape.

Or she could take the shape away from him.

She stood in the fed-in mouth of the lane a moment longer, and there was no fear in her, which frightened her more than fear would have. She had gone past it into the cold flat country on the other side, where the counting stopped mattering because you had already spent everything there was to count. A thought came up out of nowhere while she stood there, uninvited, the way they came: the almond cakes the cook used to send up before they went down to the hall, warm, out of order, against every

rule. She had loved them without knowing they were an apology. Then it was gone and she was in the square.

She put her hood back for the second time that day, and this time there were four hundred people to see it, and she walked out of the crowd into the open ground at the foot of the cross, into the one place in the world she had been told her whole life she must never be.

* * *

It was the linen girls who would have understood it. They had asked her, once, which of two dull brothers to marry, and taken her answer seriously, because she noticed things. She noticed things now. She noticed how long it took a quiet to change its quality. Two names. The tidy man on the boards saw her before the crowd did, and he did not stop reading, which told her more about him than a shout would have. He set the sheet down, corner to corner, and looked at the silver-headed girl standing where no one stood, and waited, the way a man waits who has spent his life letting other people move first.

Then the crowd found her, in a spreading turn, heads coming round, and the quiet went from the quiet of grief listening to the quiet of a great many people looking at the same thing and not yet knowing what it was.

She let them look. That was the whole of it, the thing she had climbed back down into the town to do. She stood in the yard with her hair loose and let four hundred grieving people see a young woman the colour of the moon on a cold night, pale as the underside of a leaf, exactly the thing a story would warn you about, and she did not make herself small, and she did not run the sum on their faces, and she opened her mouth and said the ugly thing first, plainly, before anyone else's mouth could say it for her.

"I'm the one you've been reading about," she said.

The wall gave it back a half-beat late, the way she had known it would. *Reading about*. It reached the church stone and came home to her doubled, and she heard exactly how flat it was, and let it be flat.

"There's no witch," she said. "There's me. My mother is the Queen and I was born of her body, in her own house, and I have hidden in it for twenty years so that none of you would ever have to know I was in the world. That was the peace. That was the whole of the peace, that I not exist." She had not raised her voice much. She did not need to. The square carried it. "You've been told there's a thing that flies and a girl who's a witch, and that between the two of us we made these lists. Half of that is a lie a man told you to give your grief a face. I'm the true half. I'm real, and I'm standing here, and now you don't have to find me. I'm not going to be a thing you're afraid of in the dark any more. Look at me in the light. This is what you were sold a war over."

Nobody moved. She had thought there might be a noise, a cry, a stone. There was only the sound of four hundred people being handed the last thing they had lacked, and it was worse than a stone, that silence, because she could feel them doing to her face what they had done to the tidy man's fortnight, welding it to a grief, making it fit.

At the church wall Maren had come off the stone. Amelia saw it out of the side of her seeing, the servant surging forward against the bored hand on her arm, her mouth opening on the name she had spent a life learning never to say, and the man's hand tightening, and the second man turning back from the reading with his own hand going to Maren's other arm, and Maren struggling now, at last, uselessly, because the girl she had walked two hundred miles to save had just stood up in a square full of the enemy and put her own head in the noose with her own two hands.

That was the moment it went wrong, and it went wrong the way she had known it might, which was that the men holding Maren decided, seeing the girl declare herself, that the servant was worth nothing now and the girl was worth everything, and they let Maren go and came for her instead.

They came fast, off the wall, two of them, and there were others turning in the crowd she had not counted, men without colours who had been standing among the grieving all along, three, four of them, converging on the open ground where she stood, and Maren was shouting something now that the square swallowed, and Amelia stood still in the middle of it and let them come, and reached for the nearest of them the way her mother had taught her in the dark.

It was the plainest thing in the world, when it came to it. That was the horror of it, standing there. She had spent her whole life believing the blood was a great and terrible power that she had to hold shut with both hands or it would flood the room. It was not a flood. It was a small precise motion, no bigger than sliding a bolt. She found the nearest man in the crowd of him, the warm knot of him that kept the time, the thing her mother had shown her a hundred quiet mornings while the household slept and the cage let them be only a mother and a girl learning a craft. In the hills a season ago she had held seven men and let every one of them keep it, and had thought, walking away clean, that the holding was the mercy. She had been wrong about which of the two choices cost the more, and about who paid it.

She stopped his heart.

He went down between one stride and the next, folding, the way a thing folds when the string is cut, and she was already reaching past him for the second, and she stopped that one too, and the third, working along them the way she worked along the acoustics of a room, plainly, without drama, one and then the next and then the next, and each

one folded and did not get up. She did not shout. She did not raise a hand. She stood in the yard at the foot of the cross with her hands quiet in her sleeves and her face doing nothing at all, and the men who had come for her lay down around her in the dirt in a rough ring, five of them, six, and the square made the sound at last that she had thought it would make when she took her hood down, the long rising note of four hundred people learning something about the world all together, and stepping back from it.

She had wanted, her whole life, to walk up to a stranger in a warm room and have him beg her pardon without knowing her name. She had six strangers at her feet now, and she knew none of their names, and never would, and she had learned them the only way the world had ever let her be known to anyone, which was by the harm she could do them.

She made the cold thing lie back down. It went easily. It had never been the part of her that struggled.

* * *

"Well," said a voice, mild, close, from the boards. "There she is."

She turned, and it was the tidy man, and she knew him for what he was the moment she looked at him full, though she had never in her life been in a room with him. He looked like someone's steward. He looked like a man you would hand your coat. He stood at the edge of the trestle boards with the last of the sheets in his hand, and he did not look at the men folded in the dirt, and he did not look afraid, and he came down off the boards toward her, unhurried, the way Maren had said he moved, the way you move when you have already reasoned that the thing in front of you must be exactly what it is and there is no more work left to do but the last small kindness of it.

"Loric," she said, before he could speak again. She said it into the square, so the wall would carry it. "His name is Loric. His father died in the last war and he wants my mother to weep, and there is not one of your dead on any of those sheets that he grieves. He lit the frontier. He'll tell you he only asks. He only ever asks."

She watched it land on him and slide off. He inclined his head a little, as though she had made a fair point in a discussion about the price of corn.

"Nobody here knows that name," he said gently. "You've just said it to four hundred people who watched you stop six hearts without lifting your hand. Do you think it's my name they'll carry home tonight?" He was not unkind about it. That was the thing that went into her somewhere soft, that he was not unkind. "You gave them the true half, you said. You did. And you gave them this." He nodded, once, at the folded men in the dirt, without looking at them. "You've done my whole night's work for me, and done it better than I could. I'd have needed a week to make them believe in you. You made them believe in a quarter of an hour."

She had known it on the down. She had done the sum up there in the wind and known every figure of it and come back down anyway, because the alternative was to slip out quiet and leave him his square and go on being a shape in the dark that he owned. She had chosen this instead. She had chosen to be the thing they feared, out loud, on the hour she picked, on ground she stood on by her own decision, and it had bought her exactly what she had gone up the down knowing it would buy her, which was that she would be seen, and hunted, and the truth of her would still not be provable, and the only thing she had truly taken from him was the pleasure of the reveal being his.

It was not nothing, that she had denied him the finding. She held to that. But it was so much smaller than she had let

herself hope on the down, and she made herself hold that too, standing in the cold ring of what she had done, because she was not a child and she would not pretend the sum had come out kind when it had not. He was right. It was his night. She had only made herself the author of the ruin instead of its victim, and there were mornings, she thought, when that would have to be enough, and this was not going to be one of them.

"You should go," Loric said, and he meant it, she could hear that he meant it, and that was the worst thing he had said. He wanted her alive and loose and terrible on the roads. A hidden witch was a rumour. A silver girl who stopped six hearts in a market square and walked away was a thing that would do his work in every town between here and the sea, and he knew it, and he was letting her have the lane on purpose, the way he let everyone have everything, so that they would carry his story out through the door themselves and never feel the hand that had set them walking.

She understood, standing there, that there was no move she could make in this square that he had not already stood behind and reasoned toward her. If she killed him too, the crowd would have their monster confirmed forever, and he would be a murdered man with clean hands, and the war would close over the top of him like water over a stone. If she left him living, he won as he was winning. He had built a place where her every choice moved into his hand. She had spent her life reading rooms for the one door no one had bolted, and he had built her a room with no unbolted door in it, and stood in the middle of it, mild, and let her look for one.

So she did the only thing left that he had not laid the ground for, which was nothing at all. She did not kill him. She did not answer him. She turned her back on him in front

of four hundred people, which a frightened girl could not have done, and which a monster did not need to, and she went to the church wall to get Maren.

* * *

Maren was on her feet against the stone with both hands pressed flat to the wall behind her, holding herself up on it, and when Amelia reached her she did not reach back. That was the second thing that went into her that day, after the almond cakes, sharp and out of order and hers to carry.

"Come away," Amelia said. Quietly. The way Della used to say things by the bed.

Maren looked at her. She had known this face since Amelia was a child, had learned the girl's height off a life of standing beside it, had helped teach the very stillness Amelia had used a quarter of an hour ago to stop a man's heart without raising a hand. And she looked at the girl now the way you look at a thing you have loved a long time and just watched become something you were not there for the making of, and her mouth did the thing it did when she was frightened, which was to go still and reckon the silver, and she did not say gladness and she did not say horror. She said the only thing her grammar had ever let her say straight, which was a refusal turned inside out.

"I'm not sorry I came," Maren said. "You hear me. I'll not be made sorry I came."

"I know," Amelia said.

"You didn't have to." Maren's voice cracked on it and she took the crack and drove it down and went on, low, fierce. "I had you out. I had it worked so I'd have you out and gone and no one the wiser, and you walked into the middle of it and —" She stopped. She looked past Amelia's shoulder at the folded men in the dirt and the crowd backed away from them and the tidy man standing mild among the sheets of

the dead, and something went out of her face, the last of the thing that had come two hundred miles to save a girl who did not, it turned out, want to be saved. "You did it on purpose," she said. It was not a question. "You stood up and let them see you on purpose."

"Yes."

Maren was quiet a moment. Around them the square had begun, at its edges, to empty, people peeling away from the open ground where the girl stood, going quietly, taking it home. "Your mother said the door was open," Maren said at last, and now her voice was only tired. "She never said you'd walk out of it into a fire and pull it shut behind you."

"She never imagined I would," Amelia said. "That's the whole of what's wrong between us. Neither of them did. She built me a cage out of love and he built me a room out of reason, and not one of the two of them ever once thought the girl inside might decide the hour she'd come out, and cost them both what it cost." She put her hand under Maren's elbow, the way you help a woman who has been standing too long, and Maren let her, which was as near to forgiveness as either of them was going to get today. "I couldn't leave you at a wall. I've been left at enough walls. Come away."

* * *

They went down the lane to the water together, the two of them, a silver girl and a grey servant, and no one stopped them, because no one in Dunmoor that evening wanted to be within reach of the thing that had stood at the cross. The crowd let them through the way a crowd lets anything through that walks as if it has the right, and this time it was not the right of the King's wax. It was the other right, the cold one, the one she had bought at the foot of the market cross with six men she would never know the names of. She had it now. She could feel the town giving it to her, the wide berth,

the dropped eyes, the door pulled shut on its chain as she passed. It was the opposite of every door she had ever stood behind, and it shut with exactly the same sound. She walked down the rutted lane in the last of the light with the chains going home one after another behind her, on the far side now of the only wall she had ever lived against, and no warmer for the change of side.

She had wanted a party. She turned the old want over, walking, the way she turned everything, and found it small and clean and completely dead, a coin from a country that no longer existed. There were no parties left in her. There was a road out of this town, and beside her on it the one person who had crossed a square to reach her, and the two of them going to be hunted now, faster than before, because she had taken the rumour Loric owned and made it a fact that walked on its own feet. She had won the frame. It was a real thing, to have won it, and she would not talk herself out of its being real. She held to that in the cold going-down of the day, because it was the only figure in the sum that came out on her side, and it was going to have to do the work of a great many that had not.

At the foot of the lane the water ran grey the colour of the old winter gown, the one her mother had had made for a fitting that was never a fitting, the one that turned a breath after her when she turned, obedient, a beat too late to be any company. She had left it folded flat on a bed a hundred years ago for Della to carry back down. She thought of Della sliding the bolt slowly, as if slowly made it less of a lock. She let the picture come and go the way the beeswax and the cold stone used to come and go, at the wrong moments, asking nothing, only there.

Maren stopped at the water's edge to breathe. Amelia stood beside her and looked south along the running grey of it, toward the capital, toward her mother, who did not yet

know that the daughter she had tried to save in wax had gone and saved herself in blood, and would have to be told, and would weep, and would understand it too late, the way she understood everything too late, from love. And then Amelia looked the other way, east, where the country climbed toward the frontier and the smoke and the war, toward the theatre where all of it was going to be decided, where the levies were marching and the clans were down out of the hills and somewhere under the coming moon there was a thing that flew.

She had never told a soul about the garden. She had not needed to. He was the only stranger she had ever walked up to as a stranger, in a warm hall on the one night her whole life had turned, and he had looked at her and not seen a witch or a weapon or a secret or a crown. He had seen a person standing in a room, which was the one impossible thing, the plain enormous ordinary miracle she had wanted her whole life, and he had done it without knowing it was a miracle at all.

And under all of it her body wanted him, plainly, in the cold at the foot of the lane. Not decently and not gently. She stood with her arms crossed over the chill of herself and let herself remember the heat of him at her back in a hut and a shieling and a cold camp behind a dyke, the weight of the arm he laid over her, the careful hands that had never been afraid of what she was. The wanting came up in her the way the gift came up, sudden and total and no respecter of the hour, all of her reaching at once toward the only warmth for a hundred cold miles. She had kept her hands to herself her whole life. It had never occurred to her, before him, that a person could be a thing you reached for like that, helplessly, with all of you. She wanted to be where he was. She wanted his hands on her and the cold gone out of her for an hour. She was so tired of being cold, in every way there was to be

cold, and he was the one fire she had ever found that did not ask her to be smaller to sit at it.

He was out there, east, under the moon, in the middle of the fire.

She found she did not have to decide it. It was already decided, the way south had already been decided by her legs before she stopped it, only this time when her body chose she went with it, because for the first time in her life the direction her blood was walking and the direction she meant to go were the same. She was done being shown and done being hidden and done being found. There was one place left in the whole grey country where the war was going to turn, and she was going to be there, on her own feet, on the hour she chose, and so was he.

"East," Maren said, watching her face, reading it the way she read the silver. It was not a question either.

"East," Amelia said, and turned into the wind, toward the fire, and began to walk faster.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

Toward the Same Fire

He came down out of the dark of the moon to listen, because a dragon learned nothing and a man in a doorway learned everything.

He had clothes now. He had worked that out on the third night, coming low over a fold farm with the byres shut, that a man could not walk into a town the way God made him, and that a country at war had left its washing on the lines and its dead in the ditches and did not begrudge a shirt to whatever took it. So he had a dead drover's coat that smelled of another man's fear, and breeches too short in the leg, and boots that were nearly right. He came into the muster town of Harrowfell on foot in the last of the dark, like any of the hundred broken men the war had put on the roads. No one looked at him twice. A big tired man in a dead man's coat was the commonest thing in the country now.

He had thought the hard part would be crossing. It was not. The hard part was being a man again for the hours it took, small and cold and slow, when the great body knew where it was going and this one only knew how much it hurt.

The inn yard at Harrowfell had a fire going under a lean-to, and a press of men round it who had not yet been given a company or a captain, levies waiting to be counted. Korvan went in among them the way you go in among strange dogs. Slow, hands where they could be seen. He took

a place at the edge of the warmth and said nothing and let the talk come to him. That was a thing his father did that he had never valued until he had to do it himself. You did not ask. You stood at the edge of a fire and were patient and the thing you needed walked up and offered itself, because men who are frightened cannot stop their own mouths.

They were talking about the witch.

He had his hands out to the fire and he did not let them stop. He had learned that much of her, standing in the shieling watching her not-feel the cold. You did not let the body say the thing the face was holding. So he warmed his hands and listened to a man with a bandaged eye tell it, and another correct him, and a third swear it on his mother, the whole of it going round the fire the way a story goes round a fire, growing a foot with every mouth.

A girl the colour of the moon had stood up in the market square at Dunmoor. She had taken her own hood down in front of the whole grieving town and said she was the one they had been reading the lists about. She had said there was no witch, there was her, and her mother was the Queen. And when the King's men came off the church wall to take her she had stood in the middle of them with her hands in her sleeves and stopped their hearts. One and then the next. Six of them down in the dirt in a ring, and not a finger raised to do it. Then she had turned her back on the whole square and walked out down the lane, and no one in Dunmoor had dared put a hand on her going.

"Six," the bandaged man said. "I had it off a carter come up this morning. Six, in a ring, and her never touched a one."

"Eight," said another.

"Six or eight, what's it matter. She's on the roads. Loose. That's what matters. There's a purse on her the size of a farm and she's east of Dunmoor somewhere walking free as

you like, and I'll tell you what I'll not be doing, and that's the man who reaches out his hand to earn it."

Korvan warmed his hands and did not stop.

He had thought, going up off that hill in his father's cloak, that he knew where she was and what kept her whole. She was walking south to the court under a King's writ that made her worth more alive than dead, and the writ would hold her together the length of the road the way a barrel-hoop holds staves, and he had let that be his comfort in the dark over the fires. She was a purse. A purse travelled. A purse got where it was going.

She was not a purse any more. She had taken the thing that kept her whole and broken it over her own knee in a public square, on purpose, the way she did everything, and made herself the very thing the writ had been drawn to deny. He stood at the fire and understood it the way you understand a step that is not there in the dark, all at once and in the stomach. There was no hoop round her now. She had stood up in a market square packed with the enemy and told them to their faces she was the monster, and stopped six hearts to prove it, so that the tidy man could never again be the one to point and say *there*. She had taken the pointing away from him. And she had made herself, in the doing of it, the most hunted thing between the sea and the falls, worth a farm to any man with a horse and no sense.

He knew why she had done it. He knew her well enough now to walk the whole cold sum of it in the space of a breath, standing at a stranger's fire in a dead man's coat. She would rather be the author of the ruin than the thing it happened to. She would rather stop six hearts by her own hand than have one man own her by keeping her secret. It was the bravest thing he had ever heard of anyone doing, and it had cut the last rope that held her out of the fire. He stood there wanting to shake her and hold her and could do neither. She

was forty miles off in the dark being the most dangerous person in the country. He was a tired man warming his hands among men who would sell her for a farm.

"East of Dunmoor," he said. It was the first thing he had said, and he made it slow and stupid, a big man half asleep on his feet. "Which way's east of Dunmoor lead."

"Up the Elver, same as everything." The bandaged man looked at him without interest. "Up toward the falls and the crossing and the whole cursed war. Where'd you think. She's not walking to it for the fishing." He spat into the fire. "That's the mad thing of it. She's walking toward the front. Toward where the two hosts are set to meet. A girl with a farm on her head walking straight at the one place in the country there's more armed men than anywhere, and no one can say why, and it's got the camp saying she's mad on top of everything, mad and a witch, which is worse."

Korvan knew why.

He knew it the way he had known the third door on the hill, in the meat before the head, and it went through him and out the other side and left him standing very still with his hands out to a fire he could no longer feel. She was not mad and she was not walking to the front for the war. There was one thing east of Dunmoor, up the Elver toward the falls, that she would walk through an army to reach, and it was the same thing he was crossing a country in the dark to reach, and neither of them had told the other, and both of them were doing it. She was walking toward the fire because he was in it. He was crossing under the whole lit war because she was walking into it. And the two of them, who had spent four days on a cold mountain unable to say the smallest true thing to each other, were saying it now in the largest possible way. With their whole bodies. Forty miles apart. Each throwing themselves at the most dangerous ground in

the country because the other one was going to be standing on it.

His father had named it on the hill. The two of them had the same trick in them, he'd said, the girl and the boy both, each forever giving up the one thing wanted most so it would go on breathing without them. His father had meant it as a fault. Standing at the Harrowfell fire, Korvan understood it was also the only way either of them had ever known to say the thing, and that they were about to say it to each other across an army.

"I'm for east," he said, to no one, and pushed off the lean-to post.

"You're a fool, then," the bandaged man said, not unkindly. "There's nothing east but the war."

"There's a thing I left there," Korvan said, and went out of the light before his face could finish being what it was becoming.

He walked out of Harrowfell northward, the wrong way, until the last of the town was down behind a shoulder of land, and then he came off the road into the black firs and stood in them and shook for a while, and let it be the cold, and knew it was not. When it had passed he took off the dead man's coat and folded it, because there was no wearing it where he went. He laid it on a rock the way he had laid his father's cloak on the turf. He stood naked in the firs with the frost coming up through his feet and the whole eastern sky pricked with the fires of a country waiting to kill itself. Then he found the low turn under his breastbone and called it up by his own hand, and went dark, and went east, faster than he had let himself go the whole way. Toward the falls. The crossing. Her.

Behind him, on the ridges he had already crossed, a beacon woke.

He did not see which one. He was already flat to the wind and climbing into the black, and the alarm ran along the tops behind him the way it always ran, one fire and then the next lighting the shape of where he had been. But it was not only the old net now, the country's net, men watching for silver. He had learned that on the second night, come down onto a scree with an arrow in the rock a hand's breadth from his eye, put there in the dark by a man who had been lying in wait for him and not for any dragon in general. The tidy man had turned his patient face on the sky. There were crews out now who did not watch the roads but the dark of the moon, who knew a dragon came down of nights and went dark by day, who had worked out his one weakness the way you work out a lock, that the thing on the banner had to be a man for the hours between. Whale-iron went where he went now. He had felt it twice, the cold wrongness of it laid across a valley he meant to cross, and turned and gone the long way round in the black.

Two nets, and both of them tightening, and the two people they were drawn to closing on the same square mile of ground from opposite sides of a war. He climbed into the dark and did not slow. Let them tighten. A thing that meant to come up at its own hour was not caught by a net it could see.

* * *

Amelia went east against the whole grain of the country, and the country did not like it.

Everything living was moving the other way. The road up the Elver was a river of the fleeing, carts and hand-barrows and grey heads and children carried on hips, all of it pouring west and south away from the falls where the two armies were set to meet. She and Maren went up through it eastward, two women wading a flood. Every face that passed

them going the sane direction looked at them going the mad one. That was the cover, in the end. A country in flight had no attention to spare for two more women on a choked road. The description was out — she knew it was out, a girl the colour of the moon, and there was not a market cross between here and the sea that did not have it nailed up by now — but a description needed a man with the leisure to read a face, and there were no such men on the Elver road. There were only the frightened, going the other way, who saw two hooded shapes against the tide and had already forgotten them by the next bend.

She kept her hood up and her head down and her hands in her sleeves and she counted the miles the way she had once counted the intervals of a room, because the counting gave the fear somewhere to stand. Four to the ford at Kell. Nine more to the burnt mill. She had stopped rating the acoustics of the places she passed. There was no one left to overhear her in a country this loud, and the old habit had gone quiet in her the way a lamp goes quiet when the sun comes up, not put out, only no longer needed. She counted miles instead. Miles were toward. For twenty years she had measured the size of the rooms she was shut in, and now for the first time the number she wanted was not how far the walls stood but how far there was left to walk, and it was a different arithmetic, and it did not come out as fear. It came out as a thing she had no practised word for, because she had never before in her life had a direction that was toward something instead of away from it.

"You'll tell me," Maren said, on the second day, "or you won't, and I'll not make you. But we're walking into the war. I've a right to know if it's a plan. Or only a way of dying you've settled on that's grander than the others."

"It's not a way of dying."

"That's not a plan either."

They were resting in the lee of a broken wall while a train of the King's baggage went by on the road, and Amelia watched the wagons go and did not answer at once, because Maren was owed a true thing and the true thing was hard to hand across without handing the whole of herself with it. Maren recounted her buttons while she waited, four of them, top to bottom and back, the way she did when the ground under her was moving.

"There's a person," Amelia said at last. "Going to the same place. From the other side of it."

Maren's hands stopped on the buttons. She was quiet a moment, reading the side of Amelia's face the way she read the silver, and whatever she found there she did not say gladness to it and she did not say the sensible thing, which would have been that walking into a battlefield toward a person was the worst reason of all the bad reasons for walking into a battlefield.

"The one from the hall," Maren said. Not a question. "The night it all went wrong. You went out to the garden and you came back changed and you'd not say why, and I thought it was the crowd, the being seen. It wasn't the crowd."

"No."

"You've said not ten words of him since the garden."

"There weren't words for him that wouldn't have been used against him." She had kept him under her tongue the whole hunted stretch of it the way you keep the one coin you will not spend, and it had cost her to keep silent and it had kept him alive, the not-saying, because a secret said aloud is a secret handed to whoever is nearest, and no one had ever been near her she could afford to hand him to. Not even Maren. Especially not Maren, who would have been made to give him up. "He's the only person in my whole life who looked at me and didn't see a use for me. Not a witch, not a weapon, not a secret, not my mother's daughter. A person

standing in a room." She turned her face away, out at the moving grey of the wagons, because saying it undid something in the set of her mouth she did not want watched, even by Maren. "I didn't know that was a thing that could happen to a person until it happened. I've been trying to walk back to it ever since."

Maren took that in. She recounted the buttons, top to bottom, and this time the count came out steady and she let her hands lie still.

"Then east," she said. "God help the pair of us. East it is."

They went on into the dark and came down to the river town of Kell in the last grey of the day. The Elver ran fast under a stone bridge the King's men had mined but not yet fired. The whole crossing was choked with the war, soldiers and the fleeing tangled together at the bottleneck of the bridge. Torches, shouting, a barge crew trying to get the last of a village's household goods across before the order came to blow the span. There was no getting through it in the light. Amelia took them off the road into the yard of an abandoned byre on the town's east edge, above the water, where the roof was mostly sound and the walls kept the wind. They got in under it and pegged the door and sat in the loud dark and ate the last of the bread. Maren fell asleep between one breath and the next, the way the truly spent do. Amelia sat with her back to the stone and did not.

She had never in her life been able to sleep in a new room. She sat and let the town's noise wash up the hill at her, the shouting at the bridge, the barge crew, a dog that would not stop, and somewhere under all of it the river going over its weir with a sound like a held breath that never ended, and she did not count any of it. She let it be. She was closer to him tonight than she had been since the mountain. She could feel it the way you feel the edge of a step in the dark, a nearness with no proof under it, and she knew it was

want and not knowledge, and she let it be want. Want was toward. She had earned the right to a little unproven want, she thought, having paid what she had paid to face the right direction.

The moon came up late over the falls, past its full now, a night off the silver, and it laid a grey road on the river below the byre. She watched it through the gap where the door-hide did not quite meet the stone.

And a shape came across it.

She knew it before her mind would say it. She knew it in the body first, the way you know a footstep in the house you grew up in, and then the knowing came up into her and she was on her feet with one hand pressed to the cold byre wall and her whole self gone still. High up, in the dark of the going-down moon, a great dun shape crossed the grey road on the water and put it out for the space of a breath and let it come back. No beacon lit. It came low and it came quiet, the way she had seen it come down out of the sky over a tarn a hundred years ago with the man still screaming somewhere inside it. It was going east, up the Elver, toward the falls, exactly where she was going. An hour ahead of her and a thousand feet above her. And it did not know she was under it.

She had a lamp. Maren had a flint. Above the byre the hill went up bald to a shoulder of open turf where a fire lit would carry to the whole valley of the sky. She stood with her hand on the stone and did the sum without wanting to, because the sum was the thing she was, and it came out in an instant and it came out cruel. She could be on that shoulder in sixty seconds. She could have a fire up in two minutes, a fire on a height, the one signal in all the world he would know for hers, because he was the only person alive who knew she could not make a fire and would understand a fire on a hill as her hand reaching up. She could bring him down out of

the sky to her tonight, this hour, into her arms in the frost above the river, and end the whole aching length of the year.

And every man in Kell would see the dragon come down.

That was the whole of it, the arithmetic plain as the interval of a room. To call him down was to call him down where four thousand frightened armed men and a barge crew and a town full of the fleeing would watch the thing on the banner come out of the songs and land. And be real. And be seen. And be the dragon shown at last, which was the one thing he had crossed a country in the dark to never be. She would buy one hour of him and spend his whole third door to do it. She would reach up her hand out of her own want and pull the string his father had wanted pulled and the tidy man had wanted pulled and every soul on both sides of the war had wanted pulled. She would be the last one to do it, the one who did it out of love. It would make no difference at all to him when they had him.

She took her hand off the stone.

She stood in the gap of the door-hide and watched him cross the moon and go on east and small, one thousand feet up and one mile off and nearer than he had been in all the weeks between, and she did not light the fire. She held still and let him fly over her and away, the way you hold still over a sleeping child so as not to wake it. Except that this was the opposite. This was holding still so as not to wake the whole world onto the one person she wanted to wake. She watched him go until the grey road lay unbroken on the water again and there was nothing over it but the moon.

"You're a fool," she said to herself, low, in Maren's voice, in the byre in the dark, "and there's nothing east but the war." And she stood there a while longer with her back to the stone and her hands quiet in her sleeves, having thrown him away again, one more time, so that he would live, which was the only way she had ever learned to hold anything at all.

He nearly came down at Kell.

He had not meant to. He had meant to overfly the crossing high and go on to the falls and find a fell to lie up on before the light, because a river town choked with the war was a lit thing and a lit thing was death, and he had crossed forty such and learned them all the same lesson. But he came up over Kell in the dark of the moon and something in the great cold body slowed him without his leave.

It was the town that did it, he told himself after, when he could make himself say anything. It was only the town. A byre on the east edge of it had a shape of light in it. A hooded lamp cracking out through a gap in a door, the smallest light in the whole valley. Everyone else's fire roared at the bridge, and this one was shut down small and careful, the way you shut a light when you do not want to be seen having it. The dragon's eye that could count the hairs on a hind at a mile went to it and would not come off it. A careful light. A light that did not want to be a light. He had spent the whole road beside the only person he had ever known who could make herself that small. She shut everything of herself down to a crack, so that the world would pass over the top of her and not know she was under it. The great body knew that shape of careful. It slowed over the light and hung on the cold air above a river town and looked, and wanted, out of some part of the animal the man had not thought could want anything but meat.

He hung there too long. A dragon over a town in the dark is a bell whether it rings or not, and he knew it, and he could not for a moment make the wings do the sane thing.

There was a byre. There was a careful little light. And there was, or he made it out of the want the way he had made her out of every pale thing for so long now, a paleness in the

gap of the door, a shape the colour of the moon standing very still in the crack of the light and looking up. He was a thousand feet up in the dark and it was one crack of lamplight in one byre in one town in a country full of them, and he could no more have sworn it was her than sworn the shape of a face in a coal. He had seen her in the underside of every wading bird. He had seen her hair on every frost-bleached branch. The want made her out of nothing so often that he had stopped trusting his own eye where she was concerned, and he did not trust it now, and he hung over Kell in the killing dark and could not make himself leave the crack of light regardless.

Come down. The animal said it, or the wanting did, or the part of him that had lain in a shieling with her heat sinking into his cold and known, whatever they had told each other with their mouths, that the thing between them was going to have to be paid for one way and there was no walking it off. Come down. It's her. You know that shape of careful. There is one person in the world who makes a light that small on purpose. Come down into the frost above the river and be a man and put your arms round the one thing that ever looked at you and saw a person. Let the town see the dragon. Let the whole war see it. Let them come. It had gone on long enough now to be a mile from the only warm thing there is and hold still over it in the dark.

He held still over it in the dark.

He made the wings do the sane thing. It was the hardest single act of the whole crossing, harder than the whale-iron valley, harder than the tarn. He did it for a plain reason. If he came down to that byre he came down as the dragon shown, into a town packed with the men who would spend the rest of their lives telling how they saw it land, every one of them a beacon walking. The third door would shut behind him with her inside it. There would be no more going dark for either

of them ever again, only the two nets closing on the one place they had finally been foolish enough to stand together in the light. He had crossed a country of fires to keep from being seen. He was not going to spend the whole of it on one hour, however much the hour was worth, and it was worth everything, and that was exactly why he could not spend it here, in front of an army, on a maybe, on a crack of light that his own starved eye had likely built out of the moon.

He turned east and climbed and left the careful little light behind him on the black water. He told himself the whole cold mile of it that it had not been her. It could not have been her. She was south, or taken, or dead, or forty miles the other way. A purse on the road to a court. Anywhere but under him in a river town in the middle of a war. Because the alternative was that he had just hung a thousand feet over the one thing he wanted in the world and made himself fly on. A man could not do that and also go on living. So it had not been her. He flew east into the dark repeating it, until the town was gone behind a shoulder of the hills and there was nothing under him but the empty fell and nothing ahead but the fires.

He came down before the light on a north-facing crag two miles short of the falls and folded into a man and lay in the frost shaking, and it was not the shift that shook him. He lay on the cold rock in the last of the dark and looked back the way he had come. West. Down the black valley toward Kell, where a careful little light had burned in a byre door. He made himself not think the thought. He thought it anyway, once, all the way through, the way she would have made herself do it.

That if it had been her, if he had been right, then two people who loved each other past sense had passed within a mile of each other in the dark tonight. Each going toward the other with the whole heart. Each choosing, out of that same

love, to let the distance stand. She would have watched him cross the moon and not lit her fire, to keep him unseen. He had hung over her light and not come down, to keep her unfound. They had each thrown the wanted thing away one more time so it would live. They had gone on alone toward the same fire from opposite sides of it, closer than they had been in weeks and further than a mile. A mile in the light was death. A mile held apart in the dark was the only road either of them had left to reach the other by.

He got up off the crag. The falls were two miles east, and under them the crossing, and beyond the crossing the whole country was gathering itself to decide the thing, and she was somewhere in the dark behind him walking toward it as hard as he was walking toward it, and the next place their two roads could possibly meet was the middle of the fire itself.

He faced east, where the sky over the falls had begun to go the colour of the coming light, and went on toward it, alone. He did not look back down the valley again. There was no reaching yet for a thing not yet in reach; he had learned from a hard master to wait for the hour he could close his hand on it for good.

The hour was coming. He could feel it the way you feel weather. He went to meet it.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

The Reunion

He came down off the crag as a man, because a dragon could not walk up to her, and he had settled it a long way back that the first thing she saw would be his own face and not the thing the world had made of him.

The falls held the whole valley in noise. He had chosen the place for that in the last of the dark, coming down onto the north bank two miles short of the crossing, where the Elver went over a stepped shoulder of black rock in three long drops and threw its roar back off both walls of the gorge until a man could stand ten feet from another man and not be heard. It was the fountain again, grown to the size of a war. A place that ate every word. A place two people could stand in and be alone inside the noise of falling water.

He waited above the lower pool where the old fish-house stood, a stone shell with half a roof, and watched the west road come up out of the mist. He had told himself the whole cold mile from Kell that it could not have been her in the byre door. She was south, or taken, or dead. He had said it until the words wore smooth, and then crossed a country of fires to stand exactly here on the chance they had meant nothing at all.

She came out of the mist on the west road a little after the light did.

He knew her before he could have sworn to a single thing about her. Knew her the way you know the one voice in a market. A hooded shape, and a second shape behind it that stopped at the broken gate and did not come on. The first shape came down the last of the road toward the fish-house, hands in her sleeves, head up, not hurrying, sure of her way. The hood came back off pale hair gone near to grey in the wet morning. It was her. It was her, and something came apart in his chest all at once.

He did not run to her. It was not doubt. The whole way, he had built this loud in his head, and now that she was here it had gone very quiet, and the quiet was the truest thing, and he did not want to spend it running.

She stopped an arm's length off. Close enough to touch and not touching. The way they had sat by the fountain.

"I saw you cross the moon at Kell," she said. The falls took most of it and gave him the rest. "I could have brought you down to me. There was a hill and a lamp and Maren's flint. I stood in the door and did the whole sum and I did not light it."

"I know," he said. "I hung over the light and I made myself go on. I told myself it wasn't you the whole way here." His voice was not doing what he told it to. "It was you."

"It was me."

"You didn't light the fire."

"You didn't come down." She looked up at him, and the small living thing he had spent so long trying to hold in his head came up into her face and it was better than the one he had held. "We threw each other away one more time. In the dark. A mile apart. So the other one would live." A corner of her mouth moved, the almost-smile, the specialty. "I have decided I am done doing that. I walked into a war to be done doing that. I would like it on the record that I got here first."

"You did not get here first," he said. "I've been on that crag since before the light."

"You cannot possibly know that. You have no clock."

"I have the whole eastern sky for a clock and I watched it go grey waiting on you. I win."

She laughed. He felt it more than heard it over the water, a small warm shake, the thing he had told himself in the shieling he would burn down the rest of himself to hear again. Here it was, handed back for free at the edge of a war. He stood in the roar of the falls and let it go through him and did not try to hold it.

"There's a roof," he said, when he could. "Most of one. It's dry in the north corner. The water covers everything. No one hears anything in there but the fall." He heard himself and stopped, because he had said very nearly those words to her once before by a smaller water, offering her a fire she said would be seen, and she caught the echo the same instant he did, he saw her catch it.

"You're offering me a warm dry place where no one can hear," she said. "You did that in the shieling. I said they'd see the smoke."

"There's no smoke in this. There's no fire. There's just the wall, and the water, and me." He held out his hand. Not to take her. Palm up, the way you offer a thing and leave the taking to the other one. "Come out of the wet. However this ends, and it ends badly, our kind always ends badly, you don't have to stand in the rain to meet it."

She looked at his open hand a long moment, the way she had looked at it once on a warm stone with an unclosed half-inch of dark between them and not taken it.

Then she took it.

Her cold hand closed in his hot one. She held on. He turned and drew her in under the broken roof, out of the mist, into the loud dry dark, and behind them the falls went

on saying nothing, keeping every word, the way the fountain had.

* * *

She had built this a hundred ways on the road and it had gone wrong every one of them.

In the good version she came over a hill and there he was and the whole hard road fell off and she was in his arms without a step taken to get there, all of it easy, all of it deserved, the reward at the end of the walking. She had never believed the good version. She was not built to believe rewards. So she had built the other kinds too, harder and more likely: that he would not come, that he would come changed, that they would stand in front of each other with a war between them and find two strangers where the two people from the garden had been, and have nothing to say, and know it.

None of them was this. She had not built this, because she had not known how.

The fish-house was small and stank of old nets and the fall filled it wall to wall with sound. He had spread what he had in the dry corner, the folded dead-man's coat, a horse-blanket gone stiff with weather, not much, the poor camp of a man who owned nothing and had crossed a country. She stood in the middle of it dripping and looked at him in the grey light coming down through the broken slates, and checked the wear the road had put on him the way she checked a coin.

He was thinner. The bones of him stood up harder than they had. There was a whiteness in the hair over one ear that had not been there in the shieling, and a stillness in him that had. The loneliest weeks a man could live had gone into his face and set, and worn on him like a year. But the eyes that came up to her face were the same eyes, and they did to her

what they had done in the garden, which was to find her and not the use of her, not the witch, not the weapon, not the Queen's daughter, not the banner. A person standing in a room.

She had walked into a war for that look. She looked at it now across six feet of loud dark and understood she had not overpaid.

"You've gone grey over the ear," she said, because the plain thing was easier than the large one. "There. It suits you. You look like a thing that's been left out in the weather and improved by it."

"You've gone grey all over. You always were." His mouth did the thing it did. "It's the first thing I ever noticed about you. Silver in the moon on a woman sitting on a fountain who wouldn't tell me her name."

"You never asked for it."

"I told you I wouldn't."

"And you never did. Weeks of war and a country hunting me by the colour of my head, and the one man who'd earned the right to my name never reached out his hand for it." She crossed the small distance between them, one step, then another, into the heat that came off him, the dragon-heat she had lain a plank's width from in the shieling and gone starved of every day since. She stopped with a hand's breadth left. The unclosed half-inch. "Ask me now," she said. "I want to give you a thing no one made me give. I've handed over my name at knife-point and under a writ and to a whole square of the enemy to spite a tidy man. I have not once handed it to a person because I wanted them to have it. Ask me."

"What's your name," Korvan said, low, over the water.

"Amelia," she said. "It's Amelia. It's been Amelia the whole time you've been carrying me around with no word for me, and I have been carrying you the same way, and I am

tired of us being two people with no words for each other. My name is Amelia and I walked into a war to say it to your face."

He said it back to her. Just the once. He said her name the way you say a thing you have wanted a long time and been careful not to want out loud, and the sound of it in his mouth over the rush of the water did something to the backs of her knees that no touch had managed yet.

"We're not them," she said. "The two in the garden. I keep waiting to be them and we're not. They didn't touch. They sat a hand apart in the dark and felt the whole pull of it and did the sensible thing and got up and walked back into their separate cages, and they were right to, then, they had nothing yet and everything to lose. We're not them. We've got nothing left to lose but each other, and I am done being sensible, and I did not walk into a war to sit a hand apart from you in the dark and do the sensible thing again."

"No," he agreed. His voice had dropped. "We're not them."

"I want to be clear about what this is." She made herself say it plainly, over the water, with the cold measuring part of her standing to one side and watching her do it and, for once, not objecting. "This isn't the story where the two of them find each other at the end and it's all been worth it. Nothing's been worth it. My mother is a hundred miles off frightened for me and my friend is asleep behind a broken gate because she can't watch me do this, and a country is going to try to kill us both across that crossing before the week is out, and I know all of it, I've done the whole sum, it comes out terrible. I'm not choosing you because it comes out well. I'm choosing you because I did the sum and it comes out terrible and I want you anyway. That's the only kind of choosing I've got left. There's nothing prettier under it. Do you understand me?"

"I understand you," he said. "There's nothing prettier under mine either. My kind had traditions for this and my kind is me, one man. No elders, no rites, no word from anyone dead about how it's done. There's just what I decide. And I decided you on a cold mountain and I've decided you every day since, with nobody to tell me it was allowed." He lifted his hand and did not quite touch her face. "I haven't got anything to give you but the deciding. Nobody handed it down to me. I made it up out of nothing and I mean it more than anything anybody ever handed me."

"Good," Amelia said. "Then decide me. Out loud. Where I can hear it over the water."

"I choose you," Korvan said. "Eyes open. With the whole thing coming for us. I choose you."

She closed the half-inch.

* * *

She kissed him with none of the shieling's blind hunger in it. That first time she had crossed a fire half-starved and frozen, the two of them unproven, everything decided in the dark by two people too spent to lie about it. This was weeks on, and every week of it had felt like a year. This was a woman who had stood in a square and stopped six hearts and come up a war-road against the whole southward run of a fleeing country to reach him, and she kissed him like every mile of it, unhurried and certain, a thing settled somewhere far back and not up for argument.

"The shieling was me frozen half to death," she said against his jaw. Her cold fingers were already working the horn buttons of his shirt, quick and sure, no fumbling in them now. "I could barely feel my own hands. I have spent every day since furious that I did not get to do it properly. Take this off."

He got it off. Her palms came flat to the bare heat of him, and this time they did not stop at his chest. They went down, over the plane of his belly to the fastening of his breeches, and her cool clever hands freed him and closed around him, and the shock of her cold grip pulled a sound out of him he did not choose.

"There," she said, and there was a dark satisfaction low in it. "I have wanted the sounds. You gave me none worth keeping the first time. You held your breath the whole while like a man expecting a blow." She worked him slow in her fist, watching his face, learning what her hand did to him the way he had once learned her. "Not tonight. Tonight I want to hear all of it."

Then she pushed him down onto his back on the folded coat and the stiff blanket in the loud dark, and knelt over him with her silver hair falling loose around them both, and put her cold mouth to him.

She started at the root. She licked up the whole hot length of him, slow, one long stroke of her cold tongue from base to crown, watching his face the entire time to read what it did to him, and then did it again, unhurried, learning him the way he had once learned her, until his hands had closed on nothing and his breath had gone to gravel. Only then did she take the head of him into the cold wet of her mouth and close her lips around it and suck, and his hips came up off the floor before he could govern them. She pressed a flat cold palm to his belly and held him down, and took him deeper.

He got a hand into her silver hair. Not to push. Only to hold to something in a world that had come apart at the seams of itself. She took the hand for the surrender it was, and sank lower on him, taking more of him into her throat than he had thought she could. The head of him touched the back of it. She breathed hard through her nose and pushed

herself down past that, and he felt himself slide into the tight clench of her throat. It forced a small choked sound out of her. Her cold hands braced flat on his thighs. Still she did not come up.

"Amelia — " It came out wrecked. His fist tightened in her hair without his deciding it, and it did not pull her off him. It held her down, held her there with the whole of him buried in her, and she let him, her eyes lifting to his over the stretch of her cold mouth, wet and bright and fierce, watching him watch her take it. She stayed until she had to have air, her throat working around him, and only then dragged herself up off him, all the way off, with a rough wet gasp, hauling breath back into herself, her lips swollen and her chin slick and something like triumph burning in her face.

"There," she got out, hoarse, wiping the back of her cold hand across her mouth. "That's a sound worth keeping." And went straight back down before he could get a word out. She licked the length of him where it was slick now from her, and took the root of him in her cold fist and worked it while her tongue and her lips worked the head, deep then shallow then deep again, in no hurry at all. She read him by every broken sound she pulled out of him and used each one against him. A woman doing a thing she had decided on a long way off, and meant to do to its end.

He let her have it far longer than was wise. She took him to the trembling edge of it with her cold hand and her hot mouth and her eyes on his face, and when he felt it start to go he reached down and stilled her by the jaw, shaking, barely holding.

"Stop — Amelia — if you keep on I'm finished, and I am not spending all that wanting into your mouth in the first hour of you."

She lifted her head, slow, and the look she gave him was pure dark satisfaction, her voice gone rough from the use of

it. "Noted," she said. "For later. I mean to have that too before this is over. But not yet." She sat back on her heels over him. "I've had my mouth on you. Now I want the rest, and I mean to take it my own way."

* * *

She sat back and drew the wet shift up over her own head and threw it into the dark, and the grey light off the broken slates fell on the whole cold length of her, silver and pale, the old faded scald low on her ribs he had learned by hand in the shieling and never asked after. He reached for her, and she let him: let him put his hot mouth to her cold breast and draw the peak of it up hard until she made a sound, let him take the weight of both in his broad hands and roll her nipples under his thumbs, but only for a moment, because she had said her own way and she meant it. She caught his wrists and set his hands down flat on the blanket where she wanted them, and rose up over him, and reached down between them to take him in her cold hand and hold the head of him against herself.

She was soaked, the one warm place on all her cold body, and he could feel the heat of her hovering over him, not taking him, only holding him there against the slick open heat of her, and she looked down the length of his body at him with the cold measuring light in her eyes gone entirely to want, and made him wait for it.

Then she sank down.

She did it slowly. So slowly it near killed him. Down she came, taking him into her by inches, the thick of him a little at a time, her cold thighs shaking with the care of it, her breath going out of her in one long unsteady sound as the stretch of him opened her, and she did not hurry it and she did not once look away from his face. He lay under her with his hands fisted in the blanket where she had put them, and

let her have the whole of it in her own keeping. He felt every inch of her take him. Felt her body give around him, tight and slick and gripping, closing hot down the length of him, until she had seated the whole of him inside her and sat flush against his hips with a low broken sound of pure want. Her head went back. Her silver hair fell down the pale line of her spine.

She held there a moment, only to feel him in her, filled and stretched and finally, after all of it, not a plank's width away. "There," she breathed. "There. God, the feel of you." She rolled her hips once, learning the drag of him inside her, and shuddered at what it did, and did it again, slower, taking her own pleasure from the fit of him. "I have wanted this in me since the shieling and told myself I didn't. I am done lying about it." She set her cold hands flat to his chest, over the hard fast knock of his heart, and began to ride him in earnest.

He set his big hands on her hips and let her have it, and letting her have him was its own undoing. She worked herself on him at exactly the pace she chose and no faster, silver hair wild, the cold gone out of her skin at last and a flush come up in its place. He slid his broad hands up off her hips to her breasts, took the cold weight of them in his palms, and worked the stiff peaks of her nipples under his thumbs in time with the roll of her hips. She arched into his hands and rode him harder for it. She got a cold hand down between them to the swollen bud of her where they were joined and set her own rhythm on it. He watched the count go out of her eyes and the whole hunted governed run of it fall off her. When she came it was with her head thrown back and her cold body clenching down the length of him, and a cry the falls did not quite take. He held still under her and let her ride out every pulse of it on him, and did not let himself go with her, held by the one leash that had never slipped.

She came down over him, gasping, loose, past the last of her governing, and let herself be held a moment. But he was nowhere near finished, and neither, he found, was she. She was still moving on him in small helpless rolls of her hips, chasing more of him even now. So he sat up under her with the whole strength of his back, still buried inside her, got his arms around her cold body, and turned her.

He laid her forward onto her hands and knees on the folded coat, silver head down, her cold spine a long pale curve in the grey light, and knelt behind her and took her by the hips and drove back into her to the root, and the angle took him deeper than she had let him go on top, and the cry it dragged out of her went up into the thunder of the falls and was lost. There was nothing careful left anywhere in him now. He had promised himself on the crag he would be gentle and he broke the promise clean. He gripped her hips in both broad hands and pulled her back onto him as he drove forward, hard, the wet crack of him against her filling the corner under the water's roar, her breasts swinging with the rhythm of it, and she braced her cold arms against the floor and shoved herself back to meet every stroke and told him the plain filthy truth of what she wanted. "Harder, like that, don't you dare go easy on me now — " the cold measured woman gone all to heat, low words she had never in her life said to anyone, and he gave her exactly that and a degree past it, reading her by the sounds and the arch of her back.

He gathered a fistful of her silver hair and drew her head up, not rough, and got his other hand down between her legs to the slick swollen bud of her and worked it in time with his driving. She broke apart a second time, loud, clenching down around him so hard that the leash finally went. All of

it. The last inch he had held every hour since the shieling. He drove deep and spilled inside her, the whole vast dangerous weight of him gone loose at the end into the only hands ever made to take it. None of the dragon anywhere in it. Only the man, emptied out and shaking, folded down over her cold back with his mouth at her nape saying her name.

He gathered her down with him onto the blanket, still joined, both arms around her from behind, and held her there while the last of it went through the two of them. After a while she turned in his arms to face him and curled along the heat of him, and for once she did not read the heart under her cheek for whether it was a man's or a dragon's. She only lay against him, spent, and let the water cover the pair of them.

"There," she said, into his throat, and there was a rough laugh under it. "That is the man I came a hundred miles for. Not the careful one. That one."

For a while neither of them moved, and that was the strangest part of it. In the shieling there had been a scrape of stone in the fold and a road at their backs, and they had taken what warmth they could like two people robbing a house they had to be clear of by dawn, half of each of them still standing watch. There was none of that in him now. All of it was on the far side of this. The hunted mile was behind. Here in the last dry corner before the crossing there was, for one hour, nothing at all to answer to, and he had never believed the after could feel like this. He lay with the cold length of her tucked against him and found his hands with nothing to hold shut and nowhere to be, and did not know what to do with the quiet except keep still inside it and let it go on being true.

* * *

After a while she shifted up and set her cheek on his chest, over the place the human heart went, and lay in the heat of him and let it come into her. She was always cold. She had been cold her whole life, a cold that owed nothing to weather, the cold of a thing kept apart and told the keeping was a kindness. He ran hotter than anything else alive, and she lay in it now and felt the cold give ground by degrees, further back than it had ever gone, into some middle of her that had not once been warm in nineteen years. His heart went too fast under her ear. She lay and felt it hurry, and let the warmth it spent itself to make soak all the way through her, and for the length of that hour asked nothing of it but that it keep going.

The falls went on. The grey light came a little stronger through the broken slates. Out past the broken gate Maren kept a watch she would never speak of, and further out the two nets were still closing, the silver-hunt and the whale-iron crews who had worked out that the dragon had to be a man for the hours between. Amelia did not name them. She knew the sum. It had not changed on the road and it did not change now. She did the smaller arithmetic instead, the one that would still come out clean, which was the count of his heart under her ear, quick, quicker than a resting man's should be, and not slowing.

"Your heart's still too fast," she said. "You told me in the shieling it had been quick since the banquet and you'd stopped expecting it to slow. It hasn't. You'll wear it out."

"I've stopped worrying about wearing it out," he said. "There's worse ways for it to go than fast. I'll take fast." His hand moved once over her silver hair. "Amelia."

"You keep saying it."

"A year of having no word for you. I'm making up for lost ground." She felt his mouth curve against the top of her head. "You'll get sick of it, and then I'm going to say it more."

"I won't get sick of it." She was quiet a moment, her hand flat on the drum of his heart, not to still it, only to feel it go. "In the garden you told me you'd swim, if the shape ever came. That you'd loved the water as a boy. I said I hoped it was something that swam. And you got the sky instead." She turned her head and looked at the water going down the black rock past the broken doorway, three long white drops of it, more water than either of them had ever stood beside. "It was a cruel wish, as it turned out. I wished you the wrong element."

"You wished me a thing that had no cage in it." He said it into her hair. "Sky's got no walls. It was the right wish. I got the one thing on this earth nobody can shut a door on. It's just that I got it alone." His arm tightened round her. "I'm not alone this morning. So I'll not call the wish cruel."

She lay in the great warmth of him and gave him no answer, because any answer would have shrunk the thing in the saying of it, and because for the first time in a life built on counting she had run clean out of things that needed a number.

But she was Amelia, and she did the last of it anyway, the once, before she let it go. The old sum. The one she had started in a shieling with a new term in it and never finished. She turned it over with her cheek on his too-quick heart. *He will get you killed. He is the only one who stayed.* Both still true. Neither cancelling the other.

And she found, this morning, that she no longer needed them to.

She set the sum down the way you set down a tool you have finished with, and did not pick it up again.

"Two miles east," she said at last, "the crossing. And the whole country come to decide the thing on both sides of it. You know that better than I do. You've flown over it."

"I have." His hand went still on her hair. "It's the biggest gathering of men I've ever seen. Both hosts, drawn up either side of the falls, waiting on the word. It'll come in a day. Two." He was quiet. "We can't stay in here, Amelia. Not past tonight. This is the calm bit. It's the last of it. After this there's no more warm dry corners with the water covering everything."

"I know." She sat up, out of his heat, into the grey chill of the ruined room, and reached for her shift where it lay on the stiff blanket, and did not hurry, because there was one more hour of the calm yet and she meant to spend all of it. She looked down at him, the enormous careful dangerous man she had decided on with nothing to inherit the deciding from, lying in a poor camp at the edge of a war with his heart still going too fast. "So we've got today," she said. "The two of us, and today, and the water. And then tomorrow we walk east into the middle of it, on our own terms, together, because there's nowhere else left that isn't apart." She pulled the shift over her head. "It's not much of a plan. It's the first one I ever made that had you in it. I find I don't mind how it comes out."

Outside, past the broken gate, past the black rock and the three falling drops of the Elver, the eastern sky over the crossing had begun to go the colour of a coming fire, and it was not the light this time. It was the light and the thing under it, both, coming up together the way they always would now, for the rest of whatever they had. She stood in the doorway of the fish-house and looked east at it, the war and the morning, and did not count either one.

Behind her Korvan got to his feet, and came and stood at her cold shoulder in the loud grey dawn, and looked east with her, toward the falls and the crossing and the whole waiting country, toward the one direction there was left to walk, which was into it, together, and not apart.

The hour was coming. They could both feel it, the way you feel weather.

They went back inside, out of the wet, and shut the last of the calm around them, and spent it.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

Outlasted (I)

They settled it in the last of the dark, and it took nine words.

"You're the seen one," Amelia said. "I'm the unseen. We swap."

He had known it was coming since the fish-house. He had lain awake in the loud grey with her cold weight against him and done her kind of arithmetic against his own grain, and it had come out the one way, and he had hated the answer the whole night the way she must have hated hers on the shelf above the ford. Now she said it plain in the doorway with the falls going down black behind her, and there was nothing in him left to argue it with.

"Say the rest," he said. "So I've heard you say it. Not just worked it out."

"You go up." Her voice had gone to the river-flat register, the cold clear one, the one that cost her most when she used it soft. "Over the crossing, in the open, in daylight, the loudest thing in the sky. Every eye on both banks goes to you. Every iron they've laid for a dragon comes off the ground and points at you, because a dragon in the air is worth two fortunes and a girl in a hood is worth nothing they can find. You draw the whole of Loric's net up off the ground and onto yourself. And you keep it there. You don't win anything. You don't burn the war down. You hang up there and take it and take it and be the thing they cannot stop

looking at, for as long as your body will let you, and longer." She stopped. "And while every set of eyes in the country is turned up at you, I walk across the ground under it to the one man the whole thing hangs on, and I take him off the board, the way I took six hearts in a square. Unseen. The dark thing that goes under the hunt and comes up where it means to. That was your part a week ago. Now it's mine."

"And I'm the loud shape."

"You're the loud shape." She laid her cold palm over the quick hard beat of his heart, the way she read a coin. Not to gentle it. To weigh it. "It's a man's, still. Good. I need it a man's for the length of this, because a dragon can't hate a plan and do it anyway, and I need you to. I need you to go up and be shot and not come down to anyone. No matter who. No matter what you see under you. You come down for one soul and the net comes off me and onto that soul and we lose it all. You've done this to me. You know the shape of it. Now I'm the one asking."

He had done it to her. On the shelf above the ford she had knelt in a foot of water with a bolt in her leg and waved him on with both arms. She had traded herself down to a purse and thrown him up into the empty sky so he would live. He had flown, and hated every beat of it. Now she handed it back to him, the same coin, and it was heavier coming than it had been going.

"Selwyn's down there," he said. It came out before he could stop it. "My father's host. He'll be at the crossing. If it goes to the water he'll be in the front of it, because that's where the fool puts himself, telling everyone round him it's the sensible spot."

"I know," she said. "That's the price of the seen door. You'll be able to see everything and reach none of it. That's the whole of it, Korvan. That's what up costs. I paid it on a rock. Now it's yours."

He looked at her a long moment in the grey. Then he said the thing that had been sitting in him since the folds, the thing he had not put words to even for her.

"It's my father's door," he said. "The one I spent the whole war telling him was cowardice. Don't spend what you'll pay interest on. Hold still and take it and stay alive to fight later. Every step of that mountain I told him a man ought to act, not endure. And now the only way to do the acting is to go up and endure the whole war onto my own back so you can be the one who acts." He heard himself, rough. "I'm about to do his exact thing on purpose, in front of both hosts, and it isn't surrender this time. It's the sharpest weapon I've got. Turns out he was right about the door. He was only ever wrong about what you use it for."

"Then use it," Amelia said.

She went up on her toes and kissed him once, hard and brief, a thing decided and not lingered over.

"Come back down a man," she said, low, at the corner of his mouth. "When it's done. I've decided I want a great deal more of you and I'll be very put out if you die being noble. Now go and be a fool where the whole country can watch you do it, and let me be the quiet one for once."

She stepped back off him into the dark, hood up, hands in her sleeves, already gone smaller than a woman standing there had any right to go. And Korvan turned east, into the greying, toward the falls and the crossing and the country that lay waiting to decide itself. He let the cold come into him. He found the deep turn under his breastbone and raised it by his own will.

* * *

The word came at midmorning, and it was not a trumpet.

He had it from above by then, hung high and dark in the grey over the falls, a shape no one had yet looked up to find.

Below him the whole valley lay open the way nothing lay open to a man on the ground. Two hosts, drawn up on the two banks of the Elver where it broke over its black steps of rock and threw its roar off the two gorge walls. His father's host on the west bank, four thousand, the horse-lines and the picket-fires and the wagons drawn up dark behind. Over the middle of it the banner hung lit from below, the witch and the dragon painted on the cloth. And across the water the Crown host, more than his father's, near twice it, a town of steel laid along the shore with the King's standards hanging limp, no wind in the grey to lift them.

Between them the crossing. Above the falls the water ran shallow across the shelf, the poor man's ford, the driven-out's road. It was the one place a man could put his feet across. So it was there the two hosts would have to meet. Both of them knew it. Both had drawn up to hold it or take it.

The word came as a single grey banner dropping on the far bank.

Then the whole east side of the river began to move.

He watched the front ranks of the Crown host come down off their line toward the shelf. Not fast. A wall coming on at a walk, shields up. He watched his father's host stir and set to meet them at the water. For one long breath nothing had happened yet, the two of them only coming on, and he understood he was watching the last moment before the thing became what it was going to be. He had time to think one clear thing in that breath. He thought: nobody down there has looked up yet. And then the two walls came into the thin water from either side and met in the middle of it, and the crossing became the thing, and the roar of the falls could not cover the other sound that came up off it.

He did not go down into that. That was not his to do. He was the loud shape, and the loud shape's whole work was to

be looked at, so he did the one thing that would turn every face on both banks up off the water and onto the sky.

He came down the grey air toward the falls, low and slow and full in the open, and let out the whole of his voice.

It was not a roar he chose. It came up out of the great chest the way the shift came, without his leave, a sound the man in him had never made and the animal had always known, and it went out over the two hosts and off the two rock walls and came back doubled, and under it, for one instant, the whole war stopped.

He saw it stop. Four thousand faces on the west bank and eight thousand on the east went up off the killing all at once, every one of them, the way a field of grass goes over in a wind. The front ranks in the water faltered with their blades half-swung. And on the painted banner below, the thing came true above their heads, the dragon out of the songs and the lie made real over the very war raised to stand in for it. He heard the sound that ran through both hosts when they understood the cloth had not been a cloth.

And along the east bank, at four places he had already marked from the dark, the whale-iron frames came round.

* * *

He had counted them from above in the last of the night, because that was the one gift the height gave and he had learned to spend it. Four frames. Long dark ship's gear dragged up from some coast on carts, set on the high ground behind the Crown host's line, barbed irons the length of a leg on coils of tarred line, windlasses cranked and locked. They were not laid for the war on the water. They were laid for him. They had always been laid for him. That was the whole of Loric's second net. Crews who watched the dark of the moon and worked out that the thing on the banner had to come down out of the sky to do its work. They had dragged

the coast's own gear a hundred miles inland to rope the one thing that could fly.

He came at them.

He did not come at them to win. He had promised her that, and promised himself. The animal did not want to keep either promise. It wanted to go down over the frames and burn them to slag and open its throat at the small men working them. He held it by main force, the way she had taught him without ever meaning to. Four frames burned meant four dives close to the ground. And down close to the ground the fifth thing they had, the thing he could not see yet, would put its iron in him and finish it. He was not here to end the frames. He was here to be the thing the frames pointed at. So he came down the sky low and full and slow, an easy shot, the easiest shot the coast had ever laid a windlass for. He gave the whole Crown host the dragon it had been promised. Every eye and every iron came up onto him and stayed.

The first frame loosed.

He heard it before he felt it, the flat wet slam of the windlass letting go, and he beat once and rolled the great body up off the line of it, and the barb went by the underside of a wing close enough that the wind of it moved the membrane, and the line ran out and out and fell spent into the gorge below with a snap he felt in his teeth. Short. She had had the reach of the thing from four seconds of looking at it above a ford, and it had not grown since. He came round over the falls with the line trailing back off the frame, and the crew on it were already cranking, fast, faces up, and he gave them his slow underside again on the turn, and let the second frame have him too.

It caught.

He felt it go in.

There was no part of the man ready for it. The barb went into the great muscle over his flank where a man had no muscle, low and to the left of the spine, and it turned and set. The pain of it was not a man's pain. It was the size of the body it was in. It whited the whole grey sky out for a beat. He lost the air and dropped a hundred feet before the wings remembered themselves. Then the line came taut off the frame and hauled. He felt for the first and only time what the coast's gear was built to do, which was to sink a rope into a living animal larger than a house and drag it down out of its element by main strength. Hauled sideways toward the east bank with the iron grinding in his flank, he understood exactly what the whale hears in the last of it.

He did the one thing there was.

He turned into the pull instead of against it. That much he had learned on a green mountain with a rope and a bolting horse. A thing stronger than you does not get pulled straight. It gets turned. He turned the whole vast weight of himself back along the line toward the frame that held him, and the sudden slack of it fouled the crew's crank. He came down the tarred line at them out of the grey with the barb yet in his flank. He did the thing he had promised not to do, once, because once was survival and not victory.

He let the fire come.

He had held opinions about fire his whole life. For years he had stood at other men's cressets and told them a green stick spits and fights you, and a seasoned one takes the flame clean and gives it back as heat, and been proud of knowing it, the one craft his withholding body had let him have. In one breath over the crossing he learned he had known nothing about fire at all. What came up out of the great chest and out between his teeth was not a thing with opinions in it. It went down the tarred line and took the frame and the windlass and the four men working it, all in

the same instant. The line went up its whole length like a fuse. The seasoned oak of the frame took the flame clean the way he had always said seasoned wood does, and gave it back as heat. The men did not give anything back at all. They were there and then they were a shape in the fire and then they were not a shape. He felt the line go slack as it burned through. The barb tore free of his flank as the weight came off it, and the pain of the tearing was worse than the pain of the going in. He took it. Then he beat up off the bank into the grey, the fire falling away below him, the smell of the frame and the men coming up after him on the heat.

One frame. Three left. And he had spent a dive down low to do it, and taken an iron to do it, and it had bought the whole Crown host a clear picture of what the dragon could do to a thing that would not move under it.

Every remaining crew turned their crank faster.

Good, he thought, through the grinding wet ruin in his flank. Look up. Keep looking up. Crank your irons and forget the ground.

He climbed, trailing his own blood on the air, and made himself the shape they could not stop watching.

* * *

He found her once from up there.

He should not have looked. Looking down for her was the one thing that could unmake the whole of it, because if he found her small under the war the way she had found herself small under his wings, he was not sure the leash would hold, and the leash was all there was between the plan and four frames' worth of ruin. But the animal's eye went where the man's want sent it, once, between one climbing beat and the next, down off the burning bank and across the churn of the crossing to the ground behind the Crown host's line, and it found her.

A hooded shape, moving the wrong way through a host that was all facing the sky.

She went through them like water finds the drain. Every soldier in the Crown host had his face turned up at the dragon. One small hooded thing walked among them the other way, unhurried, hands in her sleeves. Where a man stood in her road he went down into the churned mud with no mark on him and no sound anyone caught over the roar. She stepped past him and went on. Up toward the rise behind the line, toward the one still point in the whole moving host, a knot of standards and quiet men where the war was being run and not fought. She was the quiet one now. She moved between the fires. She had made him the loud shape so that she could come up where she chose, at the hour she chose, unseen the whole way. It was working. And the working of it was the most frightening thing he had watched from above since she had let a hunter walk her south off a rock rather than spend the blood to be free.

He tore his eye off her. He climbed, and gave the frames his belly again.

He did not look down for her a second time. He had learned that from a hard master too, that you did not reach for the wanted thing before the hour you could close your hand on it for good, and the hour was not yet, and reaching now would only cost her the one thing he had gone up to buy.

* * *

The second iron went into his wing.

He did not roll fast enough on the third frame's shot. They had learned his last pass and led him this time, aimed where he was going and not where he was. The barb went through the great membrane between two of the long finger-bones near the trailing edge. The flank had been

muscle and pain. This was a sail with a hole torn in it. And a sail with a hole in it does not hold the air.

He fell.

It was not the clean drop of before. This was a wing folding on one side because it could not do its work. The great body slewed over onto the ruined side and went down toward the gorge in a long tearing spiral. The line came taut off the frame and hauled. This time there was no turning into it. He could not fly straight enough to turn anything. He went down toward the black rock below the falls with an iron through his wing and a rope on it and a crew hauling. And thin under the roar of the water and the roar of the war, he heard the sound the whole Crown host made when it saw the dragon start to come down.

That was the sound they had paid for. That was the sound Loric had brought the coast's gear a hundred miles inland to buy. The dragon out of the songs, dragged down out of the sky in sight of both hosts, come to die where the poor crossed. The terror out of the story ended in a foot of water for the whole country to carry home in its mouth.

And in the falling, it came.

Not the warm one. Not the falling one. The old cold memory, the smallest and the deepest, up out of the black under a mountain. A few of them folded down in the long dark while the ridges burned. Holding still. Not rising to be numbered among the dead. And then, on the blindest nights, moving. Out across the emptied land from one deep hole to the next, through the whole red length of the hunt, and up alive on the far side where no fire looked.

Then it was gone, and left him falling, with the one thing in it that was not grief.

Some of them had lived by never letting the sky have them.

He stopped falling.

He did it the way the old ones had done the thing they did, not by being stronger than the pull but by refusing the shape the pull wanted him in. He quit fighting for the height he could not hold on a torn wing. He gave the pull the falling it wanted, and turned the falling into a thing of his own, down the line at the frame the way he had before, all his vast dropping weight coming back along the rope at the men who held it. They saw it coming. Some of them let go of the crank and ran, and it did them no good. He came down on the frame and the high ground behind it, not as a dive but as a fall he had taken the ownership of, and he loosed the fire on the way down. The third frame and its crew and a good part of the Crown host's high line went up in it.

He came down hard on the east bank in the wreck of it, in a foot of the thin water at the head of the shelf, a dragon down at the crossing exactly where Loric had paid for a dragon to be down, and the pain of the landing on the torn wing and the flank drove the sight half out of him. But he was not dying in a foot of water for the crowd. He was down on purpose now, the way the old ones went to ground on purpose, and being down among the Crown line put him in under the whale-iron and off the reach of the two frames left, which could not shoot into their own men. He had turned the bringing-low into the going-to-ground. He held still in the wreck and the water with two irons in him and the whole Crown host recoiling from the heat, and he did not die, and he did not stop, and the not-stopping was the whole of the weapon.

Survive the thing. Take it and take it and stay alive to fight later. His father's door, come up in him at last as the sharpest edge he owned.

He had bought her the high ground. He had cleared her a road to the high knot through fire and recoil. Now she had to walk it. He had to keep the two live frames looking at him

and not at her, and the only way left to do that was to be a dragon down and hurt and not finished in the middle of their line. That was the loudest thing in the whole country. He was that, and he made himself go on being it.

* * *

He found Selwyn by accident, the way you find the worst things.

The recoil of the Crown line had opened the crossing for a breath, and into the open breath his father's host had come on across the shelf, driving for the ground the dragon had cleared. And among the front of them, where the fool always put himself, telling the men to either side that the middle was the safe place because the two ends get flanked, was a shape Korvan knew before the head would say the name. He knew the set of the shoulders. He knew the way the man went forward half a step ahead of his own courage and then made his body catch up to it. Selwyn. In the front of the water, coming on toward the wreck and the heat and the downed dragon, into the very ground Korvan had cleared. Selwyn had said all along that he would go where Korvan went. Here at last was Korvan, down and burning in the middle of a war. And the fool was coming to him.

Korvan could not speak to him. There was no mouth in him for words, and the roar would have taken them, and Selwyn did not know the thing in the wreck was his friend. To the men around him he was only a clansman going forward into a gap, obeying the plain sense he mistook for wisdom. He came on across the thin water toward the downed dragon he thought was the enemy, blade up, saying something to the men beside him. Korvan could not hear it and did not need to. The shape of it was plain enough on the mouth. Here's the thing, Selwyn was saying. Here's the thing about a downed one.

The fourth frame, the one nearest, could not shoot into its own recoiling line. But its crew had not run. They swung the long iron off the sky and down, flat, along the crossing, into the press of the shifter host coming across the shelf. A whale-iron cast flat into a mass of men on foot does a thing no bow does. Korvan saw them swing it. He saw the line of the cast and where the barb would go before it went. There was nothing in the whole vast body he could do about it. To move was to leave the two frames a clear shot at the ground behind him, where a hooded shape was climbing the high line toward the quiet centre of the host.

He held still.

He held still and watched the fourth frame put its iron flat across the crossing into the front of his father's host, and he watched it take Selwyn off his feet.

It did not go into him clean. The thing was not built to go into a man clean. It caught him across the body on the flat of its length and the barb of it, and took him back and down into the churned red water of the shelf. The men to either side of him went too. The tarred line hauled once and dragged the whole tangle of them a yard through the water before the crew saw it had fouled on flesh and not on a dragon, and quit cranking. Korvan saw Selwyn go under the surface of the thin water and not come straight up. A hand came up out of it, once, the way a hand comes up reaching for the thing that steadies you. There was no such thing to reach. The thing that steadied him was a dragon forty feet off, holding itself still on purpose so that a girl could climb a hill unseen.

He did not go to him.

That was the anchor of the whole day, the thing he would carry into whatever was left to him. He held the great body still in the wreck and the water, both barbs still buried in him. He watched his one friend go down in a foot of the poor

man's ford, reaching up for a hand. And he did not reach the hand down. Amelia was a hundred feet up the far slope now with the high knot in front of her. The two live frames would take her the instant the dragon stopped being the loudest thing in the country. One soul was not the sum. One soul was never the sum. The man who taught him that had four thousand behind him, and had walked through this exact door his whole life, and hated it every step, and been right.

He held still. He let his friend go down. He was the loud shape, and the loud shape does not come down for one soul. She had done it on a rock above a ford. Now he did it in the middle of a war. It was the worst thing his body had ever been asked to keep from doing, and he kept from doing it.

Selwyn's hand went back under the water and did not come up again that Korvan saw.

* * *

He did not know if the fool was dead.

He would carry that too, into whatever came, the not-knowing, the same not-knowing she had carried away from the shelf about him. A downed man in a foot of water in the churn of two hosts might be dead and might be dragged clear by the men beside him and might be lying stunned with the water over his face waiting for a hand. Korvan had no way to know and no leave to find out, and the not-knowing was its own iron, in deeper than the two in his flesh, and it would not tear free with the weight coming off it.

He lifted the great ruined body up out of the wreck.

He could not fly. The torn wing would not hold air and the flank was a grinding ruin and the fire was banked low in him now, spent down close to the coals. But a dragon that cannot fly is yet the largest and loudest thing in a country, and there was a use in that, the last use, and he meant to spend it all. He dragged himself up out of the water onto the high ground

the fire had cleared, into the middle of the Crown host's broken line, on purpose, huge and burning and dying and not dead, and he made himself the one thing on the whole field that no man on either bank could look away from. The two live frames swung onto him. Let them. Every iron they put in him now was an iron not turned on the hooded shape going up the last of the slope to the high knot where the standards hung and the quiet men stood and the man who had made the whole war waited, not knowing yet that the war was walking up his own hill toward him with its hands in its sleeves.

He looked, the second time, and last.

He found her at the top of the slope. She had reached the still point. The knot of standards, the quiet men. And at the middle of them one man who had no blade drawn and needed none. A not-big man who stood easy in the wreck of his own line, empty hands open at his sides. His face was not turned up at the dragon like every other face in the country. It was turned level, on the small hooded thing that had come up his hill through his whole host to stand an arm's length off. Loric had not looked up at the dragon at all. He had known the dragon was the loud shape. He had always known. He was the one man on the field who had done Amelia's own sum, and come up looking for the quiet one. And here she was.

Korvan was a hundred feet down the slope, a dragon down and burning and out of fire and out of flight, with two irons in him and two frames swinging onto him, and there was not one thing left in the whole vast dying body that could cross those hundred feet in time to stand between her and the man with the open hands.

He had spent everything he had to put her there. And now that she was there, at the one still point the whole war turned on, an arm's length from the man who had made

every death of it, Korvan could do nothing at all. Nothing but hold the field's eyes on himself for one more breath, and one more. And watch, from a hundred feet down a slope, the two of them face each other in the middle of a stopped war.

The falls went on. The two live frames cranked.

And Amelia put back her hood.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

Outlasted (II)

"There she is," Loric said.

The falls put the rest of it down under the roar and gave her only the shape of the words on his mouth, the way the fountain had done in the garden a hundred years ago. She understood the whole of it in that first breath. Whatever passed up here would pass between the two of them alone, because the water took everything else, and no man in the standing knot around him would hear a word of it. She had wanted, once, to be heard across a bright room. She would take this instead. A place where only the person in front of her could hear her speak at all.

She counted the knot while he looked at her. It was the thing her body did when there was too much and no room to hold it, and she let it. Six standards, hung dead in the windless grey. Nine quiet men, the kind who ran a war off a folding table and never put a hand to a blade. Loric in the middle of them with his hands open and empty at his sides, exactly as he had stood on the boards at Dunmoor, a man you would hand your coat to and never think of again.

Then she counted past him, and stopped counting.

Her mother was there.

She was standing at the near edge of the knot in a grey travelling cloak that was not a Queen's, with two of the quiet men close at her elbows and no crown on her at all, and she

was not looking at Loric, and she was not looking at the war, and she was not looking at the dragon down the slope that every other face in the country was turned up to find. She was looking at Amelia. She had come to the front. The mother who had spent all of it trying to fold her daughter back into a safe dark had walked out of the safe dark herself, into the open, into the loudest and most dangerous ground in the country, because the girl was on it. Amelia read the whole reason of it off her mother's face in one look and had no time to do anything with it.

And at her mother's shoulder, one step back, in a servant's grey, holding herself very still against a war she had no business standing in, was Maren.

Maren had not stayed in the low country. Amelia had woken at the fish-house on the last morning to a cold place at the gate where a second shape had stood the night before, and had known, without a word left behind, where it had gone. The word had come down the coast that the Queen herself had ridden to the head of the war to find her lost daughter, and once it had, there was no holding Maren in the low country a day longer. Maren had gone to the Queen. Of course she had. She had spent a life walking toward the thing she was most afraid of when someone she loved was inside it, and she had walked up into the enemy's own high command to put herself at the Queen's shoulder, because that was the only grammar she owned. The two of them stood together at the top of the hill, the woman who had made Amelia and the woman who had raised her, in the one place in the whole grey country Amelia would have died to keep them out of.

"You shouldn't be here," Amelia said. She said it to both of them. Her voice had gone flat and even, the river-flat register, and it cost her nothing to hold it now, because there was nothing left in her to spend on holding it.

"You could still turn round," Loric said, close, mild, only for her under the roar. He held his open hands a little wider, the man who only offered. "No one on this hill would stop you. I'd see to it. You've done enough today to do my work in every town to the sea. You don't have to be here for the rest."

She did not answer him. She had answered him once, in a square, with a name he had let slide off, and she had learned there that the man could not be argued and could not be moved and would stand mild in the wreck of anything and ask you a reasonable question. So she gave him the one thing he had no use for. She gave him her silence, and kept her eyes on her mother, and did not spend a word.

Her mother took a step toward her, past the quiet man's arm, and her mouth opened on a word that was going to be her daughter's name.

* * *

The frame loosed down the slope.

Amelia did not see it as a thing that happened to her mother. She saw it first as work. The two live frames Korvan had left cranking had swung up off the sky and onto the broken high line, flat, the last cast of a crew that had lost their dragon into the wreck below and would put their iron into whatever moved. She heard the wet slam of the windlass letting go under the roar of the water, one flat clean note, and she knew the reach of the thing because she had known its reach from four seconds of looking at one above a ford. Where the cast would go, she had already read before it went. There was a great deal she could do to a man in the space of that knowledge. She could find the warm knot of his heart and slide it still. She could not stop a length of barbed iron in the air. It was not a heart. It had no time in it to hold or let go. It was only weight, coming, and she had no power over weight at all.

She had time to move three steps and she moved none of them, because there was no step that reached them in time, and her body, which counted everything, had already worked it out and would not spend itself on a thing that came to nothing.

The cast went flat across the crown of the hill.

She turned her head.

That was all. She turned her head so that she would not watch it, and the falls took the sound, and when she turned back the two of them were down.

* * *

Loric made a sound.

She heard it because she was close enough, under the roar, one arm's length. It was not a word. The courtesy came off him all at once, the whole tidy front of the man, and for the length of one breath there was something under it she had not seen on him at Dunmoor or in the garden or anywhere, something that had been kept in a locked place for a very long time and had just been shown the door standing open on nothing.

"No," he said. Only that. And then, lower, to himself, in a voice with the years in it, "She never even—"

He stopped himself in the middle of it. She watched him do it. She watched the door go shut on whatever the rest of the sentence was, and the tidy man come back up over the top of it, smooth, the coat-holder, the one who only asked. It took him less than a breath to bury it. But she had seen the size of the thing before he got it back under, and she would carry that too, into whatever was left to her, though she did not yet have the room to understand it.

She had already turned away from him. She went up the last of the hill to the two of them on the ground.

Her mother was not going to get up.

Amelia knelt in the churned grass and put her hand flat on her mother's chest, over the place where a heart kept its time, the way her mother had taught her a hundred quiet mornings while the household slept, and she found it. It was there. It was fast and it was wrong and it was going, and she reached for it with the cold thing that had waked low in her wrists, not to still it this time but to do what she had done for a bleeding child on a refugee road, to hold a torn thing shut and tell the blood to stay. She told it to stay. She put the whole of her will into telling it to stay.

It would not stay.

There was too much gone and too much open, and the reach she had was built to hold a single vessel closed against the tide, not to keep a body that a war had opened. She felt the difference the way she felt the difference between a room that would carry a voice and one that would swallow it. Some things her power could do. This was not one of them. She had spent her whole life believing the blood was a great and terrible force she had to hold shut with both hands, and here at the one place she would have flooded the world to save, it was a small thing, and small was not enough, and there was nothing in it that reached far enough to matter.

Her mother's hand came up and found her face.

"There you are," her mother said. The imperial register was gone. There was only the warm one, the unguarded one, the voice she had never in her life used to the world and had always used to her daughter. Her eyes moved over Amelia's face the way they had moved over it every morning of the caged years, taking inventory, making sure of her. "You got taller. When did you—" She lost the thread of it and found a

smaller one. "You're cold. You're always cold. I never could keep you warm."

"I'm warm," Amelia said. "I'm warm. I promise."

She was aware, distantly, the way she was aware of the falls, that Loric was standing at the edge of her seeing, close enough to hear if the water had let him, and that her mother had not looked at him. Not when she fell. Not now. Her mother's whole attention was on the girl's face and nowhere else in the world, and the man who had spent a lifetime building a war to be seen by her was standing an arm's length off and had not earned one glance. Amelia held that fact for a half-second and set it down. It was not for now. Her mother was dying, and there was a name in Amelia's mouth, the name she had thrown into a square at Dunmoor, the whole true reason of everything, and she did not say it. You did not hand your dying mother the architecture of why. You gave her the warm thing. She gave her the warm thing.

"Do you remember the almond cakes," Amelia said. "The ones the cook sent up before the hall. Warm. Out of order."

Her mother's face moved. "You weren't supposed to have those."

"I had them anyway."

"Good," her mother said. "Good." Her hand went slack against Amelia's cheek and Amelia held it there, held it to her own face with her own cold hand, and her mother looked at her, only at her, and did not ask why, and did not learn why, and went, still looking, with the warm register the last thing on her and the man beside her beneath her notice to the end.

Amelia did not close her mother's eyes. She could not remember, afterward, deciding not to. She simply did not, and turned her head, because Maren was still breathing.

* * *

Maren had gone down half across the Queen, the way she went toward everything she loved, in front of it. She was looking at the grey sky and her hands were moving at the front of her, low, and Amelia knew what they were doing before she looked, because she had watched those hands do it in a byre and against a church wall and on a road with the King's baggage going by. Maren was counting her buttons. Top to bottom. The thing she did when the ground was moving under her.

"Don't," Maren said, when Amelia's hand came toward her. Her voice was thin and it did not shake, because Maren had decided a long time ago that it would not. "Don't you spend it on me. I saw. It wouldn't hold for her. It'll not hold for me. I'll not have you learn twice in one hour that it won't."

"Be quiet," Amelia said. "Let me."

"No." Maren's hands went on with the buttons. Four of them, top to bottom, and back. "I'll say what I won't say. I'll not be made sorry I came. I said it to you in a square and I'll say it here." The count faltered on the second button and she took the falter and drove it down and went on. "I had a life of covered trays. I'd not trade the one road for the whole of it." Her fingers reached the bottom button and stopped there, holding it, not letting go. "There," she said. "All present. I do like it when they come out even."

Amelia sat with her and did not reach for the blood, because Maren had asked her not to, and it was the last thing Maren would ever ask of her, and she gave it. She held Maren's hand over the bottom button and Maren held it back, and the count had come out even, and then Maren's hand went easy in hers and did not hold anything at all.

She had lost her mother and she had lost the one person who had ever truly known her, in the space of a hundred feet of hill, to the same flat cast of iron, and the sum of it was a

thing she could not make come out. She tried. Her body reached for the count out of long habit, for a figure to set against it, a number of the dead or the living or the years, and there was no number that fit, and for the first time in her life the counting failed her entirely and left her sitting in the grass with two still hands, one warm-cool and one work-rough, and no number left to hide inside.

* * *

She stood up.

Loric had not moved. He was watching her, and the tidy front was all the way back up over him now, mild, whole, a man in the wreck of his own war with his hands open and empty. He had come up her mother's own hill through her mother's own host, and he had worked it out before any of them, and here at the end of it he had the thing he had built for twenty years lying in the grass at his feet.

She looked at him, and she saw what he had. She saw it plainly, from the back, the way she saw everything.

He had a corpse. He had a Queen dead on a hill, and he had nothing else at all. She had not learned his name. Not the old war, not the father in the ground, not the whole reason. She had not looked at him once. She had died with her face turned to her daughter and a word about almond cakes on her mouth, and the man who had spent his life to be the thing she understood at the last had been, to her, less than the grass. He had wanted her grief. He had built a country's worth of dead to buy her grief, one specific grief, hers, aimed and knowing. And she had gone out of the world without spending him a thought, and there was no getting it back, because you could not make the dead go back and understand.

She saw him know it. She saw him hold it under the courtesy the way he had held everything under the courtesy

his whole life, and she understood that he would go on holding it, that he had already begun the work of burying it and would not stop until it was gone, and that the burying would take the rest of his life and would not, in all of it, be finished.

There was a name in her mouth still. She did not say it. She had a colder use for it now than saying.

She reached for him the way she had reached for six men in a square. It was the plainest thing in the world when it came to it. She found the warm knot of him that kept the time, the tidy heart in the tidy man, and she did not make a speech of it and she did not let him see her decide it, because he did not deserve the ceremony of being decided about. She slid it still.

He folded. He went down into the grass among the standards the way a thing folds when the string is cut, without a word, because she had not given him one, and lay there with his hands still open and empty. She had thought, once, that this would be a great thing, the ending of the man who had made every death. It was the smallest motion she owned. It changed nothing. It did not give her back one of the two still hands in the grass behind her, and she felt exactly as much as she had felt at Dunmoor, which was nothing at all, because the thing that would have made it matter was already gone and killing him did not reach it. He had lost on the hill an hour before she ever put her hand out.

She let the cold thing lie back down. It went easily. It had never been the part of her that struggled.

* * *

The quiet men were looking at her.

She turned and found them all turned toward her, the nine of them, and the standard-bearers, and beyond them the near ranks of the Crown host that had broken and

recoiled off the dragon and now stood in the wreck of their own high line with no one to run the war off the folding table, because the man who ran it was in the grass. They were looking at the silver-haired woman standing over a dead Queen and a dead grey man on the high ground, and they were waiting, the way men wait when the thing that told them what to do has stopped and the next thing has not spoken yet.

She knew what they were looking at. She had spent her life reading exactly this, the moment a quiet changed its quality, and she read it now. Her mother had put it in the throne's own wax at Dunmoor, the acknowledged daughter, under royal protection, the one thing accusation could never prove made true by the Crown's own hand. The Queen was dead on the hill. And the natural-born heir was standing over her with the blood still cold in her wrists, in the sight of the host, and there was no one in the whole grey country with a better claim to the empty air where a Queen had been, and every man on the hilltop had come to the same figure at the same moment she did.

One of them went down on one knee in the churned grass. Then the man beside him. It went out from her in a spreading turn, the way the crowd had turned to find her at Dunmoor, heads and then knees, and she stood at the top of the hill and let it come, and did not fold herself down to nothing, and did not measure the faces the way she had all her life. She had wanted, her whole life, to be seen. She was seen now. She was the most seen thing in the country, and she had paid for it in the two still hands behind her, and she made herself hold that plainly, because she was not a child and she would not pretend the crown had come to her clean.

The eldest of them did not kneel. He was grey and dry and he had run a war off a table, and he looked from the Queen in the grass to the grey man folded among the

standards to the silver girl standing over both, and he made the same reckoning she had watched a great many men make that hour, and came to her.

"Majesty," he said. He tried it in his mouth like a coin he was not sure of, and then he was sure of it. "The line's broken here. The west bank's still coming across the shelf. We've orders standing that die with him." He did not look at Loric. He had already stopped being a man Loric ran. "What are the orders."

She looked at the standards hung dead in the windless grey, and at the frames down the slope, and she gave him the only order that would keep any of it from spending the rest of the day into the ford.

"Lower the standards," she said. "All six. A dropped banner on the high ground where both hosts can see it. Then stop the frames."

He turned and said it to the standard-bearers, and the six poles came down out of the grey together. Along both banks of the Elver the faces that had gone up to find a dragon came round and down to find the Crown host's own banners going to the ground on the hill, which was a thing every man on the field knew the grammar of, and the sound of the war began, very slowly, to change its quality.

"And the frames," she said.

It carried. The wall gave it nothing to double off up here, only the open grey, but the quiet man nearest her heard it and turned and it went down the broken line, hand to hand, the way orders go. *Stop the frames.* Down the slope, at the head of the shelf, the two live windlasses stood off their cranks. And the dragon in the wreck of the water stopped being a thing they put iron into, and became only the largest and most terrible thing on a field where the killing had been told to stop.

The war was not undone. She knew that, standing there. There were four thousand on the west bank and near eight on the east and a country of dead behind them and none of it went back into the ground it came out of because a girl said stop. But the man who had wound it was in the grass, and the frames were off their cranks, and the thing had a head now that could tell it to hold, and it held. It was not much, set against the dead. It was what there was, and she took it, and made it stand for the rest.

She looked down the slope, once, past the kneeling men, past the standards, to the wreck at the head of the shelf. A dragon lay there, huge and burning and not dead, in a foot of the poor man's water. Two irons were still in him. His torn wing was folded wrong. And she found the one dark eye of him open and turned up the hill, on her, the way it had been on her from the fish-house and the ford and the door with the falls going down behind it. He was down and he was not finished. She had asked him to go up and be shot and not come down for anyone, and he had done it, and he had lived to lie in the water and look up the hill and see that she had reached the top of it. She let herself look at him one breath longer than she needed to. Then she went to do the last of it.

* * *

She came down the hill through the broken line, and the men let her through the way a crowd lets through anything that walks as if it has the right, and this time the right was the throne's, and it felt exactly the same as the cold right she had bought in a market square, which was to say it felt like a door pulled shut on a chain as she passed.

She found Selwyn at the head of the shelf, in the thin red water, where the fourth frame's flat cast had put him and the men beside him. She had never spoken to him. She knew him only as the shape Korvan had watched go down and not

gone to, the friend the dragon had let the water have so that a hooded girl could climb a hill. Two clansmen had him half out of the water, dragging under the arms. One of them was saying a name over and over, the way you say a name to a man to keep him from leaving. Selwyn's eyes were open and going grey and his mouth was working on something. The thing at the front of him, low, was open the way a torn vessel is open. The water around him was going the colour of it.

She knelt in the ford.

"Hold him," she said, and the clansmen, who had every reason to fear the silver thing that had walked through their war, held him, because there was nothing else left to do. She put her hand into the cold water and onto the open place and reached for the power to close it, and the power came. It came the way it always came now, enormous, the cold answer her mother's blood had put in her, awake and straining up her arm — more than enough of it, the thing the whole court had gone white over the day they understood whose gift she carried. The blood in her had never been the lack. The lack was that she had used it barely a season, in stolen mornings in a locked room, and this wound was wide and it was fast, more life leaving a man at once than she had ever tried to turn, and turning that needed a hand that had done it a thousand times. Hers had done it never. She reached for all of it and could not make it move the way it would have moved for the Queen. She had the strength to command the blood and not yet the craft to catch it in time, and the space between those two things was the width of a man's life, and it ran out through her fingers into the ford while she was still learning the shape of what she held.

The power was equal to it. She was not. Not yet.

She knelt in a foot of the poor man's water with her hand shut over a wound gone still, and made herself take the whole grotesque arithmetic of it, the three of them and the

three different ways her gift had come to nothing. The iron had taken her mother in a breath, too fast for any hand, hers or the Queen's own. Maren it had not taken fast — Maren it had left the time for, and Maren had used that time to forbid her the reach, to spare her the trying and the finding out, telling her with a plain last breath that it would not hold. This one it had left slow and given no such refusal, no one to tell her not to try, and it was the very kind of hurt the gift was made for, and she had tried, and could not — not because the power was small but because it was vast and new and hers only these few weeks, and no one had ever been allowed to teach her the use of it. Her mother, with a thousand years of practice, would have held this man closed with two fingers and half her attention. Amelia had the same terrible blood and none of the hours, and so he died, and the fear the court had felt the day they learned what she was came true in the worst possible shape: not the harm she could do, but the good she could not, yet. She did not weep. There was no one on the whole field who would ever see her do it, and there was nothing in her yet that could. She only knelt in the water until the red stopped moving, because he was the thing in front of her, and reaching the thing in front of you was the only mercy the world had ever let her be good at, even the times the reaching came to nothing.

"Here's the thing," Selwyn said, up at the grey sky, thin, not to her, not to anyone, the way a man says the thing he has always said. "Here's the thing about a downed one—"

"Be quiet," Amelia said, "and breathe," but he did neither. The thing about a downed one went unfinished, the way the important things do, and the working mouth went still on it, and one of the clansmen made a wet sound that had no laughing anywhere in it at all.

The other clansman had not let go of Selwyn's arm and had not stopped watching her hand under the water, where

the red had stopped going anywhere now, the ford running clear again over a thing past holding. He was a big man and he was afraid of her, she could see it in the set of his jaw, and he held on to his dead friend anyway.

"You're the witch," he said. It was not an accusation. He was only naming the thing in front of him, the way a man names weather he cannot do anything about.

"No," Amelia said. She lifted her hand up out of the water. "No witch. Only me. And not enough of that."

The clansmen laid him back into the thin water, because there was nothing else left to do with him, and the three of them knelt over the dead man in the middle of a stopped war, a silver Queen and two men who had every reason on the field to fear her, and none of them said anything more, because there was nothing to say that the water would have let them hear.

She looked up from the body, once, along the head of the shelf, to the wreck where the dragon lay. He had watched her the whole way down. He had let this man go into the water and not gone to him, on her word — held the line, and paid for it the price she had asked. And here she was, come too late and too green to make the paying worth anything, with her empty hand coming up out of the ford. She saw the dark eye of him take it in. She had no way to tell him across the forty feet of thin water that she had tried, that the trying had not been enough, that the failing was in her hands and not in his holding. So she only held his eye, and let him read it off her, and watched the thing go through the great ruined body that goes through a man when the last hope of a thing is lifted out of him. She had come down off the hill. And the first thing the new-made Queen of the whole grey country had done with the crown was kneel in a ford and fail to keep his friend in the world.

The falls went on. They would go on after all of it, she thought, the water that took every word and gave nothing back, indifferent as her mother had never been to her and the whole cold world had always been. She took her hand up out of the red at last, empty. She did not go to him yet; there was no leave for it, not with the war only just told to hold. So the two of them stayed on the two sides of the water, both alive and both too late, with a dead boy on the shelf between them and the falls going on and on beside them, and neither of them crossed.

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

What We Choose

Twenty-two days after the Elver, they brought her into a room built to be heard in.

She knew what it was the moment the doors gave. Reading a room was the oldest thing she owned, and it came up in her without asking, the way counting had always come up, and she let it. The hall threw her own footfall back at her whole. Stone above, stone under, stone to either hand, and a vaulting cut so that a voice let go in the middle of it went out to every corner and came home unspoilt. It was the opposite of her own locked room three floors up in a castle a hundred miles east, the room she had measured against her own breath on a hundred nights and found to return a whisper at four parts in ten. That room had been built to keep a secret. This one had been built so that nothing said in it could ever be a secret again.

She stood in the middle of it and did not fold herself down small, and let it carry the sound of her.

There were more people in the hall than she had stood among in the whole of her life before that spring. She did not count them. She had counted the carriages once, from a high window, by the way iron wheels changed their note on the courtyard stone, and had wanted, with the whole of her, to be down among the arriving. She was down among them now. They had come on those same wheels from every

quarter the war had touched, lords and reeves and the grey careful men who ran countries off folding tables, and they had come to look at the silver girl set up where a Queen had always stood, and they were all of them turned toward her, and no one between her and the far wall was permitted to look away.

She had wanted, her whole life, to be heard across a bright room.

The room was very bright. They had lit it for her the way the castle had once been lit for one, branches of candles the height of a man, and the light stood in the cold air and did not warm it. She was heard across it. She was the most heard thing in the country. Every ear in the hall was bent to catch whatever she let fall, and she found, standing there with all of it come true at last, that the wanting had been a different shape than the having. She had thought being heard would feel like being let in. It felt like being set on a stone in the middle of a lake where the water carried every word to the shore and gave her nothing back to stand on but the stone.

The smell came up then, the way it did, from nowhere and whole. Beeswax, and cold stone.

There had been a gallery on the north side once, sealed, where the old lamps were kept, and she had been let to sit in it for hours because it had no window and no door a stranger could reach, and so it had been safe, and it had smelled of beeswax and old stone and nothing else in the world. The smell had come to her all her life at the wrong moments, at the edges of frightened nights, once in the middle of her mother telling her that her grandmother was dead. It came to her now in the loud bright room where she had been brought to be crowned, and she let it come and go and asked nothing of it, because it was not a sign. It was only a thing she carried. She carried a great deal now that she did not yet have the room to set down.

The crown itself was a small matter, when it came to it. That surprised her, though by then she had learned that the great things were mostly small when you were close enough to touch them.

An old man in a healer's grey put it on her, because her mother's own hands could not, and because the healer was the eldest living person the court could find who had served in the last reign and could swear he had held the true regalia before, and the court wanted the swearing more than it wanted the man. It weighed less than the grey gown had weighed. She had expected a great deal of it and it was cold and light and sat where it sat, and the hall made the sound a hall makes when a thing it has been holding its breath for finally happens, a long low fall of breath that came back off the vaulting doubled.

They knelt. She let them. She did not weigh the faces one by one the way she had all her life, reading each for what it knew of her and what it might do with the knowing. There was no use in it now. They all knew. The girl no one had been allowed to see was the most seen thing in the country, and the measuring she had built her whole survival on had no work left to do, and she stood in the loud bright hall with her mother's crown on her cold hair and her mother twenty-two days in the ground and let the country kneel, and it was not the clean thing she had wanted from a high window. She had known it would not be. She had done the sum on the night she decided to be seen, and she had believed every figure in it, and it had cost her more than the figures, because the figures had not had her mother's face in them, or Maren counting buttons in wet grass.

She held that plainly while they knelt. She was not a child, and she would not let the crown pretend it had come to her clean.

* * *

Afterward there was a room off the hall where the work was done, and the work did not wait for grief, which she found she was grateful for, because the work at least was a thing she could reach.

The grey man was there. He had run Loric's war off a folding table and had knelt to her on the hill and said *Majesty* like a coin he was not sure of, and he had ridden west with her and made himself useful in the wreck, and now he stood at the head of her council table because there was no one alive who understood the moving parts of the ruined country better than the man who had helped ruin it. She had thought a great deal about whether to let him stand there. She had decided that a peace run by the man who had built the war was an ugly thing, and that most true things were ugly close up, and that she would rather have the ugly true thing that worked than the clean one that let the roads fill with the dead through the winter.

He laid a paper in front of her. It was covered close in a clerk's good hand, and it was sealed at the foot already, wanting only her name.

"The proclamation of the succession," he said. "It goes to every town by the mail-road. It puts the question past argument." He was dry and careful and he did not flatter her, which she valued more than she could have said. "It sets out the whole of it. That you are the Queen's own get. Born, in the body, in the old way, the first in a thousand years. That the treaty was never broken because a born thing was never a made thing, and the men who wrote the peace did not forbid a miracle they were certain could not come. It is the

truth, Majesty, and it is your armour. Signed and cried in every square, it takes the one weapon your enemies have left and breaks it in their hands. No man can call you a made vampire once the Crown itself has cried you born."

She read it. It was well made. It was every word of it true, the true reason of everything, the whole architecture of why, set down in a clerk's good hand and wanting only her name to become the story the country was told about her.

She thought about a fountain in a garden that had swallowed her voice. She thought about a hall where her own hair had been enough to damn her without a word said. She thought about her mother, cool hands in her hair, telling her in the low steady voice she used for the true things: *It does not matter that it's true. The truth of it is nothing out there. It cannot be proven and cannot be shown, and no one beyond that door wants it to be true, so it will not be true for them however you say it.*

"No," she said.

The grey man did not move. He was too old and too used to rooms to show a thing he had decided not to show. "Majesty."

"I won't sign it." She set the paper down flat and put one finger on it, lightly, the way you keep a thing from blowing off a table. "You've written that the truth is my armour. It isn't. It was never going to be. I could cry it in every square in the country and the men who want an army would look at my hair and hear a made thing, because the truth was never the thing they were weighing. My mother knew that. She did the sum every night of my life and it never came out kind, and the reason it never came out kind is that being true was not going to save me, and she was right." She was aware her voice had gone level and low, the register she reached for when there was too much and no room to hold it, and she let it, because it carried in that room without her having to

spend anything on it. "I spent twenty years being a thing that could not be proven. I am not going to spend the reign proving it. If I sign this, then every day I am Queen is a day I am still arguing that I have the right to exist, and I have done that argument. I did it on a hill. I am finished with it."

"Then they will go on calling you a made thing."

"Let them." She lifted her finger off the paper. "I'm not the throne's because I can prove how I was born. No one out there can weigh it and no one out there wants to, and I will not build a reign on a thing I can't make a single doubting man believe. I'm the throne's because I was acknowledged in the wax by the Queen's own hand while she lived, and because there is no one else, and because the men on the hill knelt. That's inheritance. That will do for the getting of it." She looked at him along the table, the whole cold length of the room carrying it to him clean. "What I do with it after is mine. That part no one hands you. Take the paper away and burn it. I'll not have the truth made into a banner. I've seen what my banners do."

He took the paper. He looked at her a moment with something in his dry old face she chose not to read, and then he folded it once, and it went off the table, and she felt the small hard thing settle in her that she supposed was going to have to do the work of a great deal that had not come out on her side. She had inherited a crown. She had just chosen how she would wear it, which was the only part of any of it that had ever been hers to choose, and it had felt exactly like refusing a covered tray.

"There is the matter of the west bank," the grey man said, because the work did not wait. "Four thousand of them laid down their arms on the shelf when the standards came down. The council's mind is that a reprisal now, made plain, buys the peace cheaper than mercy does. Loric's captains among them. The nine who ran his table with me. The law

would hang them and no town would grieve it, and the country would learn what it costs to raise a hand to the Crown, and learn it once, and be quiet."

She thought about a wound in a cold ford, and a stranger's blood going out under her hands regardless, her power enormous, more than enough, and too green to hold it where she told it to stay, the way it had not stayed for the two she had made of and been raised by. She thought about how small the stilling of a heart had been, standing over the man who had built a country's worth of dead, how it had changed nothing and given her back neither of the two still hands on the hill.

"No reprisal," she said. "The captains stand a hearing, each man for what his own hand did, and no man hangs for standing near a banner. The nine come to me. If they'd rather run a table than a gallows, I've a country to mend and not enough dry old men to mend it, and I'd sooner spend them than string them." She saw the grey man weigh it, and saw him find it colder arithmetic than mercy, which it was, and let him think it whichever he liked. "I've had enough deaths that changed nothing. I'll not add to them to teach a lesson. Killing a man to make the others quiet is the loudest thing there is, and I want this country quiet the other way. Have I made it plain."

"You have, Majesty."

"Then that's the orders." She stood, because she had learned on the hill that the standing was itself a thing men read, and she read them reading it. "Selwyn."

The grey man's careful face did a small honest thing at the change of register. "Gone, Majesty. On the shelf, where the iron put him. They tell me the silver girl knelt in the ford and tried, and that the boy went out under her hands regardless." A dry, careful beat. "The clansmen carried him

off the field on their own shoulders. They talk about him a great deal. About what a downed one ought to do."

She was quiet a moment, and did not let the quiet be nothing. "See his people are told by someone who stood on the shelf," she said, "and not by a name on a list on a cross. That's an order too."

* * *

She went to Korvan in the evening, when the work let her go, and the going was the one part of the day she did not have to decide.

They had put him in the old mews on the river side, because it was the one range of the palace with a door tall enough and a court wide enough, and because a dragon that had come down in a foot of the poor man's water at the Elver could not be lodged in a bedchamber and neither could the man it folded down to. No one at the court had yet worked out which of the two things he was on a given hour. They had settled, in the way of frightened people, for putting the whole question at the far end of the grounds behind a wall.

He was a man tonight. He was sitting on the stone lip of the court with his back against the warm brick where the old kilns had stood, and he was a man, and the fading light was on him, and the healers had drawn the two irons out of him a week apart because the second had gone in near enough the great vessels that a clan woman with more nerve than any court surgeon had made them wait. The torn wing was a thing that only showed when he was the other shape, but she could see the cost of it in how he held the one shoulder, careful, the way she had held everything careful all her life.

He heard her at the gate before she was through it. He always had. The one dark eye came round to her, and the whole of the dangerous idle weight of him, the thing that had lain in a red ford and made a stopped war afraid, gathered

and turned and became, only for her, a man glad to see someone come across a court.

"Majesty," he said, and put such a load of dry insolence on it that it stopped being the word the country used and became a thing that was theirs.

"Don't." She came and sat on the stone lip beside him, close, and the cold of her and the heat of him met the way they had met in a shepherd's hut in the winter, the too-cold and the too-hot finding their level between. She did not touch him yet. She looked at the shoulder. "How is it."

"It's mending. I'll tell you what mends slow. The court surgeon's face when he has to come out here and look up my nose." He said it to make her mouth move, and it did, a little, and he watched it do that with the whole of his attention the way he watched the important things. Then he let the joke go, because the humor thinned in him now when it needed to, and he had learned when it needed to. "You did it. I heard the bells go this morning. Your mother barely in the ground, and they've put the thing on your head already."

"They've put the thing on my head."

"And you stood in a room full of them and let them look."

"I stood in a room full of them and let them look."

He was quiet a moment. The river went by beyond the wall, low, indifferent, the way the falls had gone by and taken every word. "I know what that room cost you," he said, low, not a joke in it anywhere. "I know who paid the fare and isn't in it."

She did not answer that. She could not, and he did not need her to, and that was the whole of what she had crossed the court for, the one place in the loud bright country where a thing could be true and not have to be said. She looked at her own cold hands in her lap. She had held her mother's heart and told the blood to stay and it had not stayed. She had held Maren's hand over a counted button and the count

had come out even and then had come out nothing. She had held a stranger's wound in a ford and been too green to catch it, and she had made herself hold the whole ugly figure of that, the one power she owned useless for the two she loved and too new for the one stranger it was made for, and she had not wept then and she did not weep now, because there was no one in the whole country she would let watch her do it and there was nothing in her yet that could.

"I keep the smell," she said instead, which was not the thing and was the nearest she could come to the thing. "Beeswax, and cold stone. There was a room when I was small. It comes to me at the wrong times. It came to me under the crown this morning, in front of all of them, and I stood there in the loudest room in the world smelling a locked room three floors up where no one could reach me, and I understood that I had spent my whole life wanting out of that room, and that I would give the crown back tonight to sit in it one more hour with the two of them on the far side of the bolt, alive, and unable to reach me, and safe." Her voice did the thing under her control that it had not asked her leave to do. It did not break. It only went, for the length of one word, thinner than she had told it to be, and she took the thinness and drove it down and went on, the way Maren had driven a faltered count down and gone on. "I got the enormous ordinary thing. To stand in the warm room and be known. And the two who kept me in the dark so I could have it aren't in the room to see it, and I traded them for it, and no one made me. I chose it. That's the part I have to hold. I chose to be seen, and this is the bill."

He did not tell her it was not her fault. He was the one person she had ever met who did not reach for the useless soft thing to put over a true hard one. He had said to her once, in a wood, sick and shaking, the plainest thing anyone had ever said to her — that a thing could be your doing and

not your choosing at once, and both stay standing. He gave her that grammar again now, the only kind he owned.

"You chose to be seen," he said. "You didn't choose the iron that crossed the hill. Loric chose that. And both are true, and they don't cancel, and you'll carry both, and the carrying of two things that don't cancel is the whole of what it is to be a person and not a banner." He turned his head, careful of the shoulder, and looked at her with the one dark eye, and the dangerous weight of him was all leashed and all turned to her, tender in the doing and cold as the river under it, both true. "You want to know the thing I've worked out, lying in the poor man's water and then a healer's cot with nothing to do but work things out. Come here."

She came there. She put her cold face against the warm column of his throat the way she had put it against her mother's cool one a hundred nights, and he brought one arm around her, the careful shoulder, slow, and held her, and did not squeeze the grief out of her because you could not squeeze it out, you could only stand near it, and he stood near it. Below them the river went on. It would go on after all of it, indifferent, taking every word. She let it take this one.

"You didn't inherit this," he said into her silver hair, low, the words going nowhere but into her. "That's the thing they've got wrong, all of them, kneeling in there. They think a crown fell on the nearest head. It didn't. Your mother could give you the blood in a vial and the name in the wax. She couldn't give you the choosing. Nobody can hand that down. You climbed a hill through her whole army to a man who only ever asked, and you gave him silence, and you knelt in a ford for a stranger with the crown not an hour old. You didn't get handed a Queen. You made one. That part's yours. That part nobody gave you and nobody can take."

She lifted her face from his throat. She had crossed the court to be held and not to speak, but there was one thing

left that would not go into words, and she did it in the body instead. She took his jaw in her cold hand and turned his mouth down to hers and kissed him, not the shieling's starved kiss and not the reunion's, but slow, and certain, and unhurried, the kiss of a woman laying down a claim she had already paid for in full and meant to keep. *Mine*, said the cold mouth that had given the whole country careful nothing all day. He made a low sound with the dragon still in it, the enormous leashed weight of him going over to her all at once, and brought his good hand up into the loose silver of her hair and held her there and gave the word back. *Hers*. Then he let her mouth go, slow, and she set her face against the warm column of his throat again, where it had been, claimed and claiming and for the one hour not alone.

She stayed against his throat and did not answer, because the falls were in her ears again though there were no falls here, only a river, and she let him hold the shoulder careful and hold her, and for a while the loud bright country was on the far side of a wall and it was only the two of them and the going water and the grief that did not cancel and the choosing that was hers.

* * *

The dragon was awake in the dark of the mews and Korvan lay inside it and did not sleep.

He had learned the trick of it in three weeks. The man could lie down inside the great cold weight of the other shape and be carried, the way a rider is carried, awake in the dark while the huge slow heart went under him at a pace no man's heart would ever keep. Two irons had come out of him. The wing had knit crooked and would fly crooked and he did not care. Down the range past the wall the court slept the shallow sleep of people who had bedded a monster at the end of the garden, and he heard every turn of every one of

them, and let them fear. It cost him nothing to let them fear. It was the one thing he had that the whole trembling court agreed he was for.

That was the word that had been going round the tables since the bells. *The Queen's dragon*. He had heard it through the wall, in the grey careful voices, laid down like a thing settled. She would need a dragon, they said, a Queen so new and so contested. It was well she had one. It made a tidy shape in their heads, the witch-queen and her beast, the very banner Loric had painted to burn her with, hung now the right way up over her own hall. A dragon was a thing a throne kept. A slot. A leash with a good chain on it and a wall around the far end of the garden, and a word, *hers*, that meant the way a hound is a man's, the way a sword is.

He lay in the dark and turned the word over, the man inside the beast, and found the cold thing in him that had lain in a red ford and been feared, and used it, for once, on the right question.

He was not the Queen's dragon.

There was no throne in the world that could keep him. They had bedded a thing at the end of their garden that had gone up in the open over the Elver and taken a whole net of whale-iron into its own body on purpose and come down and stopped a war, and it had done that because a hooded girl on a shelf had asked it to, and for no other reason under the sky. Not for the throne. Not for the country. Not because a chain ran to a wall. He had been a clan of one his whole life, the boy whose body would not turn when everyone else's did, the outsider at the edge of every fire, and the world had at last made him the thing the propaganda promised, the loneliest thing alive, a dragon with no elders and no traditions and not one other of his kind under the whole silver moon. The court thought that made him a thing to be kept. It had it exactly backward. A thing that answers to

no one is not a thing you keep. It is a thing that chooses, or it is nothing.

And he had chosen. He had chosen on a slope with two irons in him and his wing torn, when he could have gone down easy into the water and let the war have him, and had held instead, and endured, because up the hill a silver head was climbing to the top of the thing that had hunted her, and he had wanted, with the whole animal weight of himself, for her to reach it. That was not a leash. No one had chained him to that hill. He had authored it. He had taken the one shape the world feared most and made of it, by his own choice and no other's, the thing that stood between her and the iron. Not the Queen's dragon. Hers. The way you belong to a person you have decided on, freely, having seen the whole cost, and gone toward it anyway.

And she was his the same way, by the same choosing, which was the only kind that was worth anything. She had crossed her mother's army to a man who only asked. She had come across a court in the evening and put her cold face against his throat. No one had made her. There was no blood-tie in it and no fate in it and no old story pulling the two of them together against their will, and he was glad of that, fiercely, in the dark, because a thing that chooses you is worth ten thousand things that were only ever going to. Two people who had each been a clan of one had looked across an impossible amount of ruined ground and chosen, and the choosing had cost them nearly everything, and they had paid it and were still standing on the two banks of the same water, alive.

Down the range the court turned in its shallow frightened sleep. Beyond the wall the new Queen sat awake in the loud bright house with her mother's crown and her mother in the ground and a country to mend, the girl no one had been allowed to see, at the very center of the country that had

spent a thousand years with no place in it for either of them. He felt her awake. He had always felt her coming and going, the one instinct in him that had gone quiet and sure the day he met her, and he let it lie easy now, a heat low in the great cold body, turned toward the house.

The chief had come to the mews three days after the bells. An old shifter with weather in his face and no apology in him, who had known what his son was since a night by a war-train and had walked up alone with a torch to meet it. He had stood in the court a long while and looked at the huge crooked-winged thing his boy had become, and had said, in the end, sideways, the way he said the things that cost him: *I let go of your belly in that river so you'd not drown reaching for me. Looks like you learned to swim after all. In deep water. With a full moon on it.* And then, lower, the nearest the man had ever come to the word: *You didn't need a clan, boy. You needed the one that was coming.* And had gone, before the morning, back to the hills, to be a chief to the living.

The clan of one is now two.

Korvan lay awake in the dark inside the shape the world had made to be alone in, and did not feel alone, and let the court fear him, and kept his one warm instinct turned toward the loud bright house across the wall where the woman he had chosen sat choosing what to do with a crown that no one, in the end, had handed to either of them. The river went on outside. It would go on after all of it. He listened to her stay awake, and stayed awake with her, alive on the two sides of the same water, and choosing, for as long as there was choosing left, each other.

About the Author

Søren Stromberg writes adult fantasy romance — dangerous devotion, bonds that are chosen rather than fated, and the price of finally being seen. *A Bond of Scale and Silver* is the first novel under this name.

Also by this author

Writing upper-YA fantasy as

POST PELEOS

THE SAEREN CHRONICLES

Book One: Hazel Academy

Book Two: The Resistance

Book Three: The Weight of the Source

A completed upper-YA fantasy trilogy about grief, found family, and a girl born with the one magic her world kills to keep buried. Written for younger readers — no explicit content.

